The Final Transaction

A Novel

Chayapan Khannabha

First draft

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Chapter 1

Life lesson

Turning 40th. 25-30 were good, but pointless years. 30-35 had some growth and still floating around. 35-40… When 37 it was three years, then by 39 life has different meaning.

That is the sum. I have been looking at it for ten minutes and I am not going to improve it. A life in five-year blocks, like a quarterly report with the footnotes left off. I know where the footnotes are.

Thirty-nine years and 364 days. Fourteen thousand six hundred and nine of them, if you count days, and I count days. Tomorrow the number has a nought on the end and people will send cards about it. Tonight it is just a number one short of another number, which is the kind of thing I notice and the kind of thing nobody else does, and that, if I am honest, is the whole of my career.

This is entry 1,399. I put the number at the top of the page the way I have put it at the top of the 1,398 before it, and then I sat and did not write, which I never do, because I had the idea that a man should put down something worth keeping on the last night of his thirties. Then I wrote what I wrote. Four lines. Good but pointless. Floating. Dots. Different meaning. I am not a writer. I am a man who writes things down, which is not the same thing, and I have never pretended it was. I do not sign these. A signature is a claim, and these are not claims.

Laura is downstairs. The oven door has gone twice, which means

she is doing something for tomorrow that she believes I do not know about. I know about it. There has been a leg of lamb in the fridge since Saturday, under a tea towel, like a body. Tom and Aisha are coming at half past seven and Tom will bring a bottle that costs more than it should and a card that makes a noise. I will be surprised at the right moment. It is one of the things six years of marriage teaches you: when to be surprised, and how.

Elsie went down at 7.50 and has not stirred. Fifty weeks and five days. Nine point six kilos on Thursday, on the scales at the surgery, Laura holding her and the nurse reading the number and me writing it down on the back of my hand because I did not have a book with me, which I regretted. Six teeth. She stood in the cot this morning holding the rail with both hands and said something that Laura swears was Dad and I swear was Da, and we have agreed not to argue about it for a year.

I will come back to Elsie. I always come back to Elsie, and if anyone ever reads these books in order they will see the exact entry where that started, and they will not need me to explain it.

Twenty-five to thirty, then, since I have raised it.

A desk on a trading floor, the third from the window, and a screen with eight colours on it, and a man next to me called Tom who is coming to dinner tomorrow and still thinks of me as the one who read the footnotes. Good money. Better money than I have had since, if you count it the way the people on that floor counted it, which is by the year, and I stopped counting it that way at about twenty-eight when I noticed I did not own anything I would miss. A flat I did not like. A car I did not drive. Nights that ended at four and started at six, and I was good at them, and I can remember perhaps nine of them. Good years. Pointless years. The two words sit together perfectly well and I have never understood why people think they should not.

Thirty to thirty-five. I moved from the desk to the room behind the

desk, where the people sit who tell the desk what it may not do, and the money went down and the hours went down and I was, for the first time, interested. Three employers in five years. Risk at a bank, risk at a broker, risk at a bank again. Each time I was hired for being careful and each time I left because being careful was wanted on the brochure and not in the room. Growth, I wrote. Some. Still floating around. That is accurate. I knew what I was looking at by thirty-four and I did not yet know what to do about it, and the honest word for that condition is floating.

Thirty-five. Walbrook.

I will say what Walbrook is, once, because I have never said it in these books and if the books are ever read by anyone but me they will need it. When two banks make a promise to each other about money, and the promise lasts for years, they do not trust each other to keep it. They put Walbrook in the middle. Walbrook promises each of them that the other will pay, and to make that promise good, Walbrook takes a deposit from both: cash, or government bonds, held in Walbrook's own account where nobody can touch them. Every morning before seven an engine runs and works out how much each promise has moved overnight, and by nine every member has either paid the difference or is in default. In five years I have never seen a default. My job is to look at the deposits. Not the promises; the deposits. Whether they are what they say they are, whether they are where they say they are, whether they would still be there on a bad morning. I decide if the deposits are real. That is the short answer, and tomorrow night at dinner Tom will ask me what I do and I will give it to him and he will say it mostly is, isn't it, Jonas, and I will say not yet, and he will laugh, because he has heard me say it for fifteen years.

Thirty-six. A Tuesday, as it happens, like tonight. A member's bonds, promised to us, did not arrive, and the member said timing, and paid the nine o'clock in cash it had not had at seven, and at ten past three the bonds turned up as if nothing had happened. I wrote it down that

night on the first page of a black notebook I bought at lunchtime for the purpose. One page. A question mark. I did not know I was starting anything. I thought I was clearing my head.

One thousand three hundred and ninety-eight pages later I can tell you what I write. I write the date and the day. I write the member codes, four letters each, Walbrook's own, which mean nothing outside the building and which I have never once translated in these pages. I write the time each one's bank confirmed and what each one had in its deposit at seven and what it had at three and which lines were on the fails list and whether anybody said timing. I do not write names. I do not write the numbers from the systems, only the shape the numbers make. And the shape, on bad mornings, is always the same shape: bonds that fail to arrive in pairs, cash that was not there at seven and is there at nine, bonds that arrive in the afternoon and are gone again by the next run. One bond doing two jobs. I have never seen it. Nobody can see it; a government bond is a government bond, there are thirty billion pounds of some of those lines in issue and ours is not marked. I see what it leaves behind. Ninety-four times, by tonight's count. Ninety-four entries where the fingerprints say that something standing behind a promise to Walbrook is standing behind a promise to somebody else at the same time, and that on a sharp enough morning both promises will be called in and one of them will not be kept.

I think. I cannot prove it. I have written that sentence, or one like it, most weeks for three years, and I write it again now so that nobody reading this later can say I did not know the difference.

Thirty-seven. Three years.

I wrote it up. Six pages, Walbrook letterhead, a title I was proud of for about a day. I estimated, in a sentence I can still recite, that the system had approximately three years before a moderate shock became unmanageable. I gave it to Graham, who read it with the door shut and said he would take it forward, and took it forward with

a covering note that called it one analyst's view, and it went to the Treasury, who stamped it and filed it, and I know that because Graham told me, kindly, over a coffee he paid for, as if it were good news. He was relieved. I will put down something I have never put down: so was I. A man who has been proved right has to do something about it. A man who has been filed can go home and write it in a book.

Three years ago this month. The three years are up. I have spent the last few weeks waiting for that to mean something and it has meant nothing. Nothing happens. The call goes out at seven and is met by nine. Two members pay late on bad days and say timing. The register goes from grey to green, forty lines, every morning, and I go home. I have begun to wonder whether being early and being wrong look the same from the inside, and I have not found a way to tell them apart that does not involve waiting, and I am very good at waiting. It is the thing about me that nobody would put on a card.

Thirty-five to forty, I wrote, and then three dots.

The dots are deliberate. There are things that do not go in here, and I know what every one of them is, and the people they concern have not agreed to be written down. The dots are the only honest way to leave a gap.

Thirty-nine. Different meaning. I will not write what I mean by it tonight, because I know exactly what I mean and it will not fit on the last page of a decade, and because she is asleep eleven feet from where I am sitting and I would rather go and look at her than describe her. The entry where it started is in the seventh book. Anyone who reads in order will find it without my help.

Nine books. Eight of them are full and live in a steel toolbox on a shelf in a garage in Lewisham that my father rented for twenty-two years to keep tools in, and which I have kept on since he died because I could not think how to stop, and because by the time I thought of it the box was already there. Laura believes I go to the garage to sit

with his things. I do go to sit. The ninth book comes home every night in the bag she calls the briefcase, and every morning before it goes back in the bag I photograph the night's page and send the picture to myself, so that if the book is ever lost there is a copy somewhere that is not in a garage in Lewisham. I have done that 1,398 times without thinking about it. Tomorrow will be 1,399. I will do it in the kitchen with a child on my hip and I will not check the address, because in 1,398 mornings I have never once had to.

Today was a Tuesday. Nothing failed. I wrote that down and it took one line and I was pleased with it in a way I would not try to explain to anyone.

Tomorrow I will be forty, and the call will go out at seven, and the register will go green, and nothing will happen, which is the thing I have spent three years saying would not last. Then I will go home and be surprised by a leg of lamb.

Elsie. Your father is thirty-nine for another eight hours, if you let him sleep. He was right about something once, for three years, and it made no difference to anyone. He is writing that down so that it is written down. That is what he does.

Chapter 2

The wrong inbox

The alert was waiting for Graham Pryce when he sat down at 7.35, under the overnight summary and above a note from facilities about the lifts. He read the facilities note first.

Communications surveillance. Item held for review. Policy: inbound personal, risk-grade staff, client identifier match. Reviewer: surveillance analyst 2. Escalated: Head of Compliance, 07.19. Referred for business view: G. Pryce, 07.28.

The filter was a blunt thing. It held any message that came in from a personal webmail address to anyone on the risk-grade list, if the body or an attachment contained a string that looked like a member code, a security identifier or a sum of money, and it put the message in a queue on the second floor, where the surveillance analysts cleared most of them before breakfast. A few a year came up to Graham, because the head of compliance did not like to decide alone what was business when the business was his. In five years he had been asked for a view on a holiday booking forwarded by somebody's wife, two mortgage offers and a recruiter's letter that gave a salary in figures. He had typed *personal, no action* under each of them and thought about none of them.

Above the system's text the head of compliance had put two lines of her own. The analyst had escalated it because the attachment named

a clearing member. She would rather Graham saw it than that she decided. Would he call her.

He opened it because the sender's name was Whitlock.

From: a webmail address, the name and a string of digits. *To:* j.whitlock, the Walbrook domain. *Sent:* 6.41am. *Subject:* 1399. No text in the body. One attachment, a photograph, and under it the scanner's note of what it had read in the photograph: a four-letter code, three nominals in figures.

Graham clicked it and the page filled his screen.

It was a notebook, A5, plain black board, lying open on what looked like the arm of a chair. Two pages. The right-hand page had a heading in the top margin, underlined once: *#1399*. Below it, in the small upright hand Graham knew from five years of margin notes on his own reports, the first lines of an entry that ran on past the bottom of the picture:

Turning 40th. 25-30 were good, but pointless years. 30-35 had some growth and still floating around. 35-40… When 37 it was three years, then by 39 life has different meaning.

That was all. It was a man's diary, on his birthday, and Graham felt the small heat of having read it. He had signed the card yesterday. *Happy 40th, Jonas. Many of them. G.*

Then he looked at the left-hand page.

It was the end of the previous entry, and it was not a diary. It was a column. Three lines of gilts, each with its stock name and nominal, each in figures. A four-letter member code he recognised at once, because it belonged to one of their larger clearing members and it appeared in his own reports every month. Then a note, in the same hand, smaller:

Same line, third fail since June. Instructed Tues, failed Wed, failed Thu. Member covering in cash. Out on repo, I'd say, and due back "by two". 2 days. Q2 report signed G.P. 14th. "No material concentration." Contained.

1,398 days.

Graham read it twice. Then he enlarged the photograph until the handwriting broke into pixels, and shrank it again.

The member code was what the filter had caught. That was a fact, and he held on to it for a moment, because it was small and he could think about it. The member code and the nominals. That was why the thing had been on a screen on the second floor at ten past seven and not in Jonas's inbox, and why it had come up a floor, through two people doing exactly what they were paid to do, to the one person in the building Jonas would least have wanted to read it.

He did the arithmetic, because he could. 1,399 entries. If they were daily, and the heading said that they were, that was three years and ten months, give or take a leap day. Jonas had joined Walbrook at 35. He would have begun at 36. A year in. The memo had come at 37, so the memo was not the beginning of it; the memo was ten months of this, written up and sent upstairs with a covering note from Graham that said the paper represented *one analyst's view rather than a finding of the risk function* and that the matters raised were *being monitored*. He had used that word. He had been rather pleased with it. Simon Carrow at the Treasury had told him over lunch, some weeks later, that they had *noted it*, and Graham had understood the two of them to be speaking the same language.

And Jonas had gone on. Every day. Not a diary, or not only. A ledger. Bonds promised and not arriving, and the cash that stood in for them, and where he thought the bonds had gone, a line at a time, with the dates, and the name of the report that said it was contained and the initials of the man who had signed it.

Graham found that he had put his hand flat on the desk.

He did not go to find Jonas. He thought about it, at 7.50 and again at 8.10, and what stopped him was not a decision so much as the lack of a sentence to begin with. *Jonas, you've sent something to the wrong*

address would do, and it was even kind, and it would also tell Jonas exactly what Graham had seen, and Graham did not yet know what he thought about what he had seen. One did not, in his experience, open a conversation one could not close.

He went to the morning meeting instead, in the risk room with its wall of screens, and sat where he always sat. Jonas came in at 8.29 with his coffee and his laptop and the slightly pained look of a man who has been sung at by the collateral team. The card was going round. Somebody had bought a cake. Jonas gave the morning numbers: the 7am call had gone out on time and been met in full, two members had posted cash rather than securities, nothing to note. He was good at this. He said the figures and stopped.

'Good,' Graham said. 'Thank you, Jonas.'

Jonas looked at him for perhaps half a second longer than the words required. Graham was aware that he would normally have said something else: *many happy returns*, or *did you get the cake*. He let the half-second pass and asked the market-risk side for their update.

The rest of the morning was ordinary and he could not afterwards remember any of it. At one he walked out past Bank and along to the river and back, which he did when he needed to seem to be at lunch, and on the way he considered the proper route, as he had been trained to do. The item was a personal communication, misdirected. Nothing in it breached a rule that Graham could name. There was no client data in it that Jonas was not entitled to hold, as the head of collateral risk, in his head and on his screens; the question of whether he was entitled to hold it in a black notebook at home was, Graham thought, arguable, and the kind of thing an employment lawyer would enjoy. He could give compliance its answer. *Personal item, misdirected, no further action.* The analyst would close it, the head of compliance would countersign, the system would record that three people had looked at it and found nothing, and in a year nobody would look.

He also knew, walking back up Walbrook with the wind off the river

at his back, that if anybody ever did look, the record of his having read it and found nothing would sit next to the record itself, and the initials on the view would be his.

He drafted the email to Richard Haldane at 3.15 and deleted it. He drafted it again at 4.20 with the attachment and deleted that too, because he did not want the photograph in a fourth inbox. At 5.40, when the floor had thinned, he picked up the phone and called the chief executive's office on the fourth floor and asked whether Richard had five minutes, and Richard's assistant said he had until six.

Haldane's office faced west and the light was in it. He was 60, tall, better dressed than a clearing house strictly required, and he had the manner of a man who had been told a great many difficult things in his life and had found most of them to be manageable.

'Graham. Sit. What have I done.'

Graham sat. He said that an item had been held by the communications filter that morning, in the ordinary way, and passed up by compliance for his view, in the ordinary way, because it named a member, and that it was a personal message from Jonas Whitlock to himself, sent to his work address by mistake. A photograph of a page of a notebook.

'And.'

'And it would appear that Jonas keeps a record. A daily one. Of the collateral position. Specifically of instances where securities promised to us appear to be standing behind something else at the same time.'

'The thing in his memo.'

'The thing in his memo. Yes. Though the record predates the memo. It would seem to run from about a year after he joined us.'

Haldane did not move. 'How many entries?'

'The page is headed 1,399. That was Tuesday's.'

'Daily.'

'It would seem so.'

‘So, what. Three years—’

‘Three years and ten months. Roughly.’

‘In his own hand.’

‘In his own hand. With member codes, nominals, dates. And, on the page I saw, a reference to the quarterly report. By name. And my initials.’

Haldane looked at the window for a time. ‘Who else has seen this?’

‘The analyst who held it. The head of compliance, who sent it up; her note is about the member code and I doubt she looked further. And me. The system logs all three. I’ve not forwarded it. I’ve not spoken to Jonas.’

‘Good. Don’t.’

‘Richard, I rather think I ought to. It’s his birthday. He’ll have noticed by now that it never arrived. If I simply—’

‘Graham.’ Haldane’s voice was perfectly pleasant. ‘What do you suppose happens if you go down there and say, I’ve seen your diary. He says, right. He goes home. And tonight he moves it. Or he puts it on a memory stick and posts it to a newspaper. Or he does nothing, and sits there, and knows that we know, and we have learned nothing except that he knows that.’ He turned back from the window. ‘Give compliance their answer. Personal item, no action. That is what it is, and it is what they want to hear from you. Don’t speak to him about it; don’t speak to him about anything you wouldn’t have spoken to him about yesterday. I’ll make a call.’

‘To whom?’

Haldane smiled at him, which was not an answer, and stood, which was.

‘Go home, Graham. It’s Wednesday. Nothing happens on a Wednesday.’

Graham went back down to the third floor. The risk room was empty but for the screens, which went on quietly saying what the markets had done all day, which was nothing much. At his desk the alert was still

open where he had left it, the two pages of the notebook side by side, the column of gilts and the four lines about a life.

In the field marked *Business view* he typed *Personal item, misdirected, no further action required*, and he clicked.

Chapter 3

Forty

Forty. 14,610 days, counting the leap years. 1,400 of them in here.

Elsie did not sleep. That is the entry. The rest is what happened round it.

Up at 5.50. She was already awake and talking to the ceiling in the language she uses for the ceiling. I brought her down so Laura could have an hour. Fed her, failed to feed her, wore most of it. She has six teeth and uses them on spoons. At 6.40 I did what I do, which is photograph last night's page before the notebook goes in the bag, so that if the bag goes under a bus there is a copy. Typed the number in the subject. Sent it. Put the phone in my pocket and the notebook in the bag and Elsie on my hip, and Laura came down and said happy birthday into my neck and took her off me.

Walked to the station with the bag. Eight notebooks full. This is the ninth, 40 pages from the end. The eight live where my father kept his tools and I have not been to see them since March. The ninth comes with me, everywhere, and comes home. Laura calls it the briefcase, which it is not.

Work. Cake at 8.20 from the team, who sang. A card with 31 signatures. Graham's on it. *Many of them. G.* Graham himself said four words to me all day, in the morning meeting, and they were 'Good' and 'Thank you, Jonas', and he said them to the table. Normally he

asks after Elsie. I noted it and moved on. Men of 57 are allowed a day.

The 7am call went out on time and was met in full. Two members posted cash instead of gilts, which they do at month end when they need the bonds elsewhere. I know which two and I can guess where the bonds are. It is in here already, somewhere about #1120. Nothing new today. Nothing new most days. That is the point of writing every day: so that when a day is different, I will know.

Home by 6.15, which Laura had asked for and which I managed by leaving a meeting Graham did not notice me leave.

Tom and Aisha at 7.30. Tom brought a bottle that was too good for us and a card with 40 on it that made a noise when opened, and Elsie, who was meant to be asleep, heard it from upstairs and that was that for the evening's plan.

Laura had cooked. Lamb, slow, the thing she does when there is time, and there is not time, so she had made it on Tuesday night after I had gone up to write. I did not know that until Aisha asked how long it had been in and Laura said 'Since about eleven last night, in instalments' and looked at me. One look. I counted it.

Elsie came down at 7.50 in Laura's arms and sat on my knee through the first course and was passed to Aisha, who wanted her, and then to Tom, who did not, and who held her like a parcel at arm's length and asked her what she thought of the gilt curve. She put a hand in his wine.

Tom and I were at the bank together, 25 to 30. He stayed. He is something now with a title that has 'global' in it and he works four days and plays golf on the fifth, and he looks well on it. He said, at about nine, with Elsie finally upstairs and Laura standing in the doorway listening for her, 'So what is it you actually do, Jonas? Laura says you won't tell her either.'

Laura said, 'Laura says he tells her it's work.'

I gave him the short answer. People who buy and sell bonds and the things built on bonds have to put down a deposit so that if one of them goes bust the other is not left holding nothing. The deposit is called collateral. Walbrook stands in the middle, holds the deposits and decides each morning if they are big enough. I decide if the deposits are real.

'Real,' said Aisha.

'Whether the thing they've put down is theirs to put down.'

'Why wouldn't it be?'

'It mostly is.'

'And when it isn't?' Tom said. He was smiling; he had been on a trading floor for 15 years and the question was a joke.

'Then it isn't on one morning for everybody at once,' I said. 'And everybody finds out at 7am.'

'Has that happened?'

'Not yet.'

Aisha said, 'That's a strange way to say no.'

Tom laughed. 'That's him. That's the whole of him. "It mostly is." "Not yet."' He said that at the bank I had been the only man on the desk who read the footnotes, and that it had made me unbearable and probably rich, and I said it had made me unbearable. Laura did not laugh.

Aisha asked whether that was what I wrote about at night. Laura said, from the doorway, 'Work,' before I could, and went up to Elsie.

Elsie slept from 9.40 to 10.05. Then from 10.30 to 10.45. Laura went up each time and came down each time a little quieter.

At 10.50 I went up myself, because it was my turn and because I wanted to. Elsie standing in the cot in the dark with both hands on the rail. 51 weeks tomorrow. Everyone says one, and so do I. She did not cry when she saw me. She said the thing she says that is nearly 'Dad' and sat down hard, as if that settled it. I picked her up. She weighs

9.5 kilos, I would say. 9.6. She put her head in the place under my jaw where it goes and stopped moving, and she was asleep inside two minutes, and I stood there for 20 more because I know what happens if you put her down inside 20.

While I stood there I could hear them downstairs. Tom telling a story about the bank. Laura laughing, properly, which I had not heard this week. Aisha saying 'he was never like that' and Laura saying 'he was, actually, a bit', and then something I did not get.

I thought: this is what changed. I am not going to write down what, tonight. Not on this page. At 37 I wrote a paper that said three years, and I thought three years was a number. At 39 she was born. I am 40, and this is the year the number said, and she is a day short of 51 weeks and she weighs 9.6 kilos and she is asleep on me, and downstairs there is lamb.

Put her down at 11.12. She stayed down.

Tom and Aisha went at 11.40. At the door Tom held on to my hand a moment and said, 'You all right? Really?' and I said I was 40 and he said that wasn't what he'd asked.

I washed up. Laura dried, which she does not usually do; usually she goes up and I do the kitchen and come up after I have written, and she is asleep or doing a good job of it. Tonight she stood next to me with a cloth and said, when the last pan was done:

'What's in the notebooks, Jonas?'

Not angry. She asks the way she asks a patient what they drink. She has asked four times in four years and I have the dates. She said, before I could answer, 'You've had your jaw set since Tom's card went off. You do it when you're adding up.' She watches hands and jaws for a living. I unclenched it, which told her something too.

I said, 'Work.'

She said, 'You said that at 36.' She folded the cloth. 'I'm a GP. When a man tells me the same thing four times in the same words I don't

think he's lying. I think he's decided what he can afford to say.' She put the cloth over the tap. 'Happy birthday. Don't be long.'

She went up.

That is the fourth time. Her: four questions. Me: 1,400 nights. That is not a balance I would sign off.

The entry was going to end there. It does not, because of the phone.

I went to put it on charge and saw the email was still open from this morning. I had not thought about it all day. *Subject: 1399. One attachment.* I looked at it because I look at things, and then I looked at the address line.

j.whitlock. Walbrook.

Not my own. The work one. Same first letter and the phone chose for me at 6.41 this morning while I had a child on my hip, and I did not check, because in 1,399 mornings I have never had to check.

It did not arrive. I had the work inbox open all day. Nothing from me, no bounce, no error. An attachment from an outside address does not simply fail to arrive at Walbrook. It is held. Someone is sent a note that it is held, and someone opens it.

The page is the first page of the one above this. A man turning 40, summing himself in four lines. Nothing in it, and the rest of the entry runs on where the camera did not reach.

Except that I photograph the spread, both pages, because the pages face each other and the phone cannot be told otherwise. And the page facing #1399 is the end of #1398. Three lines of gilts, the member's code, the fail and the cash that covered it, where I think the bond went, the quarterly report. And the initials of the man who signed it.

Graham said four words to me today, to the table.

1,400 days. One mistake. I would like to know what it costs, and I am the only person in this house who could tell me, and I do not know.

Chapter 4

Twice

Thursday. Ordinary. I am writing that down because I want it on the page before whatever comes after it.

Up at 6. Elsie slept through, the first time in nine nights, and we lay in the dark not saying so in case it heard. Photographed last night's page, out of habit, and did not send it.

I should put down why. At ten past one this morning, after Laura had gone up, I opened the account those pictures go to and deleted all of them: 1,399 pages, every one I have ever sent myself. Someone at Walbrook has opened one picture. I could not tell whether the account was next, or whether a lawyer with an order could reach it, and a copy that someone else can read is not a copy, it is a leak. I think it was the right decision. It is also the stupidest I have made in five years, because the books in the garage are now the only copy there is, and I made them so at one in the morning without asking anyone. From today the picture stays on the phone.

The 7am call went out and was met by nine. Gilts down a little overnight, nothing to see.

Graham was in at 7.30 and said 'Morning, Jonas' from the far side of the risk room without stopping, and that was the whole of our first conversation. Neither of us mentioned the email. Two men not mentioning the same thing all day is a kind of conversation, and by the

evening I knew most of what it had said.

Priya found it at 10.20.

The check is routine. Every morning the team takes the list of securities each member has instructed into our account and lays it against what has actually settled there, line by line. A bond that has not settled is not collateral. It is nothing. It does not exist in our books until the settlement system says it has arrived, and until then the member covers the hole with cash, whether it wants to or not. So anything instructed and failed goes on a list. Most mornings the list is short and dull: a fat finger, a bank holiday abroad, a bond that matured and nobody told us. Priya does the list on Thursdays because she asked to, four years ago, and nobody has ever asked for it back.

One line. A pension fund, not a large one, a scheme for people who had worked for a chain of shops, hedging through the fund that does its hedging for it, clearing through one of our members. £42m nominal of a single gilt, the 2045, instructed into our account on Tuesday against the scheme's swaps. Failed Tuesday. Failed Wednesday. Sent again this morning, and at ten still not settled. The member had been paying cash against the hole since Tuesday afternoon, which members do not like doing for three days, and that, not us, is why the member had rung the fund.

The fund rang Priya back, which they should not do, and told her it was a timing error. The bonds were theirs. They had been out on repo and were due back at 2pm, at which point they would be delivered to us and everyone could get on with their day.

She brought me the sheet.

'£42m,' she said. 'The 2045. Instructed Tuesday, failed three times. Out on repo to a bank since last Thursday, by their own account. I asked them for their position report and they sent it, which tells you they don't know what it says.' She put it in front of me. 'There. That line is out on loan for cash, and they've promised the same line to us

against the swaps. The bank's got it, or has lent it on. We've got the member's cash and a promise. The fund has lent the bond out and promised it to us in the same breath. And they call that timing.'

'It might be timing.'

'It might. It's the second time in a month. I checked. September the 9th, same fund, same line, "timing".' She said the quotation marks aloud. 'Timing happens once.'

I read the sheet. I had read it before. Not this sheet, not this fund, but the shape of it. A bond that is always about to arrive, and a phone call that says *timing* in a voice that would like you to stop asking. I knew something about the 9th that she did not. Another member's client had failed a line that morning too, a different fund, a different gilt, the same word. It is in here. Two fails on one morning with one excuse is not two timing errors. It is a tight repo market, and two people who had lent out what they had promised.

'Again,' I said. I did not mean to say it aloud.

Priya heard it. She let it go, for then.

She came back at 2.15, because 2pm had come and gone and the bonds had not.

'Now it's half past two tomorrow,' she said. 'They've gone from timing to "operational". The member's treasurer has stopped being polite about the cash. I want to refuse the next instruction until the fund can show me the bonds are back in its own account, and I want to tell the member's credit officer that its client is instructing us bonds it does not hold.'

'Do that.'

'I'm going to. I want to understand first why you went white. You said "again" and you went the colour of the sheet. Explain it to me. Not what a repo is; I know what a repo is. Why this matters, to us, if it's one fund and £42m.'

She had the maths; more than I do. What she had not had, because

nobody has unless they have sat through one, was the morning.

I said: 'Part of the cushion we hold is bonds, and a bond has a price. When the price falls, every cushion in the building is thinner the next morning, so the call goes out to everybody at seven, and by nine the cash has to be in. On the same morning, every bank that has lent money against gilts calls its borrowers for more as well. That is the system working. That is what it is meant to do.'

'Fine.'

'Now put that fund in the picture. Its £42m is out on repo: it has sold the bond to a bank for cash and promised to buy it back. The same £42m is promised to us. Two promises, one bond, and on an ordinary day nobody notices, because nobody asks for the bond. On the morning the price falls, the bank wants more collateral or its cash back, and we want the bond we were promised, and the fund has one bond and two calls.'

'So one of you gets it and one of you doesn't.'

'One of us gets it. The other gets a promise, and promises don't count at nine. So the one holding the promise sells something to cover the gap. That pushes the price down a little more. The next morning everybody is called again, for a little more, and the fund is still one bond short.' I stopped. 'It isn't complicated. It's just arithmetic that only gets done once.'

She did not say anything for a while, which for Priya is a while.

'And if it isn't one fund.'

'Then it isn't one fund.'

'How many is it?'

'I don't have that number.'

I have a number. It is in the bag under my desk. I am not proud of the sentence and I am recording it because that is what this is for.

It is not the number she thinks it is. I have never seen a bond in two places. Nobody can: one gilt in the 2045 is the same as every other, there are thirty-odd billion of them, and our system only counts

what has arrived. What I have seen is what it leaves behind. Fails that come in pairs, at two members who have never met, on the mornings the repo market is tight. The word *timing* twice on one day. Cash paid at nine and swapped out for bonds at a quarter past three, when the repo market hands the bonds back, and the same swap the next day. Once in a while a position report nobody should have sent, with a line marked *on loan* that we were also promised. Fingerprints. I have been logging them for four years and I have drawn the chains they imply, and I cannot prove a single one, and I write that down too, most weeks.

'My parents,' she said, and stopped, and started again in her figures voice. 'My parents have their savings in a scheme that does exactly this. Not this one. One like it. They think it's safe because it's in government bonds. I didn't tell them that the bonds are out on loan half the week so that the scheme can make an extra quarter of a per cent.' She picked up the sheet. 'Write it up, you're going to say.'

'Write it up.'

'For whom?'

'Graham.'

'Graham will file it.'

'Yes.'

'Then what's the point.'

'Then it's written.'

She looked at me as if I had said something in a language she did not know I spoke, and went back to her desk and wrote it up. Two pages, sent to me at 4.50, exact and unkind and correct in every figure. I did not change a word.

Graham, the rest of the day.

He came by at 11 and asked whether the fail on the list was 'in hand'. I said it was. He said, 'Good.' He stood a moment longer than the word needed, as he had yesterday, and then said, 'Anything that

comes out of that, I'd like to see before it goes into the daily. Not after. Before.' He has never needed to ask that; I have always copied him. I said, 'Of course,' and he said, 'Thank you, Jonas,' like a man reading the name off a badge.

He left at 5.15, early, coat already on from the lift, and said 'Night' to the room.

He has asked about Elsie every working day since she was born. 255 of them. Yesterday and today, nothing. I knew what it was at midnight last night in the kitchen with the phone in my hand, and today confirmed it without a word, which is how Graham confirms things.

He has read both pages. He has done what he does, which is to tell someone, and I do not know who, and I am not going to ask. Asking tells him I know. Not asking tells him nothing. That is the only piece of this I still hold, so I am holding it.

Priya came back at 6.10 with her coat on.

'Sent it to you. Not to him. You can forward it; that's your job. How many times have you seen this, Jonas? Exactly.'

'I don't count.'

'You count everything. You counted the signatures on your own birthday card. 31; I heard you.' She was not smiling. 'You said "again" before you'd read which fund. You knew the shape of it before you knew the name. You've seen this a hundred times, and it isn't in a single report I've ever read, and I've read all of them. That's why you keep me.'

There is nothing in the handbook about what to say when someone is right.

'Fine,' she said. 'I'll write it up, and he'll file it, and you'll say, then it's written. And then I'm going to find whatever it is you're not putting in the reports. Because it's in the data somewhere, or you wouldn't look like that when a two-day fail comes across your desk. And you're

not the only one here who can read a spreadsheet.'

She went.

Entries in this record where the fingerprints say one line of bonds is standing behind two promises at once: 95, with today's. Times I have seen the bond itself in two places: none. Times it has been formally written up: twice. Once at 37, by me. Once today, by her.

She is the best analyst I have worked with. She will find it. I could save her a month by opening the bag. I have 95 entries that say what she will find, and no proof, and no answer to the question she will ask me when she does, which is why she is going to have to find it on her own.

Chapter 5

Hormuz

The telephone beside the bed did not ring. It had been chosen for that. It lit, and the light was enough.

Khalid Al-Mansouri was awake before he had read the name on the screen. It was 2.52 in the morning. He had been asleep for a little over two hours, and in the first second of waking he knew, as he had known on perhaps four other nights in his life, that the day had already started without him.

‘Sir.’ It was Nasser, his chief of staff, who did not telephone after midnight for anything that could wait until prayers. ‘A ship has gone down in the strait.’

‘What ship.’

‘A tanker. Loaded. Out of the Gulf, eastbound, about twenty miles short of the narrows.’ ‘There was an explosion a little after one. She was on fire within minutes and she has gone. The crew are in the water or on other ships. Nobody is saying yet how many.’

‘Whose ship.’

‘Flagged in the Marshall Islands, owned through a company in Athens, chartered by a trading house in Singapore, carrying crude for a refinery in Korea.’ Nasser had the figures in order already, which meant he had been awake longer than he admitted. ‘Everybody’s and nobody’s. The usual arrangement.’

Khalid sat up. The room was cool and black and smelt faintly of the sea, which was a hundred metres away beyond the glass. He put his feet on the floor and found his watch by habit.

‘What are they saying.’

‘The Americans have a destroyer on the way. The Omanis have put out a notice to mariners. The traffic is stopping.’ A pause. ‘Sir, nobody has closed the strait. Nobody has to. The ships are closing it themselves. Every owner who has a vessel in the Gulf tonight is calling his captain and telling him to drop anchor where he is.’

‘And the insurers will follow by breakfast.’

‘By breakfast,’ Nasser agreed.

‘Who did it.’

The pause this time was longer.

‘That is why I called you,’ Nasser said, ‘rather than letting you sleep.’

The car came at 3.20. The city at that hour belonged to the street-cleaners and the towers, which stayed lit whether anyone was in them or not. Khalid had dressed as he would for a working day because he did not know what else to do, and because the men he would be speaking to before dawn would notice if he had not.

In the car he watched the news on the small screen in the seat-back, with the sound low. He changed channels four times. Each time the picture was the same: a column of smoke in the dark, filmed from a long way off by someone’s telephone, and under it a line of white text. The text changed from channel to channel and the changes were the news.

The British channel said *Tanker sunk in Strait of Hormuz: cause unknown.*

The first American channel said *Attack on tanker closes vital oil route.*

The second American channel had a retired admiral in a studio in Washington, where it was early evening, and the admiral was explaining with the help of a map which navies operated in those waters, and

which of them had the means to put a hole in a ship that size, and which of them had been making statements lately about freedom of navigation. He did not say the name of Khalid's country. He pointed at it.

Khalid turned the sound off altogether and watched the man's hand.

He knew, or believed he knew, that it was not true. He knew the four men who would have had to give such an order and he had sat with two of them that week. Men who have decided to sink a ship do not spend an evening complaining about the price of a wedding. He had thought about that all the way from the house and he had reached the point, familiar from his banking years, where the only honest thing to say was: I believe this, and I cannot prove it, and the people who matter will not take my word.

The fund's building stood on the waterfront with its back to the city. On an ordinary day it was the quietest large building he had ever worked in. Tonight there were lights on three floors.

By four o'clock there were nine people in the room that the staff called the bridge, because the previous managing director had liked ships. Khalid did not like ships, particularly tonight, but the name had outlasted the man.

'Oil first,' he said.

The night desk had the number already. Brent crude was not trading in any normal sense at that hour, but the futures that traded in Asia had opened and gone straight up, and the number on the screen was the kind that would be in headlines by London breakfast. Someone gave him a percentage and he nodded and did not react, which was a thing he had learned in his twenties from a man in a trading room in Canary Wharf who had reacted, once, and never been allowed to forget it.

'Our own position in oil does not matter tonight,' Khalid said. 'The price can go where it likes. We own the ground it comes out of. What

matters is the other side. Where is our money that is not here.’

That was a larger question than it sounded, and he watched the room understand it.

The fund existed to put the wealth of a small country into the rest of the world, in the hope that the rest of the world would still be there when the oil was not. It owned airports, pipelines, hotels, a stake in a football club that embarrassed him, and a great deal of government debt. Most of all it owned government debt, because governments paid, and because the debt of the United Kingdom and the United States and Germany was the thing that every other thing in finance stood on.

‘I want a list,’ he said. ‘Every asset we hold in London. Not the summary. The lines. And against each line I want to know where it physically is: whose books, whose vault, whose name. Where there is collateral, I want to know where the collateral sits.’

‘Sir, the London desk will be in at seven their time—’

‘Then wake them. And wake Boston after that. I want London first because London is where they will think of first.’

‘Who, sir?’

Khalid looked at the muted screen, where the retired admiral had been replaced by a younger man outside a government building in the dark, holding an umbrella.

‘Anyone who needs to be seen to do something by Monday,’ he said.

The list took two hours and arrived in pieces.

Khalid read it at the long table with the lights down and a glass of water that nobody had seen him pour. The others had learned to leave him alone with paper. The sky outside had gone from black to the colour of a bruise.

Most of it he knew already, in the way a man knows his own house: the office towers held through a company in Jersey; the stake in a water utility; the loans; the shares; the sterling that moved in and

out each day through four banks on the same square mile. None of it was the problem. A government that wished to freeze a building could freeze a building, and the building would still be there when the lawyers had finished.

The problem was the bonds.

The fund held British government debt in a quantity that made it one of the largest foreign holders of that debt in the world; nobody published the ranking, and he had never wanted to be the one who did. The bonds did not sit in a vault. They sat in accounts, and a large part of them did not sit still even there. They had been lent out, pledged, posted. They stood behind the fund's own hedges, which were cleared, like everyone's, through the fund's banks into a clearing house in the City of London, and the clearing house held them as collateral against the day the hedges went wrong.

He ran his finger down the column that said *Collateral location* and stopped where the figures were largest.

Walbrook Clearing House.

He had known the name for years as a line on a quarterly report. He had never been inside the building and could not have said what street it was on. He knew, as every man in his position knew, that the clearing house was the place where the whole market's promises were netted against each other and secured, and that when people spoke of the system being sound, this was the kind of place they meant.

'In whose name,' he said, 'does Walbrook hold these.'

The head of the night desk looked at the paper. 'Through the members, sir. Three banks. Our bonds are posted in their client accounts.'

'So if someone in London decides tomorrow to freeze what belongs to us,' Khalid said, 'they will first have to work out which of it does.'

Nobody answered. It had not been a question.

He sat back. Through the glass the first call to prayer was beginning somewhere in the city, thin and far off, and on the muted screen a caption had appeared beneath the man with the umbrella: *UK Treasury:*

"monitoring the situation closely".

He thought about the word *closely*. He had spent his twenties in banks in London and Boston and had learned what the word meant in official English. It meant that someone had been woken.

'Nasser.'

'Sir.'

'I want a draft of the instruction we would give our three banks if we were to close every position we clear in London, take our collateral back and sell the bonds. The whole position. I want to know who has to be told, in what order, how fast the positions can be closed and how soon after that the bonds are ours to sell. Not what is polite. What is possible.'

The room had gone very still.

'I am not giving the order,' he said. 'I am asking what it would say. Have it on this table by the time London opens.'

'And then, sir?'

Khalid looked at the smoke on the screen. It had not moved in six hours. The ship under it was two hundred metres down.

'And then,' he said, 'we find out who did this before someone decides it was us.'

Chapter 6

Contained

Writing this in sittings. The morning first, and then the record. The rest of the day can wait until I have these down in order, because the rest of the day is why I went to Lewisham on the way home instead of coming straight back, and I want the numbers on the page before I write about the people.

Woke at 4.40. Not the alarm. The phone, face down on the bedside table, lighting the ceiling. Three messages from the night desk, one from Priya. Priya's said: *Have you seen.*

I had not seen. I lay there and read for eleven minutes before I got up.

A tanker. Hormuz. Sunk, not damaged. Oil up 14% in Asia and still going. Every channel with a different idea of who had done it and the two biggest American ones agreeing with each other, which is never good. Our own government, as of 4.51, "monitoring".

Laura asleep. Elsie asleep, for once. I dressed in the dark and did not shave. Left at 5.15.

Walbrook at 5.50. Not empty. The risk room was already at Monday strength and it was Friday, and the wall screens were all red, which I have seen before, and all red in the same direction, which I have seen twice.

Graham was in. Graham is never in before seven. He nodded at me across the room and did not come over, which he had also done all day Thursday, and I filed it under Thursday and went to my desk.

What we do at seven is this, for Elsie if she ever reads these and for no one else: every firm that clears through us has promised things to other firms, and we stand in the middle and guarantee the promises. To make sure we can, we hold a cushion from each of them, in cash or in bonds, and when prices move against a firm we take the day's loss from it in cash, that morning. The engine runs overnight and finishes before seven. At seven the calls go out, not by telephone but as an instruction to each member's payment bank, which has the money ready by eight and must confirm it to us by nine. Nine is the line. A member whose bank has not confirmed by nine is in default, and I have never seen it. Through the day the engine runs again every hour, and if a move has pushed a member over its threshold it calls again, whenever that is; there is no timetable for the afternoon, only the market. Normally the morning is a billion or so, spread across forty members, and nobody notices.

This morning the number on my screen at 6.52 was £9.6bn.

I counted the zeros. Then I counted the members above a billion. Four. One of them above two.

The reason is simple and I have written it a hundred times. Oil up means inflation up means interest rates up means the price of a government bond down. British government bonds fell further than most this morning because the pound fell with them and because we buy more of our energy than most, and whichever of those reasons is right the result on my screen was the same. Bonds down means every position backed by bonds is worth less and every cushion made of bonds is thinner. So we call for more, from everybody, at once.

That is the morning. The afternoon is what happens when they have to find it.

At 7.00 the calls went out. At 7.04 the first bank confirmed. I stood

behind Priya's chair and we watched them come in, line by line, grey to green, like a register.

By 7.40, 31 of 40.

By 8.15, 37.

Three outstanding. Two of them the ones I would have guessed. One of them not. Priya said the name of the one that was not and I said nothing, and she looked at me the way she has been looking at me since Thursday.

At 8.52 the last one confirmed. Eight minutes inside the deadline.

Met. All of it. Everyone could say so and by nine everyone was.

I went and stood at the window for a minute with my coffee, which was cold, and I thought: the system is sound. That is what sound looks like. Forty firms and every one of them found the money. If you had asked me at nine o'clock this morning whether the system was sound I would have had to say yes, and it would have been true, and it would have been the truest thing I will ever say that is also a lie.

Because I had watched where the money came from. The call is paid in cash. Always cash; nobody pays a loss in bonds. So the question is never what they paid with. It is where the cash came from, and how late. Three of the last five confirmed after 8.40, with a number they had had since seven. Nobody sits on a billion for an hour and a half. The cash was not there at seven. It was raised this morning, and on a morning when gilts are falling there is one place a firm raises a billion before breakfast: it lends out bonds for cash. Repo. The bond goes out of the door, the cash comes in and pays us, and the bond is somebody else's until it comes home.

And on our own fails list, at 8.31, one line changed. The pension fund's £42m of the 2045, failed since Tuesday, due back from repo at two on Thursday and then at half past two today, was not sent again. It was cancelled. You do not cancel a lodgement you are about to make. You cancel one when the bond has gone somewhere else. At 8.52 that member's bank confirmed, in cash. I cannot see the repo market. I

do not need to. The same gilt I had watched not arrive all Thursday had come home this morning and gone straight out again, for the cash to pay the call on the promise it was meant to be standing behind. I think. I cannot prove it. I have written that sentence a hundred times too.

Priya's check. The timing error.

The Chancellor was on the wall screens at 11.20. Sound off, captions on, the way we have it. Caroline Strand in a studio with a window behind her showing a river that was not the Thames, so the interview had been recorded somewhere else first and this was a repeat. Dark jacket. No notes. I have never seen her hold notes.

The captions said, in order:

The financial system is sound.

We have been in close contact with the Bank and the regulators since the early hours.

Margin calls this morning were met in full by every clearing member.

The situation is contained.

Then something about the election, which is in five weeks, and the interviewer trying to get her to say the word *crisis* and failing, four times. I counted.

Met in full by every clearing member. That was us. That sentence was our morning, on television, with the Chancellor's face in front of it, three hours after the last payment cleared. Someone had rung someone by nine. I looked for Graham and he was in his glass box with the door shut and his back to the room.

Richard Haldane came down at noon, which he does perhaps twice a year, and walked the floor shaking hands. He shook mine. He said, 'Good morning, Jonas, well held,' as if I had been in goal. He did not stop. I have thought about that handshake several times today and I will come back to it.

I left at 6.10 and went to Lewisham.

The lock-up is a row of nine garages behind the railway arch, and my father's is the sixth. The rent still comes out of my account on the 3rd and I have never changed the name on the agreement. Laura thinks I go there to sit with his things, which is true about one visit in ten.

The current notebook comes home with me every night. The other eight live here, in a steel toolbox on the shelf my father put up, under a strip light that takes two tries. I opened it tonight for the first time since the spring.

I did not need to look for the entry. I know the number. I have known it for three years. I took down the second notebook and found #212 and I sat on the upturned crate and copied it out, word for word, into tonight's entry, because I want it in front of me where I write, and I will not bring the old books into the house. This is what I wrote, 1,190 days ago, when I was 36 and the record was still a hobby:

> #212
>
> Second time. Two members, same morning, both failed a lodgement in the same line. Both told me timing. Both used the word "timing" without being asked. Both covered the hole in cash at nine and both swapped bonds back in at ten past three, within four minutes of each other, which is when the repo market gives the bonds back.
>
> Not fraud. Nobody is lying. Each of them has a piece of paper that says the bond is theirs tonight, and each piece of paper is honest. I think it is one bond, going round. I cannot prove that. Nobody can; one gilt is the same as the next and we only count what has arrived.
>
> It does not matter on a normal day. On a normal day nobody asks for the bond, they ask for its value, and its value can be in two places at once. It matters on the day everyone asks at once. Then the bond is in one place and the

> other promise is backed by air.
>
> I don't know how many times it has happened. I know it was two today. If it is two it is more than two.
>
> The sign to watch for is not a failure. A failure is too late. The sign is a call that is met, but only just, with cash that was not there at seven, and bonds that arrive in the afternoon and are gone again by the next morning, and the bonds are the ones you have seen before. The system will look soundest on the morning it has already broken. Everyone will have paid. Nobody will have the bond.
>
> Write this down every time. Nobody else is counting.

That is #212. I have not changed a word.

I put the book back in the box, and the box on the shelf, and the strip light off, and I stood in the dark of the garage for a bit with the trains going over.

Three of the last five paid with cash that was not there at seven. One lodgement cancelled at 8.31, for a bond I had watched not arrive all Thursday. The call met with eight minutes to spare.

I wrote the morning down three years and three months ago, before I had seen it. I got one thing wrong. I thought I would feel vindicated.

Then I came home. Laura and Elsie were out, and I sat down at the kitchen table with this before I had taken my coat off, because I wanted #212 copied in while I could still see the strip light. The rest of today is the people, and what happened between the handshake at noon and the lock-up at six, and I will need another sitting for it, because at four o'clock this afternoon Graham Pryce asked me for my personal notes.

Chapter 7

Not yet

Second sitting. Past eleven. Laura has gone up. The people now.

After Haldane's handshake I went back to my desk and I did what I should have done at nine. I pulled the morning apart.

Priya had already started, unasked. She had the forty calls in a sheet with three columns she had added herself: when each member's bank confirmed, to the minute; what that member had lodged into its cushion, or swapped out and back, in the five afternoons before today; and whether any of those bonds had been on a fails list this week. The third column was the one that mattered and she had filled it in by hand, from Thursday's list and from memory, because the system does not keep that column; it does not think anyone would want it.

She turned her screen towards me without a word. Seven lines in the third column said *yes*.

Seven. Out of forty. Not one.

'Thursday was one,' I said.

'Thursday was one fund and one check. This is everyone, on a bad day, in a hurry.' She said it flat, the number first, as she does. 'Seven members paid this morning after half past eight, with cash they did not have at seven. All seven have had bonds going in and out of their cushion all week: failing in the morning, arriving at three, gone again by the next run. Those bonds are financing something else by day. This

morning they lent them out again to pay us. I can't see the repo. I can see what it leaves. If Monday is worse than today, and it will be, those seven have to raise the cash again on bonds that are already out, and whoever has the bonds will be calling too.'

'How much.'

She told me. I am not writing the figure here because it is hers and because it was too small; she had only counted what she could see. I wrote the figure I thought was right underneath it, on paper, and she looked at it for a while.

'You've done this before,' she said.

'Yes.'

'Not this week.'

'No.'

She did not ask the next question. I said, 'Put it in a memo. One page. Numbers, no adjectives. Address it to Graham and copy me. I'm going to take it upstairs at half one.'

'He'll say not yet.'

'Then I'll have it in writing that he said it.'

Graham's room at 1.30. The door closed, which he never does. He had the one page in front of him and had read it; the corner was turned down where he had gone back to the top. Graham reads everything twice. It is the best thing about him and it slows him down by exactly the amount that matters.

'Seven,' he said.

'Seven that we can see.'

'This is a bad day, Jonas. Bad days look like this. People raise cash where they can.'

'They raised it on bonds that are already standing behind something else.'

'You think.'

'I think. It is what the pattern says.'

He said, ‘What are you asking for.’

‘Formal notification to the Bank this afternoon. Under our own obligations, not as a favour. That we have identified a pattern consistent with collateral being re-used across seven members, that it is material, and that we expect Monday’s call to be larger than today’s. Our number for Monday. And a request that they look across the other clearing houses and the repo market, because we can only see our own leg of it.’

‘You want me to tell the Bank, on the Friday afternoon of the worst day since—’ He stopped before he named a year. ‘You want me to tell them that Walbrook’s collateral is not sound. On a pattern.’

‘I want you to tell them what we know.’

‘Simon Carrow rang me at nine this morning,’ he said, and he said it to the page. ‘From the Treasury. He wanted the number for the morning call, and whether it was met, and he had it in the Chancellor’s mouth within two hours. If I send this upstairs at two o’clock it is in Carrow’s inbox at two fifteen and in a Cabinet briefing by four and on the front of a newspaper by Sunday with a photograph of this building, five weeks before an election, and nobody will read your assumptions.’

‘Then they’ll read them on Monday afternoon.’

‘Not yet,’ Graham said.

I waited. He has said *not yet* to me perhaps thirty times in five years and it has never once meant *later*.

‘Let’s see Monday,’ he said. ‘If Monday is what you say, we go together, with the day’s figures. If Monday is a bad day that passes, as they do, as they have, then we have not put Walbrook’s name in a report that cannot be withdrawn.’ He put his hand flat on the page. ‘I’m asking you to take this offline until then.’

I said, ‘Graham, you filed the last one.’

I had never said that to him. He went a colour I have not seen on him and did not answer, and I took my copy of Priya’s page and went out, and did not close the door behind me, because he never does.

At 2.10 I filed it myself.

There is a route. It exists for exactly this and nobody uses it, because using it is the end of your career at whichever firm you use it from. The Bank of England supervises us, and the law names the Bank as a prescribed person for clearing houses: a disclosure made to it is protected, which means they cannot lawfully sack you for making it, and that is the whole of the protection. There is no special door for people like me: same page, same address as for a clerk at a building society. I had bookmarked it when I was 37, the week after the memo went in and nothing came back, and I had never opened it since.

Priya's page. My figure for Monday underneath, with the assumptions. Four paragraphs that I wrote in eleven minutes and did not reread. My name, my title, my direct line. The time stamp said 14.21.

I did not tell Priya. I should have. She would have put her name on it and I did not want her name on it, and I am aware that is the same reasoning Graham uses about Walbrook.

Then I went back to work, because the two o'clock run would call again if the move held, and Monday does not care who I have written to.

At 3.40 the collateral database would not open.

I tried it twice. Then I tried the margin engine. Read-only. Then the member files: present, but the account-level view was gone, so I could see that a firm had paid and not what with.

The help desk said that a change had been applied to my profile at 15.32 at the request of the chief risk officer's office, and would I like a ticket. I said no.

So that was nine minutes. A disclosure went to the Bank at 2.21, and at 3.32 my access was cut to what a graduate gets on his first morning. An hour and eleven minutes. The Bank does not ring a firm to say who has written to it. Somebody rang somebody.

Priya had watched me try the database three times. She came round the desk without asking and stood behind my chair.

‘Move,’ she said.

I moved. She sat in my chair, logged me out of what was left, and logged in as herself. She opened the account-level view, the one that had been taken from me, and pulled the report I had been going to pull: forty members, how each had paid, what each had lodged this week. She sent it to the printer.

‘You didn’t see this,’ she said.

I let her. She put the pages face down on my desk and went back to her own chair, her face the colour it goes when she is angry, which is not red.

The system will have logged it. Her login, my desk, that report, at 3.46 on the afternoon my own entitlements were cut. I knew that while she was doing it and I did not stop her. I would not have done it myself; I know what that line looks like in a log, and who reads logs. I let her do it for me. I am writing that down plainly, because it is the first thing in four years I have let someone else do that I would not, and I want the date on it.

At 4.00 Graham came to my desk. Not his room. Mine, in the open, where Priya could hear. He stood beside my chair and looked at the screen, which was showing a login error, and he did not look at me. In five years he has always looked at me.

‘Richard has asked,’ he said, ‘and I’m passing this on as it was given to me, Jonas, so take it as that. Richard has asked that any personal notes relating to Walbrook’s business be made available to him. Any notes, in any form, kept anywhere. He’d like to see them on Monday morning.’

‘Personal notes.’

‘Those were the words.’

‘Whose words.’

He did not answer that. He said, ‘It’s a request. For now it’s a

request,' and he went back to his glass box and shut the door and sat with his back to the room.

Priya said, very quietly, 'What notes.'

I said, 'Work,' which is what I say to Laura.

Here is the thing I did not understand until 4.35, at a desk that no longer worked. I want it down exactly, because I will later pretend I had worked it out sooner.

Personal notes. Not *reports*, not *analysis*, not *files*. Haldane does not know the word *notebook* and he does not know the word *record*. He knows that something exists that is personal, in note form, about Walbrook's business, and he has known it long enough that the request was ready before my filing was an hour old. Graham, formal all Thursday, in at 5.50 this morning. Haldane's handshake at noon, *well held*, a half-second too long.

They did not learn this today. They learned it on Wednesday, at 6.41, when the phone chose the address for me. I wrote that night that someone had opened it. I did not know who.

I opened my sent items at 4.37. My mail still works; it is the only thing that does. The spread. #1399 on the right. On the left, the end of #1398: three lines of gilts, a member's code, a line promised to us that failed for two days, the cash that stood in for it, where I thought the bond had gone. Graham's initials on a quarterly report. The word contained.

So they have the first page of one entry and the tail of another. The page tells them my age. The tail tells them what the books are for. Together they tell them the thing that matters: that there are 1,398 others, and that someone has been counting.

That is what Graham's four words on Wednesday were. That is what the request at four o'clock was. That is why I went to Lewisham tonight, and why the old books stay there.

And one more thing, which I did not see until I had written the rest

down. Carrow had our morning number by nine. The Chancellor had it by eleven. My filing went in at 2.21 and my access was gone by 3.32, and Haldane's request for my notes was ready and worded and in Graham's mouth by four. Walbrook does not move at that speed.

Whose words, I asked Graham, and he did not answer. I think he did not answer because the answer is not Richard Haldane.

Chapter 8

The study

The room had no screens. Visitors noticed, and Sebastian Crane enjoyed watching them notice: the glance to the walls, the second glance, the small adjustment as they understood that the man who ran Greywether Capital did not look at prices. There were two chairs, a desk with nothing on it but a telephone and a fountain pen, and a window onto a street in Mayfair quiet enough that he could hear a parking warden's shoes. Prices were for the floor below. He paid 31 people to watch them. He had found, over 25 years, that people who watched prices all day could not see them at all.

The telephone rang at 4.55pm and he let it ring twice.

'Anthony.'

'You'll have seen the day,' said Sir Anthony Pell.

'I'm told it was eventful.' He had seen the day. British government bonds down hard at the open, a stagger back at lunchtime when the Chancellor went on television to say the word "contained", down again when New York woke up. Sterling as expected. Oil doing what oil did when a strait closed. Greywether had been positioned for exactly this since the spring, and the day had paid for the building. He felt about it as he felt about weather. 'How was the board?'

'Richard took us through it at a quarter past four. Twenty minutes, by telephone. The margin calls were met.'

‘Just, I hear.’

A pause. Pell did not ask where he had heard. ‘Just. That isn’t why I’m calling.’

‘No,’ Crane agreed, and waited. He had known Anthony Pell for 30 years, since a dinner neither of them remembered, and in all that time Pell had never once said anything quickly.

‘There’s a man in Richard’s risk function. Head of collateral. Whitlock. He went over Pryce’s head this afternoon, straight to the Bank, with a paper saying the collateral in the system is pledged several times over and a sharp enough move would show it.’

‘Is it?’

‘Sebastian.’

‘I’m asking what the paper says.’

‘The paper says what a man like that would say. Richard says it’s a model, and models say things. That isn’t the point either.’ Pell’s voice dropped, as if the boardroom had followed him into his car. ‘He keeps a diary. Pryce found out on Wednesday, by accident, some nonsense with an email. Every day, for four years, by hand. What he saw in the collateral, who he told, what they said back. Richard’s phrase was “where the bodies are buried”.’

Crane looked at the wall where a screen would have been.

‘Four years,’ he said.

‘Nearly. Pryce says about 1,400 entries.’

‘And Richard would like to have it.’

‘Richard would like it not to exist. He has asked the man for any personal notes relating to the firm’s business, as if it were a matter of policy. He’s narrowed the man’s access. He has told the board that we are managing it.’ Pell gave the phrase the exact weight it carried in meetings. ‘Pryce has a friend at the Treasury. Carrow. I gather the Chancellor’s office was told on Wednesday evening, which is why I’m telling you tonight and not next week. I didn’t want you hearing it from her.’

‘Caroline doesn’t call me any more, Anthony. I’m a donor. One hears from donors at Christmas.’

‘Well. Now you’ve heard it from me.’

‘I have,’ Crane said, ‘and I’m grateful. Go home.’ He put the telephone down and sat for a moment with his hands flat on the empty desk.

Greywether’s position was large and it was right, and he had spent the summer explaining to investors that right was not the same as paid. A short was a bet that something would fall. The money came when it fell, and only then, and the timing was everything. He knew that the British government’s bonds were worth less than their price. He knew the pound was carried on a confidence it had not earned. He knew that somewhere under the clearing houses the same bonds had been promised to too many people at once, so that when the first promise was called, the others would find their hands empty. What he did not know was where. Which member bank would be first to fail. Whose collateral was thinnest. On which morning. He had been guessing, expensively, for six months.

A man who had written it down every day for four years had not been guessing. He had a map.

Crane opened the desk drawer and took out the mobile phone he kept there, which had one number in it.

‘Mr Crane.’

‘Dana. Are you busy?’

‘I’m at work.’

‘There’s a man at Walbrook Clearing House, near Bank. Jonas Whitlock. Head of collateral risk. He keeps a diary. By hand. About four years of it.’

‘And you’d like to read it.’

‘I’d like to own it.’

‘Where is it?’

‘If I knew that, I’d have sent a courier.’

Kessler said nothing for a moment. He heard, faintly, a keyboard. ‘Herne Hill,’ she said. ‘Married to a doctor.’ It had taken her perhaps fifteen seconds.

‘How long do I have?’

‘Markets open on Monday. Before then would be elegant. Before Sunday night would be useful.’

‘Then I start now. I’ll have someone outside his building within the hour, and I’ll look at the house, and at anything else with his name on it. Most of what people think is hidden is on a public register for a few pounds. You’ll hear from me when there is something to hear.’

‘And not how.’

‘You’ve never wanted to know how, Mr Crane.’

‘No,’ he said. ‘I’ve never needed to.’

He put the phone back in the drawer and closed it. Below him 31 people were watching prices, and the prices were going his way, and he found that for the first time all day he had stopped being interested in them.

Third sitting. Past midnight. I said the rest of today was the people. There is one more thing, and it is not people.

Left at 6.10. Wrote that already. Didn’t write how I got to Lewisham, because I wanted #212 down first and because by the time I sat down I had half decided I’d imagined it.

A man in a grey jacket on the far side of the street when I came out. Noticed him because he wasn’t looking at his phone. Everyone else was.

Bank. From Bank I take the DLR to Lewisham, straight through, no changes, I could do it asleep. He came down the escalator 15 steps behind me. So I didn’t take the DLR.

Northern line, southbound. He got in the next carriage. London Bridge: I got off, stood by the map, let the doors beep, got on, got off again. He didn’t.

His face through the glass as it pulled out. Nothing on it. That's what I keep coming back to. A man who had missed his stop would look annoyed.

Up and out and round to the mainline side. The 7.02 to Lewisham. Looked back nine times. Nobody. By the time I had the strip light on at the second try I had decided he was a man in a grey jacket going to Borough. London is full of them.

If I had got on the DLR he would have stood in the dark of that garage with me, with the trains going over, and watched me open a steel toolbox.

Home from Lewisham by a way I'm not writing down. 8.20. Laura had texted at 6.40: at Aisha's with Elsie, back by nine. House dark. Locked, front and back. Kitchen table, coat on, #212, first sitting. Laura and Elsie home at 9.20, Elsie asleep in the car seat with her mouth open. Laura went up with her. Second sitting. Then I went up too.

I went up because of the last line of the second sitting. If the answer is not Haldane, I wanted the acknowledgement. Three years ago the Treasury sent one. Two lines and a reference number, no name. It is in the folder for that year, right-hand drawer of the desk in the study. First floor, back. I keep things where I can find them in the dark.

I know what that room looks like the way you know your own hand. I leave the chair out, at an angle, because nobody else sits in it. It was pushed in. Square to the desk.

Left drawer: three pens, the chequebook, Elsie's red book, the house insurance. Front to back, in that order. Still in that order. Chequebook the wrong way up. Right drawer: folders by year, oldest at the front. Someone had put them back in order. Just not mine. Bookshelf: fine. The box of Elsie's photographs on top of the cupboard: lid on, straight. I never get the lid on straight.

Window catch down, the way I leave it. Nothing forced. Someone had a key, or didn't need one.

Nothing missing. Counted twice. The acknowledgement was where it should be. Two lines. A number. No name.

Then the bottom of the right drawer. The spares. A box of six, same make, black, A5, hardback, the kind with the elastic, still in the plastic. It lives under the folders. It was on top.

So now they know the shape of the thing. Black. A5. Hardback. And not here.

Eight full ones. Never in this house. Not for one night. They are in a garage with my father's name on the agreement, not mine; the rent goes out of my account and nothing else of mine touches it. Number nine was on my back, in my bag, on the Northern line, with a man in a grey jacket looking at it through the glass.

Put the chair back at its angle. Turned the chequebook over. Lid on crooked. Came down and stood in the kitchen with the light off and my hands on the counter until I could feel them. That is where I am writing this.

Laura is asleep. When she came in at 9.20 she looked at me and said, 'You look like a patient,' and I said long day, and she looked at my hands. She does that: looks at what the hands are doing while the mouth talks. I put them in my pockets. Which is not what you do if you're fine. I know that. She knows that. I had not been near the study yet, and she had already seen it on me.

I haven't told her. Reasons, in order. One: she would want the police, and the police would ask what was taken, and I would say nothing, and they would ask what someone wanted, and I would have to say. Two: she would ask what is in them. Three: I would have to tell her that it was not the first lie. "Work" was the first lie. I have been telling it for four years, one word at a time.

Who. Graham. Haldane. The board, because that is what boards are for. Carrow, since nine this morning, and whoever Carrow talks to. On Wednesday morning the number of people who knew the record existed was one. Me. It is Friday. I can't count them any more. That

is the first time I have written that sentence about anything.

One more thing. Then I'll stop.

They came between 6.40 and 8.20. Laura is home every Friday evening. Every one. Tonight was the first Friday in months she wasn't, and she decided at six, and she texted me at 6.40, and they were already on their way.

They knew when the house would be empty.

They weren't watching me. I was on a train with the one they sent for me. They were watching her.

Chapter 9

Withdrawal

Khalid Al-Mansouri had slept for two hours and did not feel the want of it. He had been in the room the staff called the bridge since five, and he had not been alone in it. The Western news channels ran on the far wall with the sound off, and he found he could follow them well enough from the maps and the faces. The map was the same on all of them: the Strait, a red mark where the tanker had gone down, and to one side a coastline he had grown up looking at from the other direction. The faces changed. Overnight a senator in Washington had used the word “freeze”. A British minister had said that no option was ruled out, and the woman who hoped to replace her in five weeks had said that was not good enough. By the time the sun was fully up, a man on an American business channel was explaining to his viewers how much of the British government’s debt was owned by “the regime”, and getting the figure wrong by a third.

His own government had not sunk the tanker. He had asked, through the channels one asks, and been told no. He had been told no before about things that turned out to be yes. But the men who told him this time had been frightened, and in his experience frightened men were rarely lying. It was possible they were wrong. He set that aside. It changed nothing he had to do today.

He had taken two calls before dawn from men whose names he

would not have written down, with two opposite instructions, and had told each that he was studying the matter. That was true. He had been studying it since Thursday night, when he had asked for a list of every asset the fund held in London and where its collateral sat, and had found the largest line to be a clearing house in the City of London called Walbrook.

The list lay on the long table now, under his hand, and beside it the draft he had asked Nasser for on Friday morning: the instruction the fund would give its three clearing banks, who had to be told, in what order, and how fast it could be done. He had read the draft four times. He had the figure by heart and did not care to say it aloud.

It was not complicated. The fund held British government bonds in quantities that made it one of the largest foreign holders of that debt. A great part of them were lodged as collateral, through the three banks that cleared for the fund, against its own hedges at Walbrook, where they secured promises the fund had made to other people. As long as the bonds sat in London they were safe from everything except London. And London, this morning, was discussing on television whether to take them.

He knew what freezing meant. The money would not vanish. It would be there, exactly where it was, and untouchable, for as long as it took the lawyers of three countries to agree on who had sunk a ship. He had seen it done to others. It took years. He had one client, and he had promised that client, in a room he could picture precisely, that its wealth would never be hostage to anyone's foreign policy, including its own.

Moving too slowly lost everything. Moving too fast cost a great deal. The market knew he was there. If the fund sold at Monday's open, it would sell into a market that had watched the same channels he had, that knew he had no choice, and that would price his lack of choice to the penny. He had worked at a Western bank in his twenties and remembered how it felt to be on the other side of a seller who had to

sell. It had felt very good.

And there was the other thing. The thing he understood and most of the men on the television did not.

He could not simply take his bonds. There was no one to give notice to and nothing to wait for; that was the part the men on television had wrong in the other direction. The positions the bonds secured had to be closed first, and closing them was a matter of the banks trading them away, which cleared the same day, and the collateral behind each position came back the morning after. Nasser's draft said the whole book could be gone inside the week. What he could do today was give the instruction: so that on Monday morning Walbrook, and every bank that cleared through Walbrook, would know that the largest line in the book was leaving. If Walbrook's own man was right, those bonds had been lent and borrowed and lent again. Every bank that had used them to back a promise of its own would find, on Monday, that the bond it had borrowed was being called home, and would have to find another, in a market where everyone was looking for the same thing. He thought of it as a man asking for his coat at the end of a party and discovering that four other guests were wearing it.

It would not be his doing. He knew that it would be his doing.

At 10.20 Nasser came back in and closed the door, which in that room meant that the nine other people in it stopped pretending not to listen. Al-Mansouri gave him the shape of it, for the desks that would carry it out. Instructions to the three clearing banks today, to be acted on from Monday's open. Positions to be closed in order of size. Collateral to be withdrawn as it came free. Bonds to be sold as they came back, in London and then in New York. Proceeds to be settled anywhere that was not London or New York.

'The banks will warn the clearing house today,' Nasser said. 'They are obliged to, and they would anyway. The clearing house will tell the Bank of England, and the Bank will tell the Treasury. The British will see the instruction before the market does.'

‘Yes.’

‘And the market will see it by tonight. Three banks on a Saturday, sir. Three compliance departments, three sales desks. Nothing that passes through that many hands on a weekend is still a secret by Monday.’

‘No.’

‘They will call.’

‘They will call,’ Al-Mansouri agreed. ‘Put it in final. Do not send it until I say.’

Nasser went. Al-Mansouri read the instruction when it came back, changed one word, and put it face down on the list. Then he sat with his hands folded and watched the smoke on the far wall, which had not moved since Thursday night. It occurred to him that it was the only thing in the world that had not.

The call came at 11.40. Nasser said, ‘Mr Crane, from London,’ and waited. Nasser had been with him seven years ago. He knew the name.

‘Put him through.’

‘Khalid.’ Crane’s voice came down the line unhurried, warm, as if they had spoken the week before. ‘It’s been, what, six years?’

‘Seven.’

‘Seven. I’m sorry about the circumstances. I imagine your morning has been long.’

‘It has been a morning.’

‘Then I’ll be brief, for both our sakes. You’re going to sell. Everyone with a television knows you’re going to sell. When you do, you’ll be selling to a market that knows you have no choice, and it will charge you for the privilege in a way you won’t enjoy. I’m offering to take your gilt position off your hands tonight. All of it, or as much of it as you can free. Quietly, in one piece, settled wherever you like. At a price.’

‘What price?’

Crane named it without hesitation, as if he had carried it around all morning in his pocket. It was steep. It was, Al-Mansouri judged,

about where the market would be by Tuesday afternoon, which was the point.

‘That is not an offer,’ he said. ‘That is a forecast.’

‘It’s both. That’s what makes it fair.’

‘You would then hold a very large number of bonds you believe are about to fall.’

‘I’d be hedged, Khalid. I’m a cautious man.’

‘You were not cautious with my money.’

A pause, and the smallest change in the warmth. ‘That was a long time ago, and the fund was up when you left it.’

‘The fund was up,’ Al-Mansouri said. ‘I did not leave because of the fund.’

Crane let that go by, which was itself an answer. ‘Think about it for an hour. You’ll get a worse price from anyone else, and you know it, and I’m the only buyer who will still be a buyer on Monday. You know what your order will do to that clearing house.’

‘Yes.’

‘Then take the money and let it be someone else’s weather.’

‘No,’ Al-Mansouri said.

‘No to the price, or no to me?’

‘You have always found it difficult to tell those apart, Sebastian.’

He put the telephone down. He sat for a moment with his hand still on it, and considered how much Crane had already known before dialling: the position, the collateral, the morning’s conversations in two capitals. More than a man in Mayfair ought to know. He filed that away, in the place where he kept things about Sebastian Crane, which was not a small place.

Then he turned the instruction over and read it once more.

What he was about to do would be called, by Monday evening, the act that broke a clearing house, and by the following week the act that broke a government, and he would be named in both accounts and in neither would he be wrong. He had one client. He had been given one

duty. He had been told, by people whose only interest was in keeping the money where it was, that there was nothing to fear, and he had been hearing the word “freeze” since midnight.

He signed it at 12.14 and gave it to Nasser, and watched him carry it out of the room.

Then he picked up the telephone again. ‘The Chancellor’s private office, in London,’ he said. ‘Tell them it is not urgent.’ He paused. ‘They will know that it is.’

Chapter 10

The memo

Graham rang at 11.10am. Saturday. He has never rung me on a Saturday.

'They want you at the Treasury at four. Horse Guards Road. Bring your pass. Bring nothing else.'

'Who's they?'

'Everyone, Jonas.'

Laura was taking Elsie to the park. I said I had to go in. She said, 'On a Saturday,' not as a question, and then watched me put the ninth notebook in my bag, the way she has watched me do it 1,400 times, and said nothing, which was worse.

Train from Herne Hill to Victoria. Walked the rest, across the park. Sky the colour of a screen that has been turned off. The building is a long stone thing with a courtyard in it, and the man at the desk knew my name before I said it. Visitor's lanyard, red. Bag through the scanner. Nobody looked twice at a black notebook. Why would they.

Third floor. A room with a long table and a view of the park and nothing on the walls. Eight of us, including me.

The Chancellor at the head. Caroline Strand. Smaller than on television, and stiller. Simon Carrow on her left, who Graham has mentioned over the years the way you mention a cousin. The Governor of the Bank of England, who I had seen on television and who is shorter

in a room, and a woman from the Bank's supervision side, which for us is the regulator, so that was two chairs and one institution. Richard Haldane. Graham, as far from me as the table allowed. A young man with a laptop who was not introduced at all.

Strand didn't thank me for coming. 'Mr Whitlock. Richard, if you would.'

Haldane: at 2.06pm the first of the three banks that clear for the fund I don't name here, and never have, had rung Walbrook to warn it of an instruction it had received that morning. The other two rang within the half hour. Nothing formal. There is nothing formal to give; a client tells its banks to close it out, and the banks do it. Carrow, not looking up: the fund's chief had rung the Chancellor's private office himself at twenty past ten that morning, which is why we were all in the room before the banks had finished typing. Line one. Positions to be closed from Monday's open, in size order. Collateral back to the fund the morning after each close. Bonds to be sold as they came back. All of it.

'I'm told you are the person who can explain what that means,' Strand said. 'In terms I can use.'

So I did. The thing I have written 1,400 times, out loud, in one go, to a Chancellor. It took less time than I thought.

The fund has lodged a very large quantity of government bonds with us, through its banks, as security for what it owes. The bonds are real and they are ours while they are with us. What I cannot see is what else they are doing when they are not. For four years I have logged the signs: a bond promised to us that fails to arrive, because it is out on loan, and the member says timing; two fails on the same morning from two members, both saying timing; a call paid in cash at nine and the cash swapped for bonds in the afternoon, when the loan market has given the bonds back; position reports members should never have sent us, showing the line they lodged with us out on repo the same week. From those I infer that the collateral behind this sys-

tem is financing more than one promise at a time. It works as long as nobody asks for the bond back. On Monday the largest holder in the system asks for its bonds back. Everyone who was using them has to find others, that morning, from a market where everyone is looking for the same thing and prices are falling. The ones who can't find them, we call, in cash. The ones who can't pay, fail. And when a member fails, their losses are ours.

'How many promises,' Strand said. 'Behind one bond.'

'I don't know. Nobody in this room knows. I can see the fingerprints. I can't see the hands.'

'So you cannot prove it.'

'No.'

She let that sit. 'How much, on Monday?'

'I don't know. My access to the collateral ledgers was removed yesterday afternoon.' I didn't look at Graham. 'Mr Haldane can tell you.'

Haldane said numbers were being run. Someone on my team is running them, then. I hope it's Priya. I hope it isn't.

Strand looked at Carrow. Carrow opened a folder, took out a document and slid it across the table to me. Six pages, stapled. He did it the way you pass the salt.

Walbrook letterhead. My name. A date, three years ago, nearly to the month. "Collateral re-use in cleared markets: a note on concentration and horizon." Below it, in a sentence I could have recited: "On current growth in re-pledging, the author estimates that the system has approximately three years before a moderate shock becomes unmanageable."

I was 37. I said about three years. I wasn't far out.

Top right, a stamp: RECEIVED, HM TREASURY, and the date, a week after I wrote it. Below it, in biro, a set of initials I didn't know and two words: "Noted. File."

'We have had this for three years, Mr Whitlock,' Strand said. 'You will understand, then, that nobody at this table needs the problem

explained to them. We need it solved.'

I turned the pages. My tables. My footnotes. Someone had underlined "approximately three years" in pencil, lightly, as if they might want to rub it out.

Graham was looking at the window.

'Before Monday's call reaches the banks,' Strand said, 'Walbrook will issue a statement.' Carrow passed a second sheet. Treasury paper, two paragraphs. Walbrook's collateral arrangements are fully sound and adequate to all foreseeable conditions. 'The Bank will issue one alongside it. I will say the same on breakfast television at 7.20. The withdrawal of one participant is being managed in an orderly way.' She said "orderly" without a flicker. 'The statement is signed by Richard, by Mr Pryce as chief risk officer, and by you, as head of collateral risk. I need the signatures by six.'

'Why me?'

'Because yesterday afternoon you made a protected disclosure to the Bank saying the opposite, and by Monday someone will have told a journalist that you did.' Not unkind. Exact. The Bank does not name who files with it. It did not need to; there is one head of collateral risk at Walbrook. 'If the man who raised the alarm signs the all-clear, there is no story. If he doesn't, the story is him, and a story about a man is easier to run than a story about collateral.'

'Is it true?'

'I'm sorry?'

'The statement. Is it true?'

She looked at me for exactly as long as it took to decide I had meant it. 'Mr Whitlock, the system is held up by the belief that it is held up. That is not cynicism. It is the mechanism. If the Chancellor and the clearing house and the Bank say on Monday morning that the collateral is sound, and nobody credible says otherwise, then the banks post their margin, the fund sells into a market that still exists, and the collateral is sound. If we say anything else, it isn't. You of all people know

which of those two mornings you would rather have.'

Then the other thing. She did it in the same voice.

'I understand you have kept personal notes over some years relating to Walbrook's business. Those notes contain market-sensitive information about named institutions. The Treasury would like them lodged here, for safekeeping, until the situation has stabilised.' 'Richard's view is that they are in any case Walbrook's property; it is in your contract. I'd rather not test that. I'd rather they were safe with us than reported stolen from the clearing house. I think you would too.'

Haldane looked at the table. Graham looked at the window. The woman from the Bank looked at me as if I were a number that hadn't come in yet.

'I'd like the night,' I said.

'You have until six on Monday morning, Mr Whitlock. That is more than the night.'

'Then I'd like the night first.'

Strand considered that and found it was arithmetic. 'Simon will give you a number,' she said. 'Use it before you need to.'

Carrow gave me a card. The young man with the laptop stopped typing.

I asked if I could keep the memo. Carrow said it was a copy. I said I knew it was a copy, and he looked at Strand, and she nodded, and I put six pages and the statement into the bag with the ninth notebook, and nobody in the room knew that they were sitting a foot apart.

Then Carrow took one more sheet from the folder and turned it to face me. A confidentiality undertaking. One page, "pending the review", my name already typed under the line. Would I sign that now, at least, before I left the building. I said I had asked for the night. He said it covered only the fact of this meeting. I said then it covered the night as well. He waited. I did not pick up the pen. He put the sheet back in the folder without a word, squaring it with the others, which is how I know it mattered.

Lift down. Graham in it with me, because he had to be. Three floors of nothing. Then, to the doors: ‘I filed it, Jonas. I filed it and I told you I’d filed it, and you went home and wrote it down.’

‘Yes.’

‘Every day. For three years.’

‘Four.’

He didn’t say anything else. The doors opened.

Home 6.30. Laura had made supper. Elsie threw peas. I ate what was in front of me and could not have told you what it was. Laura asked how the Treasury was. I said big. She said, ‘You’ve got your hands in your pockets again,’ and went to run the bath.

Now. Kitchen table. Memo on the left. Statement in the middle, two paragraphs, a line for my name. This on the right.

Count. Three years I have been right and quiet. Six pages they have had the whole time. One signature they want, on one page, before 6am Monday. One set of notebooks, nine, eight in a place they have not found and one on this table. Thirty-one hours.

What I don’t know. Whether Strand is right that saying it makes it so. She might be. It has worked for 400 years. Whether Priya has the number yet, and what it is, and whether anyone will let her say it. Whether “reported stolen” was a threat or a kindness. Both, I think. That is how Strand talks. Whether the sheet I didn’t sign was Carrow’s idea or hers.

I went through the memo again, slowly, because I didn’t trust what I’d seen under the stamp with seven people watching.

The stamp and the biro are grey. It is a scan of the paper they received, printed out again, and along the foot of every page the printer has put what printers put: a file reference beginning with a T, a username that is not a name, and the date and time it came off the machine. 19.14.

Wednesday. This Wednesday.

#1400. My birthday. A day and a half before a tanker went down

in a strait that most of them couldn't find on a map. The morning Graham opened an email that wasn't meant for him.

They didn't pull my memo because the market fell. They pulled it before anything had fallen at all.

They weren't getting ready for a crisis. They were getting ready for me.

Chapter 11

Monday's number

I asked for the night. I was given it. This is what it was worth.

Slept 1.10 to 5.40. Lay still until Elsie started at 6.05, so that Laura could have the half hour. Made the bottle. Sat on the kitchen floor and watched Elsie post a wooden ring into a saucepan and take it out again. 23 times. She did not tire of it. I envied her that.

The statement was on the table where I had left it on Saturday night, between the memo and Carrow's card. Two paragraphs on Treasury paper. Walbrook's collateral arrangements are fully sound and adequate to all foreseeable conditions. A line for my name. They want it by 6am tomorrow, so that it can go out before the morning's calls reach the banks. I read it again with Elsie on my knee. It had not improved overnight. Nothing does.

I am writing this at the kitchen table at twenty past three in the afternoon, which is not when I write. I am writing early because I do not know where I will be tonight. In order, then. The record is only any use in order.

9.52. Priya.

I knew it would be bad because she did not say hello. She said a number.

'Twenty-two point four.'

'Billion.'

‘Yes, Jonas. Billion. That’s the morning run. Initial and variation, every member, every currency, if gilts open another four points down. Which they will, because the fund’s banks start closing it out at eight and everyone in the market has heard what three banks were told on a Saturday.’

I said nothing. She had not finished.

‘I don’t have their cash. Nobody in the building has their cash; that’s theirs. I’ve got what we’ve got: the liquidity ratios they publish, our own credit scores on them, and four years of what time each of them paid us. That last one is the only honest number in the building. The ones who can pay by nine can pay fourteen, maybe fifteen, between them. The gap is seven. If it’s six points instead of four, the gap is eleven. And one member is short on its own by two point eight before anyone else gets into trouble. I’m not saying which one on a phone. You know which one. It pays late every bad day. It was in the last three on Friday.’

I did know. Everyone on the third floor knows which one, and nobody says it, and that is a sentence I could have written in any of the last 1,400 entries.

‘Walk me through the fund,’ I said. I wanted to hear whether she had it.

She had it. She said it in one breath. The Gulf fund has told its banks to close it out. From Monday’s open the biggest cushion in the system starts coming out, and the market knows it, so the market sells first. Then the fund sells its bonds, and the price of every bond everyone else has posted to us goes down, so everyone has to post more, in cash, at the same hour, and they raise the cash the way they raised it on Friday, by lending out the bonds they have just told us are theirs. And the bonds are already out. That is what the fails mean. That is what the pairs mean, and the cash at nine that turns into bonds at three.

‘I can’t prove it either, Jonas,’ she said. ‘I’ve got what you’ve got. A shape. It took me all night to see the shape, and it should not have

been possible for me to see it in one night and for nobody to have said it in four years.'

That was when the number stopped and the rest began.

'You weren't surprised on Thursday.'

'No.'

'I went back through the exceptions reports. Four years of them. The pattern's in every quarter. Your initials on every sign-off. "Monitor." That's the note. Monitor. You've been monitoring this like a man monitoring a gas leak from the garden.'

'I wrote a memo.'

'When?'

'Three years ago.'

She was quiet for the length of a breath. 'Who to?'

'Graham. The Treasury.'

'And then?'

'Then I monitored.'

I heard her put something down. A mug, a pen. 'Graham asked me on Friday whether you kept personal notes. Diaries. I told him I didn't know what he meant. I do now, don't I. You've got it all written down somewhere and you've been reading it to yourself at night like scripture.'

I did not answer that because it was accurate.

'Everything my parents have is in a fund that clears through the member I'm not naming,' she said. 'Everything. By Tuesday it's an argument between lawyers. So this is what I'm doing. I'm sending the figures to the Bank's whistleblowing address the moment I put the phone down. And I'm sending them to Rhys Calloway.'

I knew the name. Financial correspondent at one of the nationals. The pensions piece last year. He rings Walbrook twice a year and is told that everything is fine, and prints it with the word "insists".

'Don't send it to Calloway yet.'

'Why not?'

‘Because once it’s out you can’t—’

‘Can’t what? Monitor it?’

She hung up. 9.59. Seven minutes.

I rang back at 10.20. Six rings, voicemail. 10.41, the same. I texted: *Ring me. Please. Not to argue.* At 11.05 it did not ring at all. Straight to the recorded voice. A phone switched off, or run flat, or in a bag in a car, or at the bottom of the Regent’s Canal. I counted the possibilities and stopped at four, because after four they are all the same possibility.

Laura was in the doorway with Elsie. ‘That was Priya.’

‘Yes.’

‘On a Sunday.’

‘I need to go to her flat.’

She looked at my hands, which is what she does instead of looking at faces. I do not know what they were doing. ‘Go, then,’ she said. She did not ask what was wrong. Four years ago she would have. I noted that, and noted that I was noting it instead of answering, and went for my coat.

Herne Hill to Blackfriars, 11.41. Circle line to Liverpool Street. Central line one stop. 51 minutes door to door, which on a Sunday is not bad. I counted stations because it was something to count.

Somewhere under the City, on the Circle line, with no signal, I took out Carrow’s card and looked at it and put it back. Eighteen hours to six. I had not rung him. I had not decided not to. I noticed that those are the same thing and that I have spent three years pretending they are not.

I have been to the flat once before, two winters ago, to drop off a laptop when she had flu and would not stop working. Second floor of a conversion on a street of them. I remembered the door because it is the only blue one.

The street door was on the latch. A man came out with a bicycle as I reached it and held it for me. Thirty-two stairs. I know because I counted them going up and again coming down and the number was

the same both times, which was the only thing that day that behaved.

Her door was shut. I knocked. I said her name twice, at a normal volume and then louder. Then I tried the handle and it turned and the door went in.

I stood on the mat and said her name a third time.

It is a small flat and she keeps it the way she keeps a spreadsheet. The radiator was on. Nothing was broken. Nothing was on the floor. In the kitchen, on the table, three stacks of printouts squared off at the edges, her handwriting down the margins in two colours. The top sheet of the middle stack had been torn across and the lower half was missing. A laptop charger plugged in at the wall with nothing on the end of it. Two mugs on the draining board, both tea, both cold, both unwashed. Priya washes up as she goes. I have watched her do it at work with a plastic cup.

The bed was made. She had not slept. The bedroom window was shut. Her coat was on the hook by the door, the long grey one she wears to work. No bag. No keys on the hook where the coat was. No phone.

I stood in the hall and rang her. Nothing rang in the flat. I listened for a long time, longer than the ringing lasted, as though a phone might start up late.

I thought about it the way I think about a collateral chain, which is the only way I know. A person who leaves with her keys and her bag locks the door behind her. A person who is taken does not get to. A person who leaves in a hurry to meet a journalist might not get to either. The two mugs fit two of those and not the third, or fit all of them if she had a visitor at seven in the morning. I could not make the facts choose.

I photographed the table. The three stacks, the torn sheet, the charger. I did not touch the papers. Then I noticed that I had been careful not to touch the papers, and I stood for a moment with that. Four days ago I was a man who photographed his diary. Today I was

a man who thought about fingerprints in a colleague's kitchen.

I wrote *Ring me. J.* on the back of a receipt from my pocket and left it on the top stack where she would see it if she came back, and where anyone else would see it too. I considered that and left it anyway.

I pulled the door to behind me. It would not lock. I had nothing to lock it with. I left it as I had found it and went down the thirty-two stairs.

The street was ordinary. Sunday. A woman across the road under the plane tree was drinking a coffee and looking at me, and when I looked back she did not look away.

Chapter 12

The offer

She crossed the road when I reached the pavement. Not quickly. She finished the coffee and put the cup in the bin on the corner first.

'Mr Whitlock. My name is Dana Kessler.' She did not offer a hand and did not offer a card, not then. 'I'd like ten minutes. There's a café on the corner, or we can walk. I think you'd rather walk.'

I would rather have walked. I did not like that she knew it.

Mid-forties. Dark coat, flat shoes, no bag, hair tied back. Nothing you would describe to anyone. She spoke the way a good anaesthetist speaks, which is Laura's phrase: quietly, in full sentences, so that you do not notice you are being told what will happen to you.

'Have you been up there?' I said.

'No.'

'Have your people?'

'I'm going to talk about you, Mr Whitlock. Not about anyone else. Shall we?'

We walked towards the park. It was 12.51. Families, dogs, a man selling balloons on the corner by the gates. I counted eleven children between the flat and the first path, because I was already counting them before I knew why.

'I act for a client,' she said. 'He would like to acquire your notebooks. All of them. Today.'

'Which notebooks?'

'Black. A5. Hard covers, the kind with the elastic. There's a box of six in the bottom of the right-hand drawer of your desk at home, still in the plastic, same make. I'm assuming the used ones match. You strike me as consistent.'

So that was Friday. I had known it was Friday. It is different to be told.

'Nine, I'd estimate,' she said. 'One every five months or so, if you write a page a day. I may be out by one.'

She was not out by one.

'My client would pay three million pounds. In any form you find convenient. Sterling, another currency, an account in a name of your choosing, or you can have it in a holdall if you'd like to feel it, though I'd advise against. Today. Before nine this evening.'

She said three million the way Laura says a dosage. No weight on it. A number that was correct for the patient.

'For notebooks.'

'For time. My client has people who could work out what you've worked out. It would take them a month. He doesn't have a month. From what I gather, nobody does.'

I did not mean to ask who the client was. I asked anyway. 'Who is he?'

'Someone who'd like to know what you know, and is prepared to pay for it rather than take it. I'd dwell on the second half of that.'

A woman went past us with a pushchair and Kessler stepped off the path to let her by, and watched the child go for half a second longer than she needed to. I noticed that because I was noticing everything. I do not know what it meant.

'Where is Priya Raman?' I said.

She did not stop walking. 'I told you I'd talk about you.'

'She's not at her flat. The door was open.'

'If I told you I didn't know where she was, you wouldn't believe me.

If I told you I did, you'd believe that, and I'd rather not be responsible for what you did next. So I'm not going to say either. That's not me being clever, Mr Whitlock. It's me being careful with you.'

I have been in a room with the Chancellor of the Exchequer and the Bank of England this week and nobody has frightened me as much as a woman declining to answer a question in a park.

'The money is the easy version,' she said. 'I want to be plain about that, because you're going to go home and think I was threatening you, and I'd like you to remember that I wasn't. I'm describing. Your wife walks to the surgery on Mondays, Tuesdays and Thursdays. Dulwich Road, along the park, Brixton Water Lane, in by quarter past eight. She drops your daughter first. Brambles, on Half Moon Lane. They open at half past seven and your wife is usually there at ten to eight, because she likes to be early and she likes to be the one who takes the coat off.'

She said all of it in the same voice as the three million. A woman reading a timetable aloud. No emphasis anywhere, which is where the emphasis was.

'I'm telling you so you know how much I know,' she said. 'Not for any other reason.'

'You've said my daughter's name.'

'I've said your daughter's nursery. I haven't said her name and I'm not going to.' A pause. The first one she had taken. 'I would very much prefer you took the money. I'd like you to understand that as a preference and not as a tactic. It is the outcome I want. It's the outcome you want, if you think about it with anything except the part of you that's been right for four years.'

We had come round to the gates again. She stopped and I stopped.

'This is how it goes,' she said. 'Today I ask. You say no, because you're going to, I can see it. You go home. You think about your family, which you should. At some point this evening you make a decision. If it's the one I'd make, you ring the number on this card before nine,

you tell me where, and somebody comes and collects nine notebooks and you never see or hear from me again. You'll be surprised how completely.'

'And if it isn't.'

'Then I stop asking.' She took a card out of her coat pocket. Plain white, a mobile number, nothing else. 'I don't enjoy the next part, Mr Whitlock. That isn't a moral position. It's untidy and it's expensive and people remember it. But I'm paid to get to the end, and I do.'

I took the card because not taking it would have been a gesture, and she was not a person you made gestures at.

'You should know,' I said, 'that the Treasury asked for them yesterday.'

She did not look surprised. I do not think she can. 'And what did they offer?'

'Safekeeping.'

'Then you've had two offers in two days for the same nine books, and one of them was free. I'd think about what that tells you about their value.' She looked at her watch, a small plain one on the inside of her wrist. 'Ten past one. You've got until nine. Theirs is six tomorrow morning, I believe. Mine comes first. Go home.'

She walked away towards the station and did not look back, which I know because I watched her the whole length of the road. At the corner a man in a grey jacket who had been reading his phone outside the newsagent put it in his pocket and went the same way, thirty yards behind her. I had seen a grey jacket on Friday, on the far side of a street and then through the glass of a train. I cannot say it was the same one. I cannot say it was not. I had been looking at children.

I stood by the gates for some time. I do not know how long. I did not count it.

Central line, Circle line, Thameslink. The same 51 minutes in reverse. On the train I took out the card and looked at the number, and then I took out my phone and looked at Priya's number, and I under-

stood that I was checking whether they were the same, and that I did not want to know. They were not. That proves nothing. I know what proves nothing. It is my job.

Somewhere past Elephant and Castle I did the sum she had told me to do. Three million is the house, cleared, four times over. It is Elsie's education and Laura never working a Saturday again and my father's garage rent paid until I am dead. It is also what a man who has been positioned for a collapse would pay without noticing, to be told which morning. I know what a position like that is worth when it comes right. I have cleared them. Three million is the change.

The house was empty. Laura had taken Elsie to Aisha's for the afternoon; there was a note on the table under the statement, which she had moved to write it. She will have read it. It is two paragraphs. *Back by 5. Eat something.*

I ate something. I do not know what it was.

Then I sat down here, at the kitchen table, with this notebook, and I began to write the day, in order, because I did not trust myself to remember it correctly by tonight and because I did not know where I would be. That was twenty past three. It is now ten to four.

I have Kessler's card on the table in front of me. I have the statement next to it, and Carrow's card on top of that. Two telephone numbers and a line for my name. Any one of the three would be the end of it. Nine books in a garage in Lewisham, three million pounds, the Chancellor's gratitude, a quiet Monday. I have added it up four times. It keeps coming out the same, and I keep not believing the total, which I have told junior analysts for ten years is the first sign that the total is correct.

Laura will be back at five. Elsie will need her tea. I have not decided what to tell her.

I have decided that she is leaving tonight. There is a bag open on our bed that is not mine.

Chapter 13

The lock-up

Top deck of a 47, going north. 11.48pm. The bag is between my feet with a foot through each strap. My left trouser leg is wet to the knee, the right knee is torn, and the back of my hand is bleeding. I am writing the rest of the day because it is the only part that matters, and because if I stop writing I will have to think.

Laura came back at 5.10. The bag was on the bed. I had put it away once and taken it out again.

She looked at it and then at me and said, 'Sit down. You're grey.'

I sat on the bed and told her what I had decided to tell her, which I had rehearsed and which came out in the wrong order anyway.

That there are people who want my notebooks, and that they had been in the house on Friday while she and Elsie were out. That today a woman in a park had told me which road Laura walks down and the name of Elsie's nursery. That Priya had rung and been angry and then stopped answering, and her door had been open and she had not been behind it. That I wanted Laura to take Elsie to her mother's tonight, tell nobody, and not come back until I rang.

She asked the questions a doctor asks. Short ones, in order.

'What's in the notebooks?'

'A record. Of what I've seen at work. Numbers.'

'Four years of numbers.'

'Yes.'

'Who are the people?'

'I don't know. She works for someone. She wouldn't say who.'

'Are we in danger, or are you?'

'I don't know.'

'That's not an answer, Jonas. That's a result pending.'

'It's the one I've got.'

'Why not the police?'

I gave her the answer I had, which is that I did not know what I would be reporting, and that the people who had wanted the notebooks on Saturday were the government. I did not say it well. She watched my hands the whole time. I put them under my thighs eventually, like a boy.

She did not argue. She said, 'All right,' and started putting Elsie's things into the bag on top of her own, properly, nappies at the bottom and the thing Elsie needs first at the top, and I stood in the doorway and was no use. I had wanted the argument. I had been ready to lose it.

She rang Margaret and said they were coming up tonight, a change of plan, nothing wrong, and listened, and said, 'I'll tell you when I'm there.' She did not look at me while she said it.

7.50. Elsie in the seat, half asleep already, the rabbit in with her. Laura in the driver's door with the keys.

'You'll ring at eight.' Not a question.

'Yes.'

'If you don't ring at eight I'm ringing the police and telling them everything you've told me and everything you haven't, and I'll be guessing the second half.'

'Yes.'

She looked at me for a count of about three. Then she said, 'Four years,' and got in and shut the door. I watched the car to the junction. Brake lights on, then off. 7.53.

Dark coat, walking boots, the empty rucksack from under the stairs. 8.31, the P4 from Herne Hill. It is the long way to Lewisham and it is the way nobody would expect, because nobody takes the P4 anywhere by choice.

Nine o'clock came somewhere past Brockley. I waited for the phone to go, and it did not. Nobody rang to ask whether I had decided. That was when I understood that the asking was over, as she had said it would be, and that silence is what the next part sounds like.

Lewisham, 9.34. Ten minutes to the arch. Nine garages behind it, my father's the sixth, the rent still going out on the 3rd in his name.

A car at the mouth of the row, lights off, nobody in it. Nothing. There are always cars.

The padlock, the key, the door up on its springs with the noise it has made since I was fifteen. The phone for light, not the strip light. His bench. His crate. The smell, which is oil and cold brick and him. The steel toolbox on the shelf he put up. Eight black books in it, in order, dates on the spines. Into the rucksack, one by one, counting. The ninth was in my coat. Nine. I had never had them all in one place before, and I stood there and thought about it, which I should not have done. A train went over.

I pulled the door down and that was when the headlights came on.

At the end of the row, pointing at me, the car not moving. And at the same moment, from the direction I had come in by, a shape at the mouth of the row that was a person standing still, which is the one thing a person does not do at a quarter to ten on a Sunday behind a railway arch.

I would like to write that I did something. What I did was drop the padlock, and bend to pick it up because it was my father's, and then understand what I was doing, and leave it. It is still there.

The row is a dead end. Between the last garage and the arch wall there is a gap I know about because I was once fifteen, and I am no longer the width I was at fifteen. I went in sideways with the bag held

in front of me. The coat caught and I heard it go. Something on the brick took the back of my hand. The person at the mouth of the row was walking now, not running, which was worse, and the car door had opened.

On the far side there is a chain-link fence and then the footpath down to the river, and I went over it the way a 40-year-old man who sits at a desk goes over a fence: I got to the top, and then I was on the ground on the other side with no clear memory of the middle. The knee went then. I got up. I checked the bag before I checked anything else, and I am not proud of the order.

The Ravensbourne is not much of a river and the path along it is not lit. I ran along it in the dark with the water on my left and my breathing so loud I could not hear whether anyone was behind me. I went down a concrete slope without meaning to and in to the knee, and the cold was the only thing that stopped me.

Footsteps on the road above. One set. Not hurrying. Then a car, slow, on the road beside the path, its lights going through the trees, stopping, going on.

There is a road bridge over the water a little further down. I got under it and sat on the ledge with the bag in my lap and my back against the brick, and I counted. To 300, four times. The car came back once. The footsteps did not come at all.

10.21. I came out and walked. Not ran. Back streets to Deptford. I did not look behind me, because looking behind is what a man does who is being followed, and I wanted to be a man walking to a bus.

The 47 came at 11.17. I am on it.

I cannot go home. They have been in the house, and the house is where a man goes who has notebooks and nowhere else. I am going to try to be a different man for a night.

I did not sign. I did not ring either number. Nine went past and I let it, and six is coming, and I will let that go too. I have nine books in a bag that smells of my father's garage, a wife driving north who gave

me until eight and meant it, and a colleague who has not answered for fourteen hours.

11.52. Wellington has been open for two hours. Sydney opens in eight minutes. Tokyo an hour after that. I do not know the number yet. Priya knew it this morning. I hope she is somewhere she can watch it come true.

She stopped at the services before Newmarket because Elsie woke and would not settle, and sat in the car park for the best part of an hour with the engine off, feeding her, watching a lorry driver eat a sandwich, and not ringing anyone. Past Thetford the road went into the forest and there were no lights except her own.

Elsie had gone under before the M11 and had not stirred. Laura had tilted the mirror so she could see her: mouth open, head to the left, the rabbit's ear across her face. Breathing fine. She checked anyway, every few minutes.

She took a history, because that is what you do when you do not know what is wrong. Presenting complaint. Onset. Course.

Wednesday: his birthday. After Tom and Aisha had gone he had sat down to write at the kitchen table before she was up the stairs, and in the morning he had the face he has after writing, which is the face of a man who has put something down. Friday: she had come home at twenty past nine and he was at the kitchen table in his coat, writing, and he had said long day and put his hands in his pockets. She had not thought: someone has been upstairs. Saturday: a meeting, on a Saturday, in a suit, and back at half past six, grey, in a different shirt, which means he had sweated through the first. He had said 'work' on Wednesday and 'work' on Saturday and 'work' every night for four years, and she had stopped asking because the answer did not change, and she saw now that she had taken a stable reading for a healthy one.

Sunday: the call at breakfast and his hands. Then a woman in a park, a road, a nursery. Then a bag on the bed and his hands under

his thighs.

What he had told her she could count on one hand. What he had not: what was in the notebooks; who the people were; why the government had wanted them on Saturday, which he had let slip and not explained; why not the police. She had asked that one straight and watched him not answer it.

She ran it as a differential. He had done something, and these were the consequences. Or he had found something, and someone wanted it kept quiet. Or he was ill, and none of it was real. She held the third one honestly for a mile and set it aside: he had been grey, not flushed; slow, not fast; and a man inventing a threat does not pack his daughter's nappies at the bottom of the bag.

Which left the first two, and from here she could not tell them apart. That was the finding. Everything she had, she had on his word. She had seen her husband sit on a bed and tell her to leave, and she had gone, with a child, into the dark, on four years of 'work'. The shape of what she had not been told sat in her like a mass under the skin: you can feel the size of it long before you know what it is.

Eight o'clock. He had said eight. She would give him until eight and not a minute past, and then she would stop being the kind of person who could be sent to Norfolk.

Midnight. She put the radio on, low, for the news, because it was something to do with her hands.

The pound had fallen sharply in early Asian trading. The market in Sydney had just opened, lower, and Tokyo would follow within the hour. The Chancellor would make a statement before London opened. There had been, the newsreader said, in the voice they use for the weather, unconfirmed reports concerning a London clearing house.

Laura had never once heard the words of his job on the news. She turned the radio off and drove.

Chapter 14

The open

Monday. Written in sittings, at a café table and then a bench, not a desk. First time in 1,405 entries. The handwriting will show it.

I did not sign.

That is the whole of the decision and I want it on the page before anything else, because by tonight there will be other versions of it. I did not sign, I did not reply, I did not hand anything to anyone for safekeeping. The phone rang 23 times between midnight and six. Treasury switchboard, nine. Graham, six. Haldane's office, four. Four withheld. None from Norfolk.

The night bus put me down at London Bridge around midnight. I am not writing where I spent the hours until 5.41, except that I spent them awake, with the rucksack between my feet. I had the rucksack on both shoulders, the way you carry a child's bag, and I walked up through the City in the dark because the City in the dark is the one place a man with a rucksack looks like he belongs. Cleaners. Night staff going home. Nobody looked.

At 6.30 the statement went out. I read it on the phone, standing outside a shuttered sandwich shop. Walbrook Clearing House confirms that its collateral arrangements are fully sound and adequate to all foreseeable conditions. Richard Haldane's name at the bottom. Not mine. They had wanted the head of collateral risk to say it and they

had settled for the chief executive, which tells you what they thought the head of collateral risk would be worth by lunchtime.

At 6.52 I tried the staff door.

I don't know why. Habit. Four years and 11 months of walking in that door. I wanted to see whether the number on the screens matched the number Priya gave me yesterday, and the only screens that would show it were on the third floor. I put the pass to the reader and the light went red. I tried it again. Red. The guard behind the glass looked at his screen, then at me, and reached for his phone, and I was back on the pavement before he had finished dialling.

So that is how I learned. Not a letter. A light.

The café opposite opens at seven and has a television above the counter. I took the table under it, back to the wall, rucksack between my feet, and ordered a coffee I did not drink.

7.04. The ticker along the bottom of the screen: Walbrook issues record margin call.

For anyone who finds this and does not know what that means. Every night Walbrook works out how much more each of its members must put up to cover what they owe. The result is on our screens from about seven, it reaches the members' banks by eight as a direct debit, and it is paid by nine or the member is in default. Usually it is a sum nobody outside the building hears about. This morning the Gulf fund's banks were closing it out from the open, and London had known since Saturday night that they would, so the bonds everyone else had posted to us were worth less than on Friday before a trade had printed. And if I am right about what I have been writing in these books since entry #212, those bonds were already doing more than one job each. If. I have never been able to drop that word. So the call was the largest in Walbrook's history. The ticker did not give the number. I did not need it. It is in yesterday's entry, in my handwriting, as Priya gave it to me down the phone. I am not writing it twice.

7.20. Breakfast television. The Chancellor from the Treasury courtyard, coat buttoned, no notes.

She was good. I want to record that. ‘The system is sound. Walbrook confirmed this morning that its collateral arrangements are fully sound, and the Bank of England stands ready to provide liquidity as required. I would caution your viewers against giving any weight to irresponsible claims from a disaffected individual.’ The interviewer asked which individual. She said she would not dignify it.

Disaffected. Four syllables. I said them under my breath and the woman at the next table moved her bag.

I have made no claims. I have made one disclosure, on Friday, to the Bank of England, through the route the Bank provides for exactly that. If that is a claim, I was irresponsible to use the right form. Unless she meant Priya. Priya said she would send the number to the Bank and to a journalist, and then she stopped answering her phone, and somewhere between those two facts there may be a newspaper that has it. I do not know. That is the point. I am sitting in a café learning what is happening to me from a ticker.

7.58. The ticker again. A clearing member tells Walbrook it will not pay, and Walbrook declares it in default an hour ahead of the deadline, on its own word.

I knew the name. Everyone in the building would know it. One of the five largest. I am not writing it down because by the time anyone reads this it will be in every paper, and because I do not want it in my hand.

Then the thing I have described a hundred times happened on a screen above a coffee machine. A member fails to pay. Walbrook declares the default, takes over the member’s book and starts hedging it: selling what that book needs sold so the hole stops growing. The auction of what is left comes days later, and the market does not wait for it. It knows which way Walbrook has to sell and it sells first. The price goes down, so every other member’s collateral is worth less, so

Walbrook calls them again, intraday, and by nine there is a second call on top of the first, and the first is not yet paid.

The pound was down about 5% against the dollar by eight. Gilt futures kept hitting their limits: a minute's hold, a wider band, another hold, so that the screen went grey every few minutes and came back lower. By half past eight the three biggest banks' shares had been thrown into auction so many times that the ticker had stopped naming them and started counting them.

I watched it the way you watch weather you forecast. No satisfaction in it. I had wanted to be wrong. I wrote that in entry #1 and I have not changed my mind.

Eight. I had said eight. I had the phone in my hand at 7.58 when the ticker said a member had failed, and I watched that instead, for 17 minutes, because it was the thing I have waited four years to see and because a man who counts everything can still fail to count the one thing he promised. I know what Laura said she would do at eight. I am writing it down so that I cannot pretend later that I forgot.

8.15. Graham.

A text, not a call. He has never texted me in five years. "Walbrook has reported theft of confidential material to the police. They want to speak to you. Don't come in. I'm sorry. G."

Theft. The books are mine. Bought with my money, written in my hand, in my own time, kept on my father's property. There is not one line in them copied from a Walbrook system. There are numbers I knew because of my job, and that is what they will say. They will say it was the firm's confidential material and I took it off the premises, and they will say it this morning, loudly, because by lunchtime the question everyone is asking will be why Walbrook did nothing and the answer they want on the record is that a man stole the evidence.

I'm sorry. G. Graham has been sorry for three years. He was sorry when he filed the memo.

8.31. Thirty-one minutes late. I rang Laura. It rang out. I rang again and got her voice telling me to leave a message. I did not leave one, because I did not know who would hear it. I rang her mother's landline. Margaret's phone rang 14 times. Nobody picked up. It was half past eight on a Monday in a village near Norwich and there was nobody in the house.

I rang Priya. Not voicemail. The number you have dialled is not available. Priya's number was available at 9.52 yesterday morning when she called me and read me the figure and told me what she thought of me. It has been not available for 22 hours.

Then I did what I should have done at midnight, which is think about the phone. The woman outside Priya's building knew the route Laura walks to the surgery and the name of the nursery. Her people found the lock-up. I have told myself since Friday that the garage is in my father's name and on no form of mine. It is on the one form that matters: his probate, which I applied for, which names me as executor and names the garage, and which anyone with his surname and sixteen pounds can read. That is what she can do: read. I do not know what else she can do. But it is not only her now. Graham's text says the police want me, and the police do not need to guess where a phone is. They ask, and the network tells them. I turned it off, wrapped it in a paper napkin from the counter, and put it in the inside pocket of the rucksack with the notebooks. Then I paid for the coffee and left, because the police had my name and the building was 200 yards away.

I will not write down how I got here. I have learned something about writing things down.

Here is a bench on a hill. From it I can see the towers where the money is, and I have been watching them all day for signs, which is stupid, because a bank in default looks exactly like a bank in credit from four miles off. The sun is on the glass. Office lights on. Lifts going up and down. Somewhere inside, screens that would tell me

the number, and I cannot see one of them.

People have passed the bench all day. I counted 60 before I stopped. Dog walkers, a school party, two runners, a man in a suit at 11 in the morning with his tie in his pocket, not looking at anything, who may have been the first of them or may just have been a man. Nobody has looked at the rucksack. Nobody knows that it is Monday for them yet. It will be Monday for them tomorrow, when the cash machines are slow.

Nine notebooks. I counted them twice on the bus. Black, A5, in order, the ninth with about 35 blank pages left. Three years, ten months and five days of evenings. Laura has asked four times in four years what was in them, and I said work, and I have been thinking all day about whether that was a lie. It was the truth. That was the problem with it.

Her client. I keep writing that. She never gave a name and I have not got one for her, so her client is what he is. I know three things about him. He wanted the books badly enough to pay, which means he did not have the map on Sunday. He wanted them before the open, which means he wanted to know where to push. And whatever he holds, he is short, because nothing else about his week makes sense. Every tick down on that screen in the café was a payment to him. He has been paid every minute since seven this morning, and he is being paid now, as I write, and he still does not have the map. That is the one thing I own that he does not.

Elsie. I don't know if you will read this. If you do, this is the day it came true, and I was on a bench.

2.35pm. I turned the phone on for three minutes, by my watch, to see New York.

New York opened, fell 7% and stopped for a quarter of an hour, as it is built to do. The ticker said so and then I did not read the ticker any more, because the phone had 41 missed calls, and one message, from a number I did not know, timed 11.02.

"Mr Whitlock. The offer stands until the London close. It is smaller now, for reasons you will understand better than most. After the close it is not an offer. D.K."

I turned the phone off.

She is right that I understand it. The map is worth less every hour the thing it maps is burning. By Friday it will be a history book. She knows that, and so does her client, so I have until 4.30 to be worth paying for and after that I am only worth stopping.

Nine notebooks. Four years. Ninety-four minutes.

I have started reading them from the beginning.

Chapter 15

Cash

Second sitting. A room with a bed, a chair, a television bolted to the wall and a window onto a yard. Monday night. Same number as the bench, because it is the same day, whatever it feels like.

4.30 came while I was in the first notebook. I looked at the watch at 4.21 and then I was at entry #41 and it was 4.52. I did not decide to let the deadline go. I read through it. I want that down honestly, because later I will want it to have been a decision.

So the offer is not an offer. She said so, and she is a woman whose sentences come true.

Cash first. £300 from a machine on a street I am not naming, at 3.40: the daily limit, and a mark on a map for anyone who asks the bank. I knew that when I put the card in. Then I walked for twenty minutes in the wrong direction before I turned round. It felt less like a film than like being late.

Then the phone. Not mine; mine is in the napkin in the inside pocket and it is staying there. A shop on the road up from the station sold me a phone with buttons and a SIM for £31 in notes and asked for nothing. No name. No card. I have known for twenty years that you can buy a telephone in this country without saying who you are and had never once thought about what that was for.

It is not going to ring Laura, or Margaret's house, because of the thing I understood this morning: the police do not need to find my phone. They need to find any phone that rings hers. They ask the network, and the network tells them. So this one does not ring Norfolk. That is a rule. I am writing it down so that at two in the morning it is still a rule.

The hotel is on a street behind King's Cross, in a row of them, each with a star rating in the window that nobody could have awarded. The man at the desk wanted £65 for the night and a name, and wanted the first more than the second. The name was not mine. I had never in my life given a false name to anyone, and it cost nothing. That bothered me more than the room.

The rucksack is on the bed beside me. Nine. I counted them when I came in and again when I got the television to work.

The news at six, then at ten, with the rolling channel in between because I could not stop. Three things I did not have this afternoon.

One. The member is named. The newsreader said the name I have not written, twice, and a man outside its building said it a third time. People were coming out of the doors with boxes at six in the evening. The man with the grey hair and the plant was the head of their collateral desk, who paid us late on every bad day for four years and rang me once, on a Friday, to say timing, and I wrote it down. I did not know he had a plant.

Two. The pound. There is a number on the screen against the dollar and I have no price for it. I have traded sterling and cleared it and I have a sense in my body of where it goes on a bad day, and this is not that. The man from the bank in the studio said nobody alive had traded it at this level, and he was not being dramatic, he was reading a chart. The Chancellor is "monitoring the situation closely". That was the whole of the Treasury's contribution to the ten o'clock news. Monitoring. Priya's word for what I did for four years, and now the

government's word for what it is doing tonight. I would like it on the record that I noticed.

Three. Me.

Not my name. Not yet. "A senior employee" of Walbrook Clearing House. Walbrook has obtained an interim injunction and an order for the delivery-up of "documents containing confidential information", from a judge, by telephone, on Sunday night. The order was served on Monday. They did not say where. I know where. Some time today a man in a suit stood on a step in Herne Hill with an envelope and nobody came to the door.

Sunday night. While I was under a bridge counting to 300, a judge was on the telephone to Walbrook's lawyers, and Graham, or Haldane, or both, had sworn to something. Graham signs things.

And the word. Theft. The newspaper fronts at ten, held up to the camera: THEFT. CLEARING HOUSE "THEFT" PROBE. One had "£bn" and "theft" in the same line, as though I had taken the money. Nobody in a wig said it. The judge made an order about documents. Walbrook's statement said "unauthorised removal of confidential material". The police "want to speak to" a senior employee. That is the whole of the legal content, and the word on every front page is the one none of them used.

I know why. A man who took something is a story. A clearing house that filed something is not.

I turned it off at 10.31.

The payphone is at the end of the road, by the station. I must have walked past it a hundred times, going to trains. It takes coins. I had £4 in coins.

9.15. Margaret's landline. Four rings and Laura picked up, which I had not prepared for, because this morning it had rung 14 times into an empty house.

'It's me.'

Nothing for a count of two. Then: 'Where are you?'

'London. I'm all right. Are you—'

'Where in London?'

'I'd rather not say on this.'

'On what? What are you on?'

'A payphone.'

'A payphone.' She said it the way she says a drug a patient has bought off the internet. 'Jonas. You said eight. This morning.'

'I rang at 8.31. Nobody—'

'I was on my mobile to the police, Jonas. Your call came in on top of it and I let it ring. Mum was in the garden, and she doesn't hear the phone from the garden. In four years.'

I did not say anything. She was not finished, and I have learned this week what it sounds like when someone is not finished.

'I rang them. The police. I said I would and I did, at ten past eight. I was in a queue for 40 minutes with Elsie on my knee and the radio on in Mum's kitchen, and your firm came on the radio, and then the word theft, and I put the phone down. Not because I believed you. Because I didn't know whose side I'd be ringing.'

'Laura—'

'I don't know what you've done. Do you understand that? I have your word, and a bag I packed in eleven minutes, and a one-year-old in a cot that was mine, and the news. I had the news before I had you.'

'I had to switch the phone off.'

'Then tell me why. No. Not on a payphone.' A breath. I could hear the kitchen behind her. A tap. 'Is she real? The woman in the park?'

'Yes.'

'Does she know where we are?'

'I don't think so.'

'You don't think so.'

'I don't know how she'd know. I haven't rung you from anything but this.'

‘From a payphone, so that nobody can find your wife.’ She laughed, once, not a laugh. ‘Do you hear it? Do you hear what you sound like?’

I heard it. I said, ‘Yes.’

‘Elsie’s fine. A bad night and a good day. Mum thinks you’ve had a breakdown, and I haven’t told her anything that would stop her thinking it, because I don’t have anything.’

‘I’ll explain. Everything. Not on this.’

‘You keep saying that.’ The coins were going. ‘Ring tomorrow. Make a time and be on the end of it.’

‘Nine.’

‘Nine. And Jonas. If you’re not on the end of it at nine, I’m ringing them again, and this time I’m staying in the queue.’

She put the phone down before I did. 9.23. Eight minutes. I stood in the box with the receiver in my hand until a man outside knocked on the glass.

She is safe. She is angrier than I have ever heard her, and I had thought I had heard it. There was no heat in it. That is what I mean. A doctor giving a diagnosis she has already checked twice.

Then I came back here and read.

Notebook one. Entry #1 is a Tuesday. Two lines about a settlement fail at a member I will not name and the word “timing” with a question mark after it. I was 36. I had written the word down because the man on the phone had said it too easily.

About 150 entries, five months. Two hours. I did not get up.

Here is what I had not seen, because I had never read them. I have gone back to a day, a week, a month, and copied out #212, and looked things up. I have never read my own record from the first page as though someone else had written it, and tonight someone else had: a man of 36 who did not know yet what he was looking at.

He was counting the wrong thing. He thought he was logging fails. Each entry is a fail, a late payment, a cash-for-bonds substitution, a

member code, a date, a stock. One at a time, with nothing joining them. One day, one entry, no cross-references. A ledger, not a map.

But read 150 of them in one sitting and the names repeat, and not randomly. By entry #90 I had stopped reading and started tallying on the back of the hotel's card, and by the end of the book there were seven members whose codes came up on more than one bad day, and three whose codes came up on every bad day, the same three, in the same order. The member on the news tonight is one of the three. It was there at #38.

If the first five months give three names in order, the other eight books give the rest, and I think I know, without having read them yet, what the number is. I have had it in my head for two years without writing it down, because writing it down would have been a claim and I do not make claims. Twelve. Twelve members whose bonds are promised the furthest beyond what they have. The one that failed this morning was not the weakest. It was first in the queue. The order has been in the books the whole time, one day at a time, so that nobody, including me, ever had to look at it whole.

That is what her client wanted. Not the fails. The order.

I cannot prove any of this. I want that on the same page as the number. I have fingerprints, four years of them, and a tally on the back of a hotel card. I do not have one chain. I have never seen one bond doing two jobs; I have seen what it leaves behind. A good lawyer would take this apart in an afternoon and be right to. It is a map drawn by a man who has never been to the country.

But the first name on it failed at 7.58 this morning, and I knew it would, and I knew it would be first.

Eight books to go. The light in this room is not good. I am going to read until I can't.

Elsie. Your mother is right. I sound like a man in a box.

Chapter 16

Monitoring

The room was under the Cabinet Office and had no windows, which was the point of it, and a clock that was a minute slow, which Caroline Strand had noticed on her first visit and never had corrected, because a minister who asks for a clock to be fixed is remembered for the clock.

Tuesday, 7.30am. The prime minister at the head of the table, in the chair that was no different from the others and was never sat in by anyone else. The Governor of the Bank of England on his right, with a deputy. The Cabinet Secretary. Simon Carrow at her left, where he had been for three years. A note-taker at the end, a young woman with a laptop, who would produce the minutes, and the minutes were the thing. Everyone in the room would be gone within a decade. The minutes would not.

The prime minister had not slept, which he wore as a kind of tan. He said, ‘Caroline. Where are we.’

She had the page in front of her and did not look at it. ‘Sterling closed in New York at a level I am not going to repeat in this room, because every figure said here finds its way out of it. The gilt market opened at eight yesterday and in any meaningful sense has not opened since. One clearing member of Walbrook has defaulted. The clearing house has taken over its book and is selling what it has to sell into a market that knows what it has to sell. The Bank provided liquidity

under its existing facilities, which is what the Bank is for, and the three largest banks are standing. Nobody has failed who should not have failed. I would ask us to hold on to that sentence, because it is true, and it is the one we need.'

'Governor.'

The Governor was a careful man, which she had always respected and this week found inconvenient. 'Prime Minister. I agree with the Chancellor's account of yesterday. I do not agree that it describes today. The defaulted member's book is being hedged, which means forced selling of long-dated gilts at a known time in a known direction. Every other member's collateral is marked down as that selling proceeds, so every other member is called again. We are watching three further members closely.' He did not name them. The not-naming sat on the table like a third party. 'The Bank's view is that this market will not clear on its own, and that the Bank should stand in it. Temporary, targeted purchases of long-dated gilts, announced before the open, for a fixed period. We did something very like it in 2022, and it worked within the hour.'

'At what size.'

'Whatever is needed. We would announce an upper figure. The figure matters less than the announcement.'

'And the losses, if there are losses.'

'Would fall on the Bank's balance sheet, and the Bank would look to the Treasury to indemnify them, as last time. Which is why it is the Chancellor's decision as much as mine.' He turned to her and did it courteously. 'Chancellor.'

She had known since Sunday that this was coming and had drafted the answer in the car. She did not use the draft. The draft had been for the Governor; this was for the minutes.

'No.'

The prime minister waited. The Governor did not move.

'I want to be exact about what I am saying no to, because I am

not saying no to the Bank. The Bank is independent, and if the Governor judges that purchases are necessary for financial stability, that is his judgement to make without me. What I am declining to do is indemnify them. The Treasury will not underwrite the Bank buying government debt, at a price nobody can defend, four weeks before polling day. If I do that, every newspaper in the country has the word by lunchtime, and it is not "stability", and it is not "orderly". It is the other word. We spent yesterday saying there would not be one. I will not provide one by Tuesday.'

'Chancellor,' the Governor said, 'with respect, the word is already in use.'

'In the press. Not in this government's mouth. The distinction is the whole of my job this month.' She turned to the prime minister, which was the only move that counted. 'Twenty-four hours. The member's book is a finite quantity and it is being sold. When it is sold, the forced selling stops. Walbrook's default fund is intact. We say what we said yesterday and we do not put the taxpayer's name on a price that falls. If the Governor's three members come under real pressure, we meet again, this afternoon if necessary. But we do not pre-empt a bailout of the City on the morning after we said the City did not need one.'

She had said "bailout" herself, once, and placed it where she wanted it: in a sentence about not doing it.

The prime minister looked at the Governor, then at the clock, then at her, and she watched him do the arithmetic she had done in the car: that the Governor would be Governor whichever way the vote went, and she would not, and neither would he. 'Twenty-four hours,' he said. 'Governor, I would be grateful if the Bank's statement this morning said what the Chancellor's says. I do not want two governments.'

The Governor said that the Bank's statement would reflect the Bank's assessment, which was the only sentence available to him. His deputy wrote something down.

‘Simon. The other matter.’

Carrow did not open his folder. He had read it in the car, and he spoke in the voice of a man reading aloud to a child who had asked for the story again.

‘Prime Minister. Walbrook’s head of collateral risk, Whitlock. He did not sign the statement on Sunday night and he has not been in contact since. His phone has been off since yesterday morning, bar three minutes in the afternoon. Walbrook obtained an interim injunction and an order for delivery-up of documents on Sunday evening, by telephone, from the duty judge; the order was served at his home address in Herne Hill yesterday morning. The house was empty. His wife and child left for her mother’s in Norfolk on Sunday evening.’ A fractional pause. ‘We understand.’

‘Where is he?’

‘In London, probably. He used a cash machine in south London at 3.40 yesterday. The police are treating him as a person they wish to speak to, not more than that, at present.’

‘And the woman.’

Carrow did not look at Strand. ‘Priya Raman. Senior analyst on his team. On Friday afternoon, after Whitlock’s system access had been narrowed, she logged in at his desk under her own credentials and extracted the member-level collateral report, which she was authorised to view at her own desk and not to extract, and certainly not to pass to him. Walbrook’s systems logged it. The police received a complaint on that basis, under the Computer Misuse Act, and she was detained at about noon on Sunday at her flat. She was interviewed under caution overnight with a duty solicitor and released yesterday morning after about twenty hours, under investigation. Her phone and laptop were retained. A bail condition that she does not contact Walbrook staff.’ He turned a hand over. ‘She is believed to have gone to her parents’. In the Midlands.’

‘Did she pass it to him?’

‘She said nothing in interview. The sent items on her laptop say it went to the Bank of England’s whistleblowing address, and to a journalist. The police have not yet told us which.’

The prime minister said, ‘Christ,’ quietly, and looked at Strand.

Strand did not ask who had made the complaint. She did not ask who had written to the police, or on what paper, or whether a Treasury director’s letter had gone in alongside Walbrook’s. She did not need to. On Sunday afternoon, at 3.10, in her office with the door shut, Simon had said that it would be prudent to put the Treasury’s concerns about the analyst to the police in writing, so that the matter was properly recorded, and she had looked at the papers on her desk for a count of about three and said that he should do whatever he judged appropriate. Which was yes. She had been a barrister for twelve years and knew precisely how much a silence weighed and who would weigh it.

What she said, for the room and for the young woman at the end of the table, was: ‘The position, Prime Minister, is that a clearing house has reported the theft of market-sensitive material by a senior employee, and the police are dealing with it. That is a matter for the police and for Walbrook. It is not a matter for this government, and I would be concerned if it were suggested that it was.’

She let the note-taker finish typing.

‘I would add only that the material concerned is, on Walbrook’s account, the firm’s confidential information about named institutions, and that its theft, at this moment, is itself a threat to stability. Whoever has it has a list of who is weak. I would like that understood.’

Twice. Both times with Walbrook’s name in front of it, so that if anyone ever read the minutes aloud in a room with lawyers in it, the word would be the firm’s, and she would merely have repeated what she was told. She knew it was not the charge. There was no charge. Information could not be stolen in this country; she had known that since her first year at the Bar, from a case about a student and an examination paper. What Walbrook had was a civil order about documents.

What the police had was a computer offence against a woman who had pulled a report for her boss. What the country had was a word, and she had used it twice before eight in the morning in a room where it would be written down and kept for thirty years.

The prime minister said, 'All right.' He was already on the next page, which was the Gulf. 'Caroline, you're on the broadcasts at 8.15. "Monitoring."'

'Monitoring,' she said. 'Closely.'

In the car, with the glass up between them and the driver, Carrow said: 'The memo.'

'What about it.'

'Whitlock took a copy out of the building on Saturday. The scan, with the footer. If he gives it to a newspaper, the footer gives them the file reference and the date we printed it, which was Wednesday.'

She looked out at the park, where a man was running in the rain in shorts, as though it were a Tuesday. 'And what does Wednesday tell them?'

'That we pulled it before the tanker.'

'We pulled it,' she said, 'because a firm reported a conduct issue with a senior employee and we were reviewing the file. That is what the records request says, I imagine, since you made it.' She did not look at him. 'Does it?'

'It will.'

'Then there is nothing in the footer that was not in the file.' She turned back to the glass. 'Four weeks, Simon. Then either I am Chancellor, and we do what the Governor wants with a mandate behind us, or I am not, and someone else can decide what to call it. In the meantime I will not have a Treasury indemnity and the word "theft" in the same bulletin, because one is a decision and the other is a report, and I intend the country to be able to tell them apart.'

Carrow said, 'Yes, Chancellor,' which was what he said when he had

already done the thing.

The car turned into Whitehall. Her phone showed the Asian close and the European open, and the gap between them, and she put it face down on the seat, because at 8.15 she would be asked what the government was doing, and the honest answer was the word the prime minister had given her, and she had spent the night making sure it was the only word there was.

Chapter 17

Off the record

Tuesday. The same room. Rain since five. I slept from about two until the bins at 6.10 and read the third notebook in bed with my coat on. The day in order, because it is the only order I trust.

9.00, a different payphone, by the canal. Laura answered on the first ring. Elsie had slept. Margaret had not. I said I would ring at nine every day, and she said, ‘Say one true thing. One. Then go,’ and I said that the member that failed yesterday was in my first notebook at entry #38, three years and nine months ago, and that I had known it would be first. A silence long enough for the coins to tick. Then: ‘That’s not what I meant,’ and the line. Four minutes. I am writing it so I do not improve it later.

The paper’s number is on its back page. I rang the switchboard on the new phone from the hotel room at 9.40, asked for Rhys Calloway, and was asked who was calling. I said a former colleague of Priya Raman’s. A pause that meant a hand over a mouthpiece. Then a desk phone, and a man’s voice, quick, London, saying his name as one word.

I said: ‘Priya sent you a number on Sunday.’

He said: ‘Don’t say anything else. Where are you?’

I said north. He named a café on a street off Clerkenwell Green, said twenty to two, not before, he had a desk to get through, said,

‘Come without a bag if you can,’ and hung up before I could tell him I could not.

The rucksack came. It has been on my back or between my feet for 36 hours and I am not sure I could put it down in a room if someone asked me to.

Four hours in the room with the fourth notebook. Then I walked. Up through the back of King’s Cross, across the Gray’s Inn Road, down through the squares, hood up, counting umbrellas, because counting is what my hands do now that they have no keyboard. Forty-one between the hotel and the café. One of them green, held by a woman at the bus stop across the road from the café, reading her phone with the umbrella low, so that I saw the umbrella and the hem of a coat and not much else. I noted it the way I note everything. I did not think about it. That is the honest record.

Wooden tables, a blackboard. He was at the back, facing the door, two coffees already, at a table where you could not sit beside him, only across, which I noticed because I would have done the same.

Rhys Calloway. Younger than his byline, older than his voice. He did not stand up. He said, ‘Phone.’

‘Sorry?’

‘Your phone. Is it on you?’

‘One of them.’

‘Christ.’ He said it mildly, the way Graham says “not yet”. ‘Give it here.’ He took the little phone, took the back off, took the battery out, and laid the three pieces on the table between us like cutlery. ‘Where’s the other one?’

‘Off. In the bag.’

‘Off since when?’

‘Yesterday morning. On for three minutes at 2.35.’

He looked at the rucksack and then at me, and I saw him decide not to ask. ‘Sit down. I’m going to say some things you’ll hate.’

‘You rang the switchboard. The switchboard logs every call: num-

ber, time, who it went to. That log sits on a server with my name next to your number. I rang you back from a desk phone the paper pays for, so now your number is on a bill as well. If anyone with a warrant wants to know who Rhys Calloway has talked to this week, they don't ask me. They go to the network with a form. A few years back the Met did exactly that to three reporters at another paper over a row about a bicycle and a gate, found the source without asking the reporter a question, and then did it to eighty-odd more journalists before anyone noticed. There's a judge in the way now. Judges say yes.'

'I bought it for cash.'

'Good. Doesn't matter. The number's the number now. Throw it away when you leave here. Not in that bin. The one in your bag is worse: that's yours, and when it's on it tells them where it is. Three minutes yesterday. Where?'

I told him. A hill, four miles out.

'Then they know you were on a hill at 2.35. They don't know where you slept. Keep it that way.' 'Second thing. This.' A small movement of his hand at the room. 'A café. In daylight. If I were looking for you I'd be looking for me, because I'm the one in the phone book.' Then, in the voice from the phone: 'What I can do for you is this. I will never give your name to anyone. Not the desk, not the lawyer, not a judge. There's a section of an Act that says a court can't make me, unless it decides it can, and if it does I'd go to prison, and I'd like you to understand that that is worth exactly nothing to you. They won't ask me. They'll find you the way they find everyone, through a phone and a bank card and a habit, and then it'll be my byline over your arrest.'

'Noted,' I said, and heard myself say it.

'Now. Priya.'

He had an email, on paper, folded in his jacket, and he did not take it out; he told me what was in it. Sunday, 10.07am, from a personal address, four pages of figures: the number I know and will not write, the assumptions, the gap, one member short on its own. Signed with

her name and job title. He had rung the number at the bottom at 11.30 and got a dead line, and every three hours since. Walbrook's press office did not comment on individuals. He had not run it.

'Why not?'

'Because I had four pages from a Gmail address and a name I couldn't reach, about a number that hadn't happened yet, on a Sunday. The desk doesn't run that. I ran the default yesterday like everyone else, with her email open on the screen next to it, watching it come true one line at a time.' He put the cup down. 'I've got the number. I haven't got the source. I can't check a single figure in it, because the figures are inside your building. What have you got?'

So I did the thing I had decided on at 4am, and I did exactly that thing and nothing else.

The second notebook. I took it out under the table and found the page without looking, because I had marked it last night with the hotel's card. One entry, #304. The day I sent the memo. I turned the book so he could read it and kept my hand on the facing page: the date, the title, who I had sent it to, Graham's phrase about one analyst's view, and the sentence I had copied in from the memo because I had wanted it in my own hand: approximately three years before a moderate shock becomes unmanageable.

He read it twice. Then he took out a spiral notebook, and I said, 'No photographs,' and he said, 'I wasn't going to,' and wrote the date, the title and the sentence in shorthand, and looked at the date for a long time.

'Three years, near enough,' he said. 'Walbrook and the Treasury. And the Treasury did what?'

'Received it. Stamped it. Wrote two words on it in biro.' I did not tell him the words, or that a copy of the stamped page was in the bag a foot from his knee, with a printer's footer that says when they went and found it. One page. That was the decision.

'What else is in there?' he said, to the rucksack.

‘Four years.’

‘Of this?’

‘Of what this turned into.’

‘Then give it to me. Not to keep. To read. One night, in a room with no windows, and I give it back.’ Both hands flat on the table. ‘You came to me, Mr Whitlock. You want it out. I can get it out. But I can’t print a date and a sentence I saw in a notebook belonging to a man the police are looking for, whose name I can’t use, about a memo I haven’t seen. I need the memo. I need the figures checked against something. I need you.’

‘You have a date.’

‘I have a date.’

‘Then you have more than you had at lunchtime.’ I put the book back into the bag under the table and did the straps up, and he watched my hands do it. ‘When I know you, you’ll have the rest.’

‘When you know me.’ He sat back. ‘Priya knew me. She’s been gone since Sunday.’

That went in and stayed in.

‘One more thing,’ he said, when I stood. ‘You can’t steal information in this country. Not under the Theft Act, not under anything. A judge told a student that in 1978 and nobody’s told a judge otherwise since. Walbrook’s lawyers know it. What they’ve got is a civil order about documents, with a return date, at a hearing you’re entitled to turn up to with a lawyer and argue. The word in the papers is for you. It’s meant to make you feel like a man who took something. Get a lawyer before you talk to me again.’

‘I don’t have one.’

‘Then that’s the first thing you don’t have.’ He put a card on the table, a number written on the back in biro. ‘Not my mobile. A friend’s. If you need me, ring that from something that isn’t yours and say the date you just showed me, and nothing else. I’ll know.’

I took it. I left the three pieces of the phone on the table.

Rain, still. I turned left, away from the Green, because left was the long way, and went two streets and crossed and went another, and at the corner by a church there was a woman under a green umbrella waiting to cross, not looking at anything, the umbrella low so that I saw the umbrella and the hem of a coat and not much else.

I did not stop. I want that on the record. I saw a thing and kept walking at the same speed, and the only part of me that changed was the part that was counting. Forty-one umbrellas between the hotel and the café. One green one. Now two, or one, twice.

I went through the market on the next street, between the stalls, where a man with a rucksack is one of forty, and down into the Underground at the first station and up again at the next and walked. On the way I went into a shop that was not yesterday's shop and bought another small phone with buttons and another SIM, £29 in notes, and the man asked for nothing. I am a man who now owns one of these a day. Nobody has this number either. The rucksack is on the bed, and nine, and it is 4.40 and I have written this in one sitting with the door locked.

Here is what I think. I was not followed to the café. Nobody needed to follow me. They needed to be where I would go, and there is one person in London I was always going to go to, and his name was on Priya's kitchen table on Sunday, on the top sheet of the middle stack, on the half that had been torn off and taken.

I have been asking for two days what was on that half. I think it was a name and a number. I think they have been standing across the road from Rhys Calloway since Sunday afternoon, waiting for me to be careful enough to find him.

She stopped asking at nine on Sunday. Nobody has asked me anything since.

I do not have a lawyer. I have a phone nobody has rung, a card with a stranger's number, nine notebooks, and a woman with a green

umbrella who knows what I look like in the rain.

Chapter 18

Billions

The word had been said to Sebastian Crane eleven times before noon and he had let it stand each time.

Investors said it. That was the odd thing. Men who had spent the summer ringing to ask, with the courtesy of people who had signed a lock-up, whether the fund's position was perhaps a little large, now rang to say it as if it were a place they had visited. 'Billions, Sebastian.' A pension consultant in Edinburgh said it twice in one sentence. A family office in Geneva said it in French and then again in English, in case the first had not carried. He thanked each of them. He said that the market had done the work and that Greywether had merely declined to be surprised, which was true and which they took, as he intended, for modesty.

He did not look at the number. It was on the floor below, on 31 screens, and it would be on a sheet of paper on his desk at six when the day's prices were in, and he would read it then, once. A number looked at all day stopped meaning anything by lunchtime, the way a word repeated enough times became a noise.

What he knew without the sheet was this. The pound had opened lower than it had closed and had not found a floor. British government bonds had opened lower again, after a night in which the Asian desks had sold them for the first time as a matter of policy rather than opin-

ion. A clearing member of the first rank was in default and its book was being hedged by a clearing house that had told the world yesterday morning, over its chief executive's signature, that its arrangements were fully sound.

Greywether was short all of it and had been since the spring. There was nothing to do but not spoil it.

At half past eleven his assistant put her head round the door to say that Sir Anthony Pell's car would be at the club at one and that Sir Anthony had asked whether Mr Crane might prefer the small dining room. Crane said the small dining room would be delightful. He had never in 30 years known Anthony Pell to ask for the small dining room when he had good news.

The club was in St James's and had the virtue of being the sort of place where two men could eat lunch unobserved by anyone who would admit to observing them. Pell had the corner table. He had aged, Crane thought, since Friday, in the way that men on boards aged: not in the face but in the hands, which did not know what to do with the cutlery.

'You'll have seen the day,' Pell said, which was how he had begun on Friday, and Crane let him have the small comfort of a routine.

'I'm told it continues eventful.'

'Richard was in with the Bank until two this morning.' Pell lowered his voice, though there was nobody within five tables. 'The member's margin is gone and the default fund is next. There's a second call going out intraday every time the price moves. He is, between ourselves, not entirely sure that there won't be another one by Friday.'

'Another call?'

'Another member.'

Crane said nothing. The waiter came and he ordered the sole, and Pell ordered what he always ordered and then did not touch the bread.

'That isn't why I asked you to lunch,' Pell said.

'No.'

'The man. Whitlock. You'll have seen "theft" in every paper. That's us. That's Richard's lawyers, on Sunday night, in front of a judge on the telephone, and I'm told the word did not pass the judge's lips at any point. What we have is an injunction and an order for delivery-up. Documents containing confidential information. Served on the house in Herne Hill yesterday morning. Nobody was in.'

'I imagine not.'

'That's the firm. Then there's the other thing, and I want you to hear it from me and not from your lunch tomorrow, because it will be lunch tomorrow.' Pell turned his knife over. 'The Treasury have gone to the police themselves.'

Crane waited.

'Carrow wrote on Sunday. Not Richard. Richard made a complaint about an access breach on Friday afternoon, a girl on Whitlock's team who logged in at his desk and pulled a report after his access had been cut; that's all the firm did, and it did it because the lawyers said it must. It was Carrow's letter that had two officers at her door on a Sunday. They held her overnight. Computer misuse, the custody sheet says. Released on bail yesterday morning, no charge. They've kept her phone and her computer and told her not to speak to anyone at the firm.'

'The girl, Anthony?'

'Raman. Priya Raman. Thirty-one, I think. Mathematics.' Pell said it as though the degree were a condition. 'And the police want him. Whitlock. Not for the firm's benefit. For theirs. There is a woman at the Treasury who has to say the word "sound" on television every morning until polling day, and she would prefer that the man who wrote the opposite three years ago were in a room with a solicitor when she says it.'

'Caroline,' Crane said, 'has always done the right thing for the wrong reason. It is her gift.' He ate a mouthful of sole. 'And you're telling me

this because?'

Pell looked at him for a long moment, and in it Crane saw the whole of Pell's weekend: the board calls, the lawyers, the gradual understanding that a man who had done nothing for four years had been keeping a note of it, in ink, with dates.

'Because if the police find him first,' Pell said, 'those books go into an evidence bag and then into a courtroom, and every page of them has Richard's name on it and Pryce's and, by the by, the dates of four board meetings I sat in. I would rather they were ash. I'm not asking what you're doing. I'd rather they were ash, Sebastian, than in anybody's hands at all. Including yours.'

'You've never wanted to know how, Anthony.'

'No.' Pell put his knife down. 'And I don't now. I'm telling you that there's a clock on it that isn't yours.'

Crane finished the sole. He thought about Anthony Pell, who had never once in 30 years said anything quickly, saying all of that in under four minutes. He thought about the word *ash*. He had no intention of burning anything. A map was not a thing one burned. One used it, and then one framed it.

'Go back to your board,' he said. 'Tell them the position is being managed. You're good at that.'

The sheet was on his desk at six. He read it once, folded it, and put it in the inside pocket of his jacket, which was where he had kept the first one, on another evening, in another crisis, when the number had been a tenth the size and had made his name. He did not compare them. He was not a sentimental man. He noted that the number on the sheet had moved a comma since Friday and that nobody alive could now call it luck, and he put it away.

The telephone in the drawer rang at 7.10.

'Mr Crane.'

'Dana. You have something.'

'Three things. I'll give them to you in the order I'd want them.' There was traffic behind her voice, a long straight road, a lorry. She was driving. 'One. The subject has been located. He was in a café in Clerkenwell at twenty to two this afternoon, for 50 minutes, with a man called Rhys Calloway, who writes about money for one of the nationals. He had the rucksack with him. He did not hand it over. He left on foot and my person lost him in the market, which I'm not pleased about and which he will have noticed, because he looked at her twice.'

'A journalist.'

'A journalist. The analyst's kitchen table had his name written down the margin of a printout. My person saw it on Sunday, after the police had taken her and before her colleague arrived. I've had someone on Calloway since. It's cheaper to watch the door a man has to walk through than to look for the man.'

'So you knew, on Sunday, where the girl was.'

'I knew she'd gone in a police car. I told you I'd tell you when there was something. A police car isn't something, Mr Crane. It's the absence of something.'

He let that pass. 'Two.'

'The notebooks have not been recovered. He has nine with him, in the rucksack, on his back, at all times, and he has stopped using his phone. He's bought another, cheap, for cash, or he will have; everyone does by the second day. He'll be sleeping somewhere that takes cash. I'll have the hotel by tomorrow night, but I'd like you to understand that a hotel is a public place with a hundred doors, and taking a bag off a man's back in one of them is the kind of thing that gets noticed. I don't do noticed.'

'Three.'

A pause in which the lorry passed.

'His wife and child are in Norfolk. The wife's mother is a widow in a village near Norwich; her husband's probate is on the same register

as the father's garage, and it names her and the house. I drove up this morning. The wife's car was on the drive. A child's seat in the back. I didn't stop.'

Crane looked at the wall where a screen would have been. It was a quarter past seven. Below him the floor would be thinning out, the day's prices in, the number in his pocket. He thought of a man on his back on a bench somewhere with four years of other people's mistakes strapped to him, and of what that man had thought worth running from, and what he had left behind on a drive in Norfolk.

'Then you know where to apply pressure,' he said.

The line was quiet long enough that he thought the road had taken her signal.

'I don't work that way with children, Mr Crane.'

He had heard a great many people tell him what they would not do, and almost all of them had been describing a price. He listened for the price in this and did not hear one.

'I hadn't realised you had a way,' he said.

'You've never asked.' Her voice had not changed at all; it was the same voice that had told him on Friday that she had someone outside a building within the hour. 'I'll have the hotel by tomorrow. I'll have the books by the weekend, by my route. If you want a different route, you'll want a different firm, and I'd advise you to think about what a different firm looks like when it's finished.'

'Dana—'

'Goodnight, Mr Crane.'

He put the telephone back in the drawer and did not close it. He sat with his hands flat on the empty desk, as he had sat on Friday, and found that the thing he was turning over was not the hotel, or the journalist, or the number in his pocket, but a woman declining to say something on a motorway.

He had not got where he was by employing people with rules. He had got there by knowing what rules cost, and he had never yet met

one that cost more than he had. But he had heard, in that silence, that this one was not for sale, and he found that he minded it less as an obstacle than as a fact about her that he had not known for as long as he had been paying her. He did not like not knowing things about people he paid.

He looked down at the drawer, at the phone with one number in it, and thought, for the first time since he had bought it, that one number was not enough.

Chapter 19

Cousins

The statement had been read on the evening news on Monday and printed in both the morning papers on Tuesday, and by Wednesday Khalid Al-Mansouri had heard it quoted back to him so often that he could have recited it in the voice of the man who read it. The nation's wealth had been protected by the prudent and timely action of its fund. The fund's leadership had acted with foresight. The nation did not seek confrontation with any party and would not be made the hostage of any party's politics. That was the whole of it, and it was true in every word, and he had not been consulted on a single one.

He read it once more, at the long table in his own house, with the sea beyond the glass, and then he turned it over and put it under the thing that was not public.

The thing that was not public was a sheet from Nasser summarising the week. Positions closed through the three London banks: a little over half, in size order, as instructed. Collateral released and sold: a little under half, because the clearing house released it only the morning after each position closed and the market, knowing this, waited for him at every open. The price he had got for the bonds already sold. The price he would get for the rest, if Thursday looked like Wednesday. The difference between those figures and the figure on Friday night was not a number he was prepared to say aloud, and

Nasser, who knew him, had not put it in words either. He had put it in a column and let it speak.

That was the private question. Nobody had asked it in those words. They had asked it in others.

One of the four men had telephoned at seven that morning, which was early for him, and had spent some minutes on the health of Khalid's mother before arriving at it. Could the fund not have waited? A week. A fortnight. Until the Americans had said the word "freeze" in a sentence with a verb in it, rather than merely in a studio. Khalid had said, with respect, that a fortnight was the difference between selling and being sold, and the man had said that he understood, which meant that he did not, and that others understood less. Then he had said, in the tone of a man mentioning the weather, that Khalid's cousin had spoken very well at the council the night before.

'Which cousin?'

'Faisal.' A pause. 'He said that the fund had shown the way. That the nation's money should never again sit where a foreign minister could reach it. He said it rather better than I have. He had figures.'

'Faisal has always had figures.'

'He has more of them this week,' the man said, and rang off.

Faisal was the son of his father's younger brother, four years his junior, and had spent his twenties as Khalid had spent his, in London and in banks, with the difference that Faisal had enjoyed it. He had come home with a taste for the things that London sold to men like him and a facility for explaining them to men who had not been. He ran the family's private money, which was a phrase that covered a great deal: the interests of one branch of a large family, held through an office with a name that was not the family's, trading through banks that were not the nation's, in instruments that the fund, with its charter and its board and its auditors, could not have touched. A family office answered to a family. Khalid's fund answered to a state. The two were

cousins in the same sense that he and Faisal were: by blood, in public, at weddings.

He had never disliked Faisal. He had found him expensive. Until this week that had been a sufficient thing to find.

Faisal rang at eleven, as Khalid had known he would, because Faisal was a man who could not hear that his name had been mentioned without wanting to be in the room where it was said.

'Khalid. I wanted to be the first to congratulate you, and I find I am the twentieth.'

'The first was the newsreader.'

'Then I am in good company.' Faisal laughed; he had a good laugh, which he knew. 'I meant what I said last night. You will have heard. You did the thing everybody has been saying should be done for ten years and nobody had the courage for. The money is coming home.'

'The money is being sold,' Khalid said. 'At a price. Home is where it will sit afterwards, and it will be smaller when it gets there.'

'A price worth paying.'

'You would say so. You were not paying it.'

A very small pause, in which Khalid heard his cousin decide to be amused.

'I did my modest best to be on the right side of it,' Faisal said. 'One does, when one can see it coming. You taught me that, you know. In London. You said a man who could read a balance sheet had no excuse for being surprised.'

'I said that of banks.'

'It applies to countries.' A sound of movement; Faisal walking, as he always did on the telephone, through some large room. 'Come to dinner on Friday. There are people I would like you to meet. People who think as you do, now. The council is going to want to talk about where the money sits from here, and it would be strange if the man who moved it were not at the table.'

Khalid said that he would see, which Faisal would understand cor-

rectly. Then he put the telephone down and sat for a moment with his hand still on it, as he had on Saturday after another call, and considered the sentence *one does, when one can see it coming*.

He had spent Saturday telling himself that his government had not sunk the tanker. He had asked, through the channels one asked, and been told no, and the men who told him had been frightened, and he had believed them. He still did. The four men who could have given the order had not given it.

He had not, until this moment, asked himself who else there was.

Nasser came at half past twelve with the midday figures and found him standing at the glass.

'Leave those,' Khalid said. 'I want the desk to do something for me, and I want it done by this evening and spoken of to nobody. Not the board. Not London.'

'Sir.'

'The week before the ship went down. Ten days, say. I want to know who in this market was positioned against us. Against the country. Our banks' shares. The sovereign, if anyone was buying protection on it. The currency, through the forwards, if anyone was foolish enough. The airline. The regional index. Anyone who sold what was ours before there was a reason to sell it.'

Nasser did not write any of it down, which was how Khalid knew he had understood it.

'Our brokers will know some of it,' Nasser said carefully. 'The banks here will know more than they should and will tell us a little of it, because we are who we are. The exchange will know what was sold. It will not be a complete picture.'

'I do not want a picture. I want names.'

'There is one name you will see, sir.'

Khalid turned from the glass. 'Say it.'

'The family office was selling banks from the Tuesday of the week

before,' Nasser said. 'Everyone on the exchange knows it. They have been too polite to say so this week, since the fund did the same thing on a larger scale three days later and was praised for it.'

'Faisal is the family office. I know what Faisal did; he has just spent ten minutes telling me in a way that will not repeat. I am not asking what he sold. I am asking who bought it. Who was on the other side. A man does not sell a country short into an empty room, Nasser. Somebody takes the other side of every one of those trades and somebody writes the swap when he wants a bigger position than the exchange will give him. I want the counterparties.'

'That is harder.'

'It is harder,' Khalid agreed. 'Do it anyway.'

The afternoon was long. He took two more calls from men whose names he would not have written down, and a third from the London office, where the day had been as the day before, only lower.

He ate alone. He read the British papers on the screen, which had the word "theft" in every headline and, under it, a man with no name: a senior risk manager at the clearing house that held his collateral, who had apparently written down, over four years, what the week had proved, and whom the police now wished to speak to for having done so. The papers did not say what he had written. They said what he had taken. Khalid thought that he would like to read it, and that he was probably the only person in two countries who wanted to read it for its own sake rather than to make it disappear.

Nasser came back at nine.

He had a single sheet. He did not sit down to give it, which was unlike him, and he did not begin with the summary, which was more unlike him still.

'The family office sold the three largest banks here from the Tuesday before the ship, sir, through two brokers, in size. It bought protection on the sovereign through a London bank, also from the Tuesday, in

a quantity the London bank will not confirm and has not denied. It sold the currency forward through the same bank. It bought oil, which anyone might do. And it did something I had not expected, which is that for the largest of the positions it did not go through the exchange or a bank at all. It went through a swap, written privately, with a single counterparty. One contract, very large, dated nine days before the ship went down.'

'And the counterparty.'

'I had it from one source and did not believe it, and then from a second.' Nasser put the sheet on the table. 'The other side of your cousin's largest trade, and of a good part of the rest, is a fund in London. Greywether Capital.'

Khalid did not touch the sheet.

He thought of a voice on Saturday, unhurried and warm, saying *you're going to sell, everyone with a television knows you're going to sell*; and offering a price that was a forecast; and knowing, before he dialled, the position and the collateral and the morning's conversations in two capitals. More than a man in Mayfair ought to know. He had filed that away in the place where he kept things about Sebastian Crane, and he found now that the place was not large enough.

A hedge fund did not take the other side of a family office for charity. Either it had been hedged elsewhere, in a market big enough to hide in, or it had been paid in something other than money.

Faisal had been paid in money. Faisal had been paid very well. And Faisal, who had never in his life kept a thing to himself that would make him seem clever, had just invited him to dinner with people who thought as he did, now.

'Nasser,' he said. 'Who else knows you asked?'

'Two brokers and a man at the London bank. They think it was about the fund's own exposure.'

'Let them go on thinking it.' He picked up the sheet at last and read the name again, as if it might have changed. 'And find out for me what

Greywether Capital was doing in London in the same nine days. Not against us. Against them.’

Chapter 20

Released

Thursday. First sitting. A kitchen table in Kentish Town that is not mine, at twenty to six in the evening, with the owner out and the other person in the flat asleep on the sofa in her coat. I will write the rest tonight when there is a rest. There is going to be.

Priya is alive. I am putting that first, as I put the decision first on Monday, because for four days I have been writing round a hole in the middle of every entry and the hole had her name on it. On Sunday I counted four possibilities and stopped. It was the fifth.

The police had her.

On Wednesday, against my own rule, I rang the friend's number, said the date, and gave Calloway the number of the second phone, because a man who can only ring out cannot be found by the one person he wants to find him. Calloway's word came at 11.20 this morning on that phone, by the arrangement we made on Tuesday, which is in Tuesday's entry and which I am not repeating. Four words. *She's here. Come now.* He did not need to say who.

Priya had walked into the front hall of his paper, south of the river, at twenty to ten, with a rucksack of her own and no phone, and asked for him by name, and sat in the lobby for 40 minutes while a receptionist decided whether she was a story or a problem. She had come from

Leicester on the first cheap train with £28 in her bag, counted on the platform. She told me the number because she knew I would want it. It was not kindness.

I will not write how I got from behind King's Cross to here. It was not far and I made it long.

She was at this table when I came in. She stood up, and we looked at each other, and she said: 'You've got them with you. Of course you have.' Then she sat down, and Calloway, who knows when a room does not need him, went out for the things we would need later.

What happened to her, in order, because she told it in order.

Sunday, 10.07am. Eight minutes after she hung up on me, she sent the figures: to the Bank's whistleblowing address, and to Calloway. From her own laptop, at her kitchen table. Two mugs of tea, both hers, neither drunk. I had stood in her kitchen building a visitor out of them.

11.55. Two police officers at the street door, plain clothes, a uniformed one in the car. Would she come with them to answer questions about an incident at her place of work on Friday afternoon. She asked whether she had to. The older one said he would rather she came voluntarily. She said that was not an answer. He said then he was arresting her, and said the words, and the offence, which was unauthorised access to a computer, and the time, 3.46pm on Friday, and the place, a desk that was not hers.

'Like a train announcement,' she said. 'Platform, time, destination.'

They let her take her bag. The laptop went into a clear bag with a label. She gave them her phone out of her pocket because she did not yet understand what she was giving. It had been off since eleven, after the emails, so that she would not have to take my calls until she had decided what to say to me. She asked to lock the door and the younger one said she would be back in an hour. The torn sheet was hers: while they labelled the laptop she tore the bottom half off the top page and

put it in the back pocket of her jeans. The member's name, in full, and the 2.8 beside it. They did not search her for paper. Nobody searches anyone for paper.

A police station east of the City; she will not say which. A custody sergeant, a form, her belt and the laces out of her trainers. A cell with a window of glass bricks. She counted them. 48. She knew I would ask.

A duty solicitor at six. The interview at 8.40pm, under caution, 50 minutes. The questions, as she remembers them. Did she log in at Jonas Whitlock's workstation on Friday afternoon. Did she know his access had been restricted. Did she run and print a member-level report. Did she give it to him. Had she passed Walbrook data to any third party. Did Mr Whitlock keep personal records of Walbrook business. Where. Had she seen them. Did she know where he was now.

She said no comment to all of it, on the solicitor's advice. The hardest thing she had done in four years, she said, because every question had an answer and she knew them all.

'Nobody said money,' she said. 'Nobody said a fund. Nobody said a woman's name. They wanted the report and they wanted you. That was all they wanted, and they wanted it on a Sunday, which the solicitor said was the only interesting thing about any of it.'

The solicitor had seen the paperwork. The complaint was Walbrook's: a report run under her credentials after the system had locked mine. The reason two officers were at a door in Bethnal Green on a Sunday instead of a letter asking her to attend on Wednesday was a second document behind the first, which the solicitor was shown and she was not, and which he described to her afterwards in the corridor as "a letter from the Treasury. A director. Asking for urgency."

A cell overnight. At 8.10 on Monday morning they gave her the bag back without the phone, and a sheet of paper. Released on bail, pending further investigation. One condition: not to contact, directly or indirectly, any person employed by Walbrook Clearing House. A

date in four weeks. The phone and the laptop retained for as long as necessary. They had asked for the passcodes. She had refused. They had told her what the notice was called that would make her, and that it carried two years, and that they would be in touch.

Twenty hours and fifteen minutes. She said that too. I did not have to ask.

Monday, 8.10am. She walked out of a police station into the morning I had watched from a café. A ticker in a bookmaker's window gave her the name of a member of Walbrook Clearing House, at 7.58, in default. She knew which one before she read it. Her parents' savings clear through it.

She went home. Her door as she had left it, open, 21 hours. Nothing taken. On the top stack, in my handwriting, a receipt. *Ring me. J.*

'I gave the man in the corner shop a pound and rang you from his,' she said. 'Twice. Not available. You'd turned it off, I expect, with that look you get when you've thought of something. I'd come out of a cell to a note that said *ring me* from a man I couldn't ring.'

8.31. I did not say so. Being exactly right about the time is not always a thing to say aloud.

She took the 2.15 to Leicester. Her parents had to be told in person that the fund with their savings in it cleared through a bank that had failed to pay Walbrook at 7.58 that morning; and it was, she said, the one address in England where she knew who would open the door.

Monday night she bought a notebook. A stationer's near the station in Leicester, £4.99, A5, soft cover, red. She said the colour was not a comment.

Monday night, Tuesday, Wednesday. No phone. 'I wasn't going to put a new one in my pocket so that somebody could ask the network where it was. I got that from you. Everything I've learned this week I got from you, Jonas, and most of it I'd give back.'

She wrote. Thursday's £42m of the 2045, Friday's seven of 40, ev-

ery figure of the forty-member report she could remember, which was most of it; she has the memory that made her the best analyst I have worked with, and I never once told her that was the reason. Sunday's number. The half-sheet from her back pocket, copied out and the original burnt in her mother's sink. Then what she could reconstruct from four years of exceptions reports read on Saturday night on a laptop the police now have. Not the record. A record. Hers.

'Paper doesn't have a login,' she said. 'I learned that from you too.'

Wednesday she read Calloway's paper from front to back and found he had printed nothing. Thursday she got on the first train.

Now the part I have to write, because it is the point of the record.

I had it wrong. From 12.51 on Sunday, when a woman declined to answer a question in a park, I have carried one version: Kessler's client took Priya. Every decision since was built on it. I did not ring Carrow on Sunday night, partly, because I believed the Treasury was the lesser danger and the woman by the gates the greater.

The Treasury took Priya. A director wrote a letter on a Sunday and two officers went to a blue door and took the one person in London who could read my work, and held her 20 hours, and asked her where I keep the books. Kessler, in the park, said that if she told me she did not know where Priya was I would not believe her. I would not have. She was being, as she said, careful with me. I have been hating the wrong person for the right reasons for four days, and the result is the same as being wrong.

So. Two. Not one hunter with a card and a client; two, and they want different things. Her client wants the books before the market finishes burning, because they are worth less every hour. The state wants them never to have existed, and me in a room saying no comment, and it has what she has not: the right to ask a network where a phone is, to a warrant, to 20 hours. The one is paying; the other is in no hurry at all. I had been afraid of the one I could see.

And the police have her phone. My number is in it. My text at 10.41 on Sunday: *Ring me. Please. Not to argue.* In a clear bag, with a label.

I said I had not told her because I was trying to protect her. I said it at this table at about half past four, and she let me finish, which was the cruellest thing she could have done.

'Protect me,' she said. 'Jonas. I pulled that report under my own login at your desk, with the camera over it, on a Friday afternoon, because you were sitting there looking like a man who needed one more number. You've always needed one more number. I thought I was giving you one. I didn't know I was giving you the hundredth of something you'd been counting since before I joined. If I'd known what was in those books, if you had told me on Thursday, I'd have done it differently. I'd have done it in my own name, properly, to the Bank, with a lawyer, on the Friday morning. Instead I did it in a cell with my laces out.'

I said I knew.

'You don't. Twenty hours, Jonas. My parents didn't know where I was, and for a while on Monday morning I thought the first they'd hear of it would be a paper with the word "theft" above my name instead of yours. You kept four years to yourself because it was safer. It was safer for you.'

She is right. I have written it down so I cannot say later that she was not.

She has not forgiven me. She said so, in those words, so that it would be on the record, and it is. She had not come for me. She had come because this was the only table in London with the numbers on it, and it happened to have me at it.

Then she took the red notebook out of her rucksack and put it on the table, and put her hand flat on it, and said:

'Mine has Monday to Thursday in it. Yours has four years. Somewhere between them is a list of who falls over and in what order, and

Calloway is on his way back with every public filing he can carry, and I am not leaving this flat until it is on one page.'

Chapter 21

The map

Second sitting. Kentish Town, a kitchen table that is not mine, 11.40pm. The first sitting is on the previous page and it is about Priya and it is not finished, because she walked in halfway through it and I put the pen down. I am not going back to it tonight. Tonight is the page.

Elsie is one today. I said it to Laura at nine, from a call box, inside the four minutes, and did not say it again all day, and the record is where I put the things I do not say. Fifty-two weeks. I was in a flat in Kentish Town with the curtains drawn.

Calloway's table seats four. He gave it to us and sat on the arm of the sofa with a laptop he said was the paper's and not his, and for the first hour he did not speak. I had not expected that of a journalist. I had not expected most of today.

Nine notebooks on the table, spines out, in order. Priya's book next to them: a red A5 notebook, soft cover, bought at a stationer's by Leicester station for £4.99, with three days of her figures in it in two colours of biro. She put it down beside mine and looked at the row and said, 'Well. Now there are ten.' It was not kind and it was not meant to be. She has not forgiven me. She has decided to work with me anyway, which is a different thing, and I will take it.

She is not supposed to be in a room with anyone from Walbrook. She said so when she came in, and sat down.

The method was hers. I would have started at #1 and read forward, because that is how I have read them all week, and it would have taken until Sunday. She said: ‘No. Give me the members. Every code you’ve ever written next to a fingerprint. I don’t want the story. I want the list.’

So I went through four years for codes.

For anyone who finds this. Walbrook has about 40 clearing members, the banks and brokers that stand between everyone else and us. I have never written a member’s name in these books. I write the code: four letters, Walbrook’s own, meaningless outside the building. Beside the code I write what I saw. A settlement fail with the excuse “timing”, paired with another member’s fail with the same excuse on the same day. The nine o’clock call paid in cash that was raised that morning by lending out bonds, and the bonds swapped back in by the afternoon. A substitution of one line of gilts for another at a time of day when nobody substitutes anything. Twice, a position report that should not have reached me and did. None of it proves anything on its own; I have said so in these books more often than I have said anything else. Together, over four years, the same codes keep standing next to the same fingerprints. That is all the record is. A list of who kept doing it.

I read codes aloud. Priya wrote: a mark against each code, a different mark when the fingerprint was one of the worse kinds. Two hours and ten minutes. My voice went about halfway, and Calloway got up without a word and put a glass of water by my hand and sat down again.

Thirty-one codes appeared at least once. Twelve appeared in every one of the last eight quarters, and those twelve are the map.

She wrote them down one side of a sheet of Calloway’s printer paper, in the order of how many marks each had, and then she stopped and said, ‘That’s not the order.’

‘No.’

‘Order by when they’d fail.’

That is harder, and it is the only part of this that I have ever been any good at. How much each one posts to us. How much of what it posts is the kind of line I have seen going out on repo in the morning and coming back in the afternoon. How late it pays on a bad day, which is the honest number, and Priya has four years of it in her head because she has done the Thursday reconciliation for four years. We argued about three of the twelve. She won two. The one I won is the one that failed on Monday, which I had at the top and she had at third, and she conceded it because it had already happened.

Then the right-hand column. What each one is holding. Which lines of gilts, roughly how much, and how much of it I think is promised elsewhere at the same time. I say think. I wrote “think” at the top of the column and she did not cross it out.

By half past nine it was one page. Twelve codes. An order. A column of what each one holds. Four years in a bag that smells of my father’s garage, and it comes to one side of A4 in Priya’s handwriting, which is better than mine.

I looked at it for a long time. You cannot see a map when you are drawing one line of it a night.

Priya did not look at it for long. She turned to Calloway and said, ‘Now I need your laptop.’

The next hour is hers, and I am going to put it down as exactly as I can because I did not do it and I want to be able to check it.

She cannot see what a hedge fund is short in gilts, or in the pound. Nobody can. Those positions are reported privately if they are reported at all, and the people who hold them do not talk. What she can see is shares. Anyone short more than half of one per cent of a company listed in London has to tell the regulator, and the regulator puts it on a list every afternoon, with the name of the fund, the name of the

company, the size and the date. It is public. It is dull. Nobody reads it except people like Priya.

‘Your twelve are members,’ she said. ‘Members are banks. Banks have parents. Parents have shares.’

Nine of the twelve have a listed parent in London. She wrote the nine parents beside the codes and then she went to the regulator’s list and started looking for who was short them.

There were a lot of names. Every fund in London with a view on British banks has had the same view since the spring. She was looking for one name that was on all nine, and she found it in about twenty minutes, and when she found it she did not say anything. She turned the laptop round so that I could read it.

Greywether Capital LLP.

I did not know the name. I want that on the record, because by the time anyone reads this it will seem impossible. I had spent four years at the centre of this and I did not know the name of the fund, and I was sitting in a kitchen in Kentish Town learning it from a list.

Calloway knew it. He had come off the arm of the sofa. ‘Sebastian Crane,’ he said. ‘Mayfair. Thirty-odd staff. Made his first money shorting a currency twenty-something years ago and has been waiting for the next one since. He doesn’t talk to us. He doesn’t talk to anyone.’

I wrote the two names at the top of this page before I wrote anything else. Greywether. Crane. I have written “her client” eleven times since Sunday. I counted them while Priya was typing. I am not going to write it again.

She did the rest with a ruler. Greywether was short all nine of the listed parents. Of the three biggest shorts on its list, the biggest was the parent of the member that failed on Monday. The second was my second. The third was Priya’s third, which she had argued for and I had argued against, and she did not look at me when it came up, which was a kindness. Below that the order wandered, but not far: no name was more than two places from where our page had it.

‘Nine out of nine, and the top three in order,’ she said. ‘Anyone would be short British banks this year. Anyone with sense would be shortest the weakest ones. That’s not a coincidence I need to explain. The order, nearly. The order I can nearly explain, if I’m generous, if he’s got very good people and they’ve been reading the same fails I have. Nearly.’

‘Could they?’

‘Could I have done this from outside the building? In a month, with the public data and a lot of luck. Maybe. Kessler told you a month.’ She stopped. ‘He didn’t have a month. That’s why she was in the park.’

I asked her the question I was paid to ask. ‘How much of this is our page, and how much is any sensible short?’

‘I’d have said half and half,’ she said, ‘an hour ago.’ She was scrolling. ‘Then I’d have said the order tips it. Now—’ and she stopped scrolling.

The list gives dates. The date on which each position crossed each threshold. She had been reading names and sizes. She had not read the dates. She read them now, down the column, nine parents, and then she went back to the top and read them again, and then she took the biro and wrote one date on the page, under the twelve codes, and put a box round it.

Greywether’s shorts in all nine parents had been running at modest size since the spring. On one day, the same day for all nine, every one of them had stepped up: the biggest of them more than doubled. Not the day the tanker sank. Not the day after, when anyone with a screen would have done it. Nine days before.

A Tuesday. The Tuesday before #1399. The week before my birthday. I took the ninth book out of the row and found the entry. #1392. Half a page. Two timing fails, paired, the usual two codes. A member’s call paid eleven minutes late. The weather. Nothing. An ordinary Tuesday in the record of a man who thought he was watching everything.

'Say it,' Priya said. 'You're the one who doesn't say things.'

'Somebody knew the date.'

'Somebody knew the date, and the shape, and the order, and he put the position on nine days early so that it would look like it had always been there. And it nearly did.' She put the biro down. 'You asked me which I think it is. I think the names are coincidence. I think the order could be. I don't think there's a coincidence big enough for the date.'

Calloway said, very quietly, 'I'm going to need to be able to print that.'

'Not yet,' I said, and heard myself say it, and heard Priya hear it. Not yet. The phrase of my life.

'Not yet,' she said. 'Not never.'

It is 11.40 and the page is in front of me, between the nine books and the red one. Twelve codes. An order. What each one holds. A name. A date with a box round it.

I have been reading these books all week as a record of what I saw. They are also a record of what I did not see. On the Tuesday before my birthday a man in Mayfair whose name I did not know bet very heavily that a ship would sink nine days later, and it did, and I wrote half a page about the weather.

Elsie is one today. The man who knew the date has had the money since Monday. I have had the map since half past nine tonight. Her client has a name now. He also, it turns out, had a calendar.

Chapter 22

A visitor

The grey car was at the end of the lane again on Friday morning, in the same place, nose towards the village, parked tight into the hedge where the lane widened for the field gate. Laura saw it from the landing window at ten past seven while she was carrying Elsie down, and she stood with Elsie on her hip and looked at it the way she would look at a rash that had come back.

Thursday she had noticed it and explained it. A birdwatcher. Somebody waiting for somebody. Her mother's village had one lane in and one lane out and the same eleven cars, and Laura had been coming to it long enough to name eight of the eleven, and a grey saloon she did not know had been a thing to notice and then let go. On Thursday she had let it go. She had other things. Elsie had turned one on Thursday and her father had rung at nine from a call box, as he now did, for four minutes, and had said happy birthday down a line to a child who was asleep, and Laura had made a cake with her mother because Elsie was one and that was what you did, and had photographed her with her hands in it, and had not sent the photograph to anyone because there was no one to send it to.

Friday it was in the same place, and nobody who is waiting for somebody waits two days in the same place.

She did not say anything to her mother. Margaret was 71 and had

spent the week pretending the radio was not on, and Laura had let her.

At twenty past eight a woman walked up the lane.

Laura saw her from the kitchen. She was alone, on foot, a dark coat buttoned, flat shoes, no bag, hands in her pockets against the wind off the field, and she walked up the middle of the lane without hurrying and without looking at the house, as though she had walked up it before. She came to the gate and opened it and closed it behind her and knocked on the front door, twice, with a knuckle.

Margaret had gone down to the shop for the paper, which she did at eight and read at nine as if it were a prescription. Elsie was on the kitchen floor with the saucepan and the wooden rings, posting and taking out, posting and taking out. Laura wiped her hands and went to the door and opened it on the chain, which her mother never used and which Laura had put across on Monday night without deciding to.

'Dr Whitlock. My name is Dana Kessler. I'm sorry to come to the house. I'd like five minutes, and I'd rather not have them on the step, but I will if you prefer.'

Mid-forties. Hair tied back. A small plain watch worn on the inside of the wrist, which Laura noticed because nurses wear them that way and almost nobody else does. She stood a full pace back from the door, square, weight even, hands out of her pockets and loose at her sides where they could be seen. It was how Laura stood when she went into a room where someone was frightened. She had been taught it. She recognised it being done to her.

'My daughter's in the kitchen,' Laura said.

'Then we can talk in the kitchen. I won't touch anything and I won't stay.'

Laura took the chain off. She would think afterwards about why, and conclude that it was because the woman had said "won't" and not "wouldn't", and Laura had believed her.

Kessler stood where Laura put her, by the door to the hall, and did not sit, and did not look round the kitchen the way a stranger does. She looked at Laura. Once, when Elsie dropped a ring on the tiles, her eyes went down and came back, and stayed back.

'Your husband has something that doesn't belong to him,' she said. 'I act for a client who would like it returned, and who has been patient. I want to be accurate about that word. He has been patient for the best part of a week and he was offered a very reasonable alternative to patience on Sunday, and he declined it. I've come to tell you two things. The first is that the offer could, with some difficulty, be revived. I'd be prepared to try.'

'And the second.'

'The second is that there are people interested in what your husband has who are less patient than my client, and who do not come to the front door and knock.'

She said it in the same voice as the first thing. Laura knew the flat voice for what it was, which was control, and she knew that the people who could hold it while they said the worst thing were the ones who had said it before.

'Who are they?'

'If I knew their names I'd be a good deal more worried than I am, and I'd like you to notice that I'm not telling you I'm not worried.'

'Who's your client?'

'Someone who'd pay money rather than take. That distinction is going to matter to you more than his name would.'

Elsie had got herself up on the leg of the table and was standing, holding on, looking at the stranger with the open, unembarrassed stare of someone who has been alive for a year and a day. Kessler did not smile at her. She did not do any of the things people do. She looked at the child for exactly as long as it took to see where she was, and then she looked at Laura again, and Laura, who had been going to

pick Elsie up, found that she did not want to cross the room to do it with this woman's attention on her and stayed where she was, by the sink, with the whole kitchen between them.

'You know where he is,' Kessler said. It was not a question.

'No.'

'You speak to him.'

Laura said nothing. The woman waited precisely as long as a doctor waits after asking how much someone drinks, and then let it go in the same way, as though the silence had been the answer and the answer had been noted.

'I'm not going to ask you where. I'd like you to give him a message, when you speak to him, and I'd like you to pass it on word for word, because the wording is the point.' She took a card from her coat pocket with two fingers and put it on the corner of the table nearest to her, not nearest to Laura, and took her hand away. Plain white. A mobile number. Nothing else. 'Tell him that I came to the house, that I knocked, and that I spoke to you in your kitchen with your daughter in the room, and that nothing happened. Tell him that is my way of doing this. Tell him it isn't everyone's.'

'Is that a threat?'

'No, Dr Whitlock. I've been very careful that it isn't.' A pause. 'That's rather the point of it.'

Then she said thank you for her time, and that she was sorry about the car, which she would move, and she let herself out, and shut the front door behind her quietly, the way you shut a door in a house where a child might be asleep.

Laura stood at the sink for a count of about twenty. Then she crossed the room and picked Elsie up, and Elsie put a hand flat on her face, and Laura realised that her own face was cold and her hands were not steady, and she looked at them, because that was what she did, as though they were someone else's. Tremor, fine, bilateral. Pulse up.

Mouth dry. She knew the presentation. She had treated it a thousand times, from the other side of the desk, in people who had just been told something by a professional.

That was the word that came, and she made herself look at it. A professional. The woman had not raised her voice or lowered it. She had not said anything that could be repeated to a police officer and sound like anything. She had kept her hands where they could be seen, used the child's presence without once using the child, and walked out leaving a card on the corner of the table and a kitchen that felt different. Laura did it for a living, the controlled delivery of a thing nobody wants to hear, and she had just had it done to her by someone better at it, and the part that frightened her most was that she had let her in because she was good.

Through the window she watched the dark coat go down the lane. The grey car's lights came on when the woman was still thirty yards from it, which meant there was someone in it, and had been on Thursday too, while Elsie had her hands in the cake.

Margaret came back from the shop at a quarter to nine and said the lane was clear for once, and Laura said yes, and looked at the clock.

He rang at nine. He had rung at nine every morning since Tuesday, from a call box, for as long as his coins lasted. He would not give her a number; he had explained why on Monday, and she had understood it and not forgiven it. It meant that she could not reach him. It meant that she had fifteen minutes to decide what to do with four.

She put Elsie in the high chair with a rusk, where she could see her, and stood by the phone with the card in her hand, and when it rang at two minutes past she picked it up before the first ring had finished.

'It's me.'

'A woman called Dana Kessler has just been in Mum's kitchen,' Laura said. 'She stood about there. Elsie was on the floor. She was very polite. She left a card.'

She heard him breathe out. She heard, behind him, a road, a lorry, the pips of a box that wanted more money. He did not say anything, and she had not left him anywhere to say it.

'She gave me a message for you and I'm going to give it to you word for word, because she said the wording was the point. She came to the house. She knocked. She spoke to me in my kitchen with my daughter in the room and nothing happened. That is her way of doing this. It isn't everyone's.' She let that sit for the length of one pip. 'I don't know what that means, Jonas. You do. I could hear you not telling me what it meant from here.'

'Laura—'

'You're going to come here. Now. Tonight. Not Sunday, not when it's safe, not when you've finished whatever you're doing. You get here tonight and you sit at this table and you tell me all of it, from the start, and I decide what we do, because I'm the one in the house. And if you're not here by the time I go to bed, I'm not waiting for eight o'clock this time. I ring the police myself, from this phone, and I give them her card and your name and I tell them everything I know, which is nothing, and that's your fault too. And this time I stay in the queue.'

'Laura—'

'Say yes.'

Three seconds. She counted those as well.

'Yes,' he said.

She put the phone down before he could say anything else, because her hands had started again, and she stood in her mother's hall with the card in her pocket and Elsie banging the tray in the kitchen and found that she was not frightened any more. She was something else. She would have to wait until he was in front of her to find out what.

Chapter 23

Norfolk

3.04am. Margaret's kitchen. The light over the cooker, because the main one shows from the lane. Elsie is asleep against my chest with her mouth open and I am writing round her, left-handed on the page edge, which is why this looks the way it does. I am not putting her down. That is a decision and I want it recorded as one.

Friday. In order.

Nine o'clock, the call box on the Kentish Town Road, Margaret's landline, as every day this week. Laura answered on the first ring and did not say hello. I wrote what she said on the previous page in the first sitting, back at Calloway's table at 9.30, while my hands were still doing it, because I wanted her words down before I started to improve them. I have read them back. I did not improve them. She said a woman called Dana Kessler had stood in her mother's kitchen with Elsie on the floor, and had been very polite, and had left a card. She said come tonight or I go to the police myself, and she said *say yes*, and I said yes, and the line went.

Then eight hours. Calloway could not leave the paper before five on a day when a second member was wobbling on every screen in the building, the car had to be in his name, and I was not going to stand on a platform at King's Cross in daylight with the rucksack on. Good

reasons. I sat behind the curtains and counted them and would have given every one away to be on a train.

While we waited for five, Calloway asked to photograph the first page of the Treasury's copy of the memo, and I let him, with my thumb across the footer, and told him it was not yet a story. Calloway hired the car. His name, his card, his licence, a branch on the Kentish Town Road. If Kessler still has someone on his door, they saw a hire car leave with two men in it, and I have decided not to think about that until I have to. At 4.50 Priya said, 'Go. We've got the page. I can copy a page. The codes and the order. Not the rest; the rest is in the books and stays there.' Then: 'She's right, you know. Whatever she said.' She did not know what Laura had said. She did not need to.

We left at 5.25. Calloway drove. Rucksack between my feet, a foot through each strap. He did not talk, and I watched the mirrors because he could not.

The M11 was Friday. Nothing until Stansted. Then, at the Cambridge turn, a marked car came off the slip road and sat behind us, two cars back, and stayed there for nine miles.

It did not close. It did not drop back. Calloway said, 'It's a motorway. There's a police car.' I said yes. We both watched it. The car was in his name; my name was on nothing. That is true, and it did not help, because the thing I have learned this week is that it is never the form you have thought about.

Cambridge. He came off for the city, and the car came off behind us. Into the traffic by the station. He slowed for a bus. I said, 'Here,' and he said, 'Here,' at the same time, and I had the door open at four miles an hour with the rucksack already on both shoulders, and I was on the pavement among people with wheeled cases before the bus had moved. I heard him pull away. I heard, a few seconds later, a second engine do the same, and I walked into the station like a man who was late for a train, which I was.

The 19.38 to Norwich. I paid in cash. Eighty minutes in the

vestibule with my back to the door. Thetford, in the dark, where Laura had driven on Sunday night with Elsie asleep behind her and the radio on.

Norwich, 20.57. No taxi; a taxi is a man who remembers where he dropped you. I walked out towards the ring road with the rucksack and a torn coat, and at a garage a man in a van who was filling up asked if I was all right, and I said I was trying to get to the village, and he said he went through it, and I got in.

He talked about the week. Everyone does. The cash machine at his bank had been empty on Wednesday. He asked what I did and I said insurance, which is the nearest true thing. He dropped me at the war memorial at 21.52.

The grey car was not at the end of it. I looked. I looked for a long time.

Laura opened the door before I knocked. She had been standing in the hall. She looked at me, and then at the rucksack, and then at my hands, in that order, and said, 'Kitchen.'

Margaret had gone up. Elsie was asleep. The card was on the table, in the middle, squared to the edge, with nothing else near it, the way you would leave a specimen. Laura sat down across from it and put her hands flat on the wood and said, 'From the start. Not from Wednesday. From the start.'

So I did. 22.40 to 00.50 by the clock on her mother's cooker. I am not going to write it all out; it is in these nine books already. I will put down what she heard.

That I was 36 and something in a reconciliation did not add up, and I wrote it down because I did not trust myself to remember, and the next night there was something else, and by the end of that year it was every night. That I was 37 and I wrote six pages to Graham and to the Treasury and said three years, and they said noted, and I was relieved. I told her that. I had never told anyone that. Relieved, because I had

done the thing, and nobody had asked me to do anything else.

That Elsie was born and I went on writing and it was different, and I could not tell her how, so I told her instead what #1 says: that I wanted to be wrong. That I kept the books in Dad's garage so that they would never be in the house. She asked why, and I said because I knew, somewhere, that one day somebody would come for them, and she looked at me for a while and said nothing.

Wednesday. The wrong inbox. Thursday, the pension fund's gilts, and the ship. Friday, the call, Graham, the Bank, the man in the grey jacket, the study. She stopped me there. 'They were in the study while I was at Aisha's.' I said yes. She said, 'You came up to bed after,' and I said yes, and she did not say the next thing.

Saturday, the Treasury: the Chancellor, the Governor, my own memo put in front of me on a table, the statement I did not sign. Sunday: Priya's number, Priya's flat, Kessler in the park, the three million. Her face did not change at the three million. It changed at Brambles. The lock-up, the gap in the wall, the fence, the river. Monday on a bench. The hotel. Calloway. Priya, held twenty hours by the police on a request from the Treasury, and I had thought it was Kessler. Last night: twelve codes on a page, and a name, Greywether, and a man, Crane, and a date nine days before the ship.

I said: I cannot prove it. I said that about four times, and the fourth time she said, 'I know, Jonas. You've said.'

She watched my hands for the first hour and my face for the second. She is a doctor taking a history, and I know what a history is for. It is for finding the thing the patient has not said.

When I stopped she sat for about a minute. Then she asked one question. I had been waiting for who, or why not the police, or how much danger; I had built answers to those on the train.

'Did you ever think of telling me?'

I said: it was work. I said: I didn't want to bring it home. I said: I thought if I told you, you'd make me do something, and I didn't know

what to do. I heard each one for what it was before it was finished. She let me get to the end of them. Then she said, 'Those are reasons you didn't. I asked if you ever thought of it.'

And the answer was no. In 1,408 entries I have never written the sentence *I should tell Laura*. I have written her name 300 times, perhaps. Her hands, her questions, the dates she asked. Never that. I sat at her mother's table at one in the morning and found that I had no good answer because there was no answer, only the fact.

I said, 'No.'

She nodded, as though a result had come back and it was the one she expected and had hoped not to see. She did not cry. I would have known what to do with that. She got up and put the kettle on and stood with her back to me while it boiled, and I looked at Kessler's card in the middle of the table and understood that the woman had used my wife's own method on her, and that I was the reason she had been able to.

Elsie woke at 1.30. Not crying. The sound she makes. Laura moved and I said, 'Let me,' and she looked at me and let me.

She was standing in the cot, holding the rail, and she looked at me in the dark for a long moment as if checking the face against the record, and then she said the thing that is nearly Dad and put her arms up.

She was one yesterday. I was in Kentish Town. She is heavier than on Sunday, which is not possible, and smells of her grandmother's house, and she went back under in four minutes and I have not put her down.

Laura came up after a while and stood in the doorway. Then she said, very quietly, 'Three million. You could have said yes and none of this.'

'Yes.'

'Would you say it now?'

I did not answer quickly, and she watched me not, and I think it was

the first thing all night she was glad to see.

'No,' I said.

'Good,' she said. 'Then it's the other thing. Whatever the other thing is, you do it. Not write it. Do it.' And went to bed.

3.04 when I started this. 3.31 now.

Here is what I know at half past three in the morning with my daughter asleep on me. A woman who does not threaten people stood in this room and did not threaten my wife, on behalf of a man I could not name on Sunday and can tonight. There are people less patient than her and I have not met them. I have rung a landline that is on every form her mother has ever filled in, at nine, these last two mornings from a box 200 yards from a journalist's door, and the police did not need to follow a car; they only need to ask.

The map is a page, and Priya has a copy of the codes and the order and nothing else, and a journalist has asked to print it and been told not yet. Four years of not yet. Laura asked if I had ever thought of telling her and I had not. The honest record of whether I have thought of telling anyone at all is 1,408 entries and a memo.

Tomorrow morning I find a call box and ring the number on Calloway's card and say the date, and when he picks up I tell him to run it. The memo, the date, the three years, and my name. Not the map; not yet; the map is the only thing that man does not have. But my name. Being right in a garage has been worth exactly nothing to the one person who asked.

Elsie is one. I am writing this with my left hand. Her right hand is holding my shirt, and I have counted her fingers, and there are five.

Chapter 24

Bailout

The Governor had asked for ten minutes without officials, and Caroline Strand had spent a career making sure that no conversation she took part in was ever without officials. A conversation without a note was a conversation that had not happened. That was its use, and that was its danger, and she had never before been on the side of the table that needed it.

So she gave him the flat. Saturday, eight o'clock, the sitting room above Downing Street with the curtains half drawn, two cups of coffee that neither of them touched and a table with nothing on it. Simon Carrow was downstairs in the outer office with the Saturday papers and instructions not to come up. The Governor arrived on foot from the Treasury side, in a coat that had seen better weather, and sat where she put him, and did not take out a pen.

'No note,' he said. It was not a question.

'No note. You asked for it.'

'I did.' He looked at the coffee and left it. 'Then I'll be quicker than I would be with one.'

A week ago, at a longer table, with the risk manager at the far end explaining the end of the world in a voice like a man reading gas meters, the Governor had said very little and let her run it. He was not letting her run this.

‘You know where we are with Walbrook,’ he said.

‘Tell me as if I didn’t.’

‘A member failed on Monday. Walbrook declared the default, took the book and has been hedging it all week. The auction of what’s left starts Tuesday; that is the fastest it has ever been done. The defaulter’s own margin is gone. Its contribution to the default fund is gone. Walbrook’s own capital, the layer they are required to put in before anyone else loses a penny, went on Thursday afternoon. They are now spending the other members’ money. The default fund is built to survive the two largest members failing at once. It has survived one, in a market that has fallen every day since.’

‘And the second.’

‘There is a second.’ He gave her the name. She had asked for it, in the sense that she had asked him to speak as if she knew nothing, and she took it the way one takes a diagnosis: without moving. It was a name people had on their debit cards. ‘It met Friday’s call at ten to nine with money it borrowed from us on Thursday night. It will meet Monday’s, probably. I do not think it meets Tuesday’s. Within days, Chancellor. Not weeks.’

‘And if it fails.’

‘Then the fund is through, and Walbrook turns to the survivors for more, and the survivors are the thirty-eight institutions who have been selling everything they own all week to pay the calls they already have. Some of them will refuse. Some of them will not be able to. At that point Walbrook Clearing House cannot meet its obligations, and it will say so, because it is required to say so, to me.’

She let a silence go by, which was a barrister’s habit: let the witness hear his own answer.

‘What does that mean,’ she said. ‘Precisely. Not the clearing house. The country.’

‘Every trade it stands behind, frozen.’

‘Frozen.’

‘Not paused. Frozen as in nobody knows what they are owed. Walbrook sits in the middle of every contract its members have cleared. If it stops, there is no middle. Every pension fund that has hedged the pensions it owes has a hedge with no counterparty. Every bank that has fixed its funding has unfixed it. Every mortgage rate in this country is priced off a market that no longer exists, and so is every rate in every country that has ever dealt in sterling, which is all of them. The last time anyone added up the contracts behind a clearing house, the answer had so many noughts that we stopped quoting it. In the meantime nobody pays anyone.’

‘We have a regime for that,’ she said. ‘Resolution. It’s yours.’

‘I have the power. I do not have the money. The power lets me take over the clearing house, tear up the contracts that cannot be met and allocate the losses. The losses are still losses. Nobody has ever put a clearing house into resolution anywhere in the world, and the reason is that by the time you need to, there is nothing left to resolve with. It is a fire door. It is not a sprinkler.’

There was no record. That was the point of the flat. She found it did not help.

‘Options,’ she said. ‘I’d like the options.’

‘There are three. Two are mine. One is yours.’ He held up a hand and did not count on it, which she noticed. ‘One: from Monday morning the Bank lends to Walbrook, and to any member that asks, against whatever collateral they can still find, at whatever rate I choose, in whatever quantity. I need nobody’s permission for that and I have already given the instruction. It buys days. Possibly a week. It does not buy the second member, because the second member’s problem is not that it cannot borrow. It is that what it has borrowed against is worth less every morning.’

‘Two.’

‘Two: the Bank buys. Government bonds, outright, in size, from Monday, for as long as it takes to put a floor under the price of the

thing everyone's collateral is made of. It worked last time. It worked because the market believed we would not stop. I may lose money doing it. It is not my money to lose. So I need your indemnity, in writing, before I do it.'

'And I said no on Tuesday.'

'You said no on Tuesday. On Tuesday one member had failed and the fund was intact and you had four weeks to polling day. You still have four weeks to polling day.' It was the only thing he said all morning that could have been called unkind, and he said it in the same voice as the rest. 'Three is yours. You are entitled to do nothing. I am then obliged to write to you, formally, that in the Bank's opinion public funds may be at risk. Once that letter exists, you may direct the Bank. I would, as it happens, welcome being directed. But the letter would exist. And so would the fact that you had it.'

So that was why he had wanted no note. Not for himself. For her. He was offering her the one morning in the week in which she could decide without having been told.

'Say it,' she said. 'The word. I'd like to hear you say it so I can stop waiting for it.'

'Bailout.'

'Thank you. Now give me the version that doesn't have it in.'

'There isn't one.' He did, finally, pick up the coffee, and held it without drinking. 'There is the word and there is the thing. You can have the thing without the word for about a week, if we start on Monday and we are lucky and nobody at the Treasury writes anything down. After that you have the word without the thing, because the thing will have happened by itself, and it will be called something worse.'

She stood up, because she thought better standing, and because she wanted a moment with her back to him.

A week ago she had sat at the head of a table and told a man that the system was held up by the belief that it was held up. The difference was that a week ago she had thought belief was something she could

manufacture by saying the right sentence on breakfast television, and that if the risk manager signed it as well, it would hold. He had not signed. She had said it anyway. It had held for forty minutes.

The memo was in her box. It had been in her box since the Wednesday before the sinking, in a folder Simon had marked with a yellow flag, and she had read Simon's cover note, two paragraphs, and not the six pages under it. She knew the phrase in it, because Carrow had put it in the cover note: approximately three years. She noticed that she was thinking about the memo instead of the decision, and recognised the manoeuvre, because she had watched juries do it.

'If I give you the indemnity on Monday,' she said, 'what do you announce?'

'That the Bank is undertaking temporary purchases of government bonds to restore orderly conditions, on the instruction of the Governor, with the full backing of the Treasury. Your name is in the second sentence. There is no form of words in which it is not.'

'And the Opposition says that a government that spent a week saying "sound" has spent the taxpayer's money four weeks before an election to prove it was lying.'

'Yes.'

'And the alternative is that I say "sound" for another week and then Walbrook rings you.'

'Yes.'

She turned round. He had put the coffee down.

'I want the weekend,' she said.

'You have it.' He stood, and did up the coat. 'I would only say, Chancellor, that Walbrook's call goes to the banks at eight on Monday morning. The weekend ends at seven. Not at midnight on Sunday. People always think it is midnight on Sunday.'

She saw him down herself, and did not offer a hand, and he did not look for one. At the door he said, 'I'm sorry it was me,' which she decided, later, had been the truth.

Simon Carrow was on the stairs before the door had closed. He had a sheet of paper in his hand and the face he wore when he had been given something he could not make smaller.

‘Chancellor. Press office. Came in at half past eight.’

She took it. A single page, an email printed out, from a journalist whose name she knew from a pensions story last autumn. Eleven questions. Numbered. The first one was the only one that mattered, and he had put it first because he knew it.

1. Did the Chancellor see a memorandum dated [three years ago], from the head of collateral risk at Walbrook Clearing House, received and stamped by HM Treasury, estimating that the system had “approximately three years before a moderate shock becomes unmanageable”? If not, who did, and what action was taken?

Response by 6pm today for publication Sunday.

The ninth question asked whether the Treasury had made any request to the police concerning any present or former Walbrook employee. She read it twice and set it aside for a worse room.

‘Draft the reply,’ Carrow said. ‘I’ll have it to you in an hour.’

‘No.’ She took a pen from the table by the door, the first pen anyone had held in the flat that morning, and wrote on the back of the sheet, standing, in the hand that had once filled a hundred blue notebooks. *The Chancellor did not see the document. Correspondence of this kind is handled at official level in the normal way and is not routinely put to ministers. The Treasury does not comment on matters that may be the subject of police inquiries.*

It was true. Every word. She had not seen the document; she had seen a cover note on a Wednesday, and a stapled copy slide across a table a week ago, and the phrase, and she had turned no page. A department’s knowledge was the department’s. She knew the doctrine by name. So, she thought, would he.

‘That’s the response,’ she said. ‘Nothing else. Not a word more.’

Carrow read it, and read it again, and his face did not change, which she had hired him for.

'Yes, Chancellor.'

She went back upstairs. The coffee had gone cold in both cups. She had asked for the weekend, and it was ten past nine on Saturday morning, and the weekend was already Sunday's front page.

Chapter 25

Warned

Sunday. Margaret's kitchen. Two sittings, I expect. The first is before anyone is up.

The cheap phone buzzed at 5.58 on the windowsill where I had left it to get a signal. One line, from the only person I have given the number to. *Up.*

I did not go and look. I sat with it for a while, because it was the last while in which I was a man in a kitchen and not a man in a newspaper. It felt like a kitchen.

Laura came down at 6.20 with Elsie on her hip and her phone in her other hand, already lit. She had heard the buzz through the floor. She put Elsie in the high chair, put the phone face up on the table between us and said, 'Well. Read it.'

So I read it. Then I read it again, with my finger on the screen, because the first time my eyes had gone to the wrong things.

The headline is five words. *Treasury was warned three years ago.* Below it, a picture of the first page of my memo, at an angle, so the reader can see the letterhead and the stamp: RECEIVED, HM TREASURY, the date, and in biro the two words. *Noted. File.* The footer is not in the picture. On Friday afternoon, at his table, waiting for five o'clock, I let him photograph the first page with my thumb across the bottom of it. He saw me do it and did not ask. One story a week,

Jonas, he said. The footer is still the only thing I own that nobody else knows about, and a journalist in Kentish Town now knows that there is something under my thumb.

The story has 1,014 words. I counted them because I count. It says that a six-page memorandum written by Walbrook's head of collateral risk, three years ago this month, and received by the Treasury a week later, estimated that the system had approximately three years before a moderate shock became unmanageable. It quotes the sentence. It says the memo was sent to the Treasury by Walbrook with a covering note describing it as one analyst's view. It says that the author of the memo is understood to be the person sought by police for questioning in connection with a complaint by Walbrook, and that Walbrook has obtained a High Court order against him for the return of documents. It does not name him. It says the paper is not naming him for legal reasons. I rang Calloway from the box by the war memorial at five to eight yesterday, before the shop had opened, and told him to run it, and to run my name with it. He said the lawyers would have a view on the name. They had a view. He said it would last until somebody else said it.

Then, two-thirds down, a Treasury spokesperson. *The Chancellor did not see the document. Correspondence of this kind is handled at official level in the normal way and is not routinely put to ministers. The Treasury does not comment on matters that may be the subject of police inquiries.*

I believe her. I want that on the page. I think she had not read it when Carrow slid it across the table, and has not since. She had the phrase. Nobody who had read the tables would have needed the phrase. And it does not matter. The stamp is the Treasury's. The biro is the Treasury's. The person who wrote *Noted* was paid by the Treasury to note things, and he noted, and the Chancellor did not see it, and all three of those are true at once. That is what a department is. I have worked inside institutions for fifteen years. The Chancellor did not see

it the way Walbrook did not see it: on purpose, in the normal way.

Laura read it standing, with Elsie's spoon in one hand. She read it faster than I did.

'Three years ago this month,' she said.

'Yes.'

'You'd have been thirty-seven.' She did not look up from the screen. 'I remember thirty-seven. You came home one night in the autumn with a face like a man who'd been to a funeral, and I asked, and you said work. I thought it was a bad week. It was the memo, wasn't it. That week.'

I had not put those two things together. Fourteen hundred entries, and I had never once written down what my face did when I got home. She had. She has been keeping a record too. Hers is just not on paper.

She put the spoon in the bowl. 'You're not named.'

'Not yet.'

'How long?'

'Walbrook will do it. They'll want it to be about me by lunchtime.'

She looked at me the way she looks at a reading she has taken herself and does not like. 'You've got a lot better at predicting them,' she said, 'for a man who was wrong about them for four years.'

Second sitting. Four in the afternoon. Elsie asleep upstairs and Margaret in the garden, not gardening, where she has been most of the day, I think so that we would have the kitchen.

I was right about lunchtime. I was out by twenty minutes.

8.30. Radio. Margaret's kitchen radio is the kind with a dial, and it was on the station she listens to, and the story was second, after the pound. The presenter read the headline and the Treasury line and then said that a former government lawyer was on the line. I did not catch the name and I am not going to pretend to. He said three things. One: no offence under the Official Secrets Act has been committed by anyone, because the Act does not cover economic information and a

note about collateral is not a secret in law, whatever it is in Whitehall. Two: whoever passed the paper to the press, if it was a civil servant, is at risk of their job and not their liberty, and if it was the author, is at risk of nothing at all, because a private citizen cannot leak his own memo. Three, which the presenter had not asked for: that it was worth saying, since the word had been used all week, that information cannot be stolen in this country, there being a case about it from the seventies involving an exam paper, and that what Walbrook had was a civil order, not a crime.

'Who's he?' Laura said.

'I don't know.'

'He's the first person all week who's said you haven't done anything.'

'He said I haven't committed anything. It's not the same.'

'Jonas.' She turned the radio down. 'Take it.'

9.40. The paper's site updated. *Walbrook: memo "considered and not accepted" at the time.* A statement over Haldane's name. Mr Whitlock's note was considered by the risk committee in the normal way and its conclusions were not accepted by the firm; the firm has since been in dialogue with the Treasury and the Bank on an ongoing basis; the firm will not comment further on an individual who is the subject of legal proceedings. Mr Whitlock. Twice. They had put my name in the second line to make a point about proceedings and the paper had the name it had been waiting for.

Risk committee. The memo went to Graham and Graham sent it to the Treasury with a note calling it one analyst's view. I have never been told it went to a committee. I have noted every risk committee for four years in the books on the floor beside me and I checked, at 9.50, with Laura watching: nothing. Either there was a committee meeting I was not told about, which I would believe, or Haldane has invented one on a Sunday morning, which I would also believe. Both are now on the record and one of them is a lie, and the only man who can show which is the man the record is about.

11.15. Named. The paper, then everyone. By noon it was everywhere Laura looked. By 12.40 there was a photograph. I had not known it existed. A conference, four years ago, the week I started the record, as it happens; somebody's phone; me at a lectern in a tie, mouth open, saying something about haircuts.

Laura looked at the photograph for a long time. 'They've chosen one where you look guilty,' she said. 'All men in ties look guilty. It's the collar.'

Elsie reached for the phone. She likes faces. She got it, and I let her, and she held my face in both hands on the kitchen table and put it in her mouth, and Laura took it off her before she could do any damage, and that was the moment I became a headline: watching my daughter try to eat it.

Counting. Six pages, three years ago. Five words. One thousand and fourteen. Twenty minutes out. One kitchen.

What has changed since six this morning, in order.

One. Everyone who knows Laura knows that her mother lives in a village near Norwich. Tom and Aisha. The surgery, all of it. Brambles. By this evening all of them will have seen my face in a tie, and some of them will put the two things together, and one of them will say so to somebody. The police do not even need that. They have the car's number, from Monday, if they want it, and the car is outside this house. Norfolk was safe when I was a name nobody knew. I have been named for five hours. The grey car has not been at the end of the lane since Friday morning, and I have stopped reading that as good news. People who stop watching have usually learned what they wanted to know.

Two. The man who wants the books now knows what the man who has them looks like. So does everyone who works for him.

Three. So does the other side. I have spent four years not writing the name of the largest line in my own reports, in my own notebook, that nobody else read. I was proud of that. Several million people

have now read that I wrote a memo, and one of them, I would bet the house four times over, works for the fund that pulled its collateral a week ago and knows exactly whose job it was to count it. The one institution in London that is long everything my hunter is short. The one that has lost more this week than anybody, and knows it, and does not know why, and has a London office with a door.

I have never walked through a door and said my name to a stranger and expected it to mean anything. It means something today. It is the only thing I own that went up this morning.

Laura came in while I was writing that. She read the last line over my shoulder, which she has never done in six years, and I let her, which I have never done either.

'You're going back,' she said.

'Tonight. Not the way I came.'

'And do what?'

'Walk into a building in St James's and say who I am.'

She stood there for a bit. Then she went to the drawer where Margaret keeps the envelopes and took out one with cash in it that I had not known about, and put it on the table next to this book.

'Mum's,' she said. 'For the roof. I'll tell her.' And then, because she is Laura, and because she has had a week to think about what she would say when I left again: 'If you're going to be in the paper anyway, be in it for something you said. Not for something they found.'

I have to pack. It is twenty to five. There is a bag open on the bed, and this time it is mine.

Chapter 26

Terms

He wanted it in person, which told Dana Kessler most of what she needed to know before she had sat down.

Clients who were pleased rang. Clients who were frightened wanted you in the room, where they could watch your face while they said the thing they had decided to say, and then tell themselves afterwards that you had agreed to it. She arrived at four minutes past nine, by the quiet street, past a parking warden writing a ticket with great care, and was shown up by a young man who did not ask her name because he had been told not to.

The room had no screens. She had been in it three times and had never liked it. A man who paid thirty-one people to watch prices on the floor below him and would not have one on his own wall was a man who wanted the numbers brought to him by hand, by someone else, so that they arrived already shaped. It was not modesty. It was a way of never having been told.

‘Dana. Sit.’

She sat. Crane did not. He stood at the window with his hands behind his back and let her see that he had been standing there a while.

‘You said Norfolk,’ he said.

‘Friday to Sunday. The wife’s mother’s house, a village outside Nor-

wich. He arrived Friday night, late, by a route that cost him most of a day, in a hire car in the journalist's name, which my people watched leave Kentish Town with two men in it. He stayed in. The wife, the child, the mother-in-law. Nobody else came or went until the paper named him yesterday morning. At twenty to seven last night he left the house and came back to London the long way, five hours of it. One of my people stayed with him. He went to the journalist's flat in Kentish Town, where the analyst is, and the light went off at ten to one. He had the rucksack on his back the whole way, both straps, the way you carry a child's bag. The notebooks have not left his body since the Sunday before last. I would be surprised if they left it to shower.'

'And you did not take them on the train.'

'A train is a tube with witnesses, Mr Crane. Six carriages, a guard, and sixty people with phones who had seen his photograph that morning. No.'

He turned round at that, and she saw his face properly for the first time, and revised her estimate of the morning downward. He looked like a man who had slept and been congratulated and had, somewhere in the small hours, decided something.

'The price has gone up,' he said.

'Whose?'

'Yours. There is no offer to him any more. I withdrew it at half past four last Monday and I am not renewing it; a man who is on the front page is not a man I can pay. So I am no longer buying, I am acquiring, and that is a different kind of work and I will pay for it as such.' He named the figure. It was double what the retainer had been, without a breath on either side. 'And the urgency has gone up with it.'

'The paper.'

'Not the paper. The paper is a nuisance; it makes him visible, and it makes him feel safe, and both of those will be useful to you by the end of the week.' He sat down at last, on his own side of the empty desk, and put his hands flat on it. 'On Friday afternoon two of my brokers

rang me within an hour of each other, which they have never done in their lives, to tell me in a roundabout way that a client of theirs had asked for the dates of certain trades of mine. A sovereign client. Not the trades themselves, which they would not have given, but the dates on which the positions were put on. Somebody in a Gulf capital has a very large loss and a very good analyst, and the analyst has noticed that I was positioned for a shipping accident before there had been one.'

'Were you?'

'I was positioned for a shock, Dana. I have been positioned for a shock since the spring, and I said so to anyone who would listen, and most of them laughed. The dates are a coincidence of the kind that a fund which has lost a great deal of money will find hard to forgive.' He smiled, briefly, the smile he used when he was pleased with a sentence. 'The point is this. The fund has the money to stop what is happening, if it knew where to put it. It does not know where. He does. If those two meet before I have the books, I am no longer the only man in London with the map, and a map that two people have is a map that nobody has. I want the notebooks by the weekend. By whatever route works.'

She let a few seconds go by, because she had learned long ago that a client would fill a silence with the thing he had been trying not to say, and because she wanted it said.

He did not fill it. He was better than most.

'The routes,' she said, 'in order. Watch. Search. Offer. Pressure. Force. We have watched, we have searched, we have offered, twice. We are at pressure, and I applied it on Friday, in a kitchen, and the result was that the subject went to his wife rather than away from her, which is a result I have seen before and did not expect from him. Force on a man with a rucksack in central London is a mugging, and a mugging goes wrong one time in three and makes the news the other two. Which leaves pressure, applied harder. Pressure, Mr Crane, means the family. You know that. You said so yourself last Tuesday.'

‘I said you would know where to apply it.’

‘You did. And I said how I work.’

‘And I said I hadn’t realised you had a way.’ He said it lightly. He was enjoying himself, she saw, which was worse than if he had been angry. ‘I’m not asking for a method. I have never once asked you for a method; you’ve said so to me, with some pride. I am asking for a result by the weekend and telling you that the route is yours to choose. Whatever works.’

‘Does whatever works include the child?’

She asked it exactly as she had asked the time of the train. She had decided on the stairs that she would ask it, and that she would ask it in that voice, so that whatever he answered would be an answer and not a reaction.

He did not say no.

He looked at her for a moment with an expression she could only have described as interest, as if she had shown him a card he had not known was in the pack, and then he said, ‘Dana, I have told you what I want,’ and then he said nothing else at all.

She counted to five. She did not hear a no.

‘I’ll be in touch,’ she said, ‘when there is something to hear.’ And she stood, and buttoned her coat, and went to the door without having agreed to anything, which she had done perhaps three times in fifteen years of government service and never since.

‘By the weekend,’ he said to her back.

‘I heard you, Mr Crane.’

The firm had three rooms over a dry cleaner’s and no name on the door, and when she came in at twenty past ten the one of her three who did not do surveillance looked up and then looked down again, which was the correct response to her face.

She sat at her own desk and did what she did with every subject on the first morning, which was the first fifteen minutes. She told

everyone who worked for her the same thing: most of what people believe is hidden is on a public register for a few pounds, and the trick is not access but order. You do the registers before you do anything else, because the registers do not know you have looked.

She opened a new file. She gave it a number, as she gave every subject a number, in the sequence, after Whitlock's.

Companies House. Greywether Capital, the limited liability partnership and the two companies that were its members; the designated members; the filing history for ten years, every change of registered office and every confirmation statement, downloaded in the order they had been filed. The FCA register, the firm's permissions, the individuals approved to run it, the dates. The Land Registry: the building on the quiet street, held through a company whose own filings she opened in a second window; the house in the country she had not known about until the title showed it; the flat. The Electoral Commission: donations by individual, by year, to a party she did not need to look up, in amounts she wrote down without comment because a figure was a figure. The Charity Commission: a museum trust, a trustee's name, the year he had joined.

None of it was secret. All of it was Crane. That was the point of the fifteen minutes: not to find the thing, but to know the shape of the man before the thing was found, so that when it was, you would know where it fitted.

Then she stopped and did what she would have told anyone else was the second step, which was to write down the question. She wrote: *What did he know, and when.*

The registers would not tell her that. A fund's positions were not public; a short on a government's bonds and its currency left no mark on any register she could reach. But dates were different. Dates were everywhere. A tanker had sunk on a Thursday night, and that was a date. A fund had, by its own founder's admission in a room with no screens, been positioned before it. The sovereign fund's analyst,

whoever he or she was, had got as far as asking brokers for dates. If a very large loss and a very good analyst could get there from the outside, so could she, and she had one thing the analyst did not, which was the client's own voice, that morning, saying *the dates are a coincidence* in the tone he used for sentences he had rehearsed.

She wrote the date of the sinking at the top of a clean page, and under it the word *before*, and left the rest of the page empty, because the rest of the page was the job.

The rule about children was not a moral position. She had said so to Whitlock in the park, about something else, and it was true of this as well. It was a rule. Rules were what you had instead of judgement at four in the morning, when judgement was the first thing to go. She had made it a long time ago and she had never had to explain it to a client, because no client had ever before failed to say no.

She did not write that down.

At 11.06 her phone went. The man she had put on the subject, from a street she could picture.

'He's gone in,' he said. 'Office building, St James's. Walked straight up to the desk. Gave his name. His real one, out loud, like he wanted it heard.'

'Whose building?'

He read her the plate beside the door.

It was the name Crane had not said.

Chapter 27

The largest line

Monday. Week three. London again.

I am not writing how I came down from Norfolk. I have learned that lesson and I am keeping it. I will write that it took five hours and 20 minutes, that I did not sit facing anyone, and that at one point a man across the aisle opened a newspaper with my face on the front of it, folded it to the crossword, and did it in biro for 40 minutes without once looking up. That is what being famous is. It is a man doing a crossword on your face.

Laura said, at the door, 'You have one week.' Not a question. She has stopped asking me questions, which is worse.

Twelve names. I have had them since Thursday night, on one page, folded inside the ninth book, in Priya's handwriting and mine. Twelve members, in the order they fail, and what, I think, each is holding that it has promised to more than one person. I cannot prove a line of it. I have written that sentence in nine books and I am writing it again so that nobody who finds this page thinks I have forgotten.

What I can do is read it. And on the train, reading it for the ninth or tenth time, I did the sum I should have done a week ago. A map of where the selling will come from is only worth anything to two sorts of people: the people who want to sell first, and the people who could

buy. Crane is the first sort. He has been paid every minute since last Monday and he still wants the books, and the reason he wants them is to know which three doors to kick next. I have spent a week running from the first sort. I have not once gone looking for the second.

There is only one buyer. I have known his line for four years without knowing his name. The largest line in the collateral report, every morning, through three clearing banks, segregated, in an account that says who it is to anyone in our building who cares to look. The fund that pulled its collateral last week and started this. The fund that has spent five working days turning British government bonds into cash and moving the cash somewhere it cannot be frozen. Everybody else in London is holding bonds that fall every hour. He is the one man holding the money.

He broke it. He is the only one who can afford to buy the pieces.

Priya said, at Calloway's table last night, that it was the stupidest idea I had had in four years and also the first one that involved leaving the room. Calloway gave me the address. He had rung it, twice, last week, for a comment, and got the same woman both times saying the fund did not comment.

St James's. A street of the kind where the brass plates do not say what the building is for. The fund's London office has a plate with four letters on it and a door that is opened for you by a man who has already decided whether to open it.

I had thought about this for five hours on a train and I still had no better plan than the truth. I gave my name. I said I would like to speak to the managing director's office. The man at the door looked at me for the length of time it takes to compare a face with a photograph, and then he said, 'One moment, sir,' and went behind a desk and picked up a phone and said my name into it, quite quietly, as if it were a password.

The lobby. Marble, a rug, two chairs nobody has sat in, a bowl of

white flowers that were real. A screen on the wall with the sound off, which this week means a red line falling. 11.04 by the clock above the desk. I stood with the rucksack on both shoulders and counted the flowers. Fourteen.

A woman came down. Not the managing director. Not anyone, as far as I could tell: a good suit, a lanyard turned round so the name faced in, a card already in her hand. The office's card. The four letters, the street, a switchboard number. She said the managing director was not in London. She said that if I had a matter to raise I was welcome to put it in writing to the address on the card. She said it very politely and she had said it before, to Calloway, twice.

I said I did not have anything in writing that I could put in the post, and that I thought Mr Al-Mansouri would want to know what else was in the notebooks. I said his name. I had never said it aloud before. Four years of a line in a report.

She did not blink. She had read the paper too. 'Is there a number,' she said, 'where you can be reached?'

There is one. It is a telephone I bought for cash from a shop on the Caledonian Road a week ago, and I can count on one hand the people who have the number. I have been careful with it the way I was careful with the books, which is to say that I have kept it and done nothing with it. I wrote the number on the visitor's slip she gave me, in the box marked Company. I did not have a company. I wrote Walbrook and then crossed it out, and she watched me do it.

'Thank you, Mr Whitlock.' And the door, opened for me, by the same man.

Eleven minutes. A lobby and a card. I stood on the pavement in St James's with a sovereign wealth fund's switchboard number in my hand and understood that I had just done the one thing I have never done in 1,412 entries, which is walk in somewhere and ask.

I went to the park. Not the one by Priya's. The one with the lake, the

one you reach from the bottom of that street in four minutes, because I could not think where else to stand still. Halfway along the water I looked up and understood where I was. Across the lake, the backs of the buildings on Horse Guards Road. Third floor. A room overlooking the park, where nine days ago a woman had put six pages in front of me and asked me to say they were wrong. I had walked to within 400 yards of the Treasury with the books on my back. I sat down on a bench with my back to it. I have sat on a lot of benches this week.

I gave it an hour, because that is what you give. If nothing came I would go back to Kentish Town and tell Priya she was right about the idea and wrong about the leaving.

11.52. The phone, which has rung four times since I bought it, rang.

A number I did not know, long, beginning with a code I did know. I let it ring twice because a man who answers at once is a man who has been waiting, and then I thought: I have been waiting for four years, and answered.

'Mr Whitlock.' A man's voice. Not the switchboard. Unhurried, exact, English learned early and kept carefully. 'My name is Khalid Al-Mansouri. You came to my office this morning. I am told you were polite about it.'

I said that I had tried to be.

'I have read Mr Calloway's article. I read it on Sunday, and again this morning, which I do not do with newspapers.' A pause that was not hesitation. 'It says that three years ago you wrote six pages to the British Treasury, and that they were filed. It says that the remainder of what you know is in a set of notebooks which the police would like to discuss with you. It does not say what is in them. I would like to know what is in them.'

'A list,' I said.

'Of what?'

'Of who is next. In order.'

Nothing on the line for a moment. Somewhere behind him a door

closed. When he spoke again his voice had not changed at all, and I noticed that it had not.

'How long is the list, Mr Whitlock?'

'Twelve.'

'And how long have you had it?'

'Since Thursday, on one page. Since I was 36, in pieces.'

'Yes,' he said. 'The article gave that impression.' And then, as if it followed: 'I am not in London. I will be, tomorrow. There is a hotel on Park Lane that my office uses. Seven o'clock, tomorrow evening. Give your name at the desk and ask for Nasser; he is my chief of staff and he will bring you up. You will be searched, and I apologise for that in advance. You will come alone.'

'How do I know who you are?'

'You do not,' he said. 'You have my switchboard number on a card in your pocket. Ring it and ask for me, and you will be told that I am not in London, which is true. I am afraid that is the best I can do by telephone. Mr Whitlock. You came to me. I am assuming you had a reason, and that it was not money.'

'I had a reason,' I said.

'Then you may tell me tomorrow. I will listen for as long as it takes. Good morning.'

The line went. 11.57. Five minutes. I have had longer conversations with the man who sells me a travelcard.

I sat on the bench for some time afterwards and did what I do, which is count what had changed.

One hand's worth of people had this number this morning. The newest is a state. I do not know what a state does with a telephone number. I know what the police can do with one. I have decided, sitting here, that I will keep the phone on, because a man who has just asked a sovereign wealth fund to ring him back cannot then hide from the call, and because I am tired of being a person who cannot be

reached. Laura would say that is the first sensible thing I have written in a fortnight. She would also ask why it took a stranger.

Crane's people, Walbrook, the Treasury, the police, a newspaper, and now a Gulf fund: every one of them knew more about my week than my wife did until Friday night. That is the record I actually kept. Not the one in the bag.

The bag. I have it on my knees as I write this, in a room in Kentish Town that is not mine, at a table that is not mine, with Priya across from me reading what I have written over my shoulder and not commenting, which for her is an act of love. Nine books. The twelve names folded inside the ninth. The pay-as-you-go on the table, face up, on. Everywhere I have gone since Sunday week I have carried it all, on both shoulders, and I have told myself that this was the safe way, because the books are only safe where I am.

Tomorrow I go into a hotel on Park Lane and I am searched before I am let into a room. Nobody has yet said what happens to a rucksack.

Chapter 28

The hotel

Tuesday. Written on hotel paper, four sheets of it, taken from the writing desk in a lobby on Park Lane while a man in a waistcoat looked for a bag that was not there. The pen is mine. It was in my coat. That is why I still have it.

I am going to write the meeting first, in order, and try to write it the way I would have at seven o'clock, when I knew less. I will not manage it. You will see where I do not.

Nasser met me in the lobby at 6.58. Grey suit, no lanyard, a face that had decided about me on the way across the carpet. He shook my hand. Then he said, 'The bag, Mr Whitlock,' and I said the bag came with me, and he said, quite kindly, that it did not: nothing went up to the floor that had not been through his people, and his people did not open other men's bags, so the hotel would hold it. A girl in a waistcoat at the cloakroom gave me a numbered ticket, thin card with a crest on it, and hung the rucksack on a rail between a camel coat and an umbrella, and I watched it go onto the hook the way you watch a child go through a school gate. Ticket 63. I buttoned it into the inside pocket of my coat and went upstairs with the man who had made me do it. Two men outside the suite went through the coat and gave me back the pen, the phone and the ticket.

Khalid Al-Mansouri stood up when I came in. I do not know why I

had not expected that.

A long room, a table under the window with the park going dark behind it and Park Lane's traffic making the glass hum. No screens. Papers in four piles, squared. He is 47 and looks it in the way men do who have been tired for a long time and do not mention it. He gave me his hand and then a chair, and said, 'I have not slept in your time zone yet. You will forgive me if I am direct. I owe you an account first, because you cannot judge what I ask for until you know what I know. Then you will owe me one.'

He turned the first pile round to face me. Trade confirmations, a dozen pages, the counterparty names blacked out properly. Dates down the left-hand side. I read dates for a living. I saw it before he said it.

'My cousin's name is Faisal. He runs a private office at home for a part of my family. Not a large one. Three weeks ago it became large. These are its trades, from nine days before a ship sank in the Strait. Oil, bought. My own country's currency, sold forward. British government bonds, sold, through two intermediaries, in size. Freight. Insurers. Everything a man would do if he knew that on a certain night the Strait would close and nobody would know why.'

I asked who the counterparty was.

'On nine of the twelve tickets, the same name. Greywether Capital. You know it. Mr Calloway did not print it, but a man who has sat where you sat for four years does not need a newspaper for that.'

I said that Priya had found Greywether's largest positions dated nine days before the sinking, and that we had not known what it meant.

'It means this. Faisal is not a trader. He needed to move a great deal of money quietly, in a market that watches my country's money the way you watch a line in your report. He needed someone on the other side who would not ask why, who would take the risk onto his own book for a day and lay it off in pieces so that nothing showed. Mr Crane stood there, and was paid in the only coin that matters to

him, which is the date. He did not sink the ship. He knew the night it would sink, and every pension fund in London has paid him for that knowledge since.'

I asked whether his government had done it.

'A faction in my family did it, to remove the men who run my country, by making my country the thing the world is afraid of. They have very nearly succeeded. My government has spent two weeks saying it was not us, and it was not, and it was. I cannot say that on television. I can say it to a man who has spent four years writing down what he could not prove.'

It was never an accident. I have written the word "accident" about that ship in six entries and I was wrong six times.

Then it was my turn. I am not writing it out; I have written it 1,412 times already and tonight I cannot carry it. Fingerprints, paired fails, cash at nine and bonds at three, four years of it. The memo. Twelve names and an order. That I could not prove the chains and had never claimed to. He listened without taking a note, and when I said "cannot prove" he nodded as if I had passed something.

'You did not bring the page.' Not a question.

'It is in the bag.'

'Which my people would not let up.' The smallest movement of his mouth. 'That is the first thing my security has protected me from this week that I actually wanted.'

I am writing that sentence down exactly because of what it turned out to mean.

'Mr Whitlock. You did not come to St James's to tell a stranger he was right. What do you want from me?'

I told him, in plain words. Twelve members are going to be forced to sell what they hold, in an order I know, over the next week, and each sale makes the next one certain. Nobody in London can buy; everyone in London is a seller. The one man in the world with the cash and a reason was sitting across a table from me. If a buyer with the map

bought exactly what the weakest members were about to be forced to sell, at the moment they had to sell it, in the order they were going to fail, the selling would stop. Not slow. Stop. And anyone who had been short those twelve names since nine days before the ship would be squeezed until he broke.

'I want a buyer,' I said. 'You want what is in the books. It is the same thing.'

He looked at the table rather than at me. I know the look; I have worn it. A man who has seen the figure and is checking it before he says it aloud.

'You are asking me to bring my client's money back into the one jurisdiction I have spent a week removing it from. On the word of a man wanted by the police, using a list he cannot prove.'

'Yes.'

'I cannot carry it alone. I must be able to borrow against what I buy the same morning, or I am simply the next man holding bonds that fall. That means the Bank of England, and the Bank will not lend without the Treasury behind it, and the Treasury is run by a woman who denied on Sunday that she had ever seen your memo.'

'Yes.'

'And it must be done in one morning. The moment the market sees what I am buying, it will know the list.'

'One morning,' I said. 'One transaction.'

I have been in a room with the Governor, the Chancellor and a woman offering three million pounds, and never before with someone who saw the same thing at the same moment I did. He saw the transaction, whole, in the order it would have to go. I watched him see it.

'Then we need the Bank in the room,' he said, 'and before I am recalled, which will happen, because my cousin is not stupid. I will ask for the meeting tonight. You will bring the page.' He stood. 'For two weeks I have believed that I served my client best by leaving. You

are the first person to suggest that I might serve it by coming back. I do not yet know whether you are right. Nobody else has suggested it.'

8.37 by the mantelpiece clock. Nasser took me down. I was already feeling for the ticket in the buttoned pocket before the doors opened, because for one hour and 39 minutes I had done the thing I have not done since Sunday week, which is let the books out of my sight.

She had taken the chair at the far end of the lobby at 6.40, with its back to the window and a sightline to the cloakroom and the lifts, and had ordered a tea she did not want so that she would be a woman with a tea. Dark trousers tonight, a pale jacket, hair down. He had looked at her face for 19 minutes in a park nine days ago and she had let him, and this was the cost: she could not be the one to go to the counter.

She had watched him come in at 6.52 with the bag on both shoulders. She had watched the chief of staff refuse it, which she had not expected, and had felt the small cold pleasure of a plan improving itself. Then she had read the number off the stub as the girl held the book to the light to tear it straight; Kessler had chosen the chair for the light. Sixty-three.

Ten minutes earlier the first of her two men had checked an umbrella, received 61, and photographed both sides of it. She had sent the pictures to the office at 6.55 with one line, and the number at seven. The office had the card stock already: on Monday morning her people had watched him walk into an office in St James's, and she had decided that a man wanted by the police would meet a sovereign fund in one of four hotels, and had had a coat checked at each. The third member of her firm, the one she did not use on the street, had a very expensive printer and no curiosity. The cab took 38 minutes; the ticket in it had taken 14 to make. She timed things.

At 8.12 her second man, in a good coat that was not his, walked to the cloakroom with 63 in his hand and said, before he was asked, that it was the black rucksack, the old one, he was afraid, and the girl

laughed and said it was the only rucksack she had taken all night. He tipped her, and went out through the revolving door with four years of another man's evenings on his shoulder and did not look at the chair by the window, because he had been told not to.

She stayed. That was the only part not in the plan, and she told herself it was to be sure he came down alone.

The lift doors opened at 8.41. He was already reaching into his coat. He crossed the carpet at a walk that wanted to be a run and put the ticket on the counter, and the girl went to the rail and stood in front of it, looked at the ticket again, went to the back, and came out with the man in the waistcoat, and Kessler watched Jonas Whitlock understand.

He did not shout. He stood with both hands flat on the counter and his head down, and she saw his lips move and knew that he was counting. The man in the waistcoat went along the rail coat by coat. Whitlock did not watch him. He had turned and was looking at the lobby, every chair, every face, and his eyes went over her and did not stop, because she was a woman with a tea and her hair down and he had never once seen her sitting.

She felt what she usually felt at this point, a column adding up. Underneath it was something else, and she made herself look at it, because she did not permit herself things she had not looked at.

The subject had just spent an hour and 39 minutes with the managing director of a Gulf sovereign wealth fund. Her client had told her yesterday that the price had gone up because a Gulf fund was asking questions about Greywether's trades. He had not said which questions, or why a fund that had made more in a fortnight than in the previous nine years should mind who asked. He had said "by whatever route works", and when she had asked whether that included the child he had not said no.

Twelve names and an order. She had assumed, because it was her job to assume, that he wanted to know where to push. She looked at

the man at the counter, who had spent four years writing down what he could not prove and had just lost it to a girl with a book of tickets, and understood that she did not know what Sebastian Crane would do with twelve names, and that in fifteen years of government work and six on her own account she had never handed something over without knowing that.

The man in the waistcoat reached the end of the rail. Whitlock asked for something, and the girl, red now, gave him paper from the writing desk, four sheets, and he folded them once and put them in the pocket where the ticket had been, and buttoned it.

Kessler put a note under the saucer and left by the side door onto the park, where the car was.

'Mayfair?' the driver said.

'The office. The safe. Mr Crane can have them at nine.' She looked at the rucksack on the seat beside her and did not open it. 'I want to know what I'm carrying first.'

Chapter 29

Reading

She brought it up herself, at nine, which Sebastian Crane had not expected. He had expected one of her men and a receipt.

Wednesday. The rucksack was black and old and had a tear in one shoulder strap that had been sewn, badly, by hand. She put it on the desk, not on the floor, and stood back from it, and he understood that she wanted him to see that it had not been in anyone's hands but hers since the hotel. A man he had not seen before waited at the door with his coat on; she had not introduced him and did not now.

'Nine books,' Kessler said. 'Black, A5, in order. The page he made with the analyst is folded inside the last one, about thirty pages from the end. It's one side. Twelve codes, an order, and a column.'

'You've read them.'

'I've read enough to know what I was carrying.' Her hands were in her coat pockets. 'You told me on Monday you wanted them by the weekend. It's Wednesday. The invoice will follow.'

In two years she had never once referred to money in his room. He noted it and, since the rucksack was on his desk, let it go.

'Dana. You've done what I asked.'

'Yes.' She looked at the bag rather than at him. 'What will you do with the order, Mr Crane?'

'Read it.'

She waited a moment, as if there might be more, then nodded once and went to the door, and the man there stepped back to let her through first. Crane looked at the man's face for the two seconds it was turned towards him. Broad, patient, forty or so, nothing in it. Then the door was shut, and he was alone with four years of another man's evenings.

Something about the handover had registered. Thirty pages from the end. She had counted. He turned it over, found that it was simply what a careful woman did with goods before delivering them, and set it down.

He did not go to the page first. That surprised him a little, and he was seldom surprised by himself.

He took the first book out. The elastic band had gone slack with four years of stretching. Inside the front cover, no name. A date, a Tuesday, two lines about a bond that had not arrived and a man who had said "timing" too easily, and a question mark. The handwriting was small and upright and did not change over the pages in the way most men's did when they were tired or had been drinking. This man had been neither. He had sat down every night at about the same hour and written about the same thing in the same hand, and the hand was a clerk's.

Crane read for an hour before he looked up.

The entries were short. The man counted everything: minutes, confirmations, the number of times a word was used in a day. He never wrote a name. He wrote codes, four letters, which Crane did not know and did not yet need to. He wrote what each code had posted at seven and what it had at three, which lines had failed, who had paid late and by how many minutes, and then, most weeks, a sentence that was not a fact. *I think this is one bond going round. I cannot prove that.*

By the end of the first book Crane had eleven codes down the margin of a sheet of his own paper with a mark beside each for every bad

morning it appeared on, and found that he was doing, with a pencil, exactly what the man in the books had never once done. The man had written it all down one day at a time and never turned round to look at the row of days behind him. It had taken a stranger an hour.

His assistant brought coffee at eleven and did not speak. The floor hummed through the carpet, thirty-one people watching the thing he had not needed to watch since the spring.

The second book had the entry he had heard about and not seen. #212. Two members, the same line, the same morning, both saying timing, both paying cash at nine and swapping bonds back in within four minutes of each other at ten past three. The man had written: *I think it is one bond, going round. I cannot prove that.* Crane read it twice. It was good. It was exactly right, and it had been exactly right 1,200 days ago, and the man had closed the book and gone to bed.

The second book had the memo. #304: a date, a title that Crane thought rather fine, the recipients, the covering phrase, *one analyst's view*, and the sentence about three years. And then, three weeks later, an entry that Crane read standing up, because he had got up to stretch and had not sat down again.

Graham says the Treasury have noted it. He was relieved. He paid for the coffee.

And in the ninth book, on the page after the one with the four lines about turning forty, the sentence the earlier entry had not finished: *I will put down something I have never put down: so was I.* Three years to say it.

Crane put the book down and went to the window. A warden was writing a ticket in the quiet street. He had spent twenty-five years being told by men like the one in these books that he was lucky, and had come to understand that they were describing themselves: a man who believes in luck is a man who has seen the thing coming and decided that seeing was enough. Here was one who had seen it at

thirty-six, written it down at thirty-seven, been *relieved* when nobody listened, and gone on seeing it for three more years, every night, in a hand that never shook, and had never once in 1,400 evenings done anything about it that could not be filed.

So much knowledge. He could not remember when he had last felt contempt for a man he had never met, and he took a moment to enjoy it, because it was rare.

He read through lunch. The seventh book changed somewhere in the middle, and he saw where before he understood why: the entries grew a last paragraph that was not about bonds, and the paragraph had a child's name in it. He skipped those. A baby's weight to one decimal place told him nothing about the gilt market.

The ninth book he read slowly for its last fortnight. The birthday. The wrong inbox. A pension fund's bonds in two places, Thursday, and that night a ship. The Treasury on the Saturday, in a voice so level that Crane had to remind himself the man had been looking at his own memo across a table. Sunday: a woman by a park gate, a figure, *the house, cleared, four times over*. Monday on a bench. Then the entries went short and frightened and were written on buses and in hotels, and Crane found himself less interested, because a frightened man was any man.

He turned back, before he went to the folded page, to the week before the birthday, and found the Tuesday. #1392. Half a page. Two timing fails, the usual pair. A member's call paid eleven minutes late. The weather.

He read it with real pleasure. On that Tuesday, at a desk with no screen on the wall, he had put on the largest positions of his life. The man whose job it was to see everything had seen two fails and some rain.

The page was where she had said it was.

One side of A4, printer paper, in two hands: a woman's, quick and clear, for the codes and the order; his, small and upright, for the right-hand column. Twelve four-letter codes down the left. Beside each, a rank. Beside each rank, a line or two: which gilts, roughly how much, how much of it the man believed was promised elsewhere at the same time. At the head of the column, one word, underlined: *think*.

Under the twelve, a date with a box round it. Nine days before the sinking. In the woman's hand, with no comment.

He looked at the date for some time. Then he turned the page face down, because he had seen what he needed from it and did not care for the box.

The codes meant nothing to him. They were Walbrook's own, four letters, and the man had been faithful to his rule: not one name in nine books. Crane had, from the tallies in his margin, a reasonable idea which code had failed on Monday week, because it was the one that had stopped appearing, and he could guess two more from their size. Guessing was for the men downstairs.

He used the ordinary telephone, not the one in the drawer.

Anthony Pell answered on the fourth ring from somewhere with a dog in it. Crane said that he had a small question about the firm, and read him a four-letter code.

The silence told Crane that Pell knew what he was being asked and where the code had come from.

'Sebastian. You're asking me to read you the membership list.'

'I'm asking you what twelve words mean. The codes are in the appendix of every pack Richard has ever sent you.'

'Those packs are confidential.'

'So, you told me, is everything in these books, and you wanted them ash. The next best thing is a room with no screens and one reader. Twelve words.'

Pell gave him twelve words, in the voice of a man reading out his own evidence. Twice he asked Crane to repeat a code; once, at the

fourth, he said ‘Christ’ quietly. The second was the name people had on their debit cards. The dog barked and was told to stop.

‘I don’t want to know,’ Pell said at the end, ‘what you’re going to do with those.’

‘You never have,’ Crane said, and thanked him, and put the telephone down, and wrote the twelve names on his own sheet beside the twelve codes in a hand that was, he noticed, not as steady as the clerk’s.

Then he planned it, which took less time than reading had, because he had been planning it since the spring without knowing the names.

The first on the list was gone; the auction of what was left of its book had started yesterday. The default fund had paid for that, and the Governor’s money had paid for the rest; the market had steadied on Monday in the way a market steadies when a central bank is lending to anyone who asks. The second on the list was alive on that lending and on nothing else. Its collateral, the man’s column said, was long gilts, three lines in particular, and more than half of it the man believed was working another job in the repo market at the same time.

Three. The second, the third and the fourth. Not the whole map; a man who sold twelve things at once would be seen, and three would do the work. He knew now which lines each had posted. One could borrow those lines and sell them, specifically, hard, so that the exact bonds those three had lodged fell faster than the market; one could, through the right desks, make those lines expensive to borrow on the days the three members needed them back. Walbrook would mark the collateral down and call them for cash the same morning, and they would go to the repo market for the cash, and the repo market would have been there first. The fund was built for two large members at once. Three, within a day, and the fund was gone, and Walbrook would have to say to the Governor what a clearing house was required to say, and the Governor would have to do the thing nobody had ever

done.

He did not think of that as a bad outcome. He thought of it as the market telling the truth about itself, at last, with his help, and of nobody, anywhere, ever again saying luck.

The day. The books had it. The man had logged payment times for four years, and the three names paid latest on Tuesdays, every bad Tuesday, by a margin Crane could see without a pencil; something in how their collateral came home from the repo market at the start of each week left them short on Tuesday mornings. And by Monday the auction of the first member's book would be done, the loss known, and Walbrook calling the survivors to refill the fund, so that on Tuesday morning every one of the twelve would be meeting the ordinary call and the refill at once. The man had written, in the ninth book, *the one that failed this morning was not the weakest. It was first in the queue.* Crane intended to shorten the queue.

Tuesday. He wrote the date at the top of the sheet. Four trading days to build it without being seen, which was enough, because nobody was looking at anything but the pound.

The sheet with the day's number came at six and he read it once and put it in his pocket without comparing it with anything.

Nine books on his desk, in order, spines out, the way she had brought them. He put the elastic band back on the first one and it would not hold, and he left it. He had been going to telephone her, on the phone in the drawer, to say the work had been satisfactory, and found that he did not want to hear her ask again what he would do with the order. He had never, in two years, declined to pick up that phone.

He turned the folded page face up again, and looked at the box round the date, and at the two hands on the one sheet, and at the word *think*, and understood that the clerk had been right about one more thing. A map that two people had was a map that nobody had.

The second person was in Kentish Town with the woman whose hand was on this page, and he had read it, by his own account, a hundred times.

Crane picked up the ordinary telephone again and asked the man at the door to come back up.

Chapter 30

In his head

Wednesday. #1414. A reporter's pad of Calloway's, spiral at the top, lined, the first eleven pages torn out by him and the twelfth by me because it had a phone number on it. I have never written an entry on anything but a black A5 book with an elastic band, and I am going to write that once and not again: from here on I write on what there is.

This is the worst entry I have written. I have been sitting with that sentence for some time, in the hope of a better one, and there is not one. I am writing it so that it is at the top.

The four hotel sheets are on the table beside the pad. I wrote them last night in the lobby and on the bus and at this table, and they are #1413, and they are the whole of the record that exists in my hand. Four sheets. Nine books.

I did not sleep. I sat here from a quarter to eleven, when I got back, with the sheets squared in front of me, and at some point Calloway came in and looked at me and at the empty floor by the chair where the bag goes, and did not ask, and went to bed, which is the kindest thing a journalist has ever done to me. Priya was asleep on the sofa. The flat has one bedroom and a sofa and a kitchen, and I have been given the kitchen.

She found me at ten past six. She came in for water and stopped in

the doorway and looked where Calloway had looked, and said, 'Where is it.'

'Gone.'

'Gone where.'

'The cloakroom at the hotel. They wouldn't let it upstairs. I had a ticket. Somebody else had the same ticket at twelve minutes past eight.'

She sat down across from me. She did not say anything for a while. Then she said, 'All nine.'

'All nine. And the page.'

'The page was in the ninth.'

'Yes.'

'Is there a copy? Anywhere. You photographed them. You told me you photographed every page.'

I had told her. 'Every morning, for 1,398 mornings, to my own inbox. I deleted the lot at one o'clock on the Thursday morning after the email went to the wrong address, 1,399 photographs, because I thought the account was watched and that Walbrook's lawyers would be in it by the weekend. It was the right decision. It was also the stupidest thing I have ever done, and I did both with the same hand.'

'So no.'

'No.'

She put her hands flat on the table the way Laura does, and I understood that I have been living for a week among women who do that before they say something.

'Jonas. I am going to say one thing about this and then I am never going to say it again, because we haven't got time. You carried them on both shoulders for nine days and the first time somebody made you put them down you put them down.'

'Yes.'

'Right.' She got up and put the kettle on. 'That's said.'

Nine o'clock. The box on the Kentish Town Road. Laura on the first ring. I told her. Not all of it: that I had met a man who could help, that the meeting had gone well, and that the books had been taken while I was in it, all nine, by the people who had been to her mother's door.

She was quiet for a count of three.

'Are you hurt?'

'No.'

'Then it's a bag, Jonas.' And then, because she is Laura: 'You've got five days.'

Four minutes. I have begun to think of the four minutes as the most honest part of the day.

Who has them. I have had the night to do that sum and it comes out the same each time.

Not the police. The police do not forge cloakroom tickets; they stand at the counter and show a card. Not Al-Mansouri's people; they would not let the bag up, and that is the opposite of wanting it. A ticket with a 63 on it, made in the hours between my handing in the bag and a man in a good coat collecting it, is a piece of work, and I have met exactly one person this fortnight who does pieces of work. She was in that lobby. I did not see her. I looked at every face in it and I did not see her, and that is what she is for.

So by now, nine on a Wednesday, a man in Mayfair whose name I first wrote down six days ago has nine books on his desk. He has the twelve. He has the order. He has what each one is holding, in my hand, under the word *think*, which he will not read as a caveat because men like him do not have caveats. He has the date in Priya's box, which he already knew, because it is his date. And he has four years of me.

I have been trying all night to decide which of those is worst and I keep arriving at the same one, and it is not the map. It is that he can now read what I did about it. Nothing. He will see the entry where I

was relieved. I know he will, because it is the one I would go to.

What he does next I can also do as a sum, and I would rather not, and I will. He does not need twelve. He needs the next three. He knows which lines they hold. He knows what days they pay late. If I were short the pound and the gilt and wanted the clearing house to break rather than bend, I would go for two, three and four, together, on a morning when they are already stretched, and I would make their exact collateral fall faster than everyone else's. I know how I would do that. So does he. The difference is that he will.

Priya came back from the kettle with two mugs and the red notebook, and opened it at the page.

Her copy. Twelve codes down the left, in her hand, and a number beside each one. Nothing else. No column. No lines of gilts, no amounts, no "think". On Friday afternoon, at ten to five, with the hire car waiting, she had copied the codes and the order and said the rest stays in the books.

'That's what I've got,' she said.

'That's a list.'

'Yes.'

'A list of twelve four-letter codes that mean nothing outside the building, in the order I think they fall over.' I said it before she could, which was a mistake, because she had been going to say it more precisely.

'Jonas. If I walk into the Bank of England with this page, what is it?'

'Nothing.'

'It's a page with twelve words on it. The holdings were the evidence. The dates were the evidence. Four years of a code standing next to a fingerprint was the evidence. A central bank needs to be told what each of these twelve is holding and what the fingerprints say and on what day you read them, with the entry number, and then it needs to be able to check, and we can't give it one of those things. We can give

it twelve words and your face.'

'Yes.'

'Good. Now the other thing.'

She turned the red book round so that the list faced me, and put her finger on the first code, and said: 'What's it holding?'

I looked at her.

'You wrote it. Four years. You read them every night for a week on a bench and in a hotel and at this table, from the first page. You read that column on the train on Monday for the ninth or tenth time; you said so. It's not in Mayfair, Jonas. It's in your head. It was always in your head. The books were where you put it so that you wouldn't have to carry it. Well.' She tapped the code. 'Carry it.'

So we started. 6.40 by the cooker clock.

The first one is easy, because it has failed and because I have written about it more than any other: three lines of long gilts, and the amounts, and the pattern over four years, and the Friday it paid us with cash it raised that morning by lending out the very bonds Priya had seen failing the day before. I gave it to her in a minute and a half and she wrote it down and checked it against her own figures for Friday's seven of forty, and it held.

The second is the one that is standing because the Bank is lending to it. I know its lines. I know roughly what it posts, because I have looked at it every morning for four years and it is large, and large is easy to remember. What I do not know, to the number, is how much of it I believe is working another job at the same time, because that is not a number I ever carried in my head; it is a number I built, every quarter, from a stack of entries, and wrote in the column, and then let go of, because it was written down.

I got to a figure. Priya looked at it and looked at her Friday reconstruction and said, 'Within ten per cent,' and wrote it with a question mark, and I had to let her.

The third took forty minutes. The fourth took an hour and I changed my mind twice and the second time she put the pen down and said, ‘Stop guessing. Tell me what you saw. Not the number. What you saw.’ So I told her what I saw: a Tuesday in the fifth book, a substitution at a time of day when nobody substitutes anything, and the same line coming home through two members in the same week in the eighth, and she built the number herself out of what I saw, which is what she does, and it was better than mine.

By two in the afternoon we had four of twelve that I would put my name to, two with question marks, and six that were a code and a rank and my sense of them, which is not evidence.

It is slow. I want that written down, because for four years I have thought of the record as a thing I had, and it turns out I had the pages. What I have is the shape. I can tell you that the seventh name was always late on the same mornings as the second, and that there is a line it posts that I have seen going out in the morning and coming back at three more times than I can count. I cannot tell you how many times, or the dates. A man in a room in Mayfair can. He has the dates.

Priya said, at about three, with her head on her hand: ‘We can get to twelve like this. By Friday, maybe. And it will be a page I’d argue for and you’d argue for and nobody at the Bank would move a pound on, because it’s two people’s memory of a notebook they haven’t got.’

‘What would move them?’

‘Our own data. Walbrook’s. The member collateral reports, the fails lists, the concentration numbers, with the firm’s name at the top, matching what you remember. Then it stops being your memory and starts being their records.’ She rubbed her eyes. ‘Which are in a building I’m bailed not to go near, on systems you’ve been cut off from, under a man who’s spent the week saying the memo went to a committee that never met.’

‘Yes.’

‘So we need somebody inside. Or somebody who was.’

I did not say the name. Nor did she. I have written his name in a different hand in nine books and he signed my birthday card *many of them*, and I am not writing it tonight.

Calloway came back at half past five with the evening's paper under his arm and his face already arranged. The second member, the one everyone has on their debit cards, had met the morning call at 8.55. The pound had done something he described with a word I will not write. The Chancellor had been "in discussions with the Bank". The auction of the first member's book was into its second day and the prices, he said, were the kind that get described as "in line with expectations" because nobody wants to say what the expectations were.

He asked, carefully, what we had.

'Four,' Priya said. 'Two more with a question mark. By Friday, twelve, if he doesn't fall asleep.'

'And the Bank?'

'Twelve words and his face.'

He did not laugh. He sat on the arm of the sofa, where he sits, and said: 'The thing in the lobby. The ticket. Is that a story?'

'Not yet,' I said. He looked at Priya. She said, 'Not yet,' and he nodded as if he had expected to lose that twice.

7.52. Phone two, on the table by the pad, face up, on. The long number with the code I know.

Not him. Nasser. The voice of a man who had decided about me on a carpet and had not revised it.

'Mr Whitlock. Mr Al-Mansouri asked me to tell you himself but he is in a car. The Bank has agreed to meet. Tomorrow. Thursday, at three; you will be told the door and who will bring you in. He asks me to say that he does not expect to be in London many more days and that this may be the only occasion.' A pause that was not a pause; he was reading the next line. 'He asks that you bring the page.'

I said nothing for long enough that he said my name again.

'The page was in the bag,' I said. 'The bag is gone. I'm rebuilding it.'

A silence that cost him something. 'Then Mr Al-Mansouri goes alone. The Bank will not see a man with nothing in his hands, and it will not see him twice.'

'Tell him I'll have it by Sunday.' I rang off before he could ask me what I had.

'And the page, Mr Whitlock.'

'Yes.'

He rang off. 7.54.

Priya had heard it. Everyone in this kitchen heard it. She looked at the red book with its twelve words and the pad with four of them filled in, and she said, 'Well. You've got until tomorrow evening to have a head worth taking into the Bank of England.'

Elsie. On Thursday a man your father has met once is going to walk into the Bank of England without the page, and your father is going to sit in a room south of the river rebuilding it from four names he can swear to, eight he can't, and a sentence he has written 1,414 times. *I cannot prove it.* He has never been so sure of it, and it has never been so true.

Chapter 31

The minutes

The second story was shorter than the first, and Caroline Strand, who had read a great many documents whose length was a measure of their weakness, knew what that meant before she had finished the headline.

Thursday, 6.15am, the car, the glass up. *Treasury asked police to detain Walbrook analyst*. Six hundred words. A letter from "a senior Treasury official", dated the Sunday before last, to the Metropolitan Police, "asking that the matter be dealt with as one of urgency", described to the paper by "a person who has seen it". The analyst, named now, thirty-one, held about twenty hours, released on bail with one condition. A line from a former Director of Public Prosecutions that a government department asking the police to hurry was "not improper in itself, but unusual, and the kind of thing one would expect to be recorded". And, two-thirds down, where he had put the Treasury's reply on Sunday, the Treasury's reply from Saturday, printed again, word for word, in her own sentences: *The Treasury does not comment on matters that may be the subject of police inquiries*.

He had asked her eleven questions and she had answered one and a half. He had answered the ninth himself.

She read it twice, which she did not usually do, and then she put the phone face down and looked at the park, where nobody was running this morning, because it was raining properly.

'Simon.'

'Chancellor.'

'Who has seen your letter?'

Carrow did not open his folder. 'The police. The Crown Prosecution Service, if it went that far, which I doubt. Walbrook's solicitors, possibly, as the complainant. The analyst's duty solicitor, in disclosure before interview, if the officers chose to show it, which they should not have.' He said the last part as a man says the name of a colleague who has disappointed him. 'It did not come from this building.'

'It has my department's name on it and the word "urgency" in it, and on Tuesday week, in a room under the Cabinet Office, with the Governor and the Cabinet Secretary present, I said that the matter was one for the police and for Walbrook and not for this government.' She did not raise her voice. She had never found that raising it did anything a pause could not. 'Those minutes exist.'

'They do.'

'And they record me saying it twice.'

'They record you saying "theft" twice, Chancellor, attributing it both times to Walbrook, and saying once that the matter was not one for government.' He had read them; of course he had. 'They do not record the letter, because the letter was not raised.'

'By me.'

'By anyone.'

She let that lie where it fell. It was a perfectly good answer, and it was the answer of an official, and she was not going to be examined by an official. She had spent twenty years asking the question underneath the question, and the question underneath this one was: had a Treasury director written to the police on his own motion, as the minutes implied by their silence, or had the Chancellor, in her room, with the door shut, at ten past three on a Sunday, been told that it would be prudent, and said that he should do whatever he judged appropriate. Both were true. One was on paper. The other was in a room with

two people in it, one of whom was being very careful with her this morning.

'When were you going to tell me that it was in writing?'

'You knew it was in writing, Chancellor. I said so.'

'Yes,' she said. 'You did.'

The prime minister saw her at a quarter to eight, in the study, standing, which was how he conducted conversations he intended to be short.

He had the paper. He had, she saw, the online version on his phone as well, as though the two might differ. He did not sit down and he did not ask her to.

'Caroline. On Tuesday you told the room it was nothing to do with us.'

'I told the room, Prime Minister, that a clearing house had made a complaint and that the police were dealing with it, and that it was not a matter for this government. All of which was accurate.'

'A Treasury director wrote to the Met.'

'A Treasury director drew the attention of the police, in writing, to a matter of concern to the department. Officials do that. It is recorded, as the former DPP helpfully says it should be, and it was.'

'Did you know?'

She had known he would ask it, and had decided in the car that she would answer it exactly.

'I knew that Simon considered it prudent to put the department's concern in writing, and I did not object.'

He looked at her for a moment in the way that he had, which was to seem not to be looking at anyone. He was not a stupid man. He was a man who had worked out, some years ago, that being thought a little stupid was restful.

'So you knew.'

'I have told you what I knew.'

'All right.' He put the phone in his pocket. 'Here is where I am. I have a clearing house that the Governor tells me, in words of one syllable, may not be a clearing house by the end of next week. I have a pound that I am not allowed to say the price of. I have a Bank that wants to buy bonds and a Chancellor who will not sign for it, and I backed the Chancellor, and I would like to go on doing that, because there are three weeks to polling and the alternative is a new Chancellor with three weeks to polling. But I now also have a Treasury that has been hunting a thirty-one-year-old analyst through the police while its Chancellor said on television that she had never seen a memo that turns out to have been in her box for a fortnight.'

'Prime Minister—'

'Monday.' He said it quite gently. 'I would like the situation stabilised by Monday. I don't mean the pound; I am not a fool. I mean this.' He touched the paper. 'I would like there to be no third story. I would like the Governor to stop ringing me at six in the morning. I would like, when I am asked on Monday whether I have full confidence in my Chancellor, to be able to say yes without my press secretary closing her eyes. Stabilise the situation, Caroline. You are the one who keeps telling me that is what you are for.'

'Yes, Prime Minister.'

'Good.' He opened the door for her himself, which he did when he wanted a thing to look courteous in the corridor. 'And Caroline. The memo. I'd read it, if I were you. Before somebody asks you a question about page four.'

The day was the day. There was a call with the Governor, who told her that the Bank had now lent to Walbrook and to eleven of its members, that the second member had met the morning call at five to nine on the Bank's money and would do so again tomorrow and after that he would not say, and that the auction of the first member's book was in its third day and the prices were "instructive". He told her, in the

tone he used for things he was obliged to tell her, that he would be meeting the managing director of the Gulf fund that afternoon, at the fund's request, and that the Treasury was welcome to send someone. She said that she would consider it, and did not send anyone, because a Treasury official in a room with the Bank and the fund whose withdrawal had started this was a photograph she could not afford, and because she already knew what the fund would ask for.

There was the eleven o'clock, where she said "monitoring" and "the Bank has the tools it needs" and did not say the other thing. There was a lunch she did not eat, and the Opposition's letter, and a request from the Treasury Committee for the minutes of all meetings on the Walbrook matter, which Carrow said would be resisted in the normal way and she told him to resist in the normal way and found that she did not enjoy saying it. There was Carrow, all day, at her left, being very careful.

At twenty past seven the private office emptied, and she said that she would read for an hour and did not need anyone, and the door closed, and the Treasury went quiet in the way it did at that hour, a building the size of a town with the sound turned down.

The box was on the side table. The folder was where it had been since the Wednesday before the sinking, with Simon's yellow flag on it, and his cover note on top, two paragraphs, which she had read. She took the cover note off and put it face down on the desk and sat with the six pages in front of her and did not, for a moment, turn the first one.

She had cross-examined on a thousand documents. She knew how to read one: not for what it said, but for where it was weak, for the adjective that was doing work the facts would not do, for the table whose columns did not quite add. She had read the first page of this one a week ago Saturday, across a table, upside down, while a man in a good suit told her what it meant, or in the one he had been given, and she had read the sentence everyone had read, and she had turned

no page because she had not needed to; she had needed the man's signature, not his argument.

She turned the page.

It was a note, not a memorandum. It did not argue. It set out, in a prose so plain that she found herself looking for the trick, what a clearing house could see and what it could not, and then it showed her, in four tables and a footnote, what the writer had seen over eleven months: fails that came in pairs, with the same excuse on the same mornings; cash paid at nine against bonds returned at three; the same lines of government debt arriving and leaving by routes that had no reason to be the same. He did not say that the collateral was pledged twice. He said, in a sentence she read three times, that the pattern was "consistent with" collateral financing more than one obligation at a time, that he had "no direct evidence of any individual chain", and that he was "unable to exclude" the benign explanation but could "no longer regard it as the more probable". Page four had the estimate, and the working under it, and the working was an assumption about how fast the thing was growing, stated as an assumption, with a range. Three years was the middle of the range. The bottom of the range was two.

The sixth page was a list of five things that could be done, in order of how little they would cost. The first was a reconciliation that would have taken one analyst a month. None of them had been done. She knew that without asking, because if any of them had been done the man would have said so in the room, and he had not said so, and he was not a man who left things out.

It was right. Not clever: right, in the way that a well-drawn pleading was right, so that you could not find the sentence to pull at. She had spent twenty years finding the sentence. There was not one. He had written down every weakness in his own case before she could, and then he had estimated three years, and it had been three years, and a week ago Saturday she had put two paragraphs on Treasury pa-

per in front of him and asked him to say the opposite over his name.

She sat for some time with page four under her hand.

Then she did a thing she had done on every document she had ever read in practice, without thinking, for twenty years, and had not done on any document since she had entered government, because in government the rule was that a minister's hand on a page was a fact that could be requested. She took the pen from the holder, and in the margin beside the sentence with the three years in it she wrote the date, and the time, and her initials, in the small hand that had filled a hundred blue notebooks.

She looked at it. Three letters and a date. The only record that would ever exist of the Chancellor of the Exchequer having read the thing she had said she had not seen, in her own hand, on the Treasury's copy, where anyone with a file reference could ask for it.

She did not cross it out. She put the six pages back in the folder, and the cover note on top, and the folder in the box, and the box where the box went, and she turned off the lamp.

In the car she rang nobody. She watched the park go by in the rain and thought about the first of the five things on the sixth page, the one that would have taken a month, and about the word she had made Simon put in a letter, and about the minutes of a room under the Cabinet Office, which existed, and would exist in thirty years, and had her saying twice, in her exact voice, the thing she had known at the time was not true.

Monday, he had said. She had until Monday to stabilise the situation. She had just, with three letters, made it a very small amount less stable, and she found that she knew precisely why she had done it, and that she was not going to tell anyone, and that it was the first thing she had done in a fortnight that she would have advised a client to do.

Chapter 32

I filed it

Graham Pryce read the second article on the 7.02, standing, because the train was full of people reading it sitting down. Thursday. He had the paper folded to the page the way he folded it to the crossword, and he read the piece twice, and at the second reading he found that he had been expecting it since Monday week, in the way one expects a result one has already seen in the draft.

Treasury asked police to detain Walbrook analyst. A letter from a director at the Treasury, on the Sunday, asking for urgency. The analyst's name. Twenty hours. The Treasury did not comment on matters that might be the subject of police inquiries, which was what the Treasury said when the matter was the Treasury.

He had worked it out on Tuesday, without the article, and had spent two days not quite saying so to himself, which was a skill he had and had been paid for. The firm's complaint about Priya's login had gone to a police inbox on the Saturday morning, because the lawyers said it must, and the general counsel had told him on the Tuesday, in the lift, that nobody at the firm had expected anything to happen before Wednesday, if then. But Richard had rung Graham at five past eight on the Monday morning and told him the police had the girl, and had given him the word to put in a text, and Graham had used it. Richard had known on the Sunday night. The firm's own lawyers had not

known until the Monday afternoon. Graham had put those two times side by side, the way Jonas put times side by side, and had understood.

The train went into the tunnel. He folded the paper the other way.

He was at his desk at 7.35, as he was every day, and he wrote the letter in longhand first, because he found he could not type it. Four lines. Effective immediately. No reasons; a letter that gave reasons was a document, and he had spent thirty years learning what a document was for.

At 8.50 he went up to the fourth floor and asked Richard's assistant whether Richard had five minutes, and was told that he had until nine, and thought that this was where he had come in.

Haldane was at the window. He had been at the window, Graham thought, since the Sunday before last.

'Graham. You've seen it.'

'I've seen it.' He put the letter on the desk. 'That's my resignation. Effective this morning. I've left my pass and the laptop with your assistant. My phone is on my desk. I haven't taken anything out of the building, and I don't want anything sent on.'

Haldane read it without picking it up. Then he looked at Graham with the expression of a man who has been told a difficult thing and is finding out whether it is manageable.

'This isn't the week, Graham.'

'No.'

'You understand the Bank has to be notified. Chief risk officer, mid-crisis. They'll want to know why.'

'Tell them.'

'Tell them what, exactly?'

Graham considered the hedges available to him. Take some leave. Think it over. Let's take this offline. He could feel the shape of each in his mouth, and found that he did not want any of them, and that this was the first time in his working life that this had been true.

‘Tell them that on Sunday the firm’s chief executive issued a statement saying that a memorandum was considered by the risk committee in the normal way and its conclusions were not accepted. I chaired that committee for eleven years. The memorandum was never put to it. I know, because I would have had to write the paper, and I didn’t. I sent it to the Treasury with a note calling it one analyst’s view, and I told Jonas it had been filed, and that was the whole of the committee’s consideration.’ He heard his own voice and was surprised by how level it was. ‘And tell them that on Sunday night you knew the police were going to hold a member of my team before the firm’s lawyers knew, and that you gave me a word to put in a text message that no lawyer in this building has ever been willing to say.’

Haldane did not move. He was good; Graham had always thought so.

‘You’re a decent man, Graham. You’re also three years from your pension.’

‘Yes.’

‘Then I’d think very carefully about what you say outside this building, and to whom. The order against Whitlock covers documents containing the firm’s confidential information. All of them. Wherever they are.’

‘I’m aware of the order,’ Graham said. ‘I helped draft the schedule.’

He went down in the lift, three floors, with nobody, and out past the staff door at 9.14 with an empty clip on his coat where the pass had been, and walked to the river because he did not know what else to do with his feet.

The paper’s number was on its back page. He rang it from his own mobile, standing on the embankment, because he had nothing left to hide from anyone and found the condition strange. He asked for Rhys Calloway and was asked who was calling, and said, ‘Graham Pryce. I was, until an hour ago, chief risk officer of Walbrook Clearing House.

Mr Calloway has written about my department twice this week. I'd like to speak to him before he does it a third time.'

A pause that meant a hand over a mouthpiece. Then a man's voice, quick, London, saying his name as one word.

'Mr Pryce. I'll say this once. Don't tell me anything on this line. Nothing at all.'

'I wasn't going to. I'd like to see him.'

'Who?'

'I'm not asking you to tell me where anyone is. I'm asking you to tell him I'd like to see him, that I have something he'll want, and that I'm no longer anybody's employee. He'll know what I'd bring.'

Silence. Traffic behind it, and a keyboard.

'Six o'clock,' Calloway said. 'Our front hall. Ask for me. Bring whatever it is with you, and don't bring anyone.' And the line.

He took the train home, at ten in the morning on a weekday, for the first time in eleven years.

The packs were in the box room, in box files, on the shelf he had put up for them, one quarter to a file, going back ten years: a decade's habit, begun when the committee had still sent paper and continued after it had stopped, because he had never trusted a thing he could not hold. Forty box files. Each pack a hundred pages or so. The agenda, the minutes, the market-risk section, the default-fund stress numbers, and at the back, every quarter, the collateral concentration appendix: each clearing member, by code, what it had lodged with the firm, in which lines, in what size, with what haircut, and a column headed *observations* that for the last four years had said, in Graham's own words, *no material concentration*. He had signed the Q2 one on the 14th. He had seen his own initials on it in a photograph on Jonas's birthday.

It was, he knew, exactly the thing the order described. He had kept it at home for ten years without once thinking about it, and had spent

the last ten days helping to pursue a man for the same offence, and he stood in the box room and let that be true for a full minute before he did anything else.

Then he took down the last sixteen. Four years. He knew when Jonas had started.

They went into the wheeled case he and his wife used for the one holiday a year, and it was heavy, and he did not care.

The paper's front hall, south of the river. Calloway came down himself at 6.04: younger than his byline, a look at the case and then at Graham that did the arithmetic in one go.

'Up,' he said. 'Fourth floor. They're in a room at the back.'

They.

The room had no windows, a table, a whiteboard with four-letter codes on it in two hands, and a printer in the corner with its light blinking. Jonas stood up when Graham came in. He had lost weight and his coat had a tear at the knee and there was no bag. There had always been a bag. Graham noticed, and did not ask.

Priya did not stand up. She looked at the case and then at him and said, 'What time?'

'I'm sorry?'

'What time did you resign.'

'Nine. A little before.'

'Then I can be in a room with you,' she said. 'As of nine. Sit down, Graham.'

He sat. Jonas sat. Calloway stayed by the door, which Graham understood to be a courtesy and a precaution in the same movement.

He opened the case and put the box files on the table, sixteen in two rows, and then he said what he had come to say, without one of the words he had used for thirty years to make a thing smaller than it was.

'The risk committee packs. Every quarter for four years. The collat-

eral appendix at the back of each one has every member's lodgements by code and by line, with the haircuts and the substitutions for the quarter. It's what you'd have had on your screens and can't now. It's what she pulled on the Friday and the police have.' He looked at Priya when he said it, and then at Jonas. 'The memo is not in any of them. It was never put to the committee. Richard said on Sunday that it was, and he was lying, and these show it. That's the second thing.'

Nobody spoke. The printer's light blinked.

'The third thing. The police action against Priya was not the firm's. The firm's complaint went in on the Saturday because the lawyers said it had to, and nobody at Walbrook expected a car before midweek. The urgency was the Treasury's. Carrow wrote on the Sunday. And Richard knew on the Sunday night, because he rang me at five past eight on Monday and told me what to text you, before our own lawyers had heard a word. I worked it out from the times. This morning's paper says the same thing, and I'm ashamed that I needed it to.'

Then the thing itself. He had not rehearsed it. There had been nothing to rehearse.

'I filed it, Jonas. Three years ago I read six pages that were right, and I was frightened of what they meant for me, and I filed them with a note that made them smaller, and I told you over a coffee as if it were good news. I filed Priya when I asked her on the Friday if you kept notes. I filed you when I sent that text.' He put both hands flat on the table. 'I'm sorry. I'm not asking for anything. I'm saying it because it is true and it has not been said, and I'd like it to have been said once by the person who should say it.'

Jonas looked at him for a long time and said nothing at all, which Graham found he had expected, and could bear.

Priya said: 'It's not enough.'

'No.'

'I want you to know that I know that. It isn't a thing you say and it's done. Twenty hours in a cell with my laces out, Graham, and my

parents' money in a bank that fell over while I was in it, and you're sorry. Fine. You're sorry.' She pulled the first box file across the table towards her and opened it at the back, and he watched her eyes find the appendix and start down the column. 'What I want from you is the four years. Not the apology. The four years, every quarter, and you sitting there until I've got it onto one page, and then I'll decide what else you're for.'

'Yes,' Graham said.

'Good.' She was already reading. 'Jonas. Q3, three years ago. Your second name. Read me what you had for it.'

Jonas had taken a pen out of his coat.

Calloway said, from the door, 'You'll want to know you've got until when.'

'Tuesday,' Graham said. He had not meant to say it yet. He said it anyway, because the hedges were gone and he could not find where he had put them. 'The firm's own forecast, as of yesterday afternoon. The second member meets Monday's call with what the Bank lends it. It does not meet Tuesday's. When it goes, the default fund goes with it, and Richard rings the Bank and says the sentence nobody has ever said.' He looked at the sixteen box files, four years of his own signature. 'Whatever you are doing in this room, you have until Tuesday morning to have done it.'

Chapter 33

Recall

The call came at ten to six on Friday morning, London time, which was mid-morning at home and the hour at which the men who ran his country liked to have done something before lunch. Khalid Al-Mansouri was dressed. He had been dressed since four, at the table under the window of a suite on Park Lane that his office kept for him and that he had not asked for, reading the overnight prices on a single sheet because he would not have a screen in the room.

He knew the voice. The secretary to the council had been a clerk when Khalid was a boy and had risen by never once being the man who delivered news; he delivered texts, and read them in a tone that made clear he had not written them. He read this one in full. The council thanked the managing director for his service in a period of exceptional difficulty. It wished to consult him in person on the future disposition of the nation's assets abroad. He was recalled for consultations from Monday, and the council would confirm his position, which was the clerk's phrase for ending it, when it sat on Wednesday morning. A seat had been reserved on Wednesday's noon flight. In his absence from London the office would report to the council directly.

'Who drafted it?' Khalid said.

'It was agreed,' the secretary said, which was the answer, and then, because he had known Khalid's father: 'Your cousin was in the room.

He did not speak. He did not need to.'

'Thank you.'

'Sir. Sunday night.'

'I heard you.'

He put the telephone down and sat with his hand on it, as he had sat twice before in a fortnight, and found that this time there was nothing to consider. He had expected it. He had said as much to a man with a rucksack, three days ago, in this room. *Before I am recalled, which will happen, because my cousin is not stupid.* It was almost a relief to be right about something.

Nasser came at seven with the morning's figures and the knowledge already on his face. The office at home would have rung him first; that was how a recall worked. One did not tell the man. One told the men around him, so that by the time he knew, they knew what they were.

'You have seen the text,' Khalid said.

'I have been sent it, sir. For the file.'

'Sit.'

Nasser sat, which he did not usually do with the figures in his hand. Outside, the park was coming up grey and the traffic on Park Lane had begun to make the glass hum, as it had every morning since Tuesday.

'Tell me where we are. Not the council. The book.'

'Closed, all but a fraction. The last of the positions go today and Monday. The collateral released, sold, settled. The proceeds are where you sent them, in four places, none of them London or New York.' He did not give the figure for what the fortnight had cost; he had stopped giving it on the Wednesday of the first week, and Khalid had let him stop. 'We are, as of this morning, very nearly out. The thing you set out to do on the Saturday is done.'

'Yes.'

'And the thing you set out to do on Tuesday night is not.'

'No.'

He had gone to the Bank on Thursday afternoon with nothing in his hands. That was the honest account, and he made himself give it, silently, in the words he would have used to his father. He had asked for the meeting on the Tuesday night from this table, within an hour of Whitlock leaving, and had been given Thursday at three: a deputy governor, two people from the side of the Bank that watched clearing houses, a room on the second floor with a portrait in it, tea. He had been meant to bring a page with twelve names on it and an order, and the man who had the page. On Wednesday evening, when Nasser had rung the number the office had on a visitor's slip, Whitlock had said that the page had been in the bag, and the bag was gone, and he was rebuilding it, and had rung off before Nasser could ask him anything, which Nasser had reported with something close to respect.

So Khalid had gone to the Bank with a proposal and no map. He had said what he could say. That the fund was prepared, in principle, to bring a part of its proceeds back into London to buy what certain clearing members would shortly be forced to sell, at the moment they were forced to sell it, if the Bank would lend against the purchases the same morning and if the Treasury stood behind the Bank. He had said that he had reason to believe the order of those sales could be known in advance. He had not said how. He had not said the name of the man, though they knew it; he had not said that the man had lost the thing that made him worth listening to.

The deputy governor had been courteous. Courtesy, Khalid had learned at nineteen in this city, was what the English did instead of saying no. The Bank could not lend against what the fund had not yet bought, to buy what the fund could not yet name, under an indemnity which the Chancellor had declined, in writing, to give. The Bank was already lending to the clearing house and its members, from Monday, under its own powers; that was what was keeping the second member standing. Beyond that, the Bank's hands were where the Treasury had put them. If the fund were to come back with something more con-

crete, the Bank would of course be glad to see it. The deputy governor had used the word *concrete* twice, and had looked, both times, at the empty table in front of Khalid's hands.

Forty minutes. He had walked back along Threadneedle Street in the rain and had understood that he had done something he had not done since he was a young man at a Western bank: he had gone into a room without the number.

'It went nowhere,' he said now, to Nasser. 'You know that. You were there.'

'It went nowhere because there was nothing to carry, sir. Not because the room was closed.'

'The room is closed on Monday. I am recalled on Monday. Whoever sits at this table on Tuesday will not go to the Bank.'

Nasser said nothing. He had learned long ago that a silence would be filled.

'Say the name.'

'They are saying a name at home, sir. It is not confirmed. It is a man who has dined with your cousin twice this fortnight and who said at the council on Tuesday that the nation's money should never again sit where a foreign minister could reach it, in words that were not his. If it is he, he will sell what is left, keep the proceeds where they are, and recommend that no part of them ever return to London in his lifetime. He will be praised for it. He will be right, by every measure the council uses.'

'And London?'

'London is not his client, sir. It was not yours.'

That was fair. Khalid let it be fair. He had said it himself, in the bridge, on the Saturday, with his hand on an instruction: one client, one duty. He had pulled the largest line out of a clearing house because the alternative was to watch it frozen, and he had known what the pulling would do, and it had done it. A member had failed. A second was standing on money the Bank lent it each night. A man who had

written down the shape of it for four years had been chased across two counties and had lost his books to a woman with a forged cloakroom ticket, in the lobby of this hotel, while Khalid sat upstairs being told it was never an accident.

He had believed for two weeks that he served his client best by leaving. He had been told, by a stranger, that he might serve it by coming back, and had not yet decided whether the stranger was right. He found that the recall had decided it for him, in the way a deadline decided things: not by argument, but by removing the time in which to go on not deciding.

'How long,' he said, 'before the new man is in this chair and able to sign?'

Nasser considered. 'The council sits on Wednesday. Consultations, they say, so there will be a form of hearing, which is to say they will let you speak. A week, sir, perhaps. Perhaps less, if your cousin has done his counting. Before the end of next week, somebody else will be the fund in London.'

'Then I have a week in which I am still the fund in London.'

'You have until the council sits on Wednesday morning in which you are the fund in London with authority, sir. After that you are a man awaiting consultations.'

'Yes,' Khalid said. 'I know the difference. I am going to ask you to pretend, for three days, that you do not.'

He stood, and went to the window, which he had not done all week because the man who had sat across this table from him had told him that a fund manager in Mayfair stood at his window, and he had not wished to resemble him.

'I want the London office ready to transact on Tuesday morning. Lines reopened with the three clearing banks, in writing, today, so that they can take the other side in size at the open without ringing anyone for permission. Custody accounts in London able to receive cash from

the four places by Monday night; the instructions drafted and signed now, dated and held. Dealers on call from six on Tuesday. A mandate letter to the Bank, ready for whoever may be in a position to accept it, setting out what we would buy, in what order, and against what we would borrow. The order to be left blank. The man who knows it is not in a position to give it to us yet.'

Nasser did not write any of it down.

'And the authority for the purchases themselves?'

'I will sign on Sunday. Everything, dated Sunday.'

'Sir.' Nasser had stood up as well. He did not often choose his words in front of Khalid; he chose them now, and Khalid watched him do it. 'I have been with you seven years. I was in the room when you took the money out of Mr Crane's fund and I will go where you go after Monday, wherever that is. So I am going to say this once, so that it has been said by somebody who is not your cousin.

'A recall is not a dismissal. It is the step before one, and the step is there so that a man may come home and be dismissed with honour and a pension and his name. If you sign on Sunday what you have just described, and it is acted on Tuesday, after you have been told in writing that your authority ends Monday, then you have moved the nation's money back into the one country it was taken out of, on your own signature, against the council's instruction, on the word of a man wanted by the English police, using a list he cannot prove and no longer has. If it works, the fund did it, and you will be forgiven in the way men are forgiven at home, which is quietly and not entirely. If it does not work, you did it. Alone. With money that was not yours.' He paused. 'You know what they will call that at home, sir. It is the same word the English have been using about Mr Whitlock all week. And they do not have a civil order for it there. They have another thing.'

The glass hummed. A bus went by below, red, full of people on their way to a Friday.

'You are telling me not to do it.'

'No, sir. I am telling you what it costs. You asked me on the Saturday what the instruction would cost and I told you, and you signed it. I would not have you sign this one knowing less.'

'And if I had asked you what it costs to do nothing?'

Nasser looked at him for a moment. 'Then I would have said that you have already paid that, sir, and so has London, and it is on the sheet in my hand, and you have asked me not to read it to you.'

Khalid almost smiled. 'Prepare the office. All of it. Bring me the papers tonight.'

'Sir.'

'And ring Mr Whitlock. The number on the slip. Tell him Sunday, here, at whatever hour he can manage, with whatever he has by then. Tell him the Bank said *concrete*.' He turned back to the window, to the park, and the roofs beyond it, and somewhere beyond those a clearing house that was standing up each morning on borrowed money. 'And Nasser. The flight on Sunday night. Do not cancel it. I would like my cousin to believe, until Monday, that I am on it.'

Chapter 34

Calloway's office

Friday. #1416. Begun at 12.40 on Saturday morning by the clock over the doors, in a hospital corridor, on the backs of a leaflet about head injuries that a nurse gave me to read. I have read it. The pen is mine.

The day before the stairs. The stairs took four minutes and the day took fourteen hours, and the day is the reason there were stairs.

Nine o'clock, the box on the Kentish Town Road, Margaret's landline. Laura. Four minutes. Nothing to report at either end, which I have learned to count as a good morning.

The paper's building by ten, by the back way. Fourth floor, the room with no windows. Graham was already there with the wheeled case, in his coat, because he has been a 7.35 man for thirty years and has nowhere to be at 7.35.

The work, in one paragraph. Sixteen box files: four years of what Walbrook's own risk committee was told each member had lodged with us, by code, by line, by size, with Graham's initials under "no material concentration" at the foot of every quarter. Priya read. I wrote. Graham found the pages and said the names, which he is allowed to say and I am not. By six the right-hand column of the page in my coat had, against all twelve codes, what the firm's own papers say each one holds to the end of September. Not the fingerprints; those are

in Mayfair. But a column a central bank can check against the firm's records is a different thing from two people's memory of a notebook, and Priya said so at six, pen down: 'Now it's their records.' The red book was open beside her all day and did not leave her reach once. I noticed, because it is what I used to do.

12.10. Phone two. Nasser, from a car. Mr Al-Mansouri asked him to say Sunday, at the hotel, at whatever hour I could manage, with whatever I had by then. 'And he asked me to tell you, Mr Whitlock, that the Bank said *concrete*. Twice. He was looking at the table.' I said Sunday.

The second name paid its nine o'clock on the Bank's money, Graham said. Four more mornings of that, by his arithmetic, and then Tuesday. He left at twenty to nine with the case. He would not leave it in the room, and I did not ask him to.

10.50. Calloway's rule since Thursday: not the lifts, which open onto the night desk and a camera, but the back stairs to the loading bay, where he would meet us with the car at eleven. Priya wiped the board, as she has every night. She came out behind me with her rucksack on one shoulder and the red book inside it. I had the page where it has been since Wednesday, folded once, in the inside pocket of my coat, where the cloakroom ticket was.

The stairs are concrete. A half-landing between floors, a steel rail, a light on each landing and none between. I was six steps down from the fourth. Priya was on the landing above me, pulling the door to.

I heard feet coming down from the fifth and thought: Calloway. I have had three hours to improve that and I am not going to.

Two men. I am not going to describe them well, because I did not see them well, and I know what a description is worth when a man has written it afterwards to sound as though he looked. Dark coats. One broad, older, forty or more. One younger, quicker. Neither said a word on the way down. I have seen two of her people before, in the

dark and at a distance, and I could not swear to either of these.

The older one took hold of Priya's bag.

That was the whole of it. He took the strap and pulled, and Priya did not let go. Four years I have worked with her and I have never once seen her let go of anything, and she did not let go of a £30 rucksack on a staircase in the dark, and so when he pulled she came with it. Over the top step of the half-flight and down it, nine steps, onto the landing where I was standing, and I heard her wrist go before I heard her head. I did not know until tonight that you can tell the two sounds apart. You can.

Then I did the wrong thing. I went down to her. Not up at him; not down and away with the page; down, onto my knees, which is what anyone would do and is exactly what a man who wants your coat would like you to do. The younger one was on me before I had her head in my hands. His fist, the side of my face. I went over her legs. Two kicks, in the ribs, where the coat had swung open. He said, 'Where's the bag.' Not to me, exactly. Then his hand was inside my coat.

I felt the paper move. I want that down. His hand was on the page, through the lining, and it moved, and that is what four years and nine books and a fortnight had come to: a stranger's fingers in my pocket in the dark with Priya's blood running under my knee.

A door went below us. Two floors down, the bang a fire door makes, a man's voice, the lights on the lower landings coming on in order. He looked down. Not in; down. The older one said, 'Leave it,' from above, in the voice of a man who has been given a time and run out of it, and the hand came out of my coat empty, and they went up, not down, with Priya's bag, and I heard a door on the fifth, and nothing.

If anyone reading this wants to know what saved the map, it was a door. I would like it to have been me. It was a door, and a night guard who had heard a woman fall, and Calloway behind him taking the stairs two at a time. 10.54 by my watch. I had started counting

when her head hit the step.

Forty-one seconds. She was out for forty-one seconds, face against the concrete, right arm under her at an angle I am not going to describe, and then she was back, and the first thing she said was: 'What day is it.' Not asking. Checking. I said Friday. She said, 'Friday. Fourteen-sixteen. Ask me the pound.' I did not ask her the pound. Blood was coming out of her hair above the right ear faster than I would have thought a head could spare, and I had my handkerchief on it, and then Calloway's scarf. I have been told since, twice, by people in uniform, that scalps bleed and it means nothing. Nobody told me that at 10.55.

The guard rang 999. The ambulance was in the loading bay at 11.09. She was sick once on the way, Calloway says. I was not in it. A wanted man does not get into an ambulance; it goes to a building with a desk and a form and, at the end of the form, a constable. I watched the doors shut on her and walked, collar up, to the nearest hospital, which is on the river and which I am not naming. Twenty-six minutes.

Calloway gave her name at the desk. Not her name. He had one ready, and a date of birth, and said both without stopping, and the woman typed them, because nobody in this country has ever been asked for a passport to bleed. He told me afterwards that it belonged to someone who would not mind. I did not ask who. I am not writing it. It is the one thing in this entry I am keeping off the page on purpose, because a page is what they came for, and because Priya Raman is a name that was in a newspaper on Thursday in a sentence with the word "detained" in it, on bail, with a condition about Walbrook staff that she has broken every day this week in a room with me, and a hospital is a building full of people who read.

11.50. The wrist is broken: two bones, the doctor said, at the end nearest the hand, and showed me on a screen, and I understood none of it except the shape, which was wrong. They put it back behind a

curtain, under something local, and I heard her, and I did not know she had that language. A splint tonight; plaster to the elbow once the swelling goes.

12.20. The head. Stitched, above the ear. I did not count the stitches; she will, and she will tell me. The scan at 12.50. Clear. A clear scan is not a clear head, the doctor said, and they are keeping her: a torch in the eyes every two hours, and the date. She knew where she was and what day it was. Out for under a minute, sick once: I gave both before I was asked, and the doctor looked at me the way Laura looks at a patient who has written things down.

Me. The left side of my face, the ribs on the left, and nothing that stops a hand writing. I am not adding to that.

Second sitting. 2.20. A chair beside a bed, in a bay with the curtain half drawn, a name on the board above her that is not hers, which she has read three times since they brought her up at two. Her right arm is on a pillow. That side of her face is going a colour.

The bag. They took it. Her purse, with not much in it. The piece of paper the police gave her on Monday, with her name on it and a date four weeks off. The red book: her copy of the twelve codes and the order, Monday to Thursday in two colours of biro, and four days of our working. Everything in that bag, a man in Mayfair already has in better handwriting. I said that to her. She said, 'It was mine,' and shut her eyes, and she was right.

What they did not get is folded once in my coat. I have taken it out twice tonight and I am not going to again. Twelve codes, an order, a column in the firm's own figures. One corner is brown. That is hers. I am not writing round it.

Now the thing I have been thinking since 10.54, in the order I thought it.

For a fortnight the people who wanted the books said please. They sat in parks, left cards, stood a pace back from a kitchen door with

their hands where you could see them. Tonight nobody said please, and the woman who says please was not on the stairs. I do not know what that means. I am writing that I do not know, because in a week I will want to say I knew.

I do know what the bag means. *Where's the bag.* They went for a bag because they were told a bag, and whoever told them has not been watching us this week, because this week there has been no bag. He has read about one. Nine books, and in every one of them I am a man with a bag on both shoulders, the way you carry a child's bag. I would bet the house four times over that a man in Mayfair has read every line of it. He knows how I carry things. He does not know that I have stopped, because the book that would tell him is this leaflet.

He knows the rest. The ninth book runs to Tuesday. #1405 is in it: Margaret's landline, every morning at nine, from a payphone. #1409: the village, the war memorial, a lane with one way in. #1412: the box on the Kentish Town Road, 200 yards from a journalist's door. Everything I have done this fortnight to keep my wife out of it is written down in my hand on a desk in Mayfair, and tonight the man who owns that desk stopped asking.

It is 2.40. There is a payphone at the end of this ward, by the lifts, and I have a pound. In six hours and twenty minutes I ring a number that is in no book of mine, at a time that is in the last one.

Chapter 35

The press outside

There were three cars at the end of the lane on Saturday morning and a van with a dish on its roof, and a man standing on the second rung of a stepladder in the field gateway with a lens the length of his forearm, and Laura Whitlock stood at the landing window with Elsie on her hip and counted them the way she had counted the grey car eight days before. She found that counting them did not help. The grey car had been one thing that did not belong. These belonged to the week. They had come on Friday at about one, the first two cars within ten minutes of each other, and by the time the light went there had been seven people at the gate and a woman doing her face in a wing mirror, and this morning there were fewer, because Saturday, and because a lane in Norfolk gives you one picture and they had it.

The picture was on page five. Margaret's neighbour had brought the paper up at eight, because Margaret had not gone down for it, which she had done at eight every morning for the eleven years since Laura's father died. The house, from the lane, with the kitchen light on. Underneath, a sentence about the wife of the Walbrook risk manager being "understood to be staying with relatives in the area". Understood to be. Laura had read it standing at the sink and thought: that is a sentence written by someone who has been told not to say the village, and has said it.

Margaret was at the table with her hands round a mug she had not drunk from. She had been 71 for most of a year and had looked it for about a day and a half. On Friday evening one of them had come up the lane and knocked, a young man with a nice voice, and Margaret had opened the door before Laura could get to the hall, and had said, 'He's a good man, you know. He always rings,' and the young man had thanked her and written it down. Laura had got the door shut. Margaret had sat down in the hall chair and not got up for twenty minutes, and had said, when she did, that she did not know why she had said that, and Laura had said that it was because it was true, and that was what they were for.

Now she said, 'They'll go when there's nothing to see.'

'There's nothing to see now,' her mother said. 'There's me.'

He rang at nine. He had rung at nine every morning for twelve days, and she had stopped standing by the phone for it and started being in the room when it happened, which she knew was not the same and had decided not to think about.

She picked up on the first ring. 'Yes.'

'It's me.'

Different, behind him. Not a road. A hard floor, a trolley with a wheel that needed looking at, a voice on a tannoy asking somebody to go somewhere, the particular hum of a corridor that was lit all night. She had spent six years of her life in that sound and she knew it before he had finished the second word.

'You're in a hospital.'

'Yes.'

'Are you hurt?'

'No. Priya is.'

He told it the way he told things, in order, with the times. Friday night, the paper's building, south of the river, a stairwell. Two men. Not Kessler; Kessler was not there, and he had thought about that and

did not yet know what it meant. They had wanted what was in his coat and had gone for the person nearer the top of the stairs. Priya had gone down a flight. She had been out, he thought, for under a minute. Her right wrist. Her head, above the ear, which had bled a great deal and had been stitched. They had scanned it. They were keeping her. She was in a bed under a name that was not hers, and he had been in the chair beside it since two, and the payphone was at the end of the ward by the lifts, and he had come to it with a pound.

Laura asked the questions in the order she would have asked them of a registrar. Loss of consciousness, how long. Vomiting. Did she know where she was when she came round. Did she know what day it was. Was she talking sense. Was the scan clear. He answered every one and the answers were right, in the sense that they were the answers of a man who had sat through a night in a chair listening to doctors and had written down what they said, and she heard, under them, that he was not answering the one she had asked first.

'And you.'

'I'm fine.'

'Jonas.'

'My hands work. I can write. That's all I need them for.' A trolley went past him. 'The page is in my coat. That's what they came for and they didn't get it. Everything else is in a bag in Mayfair.'

'That's not what I asked either.'

He said nothing for a count of two, which was his way of agreeing.

'Laura. The cars at the end of the lane.'

'You've seen the paper.'

'Priya's got one. They're photographers. They'll stand there and they'll go. They can't hurt you.'

'Neither could she. She stood in the kitchen.'

'That's—' He stopped. She heard him start again, lower, with the care he used when he had decided what he was going to say and was going to say it whatever she did. 'Listen to me. Whatever you see at

the end of that lane, you stay inside it. The men on Friday knew which of us to go for and they will know where you are, because everyone does now, and the one thing that lane has is that you can see who's coming up it. Don't come to London. I mean it. Don't put Elsie in a car. Say it.'

She did not say it. She stood in her mother's hall with the receiver against her ear and watched her mother through the kitchen door, not drinking her tea, and she did not say it, and the pips went, and he said 'Laura' once more in the voice of a man who has one coin, and the line went.

She put the phone down and looked at her hands. Steady. That interested her.

She took the history, because that was what she did when she did not know yet what she thought.

Presenting complaint: a man on a stepladder. Onset: Friday, one o'clock. Course: fewer today; would be more on Monday, when the paper that had the house had a quote from a neighbour, and the ones that did not have the house came for it. Then the relevant history, and she made herself go through it in order and not skip, as she would have for a patient who wanted to tell her only about the knee.

She had been sent here on a Sunday night because nobody knew about it. A week later a woman had stood in the kitchen and known Elsie's name without saying it. The police had the number of the car on the drive. The Treasury had sent two officers to Priya's door on a letter. Last night two men had broken Priya's wrist in a stairwell because she was nearer the top of the stairs than Jonas was, and the people who sent them had lost the thing they wanted, and there was a photograph on page five that told anyone who had not been paying attention where the wife was. The lane had one thing: you could see who was coming up it. You could see, and then they were at the door, and you opened it on the chain, and they were courteous.

Safe was a reading. She had taken it herself on the first night, with the engine off at the services and Elsie feeding, and she had not checked it since, because it was the reading she wanted. She knew that failure. She had seen it in better doctors than herself. A stable number taken for a healthy one.

The other thing. She had said, on Monday, at the door, *you have one week*, and had not said what happened at the end of it, because she had not known. The week ran out on Monday. She stood in the hall and found that she did know now, and that she had known since the hospital corridor came down the line behind his voice, and that it had nothing to do with photographers. He was in a chair beside a bed in a hospital she could not name, and the one thing he had asked her for in twelve days was to stay somewhere he could not reach her, and she had spent six years of marriage and twelve days of this being the one who was kept. There was no safe. There was where he was and where he was not, and she had found that she minded the second more than she minded the first.

'You can't take her into that,' Margaret said.

'She's in it. She's in it here. She's in it on page five.'

Margaret had got up when Laura came into the kitchen and said it, and had sat down again, and her hands had gone to the mug. Laura watched the hands. Fine tremor, both sides, worse than Friday. Her mother had spent the week pretending the radio was not on and had let a young man with a nice voice write down the only thing she knew.

'Then stay and we'll be in it together. There's two of us.'

'Mum. There isn't a together. They're not here for you, and they're not here for Elsie, they're here for a picture of the house, and when I'm gone they'll have the picture and they'll go, and you can go down for the paper.' She crouched, so that she was below her mother's eyeline, which was a thing you did, and took one of the hands off the mug and held it. 'He rings at nine. He'll ring tomorrow. You answer. You tell

him I've gone to London with her, and that I'm all right, and that he's to keep ringing here, every day, because I'll ring you, and that's how it works now.'

'He'll ask where.'

'Tell him he knows where I'd go and he's not to go there.' She had thought about that in the hall. He would know. Aisha would open the door and not ask, and Jonas would not ring Aisha's number from a box because of the thing he understood about telephones, and she had decided, standing in the hall, that she was going to use what he had taught her against him and not feel bad about it. 'Tell him I'll find him. He walked into a building in St James's and said his name and a man rang him back in an hour. Tell him I can walk into a building too.'

Margaret looked at her for a while. Then she said, 'You've got his face on. The one he had at the table.'

'Good,' Laura said, and stood up.

She packed properly this time. The Sunday-night bag had taken eleven minutes; this took forty, and she did it the way she had done it then, nappies at the bottom, the thing Elsie would need first at the top, and she took the time because she had it and because packing was a thing her hands knew how to do while the rest of her did something else. The rabbit went in last, on top, where Elsie could see it from the seat.

In the kitchen she opened the drawer where she had put the card. Plain white, a mobile number, nothing else. She stood with it for a moment and could not have said what she meant by it, except that it was the one telephone number in the country that led to the people who knew where her husband was before she did, and she was done with being the person in the house who had nothing. She put it in the back of her phone case. Elsie went into the seat at twenty past ten and did not argue, because the car was a thing that happened to her and

she liked the trees going past. Margaret stood in the door with her arms folded over her cardigan and did not come to the gate, which Laura understood: a woman at a gate is a photograph, and a woman in a doorway is not.

'Ring me,' Margaret said.

'From a phone that isn't mine.' She saw her mother not understand it, and let it go. 'Tonight. I promise.'

The lane was 300 yards to the field gate. She drove it at the speed she drove it to the shop. The man came down off the stepladder when he saw the car move and the others came out of the cars, and by the time she was fifty yards off there were five of them in the lane with the van behind, and the one in front had his hand up, flat, the way a policeman stops you, as though he were anyone.

She did not slow for the hand. She slowed for the lane. At walking pace she went through them, and they went round her the way water goes round a stone, and the lenses came up to the glass on both sides, and a woman said her name through the window twice, 'Laura, Laura,' as if they were friends. She looked straight ahead. She had treated people who looked at the floor and people who looked at the camera and she had never, until that moment, understood why anyone would do either, and she found that there was a third thing, which was to look at the road, because the road was where you were going.

In the mirror Elsie had the rabbit's ear in her mouth and was watching the men with the open stare of someone who had been alive for a year and nine days and had not yet been told what any of it was for.

Past the village sign one of the cars pulled out behind her. She watched it for a mile and then stopped watching it, because the police had her number plate and the woman had stood in the kitchen and a man with a lens had stood on a ladder, and all of them, every one, knew exactly where she was, and the only person in England who did not was the man she had married.

She had been sent to Norfolk on a Sunday night with a bag she had

packed in eleven minutes. Nobody was sending her back.

At Thetford the road went into the forest, and she put the radio on, low, out of habit, and the news said his name, and she left it on.

Chapter 36

The transaction

Sunday. First sitting, ten past five, on a pad with four letters at the top of every sheet, in a room in St James's with no window that opens. I said on Wednesday that I would write on whatever I had and not say so again. This is what I have.

I am going to write the morning before I write the thing, because the thing is the point of 1,418 entries and I want to get to it with my hands steady.

Nine o'clock. The payphone by the lifts on Priya's ward, with a pound. Margaret answered. Not Laura. Margaret has not answered that telephone in twelve days.

Laura left yesterday at twenty past ten with Elsie and the bag, through the photographers, for London. She is all right. She rang Margaret last night from a telephone that was not hers. I am to keep ringing at nine, every day, because that is how it works now. She said I would know where she had gone and that I was not to go there. She said she would find me. Margaret read the last part off a piece of paper, because Laura had made her write it down, and I stood in a hospital corridor and heard my wife use my own method on me.

I know where. I am not writing it. I am not going there, which is what she meant.

Twelve days of asking her to stay in one place, and she stayed for twelve, and yesterday I rang from a hospital and asked her to say she would not come, and she did not say it, and I heard her not say it, and I let the pips take the line because I had one coin. One week, she said on Monday at the door. It runs out tomorrow. She has come down to collect.

Priya's room. Not a ward; a side room off one, with a door, which Nasser's office arranged on Saturday afternoon in a way that was not explained to me and that I did not ask about. Her right wrist in plaster to the elbow. Stitches above the ear, eleven of them; she counted by touch and told me the number because she knew I would want it. A name on the board above the bed that is not hers, which she looks at every so often with the expression of a woman reading a figure she did not produce. They want to keep her until Monday. She wants to leave. They have taken her shoes, which seems to be how hospitals win.

She cannot write. For four years she has checked my work by rewriting it, and today she sat up against three pillows and said numbers and I wrote them down, and I understood for the first time what it is to be the hand and not the head. She is better at it than I am. She gave the figures and then the reason, in that order, as she always has, and twice she said 'No. Again,' and I crossed out and started again.

Graham came at twenty to ten with the wheeled case. The holiday case he wheeled into the paper on Thursday and has not let out of his sight since, and inside it sixteen box files, four years of risk committee packs, the ones the committee saw and the ones it did not, kept at home because that is what a man does who signs things and would like, later, to be able to say what he signed. Member codes against names. Collateral balances, by member, by quarter, cash and bonds, the lines and the sizes. The concentration reports with "no material concentration" at the foot of every one, and his initials. He put it on the bed by Priya's feet and stood back from it, as if it might go off.

He looks ten years older than he did at the Treasury. He did not say "not yet" once all morning. I noticed because I was waiting for it.

Nasser came at ten with two people from the fund's London desk, a woman who runs its sterling book and a man who does its legal, and three laptops, and a ward sister who looked at the room and the laptops and the man in the suit and went away again. Six people and a bed. Priya looked at it and said, 'Well. That's a committee,' and we began.

Here is the thing. I am going to write it the way we built it, one piece at a time, so that anyone who finds this page can follow it without having done my job. Priya made me do it that way in the room. 'Say it so the sister could understand it,' she said. 'If you can't, it's not a plan, it's a feeling.'

The problem first. I think twelve members of Walbrook are holding bonds that are promised to more people than own them. I have never seen that; the fingerprints say it, and I have said so for four years. Every morning the price of those bonds falls, Walbrook calls them for the difference in cash, and they find the cash by selling bonds, which makes the price fall, which brings the next call. One of the twelve failed on the Monday before last. The second is the name on your debit card and it has been paying its calls since Thursday week with money borrowed from the Bank of England, and Graham, who knows the rules, says the auction of the first one's book closes on Monday, and that the second one will not survive Tuesday's call, when the survivors are asked to put back what the auction cost them. When the second goes, the fund that stands behind every trade Walbrook guarantees is gone, and the Bank starts talking about a word that means Walbrook stops. Everything it stands in the middle of, frozen. Not falling. Frozen.

Now the buyer. The forced selling only stops if someone stands on the other side of it with enough cash and no need to sell. There

is nobody in London. Everyone in London is a seller. There is one man in the world who has spent nine working days turning British government bonds into cash and moving the cash somewhere it cannot be frozen, and he is in St James's, and he is the reason the thing started, and he is the only one who can afford to stop it.

The map. The twelve codes, in the order they fail, and the right-hand column: what each one is holding that is promised twice, which lines, roughly how much. The page in my coat has the codes and the order and a column that Priya and I rebuilt from memory on Wednesday and Thursday. Graham's packs gave it names, and sizes to the quarter end, and Priya corrected the sizes forward from what she knows of the last fortnight, which is a great deal. The sterling woman put it into her machine line by line and said, at one point, 'I've been trying to guess this list for a week.' Nobody answered her. That is the map Crane has, in nine books in Mayfair, which are now the only copy there is. He can use it to know where to push. It is also, read the other way, a shopping list.

The transaction. On Tuesday morning, when the market opens and the twelve are forced to sell, the fund buys. Not everything; exactly what each of the twelve is forced to sell, in the lines the map says, in the sizes the map says, in the order the map says they fail, through the fund's three clearing banks, which are the same banks it sold through last week. The first name sells and the fund is the bid. The second name sells and the fund is the bid. The market, which has spent two weeks learning that there is no bid, discovers that there is one, and that it does not go away, and that it is standing exactly where the selling comes from. The man who does legal called it "meeting the market". Priya said, 'It's catching the plates.' Both are right. The fund's own name for it, Nasser said, is "the final transaction", because it is the last the fund intends to make in London.

Why the order. This is the part I had to say three times. If the fund buys in the wrong order, it is buying what nobody is selling yet,

and the thing that is being sold still falls, and the fund has spent its cash early and holds bonds that are going down. Worse: the market reads the list from the buying. If the fund stands in the right lines at the right moment it looks like a buyer meeting sellers; if it stands in the wrong ones it looks like a man with a list, and the list becomes public in the first hour, and every fund in London that is short those names sells them harder. The order has to be the order. The order is in my head. Priya has it on paper, from memory, as I gave it to her; Graham's packs confirm the sizes to September. But the fingerprints behind every line, which is what tells you how fast each one goes, are in nine notebooks I do not have and in a man who read them for four years. The sterling woman asked, quite reasonably, who would be in her room on Tuesday morning to say which line was next. Nasser said, 'Mr Whitlock.' Nobody said that Mr Whitlock is wanted by the police. It did not need saying.

The money. Nasser wrote a figure and turned the pad round. I am not writing it. It is more than came out of London in the week, and it is nearly all of what the fund holds that is not bolted to the ground. Priya said the number back to him and then said what it meant: a buyer that size cannot carry what it buys, because by ten o'clock it is simply the next man holding bonds that are falling, with more of them than anyone. It has to be able to turn each purchase back into cash the same morning or it runs out by the fourth name.

The Bank. That is what the Bank is for. The Bank of England lends cash against government bonds every day of its life; it is the thing it does. On Tuesday morning it lends against the bonds the fund buys, as it buys them, through the fund's three banks, so that each purchase becomes cash again inside the hour and the cash buys the next line. The fund never holds more than one name's bonds at a time. The Bank holds them all, against cash, which is a thing the Bank has done since before there was a Walbrook. And if the Bank is the lender, the market knows the buyer does not stop, because the buyer is the Bank's

money going round. Strand said to me at her own table that the system is held up by the belief that it is held up. She was right. On Tuesday the belief has to be that there is a bid. There is one. She only has to let the market believe it.

The indemnity. Lending against bonds usually needs no such paper. This does, Graham says, for three reasons: the size, which the Bank has never lent in a morning; the borrower, a sovereign fund and not a bank; and the haircuts, which will be set line by line, on lines the Bank would not normally lend against at all. If the bonds keep falling, the Bank is holding them against cash it has lent and the Bank loses, and the Bank's loss is public money, and the Governor, by every account Graham and Nasser can give me, will not do it without her signature on a piece of paper that says the Treasury carries the loss. Graham knows the piece of paper. It is one page. It has been signed before, in 2022, by a Chancellor who was gone within the month, which Graham said and then wished he had not.

The time. Walbrook's calls go to the banks at eight and are due at nine. The exchanges open at eight. The fund needs the selling to come to it, not to come before it. So the Bank asks the exchanges to open late, and asks Walbrook to move its deadline from nine to noon, which the rulebook allows and which Walbrook has never once done, and the room gets three hours in which the twelve can sell to a buyer instead of into nothing. Graham said the extension would itself be read as panic. Priya said that a market which has watched a clearing house eat its own default fund for a fortnight is not going to be frightened by a late start.

The squeeze. Anyone who has been short the twelve names since nine days before a ship sank, in their parents' shares and in the bonds under them and in the pound, has been paid every minute since. On Tuesday the thing he is short goes up, hard, in the first hour, in every line at once, and the bonds he has borrowed to sell are the bonds the Bank is now holding, and he has to buy back what he sold into a

market with one buyer, which is not him. The sterling woman asked who. Nasser said the fund did not speculate about other participants. Priya said, ‘Greywether,’ and the room was quiet for a moment, and then the man who does legal wrote it down.

Done right, the forced selling stops in an hour. Not slows. Stops. The second name pays its nine o’clock, or its noon, with the price of its collateral going up instead of down, and the fund that stands behind Walbrook stops being spent, and the twelve are twelve banks with a bad fortnight instead of a list. Done wrong, or late, or in the wrong order, or without the Bank, the fund has brought its client’s money back into the one city it spent a week leaving, and bought bonds that fall, and it fails with Walbrook, on the same morning, and a man who has one client does not go home.

Nasser said that last part. He said it in the voice he uses for everything, and then he said, ‘My principal has instructed me to say it to you, Mr Whitlock, so that you have heard it before you ask him for it.’

It needs one signature. Not the Governor’s; the Governor wants it, Graham says, and has wanted it for a week. The one that is missing is the one that goes on the indemnity, and it belongs to a woman who denied last Sunday that she had seen six pages with her department’s stamp on them, and who asked me, a fortnight ago, for mine.

12.40. Nasser rang his principal from the corridor and came back and said two things. The Governor will be in the room. The Chancellor will see Mr Al-Mansouri at eight o’clock tonight, at the Treasury, with whoever he chooses to bring, for thirty minutes, without officials. Then he looked at me and said, ‘He chooses to bring you.’

Priya said, ‘Shoes,’ and the sister would not give them to her, so she is not coming, and she has said what she thinks of that, and the man in the suit from legal has gone a colour.

Graham will not come either. He said he had sat at that table once and that his presence would not help, and he is right, and I think it is

also true that he could not. He put his hand on the case by the bed and then took it away and left it there, and said, 'It's hers now. She'll read it properly,' and went.

Horse Guards Road. Third floor. A long table and a view of the park going dark. I have sat at it once, with my own memo put in front of me and a statement with a line for my name, and I asked for the night and was given until six on Monday. Tonight I go back in with a sovereign wealth fund on one side and the Governor of the Bank of England on the other and I ask the Chancellor of the Exchequer for her signature on one page.

I have written 1,417 entries about what happens when someone asks me for mine. I am about to find out what it is like from the other chair.

Second sitting after. If there is anything to write.

Chapter 37

No

He had asked for no officials, and Caroline Strand had said yes to that on the telephone at half past twelve and then, at half past seven, brought two. Simon Carrow, at her left, where he had been for three years, and the young man with the laptop at the end of the table, who had typed through the Saturday meeting a fortnight ago and would type through this one. A week ago she had given the Governor a room with no note in it and had found that it did not help. She was not going to make the same mistake with a foreign state.

The same room. She had chosen it. Third floor, the long table, the park beyond the glass gone from grey to black while she waited, nothing on the walls. Sunday, eight o'clock. The building was Sunday-empty and the lights in the corridor had come on for them in sections.

Al-Mansouri came in first, which she noted. A good dark suit, no tie, a man who had been tired for a long time and had decided not to mention it; he shook her hand and the Governor's and sat where she put him, and did not look round the room, because he had been in rooms. His chief of staff stayed outside with the door. Then the Governor, who had come on foot again, in the same coat, and who had telephoned her at one o'clock to say that he would attend and that she should understand what his attending meant. She understood it. He sat on her right, which was his place, and did not take out a pen.

Then Whitlock.

He had been searched downstairs, courteously, by her own people, on her instruction, and had carried in nothing but a coat that had been torn at the knee and mended by someone who did not sew. He stood for a moment inside the door and looked at the table, and she watched him find the chair he had sat in two weeks ago, at the far end, and take a different one, nearer, and sit down in it, and put his hands flat on the wood where she could see them. He had learned that somewhere. She wondered from whom.

There were four police officers in London who would have liked very much to know that this man was in this building. She had thought about that in the car and decided it in the car. A man wanted for questioning, arrested in the Treasury, on a Sunday night, having arrived as the guest of a sovereign wealth fund: that was Monday's front page, and it was not a page about collateral. She had said to the Governor, a fortnight ago, that a story about a man was easier to run than a story about collateral. It was still true. It was now true against her.

'Mr Al-Mansouri. You asked for thirty minutes. The Governor has told me what you are going to ask for. I would like to hear it from you, in your words, and then I will ask Mr Whitlock some questions, and then I will tell you my decision tonight, because I understand that time is the point.'

'It is the whole of the point, Chancellor.' Formal, unhurried, the English of a man who had learned it young and kept it carefully. 'I will be brief, because the Governor has been thorough.'

He was brief. On Tuesday morning the fund he directed would buy, through its London clearing banks, the government bonds that twelve named members of Walbrook Clearing House would be forced to sell to meet their calls, in the order and in the quantities set out on a page that Mr Whitlock had, in the sense that he could produce it, and had, in the sense that he could not. The Bank of England would lend to the fund's banks against the bonds as they were bought, so that the

fund's cash went round rather than out. The Bank and the exchanges would open late, and Walbrook would move its deadline to noon. The Treasury would indemnify the Bank against loss. If it worked, and he said "if" without emphasis, the forced selling would stop by nine, the second member would survive the morning, and anyone who had sold those twelve names short would need to buy them back from a market in which there was one buyer, who was not them. If it did not, his fund would have returned to London the greater part of what it had spent a week removing, and would lose it, and the clearing house would fail in any case, and he would not be the man answering for it at home, because he would not be at home.

He had not raised his voice or dropped it. He had, she noticed, not once said the word "state".

'Governor.'

'It is a repo, Chancellor. It is what the Bank does. I would do it tomorrow morning if you would sign the indemnity, and I would have the exchanges and Walbrook on the telephone tonight. I have said as much to you for a week. The difference tonight is that there is a buyer. Last Saturday there was not.'

'And the scale.'

He gave it. She had it already, from the one o'clock call, and had spent the afternoon with it, and hearing it aloud in the room did not improve it.

She turned to Whitlock. She had crossed better witnesses, and worse, and she knew within a minute which this was: the kind who answered the question asked and no other, which was the hardest kind, because it left nothing to hang him with except what he said.

'Mr Whitlock. The order in which these twelve institutions fail. You cannot prove it.'

'No.'

'You have inferred it.'

'From four years of what I saw. Yes.'

‘The notebooks in which you saw it.’

‘Were taken from me on Tuesday night.’

‘By whom?’

‘I was not told. I can tell you who has them now.’

‘I did not ask you that.’ She let the silence sit, a barrister’s habit, and he let it sit too, which almost nobody did. ‘So the Treasury is asked to indemnify the Bank of England to lend against purchases made by a foreign state, in an order the state cannot verify, from a list that exists on one page in your coat and otherwise in your memory, because the evidence for it is in the possession of someone you are not prepared to name in this room.’

‘The evidence for it is on Tuesday morning, Chancellor. The first name on the list failed at 7.58 on the Monday before last. I had it first. The second name is borrowing from the Bank to pay its calls. I had it second. You can wait for the third and the fourth and then you will have proof, and no clearing house.’

She looked at the Governor. The Governor looked at the table.

‘Mr Al-Mansouri. Your country is, as of yesterday evening, the subject of a motion in the American Senate to freeze its assets in connection with the sinking. Your government denies it. You will understand that I have to proceed on the basis of what is said in public, not what is said in rooms.’

‘My government did not sink the ship, Chancellor.’

‘I note that you say so, and that you offer me nothing with it.’ He inclined his head, very slightly, as if she had made a fair point in a game. ‘And you are, I am told, recalled.’

‘For consultations.’

‘Which may not go well.’

‘Which may not.’

‘Then I would be signing a piece of paper that lets a state publicly blamed for this fortnight buy, at the bottom, what British pension funds are forced to sell, with the Bank lending it the money to do so and the

taxpayer carrying the loss; and by Friday the man I signed it with may have been replaced by one who holds those bonds and does not care for London at all.'

'He would hold them, Chancellor,' the Governor said, 'at the Bank. Against cash. That is what a repo is. Whoever runs the fund on Friday, the bonds are in my vault, and if he does not want them back I keep them and he keeps the cash, and I have bought gilts at Tuesday's price with the Treasury's name on it, which is what you have been refusing to let me do for a week.'

'Buying British institutions.' She said it to see what it did in the room. 'That is what it will be called.'

'Bonds,' Whitlock said. 'Not institutions. Government bonds, which your department sold him in the first place.'

'And you believe the public will tell the difference.'

He did not answer that, because it was not a question, and she saw that he knew it was not.

She stood, because she thought better standing, and went to the glass. The park was black. Horse Guards was lit, and empty, and beyond it the Admiralty, and beyond that the city that had spent a fortnight learning the word "collateral".

The prime minister had given her until Monday to stabilise the situation. He had used that phrase, and she had let him. On Thursday a journalist had printed that her department had asked the police to detain a woman who pulled a report for her boss, and she had said that the Treasury did not comment on police matters, and the sentence had held for about a day. On Thursday night she had read the memo. All of it, the tables, the footnotes, the sentence everyone knew and the pages nobody had turned. It was right. She had sat with that for an hour and then put it back under its cover note, where it had been for three years, because a department's knowledge was the department's, and the doctrine had a name, and she had been going to need it.

What she had in front of her was a mechanism that would work. She could see that it would work. It was the Governor's own proposal from a week ago with a buyer in it, and the buyer was the one thing that had been missing, and the one thing she could not be seen beside. Two and a half weeks. Nineteen days. A Gulf state, a Treasury indemnity, a bailout with a foreign flag on it and a wanted man in the dealing room. She did not need to imagine the front page. She could have written it, and the Opposition's line under it, and the question at the first press conference, and her answer, and the next question, and she found she could not write the second answer, and that was the test, and she had known it in the car.

She had the other page too. The one for Wednesday, if Tuesday went as the Governor said. She had not let herself write that one, because she had found, a week ago, that she thought about the memo instead of the decision, and had recognised the manoeuvre, and she recognised it now. She was thinking about Wednesday's page because it was easier than Monday's.

The thing about belief, she had told this man at this table, was that it was the mechanism. She had meant the market's belief. She found she had not, until this fortnight, considered whose else.

She turned round.

'No.'

Nobody moved. The young man at the end of the table had stopped typing and she waited until he started again.

'I want to be exact, because I would like the exactness recorded. I am not refusing the Bank. The Governor may lend to whom he judges fit, against what he judges fit, on his own authority and his own balance sheet, and he knows that. What I am declining to do is to put the Treasury's name to it. The government will not indemnify a transaction in which a foreign sovereign fund, whose country is the subject of a freezing motion in a friendly legislature, buys British government debt at distressed prices in an order dictated by a man the police wish

to interview and whose evidence he cannot produce. Not because of the election. Because no Chancellor could defend it to a select committee in any month of any year, and I am not going to be the first to try. That is not politics, Governor. It is prudence.'

She heard the sentence land, and heard what it was, and did not take it back.

Al-Mansouri stood. He did it without hurry and buttoned his jacket, and she saw that he had expected it, and that expecting it had not helped him either.

'Thank you for the thirty minutes, Chancellor. I shall go home. I had hoped to be able to tell them that London had asked me to stay.' He paused at the door. 'When it is useful to you to know who sank the ship, I will still know. I do not expect that to be soon.'

Whitlock got up more slowly. He had not looked at her since "bonds". He looked at her now, from the chair he had chosen, and said, quite quietly, as if he were noting a time: 'You asked me for a signature once. I asked for the night. You gave me until six on Monday.'

'I remember.'

'It's Sunday,' he said, and went out behind the man who had brought him, and she heard, through the door, the chief of staff say something in a language she did not have.

The Governor did not get up. He sat with his hands folded and looked at the place at the table where the fund had been.

'Walbrook's call goes to the banks at eight on Tuesday,' he said. 'The survivors' call to refill the fund goes with it. I will be lending to the second member from seven. I will keep lending until there is nothing left to lend against, which on my figures is Tuesday afternoon. After that I write to you. The letter will say what I told you in the flat it would say.'

'I know what it will say.'

‘Then you know that once it exists, you may direct me to do precisely what you have just declined to indemnify, and that the only difference will be the date on it and the number of institutions still standing.’ He stood, and did up the coat. ‘I am not arguing, Chancellor. You have decided. I am telling you the timetable, because people always think it is midnight on Monday.’

He saw himself out.

Carrow waited until the lift had gone. He had the face he wore when he had been given something he could not make smaller, and she had hired him for it, and tonight she did not want to see it.

‘Chancellor. The officers downstairs would like to know whether the gentleman who came in with the fund has left the building.’

‘He came in as the guest of a foreign state. He may leave as one. The Treasury does not involve itself in operational policing.’ She picked up her bag. ‘And Simon. For the minutes. The word tonight was prudence. I would like it in.’

‘Yes, Chancellor.’

He had already written it down. She had watched him do it, at the moment she said it, and she had watched him not look up, and she found, walking to the lift along a corridor whose lights came on in sections ahead of her and went off behind, that she could not remember whether she had rehearsed the word in the car, or only found it in the room, and that for the first time in twelve years at the Bar and fourteen in the House she could not tell the difference.

Chapter 38

Tuesday

Tuesday. Week four. Entry #1420, on the back of Calloway's printer paper, in sittings, because the day did not allow for anything else. First sitting 10.20am, his kitchen table, the television on in the next room with the sound off.

Monday first, since Monday did not get an entry. It is the first day in 1,419 that did not, and the reason is that I could not lift the pen. I number days, not pages, so today is 1,420 and Monday stays empty, and the gap is the entry. Four lines. The week Laura gave me ran out at nine on Monday morning; I know the time because I was standing in a phone box on the Kentish Town Road when it did. This morning at nine, from the same box, I got her mother again, and a message read off paper, and rang off. The auction of the first member's book closed, the loss was a number the papers printed and I will not, and Walbrook asked the 38 survivors to put the default fund back to where it had been, by this morning's call. The Bank lent again, to the second name on the page and to anyone else who asked, and the second name met Monday's call at 8.51 with the Bank's money, and the market went up a little, the way a man feels better on the second day of a fever. Nothing moved. The woman who said no on Sunday was still saying it. The man who said yes was on an aeroplane home.

I had the page in my coat before I was awake. I have been sleeping

in the coat.

What I could do this morning, counted at six. Nothing. The working: no notebooks; they are in a room in Mayfair, read by a man who has already acted on them. A telephone four people can ring, none of them the one man who could act, because he has been recalled. No signature; the Chancellor gave her answer in person on Sunday. The map, in my head and on a page in my coat, rebuilt from memory and Graham's papers and Priya's red book, and as far as I can check it, right. A colleague in a hospital bed under a name that is not hers. That is the inventory. A man who can see exactly what is going to happen and cannot touch any of it. Priya would say I have had four years of practice.

7.04. Walbrook's call went out and the ticker said record, as it has said every morning for a fortnight, so that the word has stopped meaning anything, like a bell that will not stop.

8.00. The open.

It came in the order on the page. I want that down plainly while I can still write plainly. The second name, then the third, then the fourth. Not the whole list, and not the market; the market had been going down for two weeks, and this was something else inside it, with edges. The second member's parent, the bank whose name is on more plastic in more pockets than any other in the country, was thrown into auction on the exchange at 8.02, came out lower, and was thrown in again. Nobody does that to a bank on the first morning of the week's hope unless they have decided to. Then, on the prices page Calloway had left open on his laptop, the three long gilt lines I had written against its code in the holdings column fell faster than the gilts beside them. I know which lines they were because I was watching for them, which is the only reason anyone would have seen it. Three lines out of a few dozen, a little ahead of the rest, as if they had been pushed.

I have written since entry #212 about bonds lent out in the morning

to raise the cash for the nine o'clock. If you want to break a man who pays that way, you do not attack him. You get to the repo market before him, borrow the exact bonds he will need, sell them, and make them dear to get back. Then Walbrook marks his collateral down and calls him for cash at the moment the cash has gone. I wrote that on a Tuesday when I was 36 as a thing that might happen to somebody one day. Somebody had read it.

8.30. The news had the phrase it uses when it has heard something it cannot source. *Reports that a major clearing member is experiencing difficulty rolling its overnight funding.* Experiencing difficulty. Four syllables again.

9.00. The deadline. The register in a room I have not stood in for two weeks going from grey to green, 38 lines, or 37. I could not see it. I have never in four years not been able to see it at nine. I sat in a stranger's kitchen with my hands flat on the table and tried to feel the room from four miles off, and could not.

9.40. Calloway, on phone two, from his desk: 'They're saying it hasn't confirmed.' I said I knew. He said how. I said it was the second name on the page.

10.02. The ticker. *Walbrook declares second clearing member in default.*

Mine. My second. I had it second at this table a fortnight ago and Priya argued and conceded; Greywether's list had it second; this morning the market had it second; now Walbrook has it second. Everyone's second. It is the name on Laura's debit card and on mine. There is a cash machine with its name on it 200 yards from this door, and by this afternoon there will be a queue at it, and tomorrow the queue will be the news.

I am stopping because I am going to the hospital. A wanted man in a hospital corridor at eleven on the worst day of the century is the safest man in London, because nobody in a hospital looks at anyone, and she will have found a screen by now and I would rather she did

not watch it alone.

Second sitting. 1.40pm. A plastic chair in the corridor outside her side room, this paper on my knee.

The name on her chart is not hers and I am not writing the one it is. A wrist in plaster to the elbow, a bruise down the right side of her face that has gone from purple to a colour I have no word for, and a nurse every two hours with a torch who asks her the date, and she tells them, and then she tells them the pound.

She had a screen; a nurse had lent her a tablet. When I came round the curtain she said, ‘Ten o’clock two minutes. You said by ten. You’re slipping.’

We watched it the way we used to watch the register, without talking. What happened to Walbrook between ten and noon, as I would have written it in the room: Walbrook took the second book and had to hedge it, which means selling what it was long of into a market that knew exactly what was coming. The second member’s own margin went first. Then its contribution to the default fund. Then what was left of the survivors’ contributions, spent all last week on the first default and not yet put back, because this morning’s refill was the call that half of them had just struggled to pay. The fund is sized for the two largest members failing at once. We have had two, a fortnight apart, in a market that fell every day between. Priya did the arithmetic on the back of her cast, left-handed, and got there before the screen did.

11.50. The third name. An intraday call, triggered by the price crossing a line. An hour to confirm. It confirmed at 12.44, 54 minutes in, with money I would bet came from Threadneedle Street at 12.30, because that is what the lending has been for. Four years of payment times in my head, and I have never seen that name go past twenty minutes.

12.00. Richard Haldane, live, in front of the building I walked into

every morning for four years and eleven months. He had shaved. He read a statement, and I am putting it down as near as I can because I want his words and not mine. Walbrook Clearing House had today declared a second clearing member in default. The firm's pre-funded resources had, in the course of the morning, been fully utilised. Walbrook had called upon its clearing members for further contributions under its rules and was in continuous contact with the Bank of England. Unless those contributions were received in full by the start of business tomorrow, Walbrook might not be in a position to meet its obligations. A further statement would be made at the close.

May not be in a position to meet its obligations.

Priya said, 'He said it. He actually said it on television,' and then nothing for some time, and neither did I. In the corridor a daughter asked her father what it meant and he said he did not know, love, something about banks.

I will put down what it means, once. Walbrook stands in the middle; every promise between two members is a promise to Walbrook and from Walbrook, and that is the only reason they trust each other. If Walbrook cannot meet its obligations, then tomorrow morning nobody knows what they are owed. Not a loss; a loss is a number. A blank. Working it through as I would a call sheet: a pension fund that hedged its pensions through the clearing house would be holding a hedge it could no longer be sure had anyone on the other end. Every rate in the country is priced off a market, and a market with a blank in the middle of it cannot price anything, in the country or anywhere that has ever dealt in pounds. The first thing people do when they do not know what they are owed is not pay anyone. That is the freeze. Nine books describing it, and I had to write the sentence in a hospital.

12.20. The pound fell through a number last seen before I was born.

1.05. The fourth name. Not a default; a mention. A broker's note the news had got hold of, naming the fourth parent as "the next focus of market attention". I had it fourth. Greywether's list had it near

enough fourth. The market has got there, two weeks after I did and a fortnight after he did, with the whole page still in my coat.

Priya watched my face while I read that and said, ‘Don’t.’

‘Don’t what.’

‘Don’t do the sum. I can see you doing it. Two of twelve, third in trouble, fourth named, and you’re working out the day of the week for the twelfth. Stop.’ She shut her eyes and opened them again. ‘And I’ll say this once, because you won’t. Second, third, fourth in the order on the page doesn’t prove the page. Crane had the page. He pushed them in that order.’

‘Then they fell because—’

‘It proves he read it the way you do. It doesn’t prove the map.’

I did not argue. It is the first sum today that came out as something I could not use. Being right and being proved right have come apart, and I am sitting in the gap, in a plastic chair.

‘Everybody in the country knows the names now,’ she said, ‘and it’s doing them precisely as much good as it did you.’

They came with the torch at 1.30 and asked her the date and she told them, and the pound. I came out here because she had gone very quiet and I know what her quiet is for.

Third sitting. Calloway’s kitchen. 7.05pm. The afternoon in order, since order is the one thing I have that nobody else does.

2.30. New York opened and did not halt. It simply fell, steadily, which is worse to watch than a halt, because a halt is at least somebody doing something.

3.10. I rang the office in St James’s on phone two. The woman answered. The managing director was not in London. I said I knew that. If I had a matter to raise I was welcome to put it in writing. The same sentence as three weeks ago, when it was a door that opened eleven minutes later. Today it was a door.

4.00. The second member’s parent was suspended from trading at

its own request. The cash machine 200 yards from this door had a queue of 30 when I passed at half past four with my collar up, and a man at the front hitting the screen with the flat of his hand. Nobody looked at me.

4.30. The close. Walbrook's further statement did not come. Its site said "in due course", which is what institutions say when the statement is being written by someone else.

6.40. The Bank of England. Not the Governor; a statement over no name, read out by a correspondent in Threadneedle Street in the rain. The Bank was aware of the position of Walbrook Clearing House. It had provided and would continue to provide liquidity to the clearing house and its members. It was in close contact with the Treasury and was considering all options, including the use of its resolution powers, in order to protect financial stability.

All options including resolution. Nobody has ever done it. Resolution is a fire door and not a sprinkler; I wrote that in the fourth book, about a different building. A fire door is a thing you go through when the building is already lost.

Twelve names. I have checked the order against today and it is the order. Second at 10.02. Third at 12.44, alive on borrowed money. Fourth named by one. I have a page and a memory and the fact that every single thing on the page has been right, in sequence, at the hour, and that the man who stole it has made more money today than most countries, and that the man who drew it is in a borrowed kitchen with the lights off, correct.

What the man who drew it could have done at 36 is for another night. Tonight only the fact: The names and the order and the day came out as I wrote them, which means I was right or that he read it as I do, and the two look the same from here; and the clearing house I spent five years inside may not exist tomorrow, and the first did nothing whatever to the second.

I know roughly where my wife is tonight, and I cannot go there. I have written round that sentence twice today and I am putting it down straight. Nor my daughter. I have the number of a landline in Norfolk and a rule about not ringing it from a phone, and the rule is still the right rule, and it means the only two people I could not bear to lose are the two I cannot reach.

7.15. Someone is knocking at the street door. Two knocks, with a knuckle, and then nothing: no bell, no second go. Calloway rings the bell. Priya is in a bed. There is nobody left who knocks like that, and I know, from a kitchen in Norfolk I was not in, exactly who does.

Chapter 39

The rule

The page had a date on it and a word under the date, and on Tuesday afternoon, eight days after she had written them, Dana Kessler put a sheet of paper beneath the word and the job was done.

It was one sheet. A confirmation: the document two parties send each other after a trade so that each has, in writing, what the other thinks it agreed. A swap, on this one; she did not need to understand the swap, and did not try. She needed the four things a confirmation always carried, and it carried them. The counterparty: Greywether Capital LLP, Mayfair. The other party: a company with a name that said nothing and a correspondence address in a Gulf capital. The broker who had stood between them, a firm whose name she had first heard on the Monday before last, in a room with no screens, in a sentence beginning *two of my brokers rang me*. And the trade date. Nine days before the ship.

She had not stolen it. She wanted to be exact about that, even to herself. A woman she had trained, eleven years ago, in a building that had no name on the door either, now ran a middle office at the broker and had never once in eleven years been asked for anything. Kessler had asked on Thursday. The envelope had come by hand on Tuesday at ten past two, with nothing written on it, and would never be discussed again by either of them, and that was the sum of what Kessler owed

anyone.

The company with the empty name had taken four days. It sat in a jurisdiction whose register gave a registered agent and nothing else, and the agent's other companies, pulled one at a time, had given a director's name on a dormant one, and the director's name had given, on the third page of a newspaper's society column in that capital, a wedding, and the wedding had given the family. A private office. A cousin of the managing director of the fund whose brass plate the subject had walked up to on Monday week. The two men whose names she had, one from a brass plate in St James's and one from four days of registers, were related.

She did not write the cousin's name in the file. She did not need it. The question on the page was *what did he know, and when*, and the sheet of paper answered it in the one way a client could not argue with, which was in his own counterparty's hand, dated.

Sebastian Crane had taken the other side of a trade on the one date that only mattered if you knew why it mattered. He had known. Eight days ago, in the room, he had called it a coincidence in the voice he used for sentences he had rehearsed, and she had written the word *before* and left the page blank beneath it, and now the page was not blank.

She sat with it for a quarter of an hour. Below her the dry cleaner's steam press thumped through the floor. The one of her three who did not do surveillance was in the next room photocopying, which was the only sound in the firm, because the other two had not been in since Friday.

That was the other thing she knew, and had known since Saturday morning, when the older of them had rung her from a car and told her, in the voice of a man reading his own custody sheet, what Mr Crane had asked them to do on Friday night and what they had done. A stairwell at a newspaper. A girl on the stairs. A wrist, and the sound a head makes. They had not got the page. He had rung her, she thought,

because he wanted to have told someone before it was in a newspaper, and she had let him finish and said, ‘Thank you. Don’t come in,’ and he had not. Crane had paid them directly, out of a drawer, and they had taken it, and the thing she had told herself for six years, that her people were hers, had turned out to be a thing she had told herself. She had not reported any of it to anyone, because there was nobody to report it to. That was private work. The pay was better and nobody asked for a report, and nobody, it turned out, read one either.

The radio on the windowsill had been on all day with the sound low. At noon she had turned it up for a man called Haldane saying that his clearing house might not be in a position to meet its obligations, and had turned it down again, because she did not care about bonds and never had. She cared about the sentence a man used when he had decided something. Haldane had sounded like a man reading a sentence somebody else had decided.

The phone in her bag rang at 3.40. The number was the one in his drawer.

‘Dana.’

‘Mr Crane.’

‘You’ve been quiet.’ He sounded well. He sounded like a man who had been given a day he had designed. ‘I’d assumed you were sulking about Friday and I’ve been prepared to allow it, because you’ve earned it. You’ll have seen the news.’

‘I’ve heard it.’

‘Then you know we are nearly finished. Nearly. I don’t like nearly.’ A pause in which she could hear him choose not to look at a screen. ‘Whitlock went to the Treasury on Sunday with the Gulf fund and a plan, and was refused. I know that because the woman who refused him has been telling people since, which is her way of making it true. A man refused on Sunday does not go home. He has until tomorrow morning, and he has a buyer who has been recalled and may not stay

recalled, and I have spent two years and a very great deal of money not having to care what one clerk does with his evenings. I would like him to stop. Tonight. There is exactly one thing he will stop for, and you know where it is.'

She waited. He did not fill the silence; he never had. So she filled it, because she had decided on the stairs eight days ago that when he said it, she would make him have said it.

'Say what you want, Mr Crane.'

'Bring me the child.'

Four words. He said them in the tone he had used for the figure, and for *by whatever route works*. No weight anywhere; that was where the weight was. She found that she had known for eight days exactly what the words would be and had still wanted to hear whether he would say them, and that he had, and that it had cost him nothing.

'No.'

'Dana—'

'I said it to you on a motorway and I said it in your room and you did not say no on either occasion, and I noticed, and I kept the job anyway, which is mine to answer for. This one is yours. I don't work that way with children. It isn't a price. You've listened for the price twice. There isn't one.'

'Then I'll find someone who will.'

'You already have. On Friday. Out of your drawer.' She kept her voice where she kept it. 'They were good men for watching doors, and you've made them something else, and when it goes wrong, which it will, because they are not built for it, you will say you never gave an instruction, and there will be no paper that says you did. I know how that goes. I used to work for people who did it to me with a pension attached.'

A silence of a different kind.

'You understand,' he said, quite gently, 'that you are no longer retained.'

‘I understood that at twenty to four.’

‘And that anything you may believe you know—’

‘Goodbye, Mr Crane.’

She ended the call, and took the back off the phone, and took the SIM card out, and sat with the two pieces on the desk in front of her next to the confirmation. It was 3.46. She noticed the time because it was the time, two and a half weeks ago, that an analyst had logged in at a desk that was not hers, and because she noticed things.

The question was where to put it.

She went through the list the way she went through registers: in order, without hope, so that hope could not choose for her.

The police would take the sheet, thank her, and file it in a case about a stolen rucksack, which she would be in. The Bank of England would read it on Thursday. The newspaper would want a second source and a lawyer, and Crane’s lawyers had been writing to that newspaper since Sunday week. The Gulf fund already knew; it had asked the brokers for the dates itself, on a Friday, which was how she had known where to look. Any of them would be rid of it. None of them would do what she wanted done, which she had not until that moment allowed herself to name, and which was to hurt him.

She had not liked him. She had thought that did not matter, and in fifteen years of government work it had not, because the thing she served had not been a man. It mattered now. He had read four years of a stranger’s evenings and told her, when she brought them, that he would *read* them, as if that were an answer; and she had stood at the door and watched him enjoy saying it. He had found the man in the books contemptible. She had read enough of the books, in a safe, overnight, to know what the man was, and it was not that.

There was one person Crane had never once, in all of it, considered as an actor. The man had been a bag to be taken and a clerk to be despised and now a nuisance to be stopped by Wednesday. He had

never been to Crane a man who might be handed something and use it.

That was where it would hurt.

She photocopied the sheet herself, twice, and put one copy in the file and the original in her coat, and she said to the one of her three who was still hers that the firm was closed for the day and would possibly be closed for longer, and that there would be money for the month, and she watched the woman decide not to ask. Then she went down the stairs past the dry cleaner's and into the street, and did not look for the grey car, because the grey car had been Crane's since Friday too.

Kentish Town. She knew the door; she had paid two men to watch it for a fortnight. A street door with three bells and a flat on the second floor with the curtains drawn in daylight, which was the only flat in the street with its curtains drawn. She did not ring. She knocked, twice, with a knuckle, and stood back a full pace with her hands out of her pockets, and waited for the time it takes a frightened man to decide, which she had measured often and which was longer than people thought.

The door opened on a chain. He had a kitchen knife in his left hand, held low, as a man holds a thing he has never used and does not intend to, and she looked at it and then at him and said, 'Mr Whitlock. I'm alone. I have nothing in my hands and I'm going to keep them where you can see them. I'd like five minutes. I'd rather not have them on the step, but I will if you prefer.'

'My wife said you said that.'

'I expect I did.'

He looked at her for a while longer. He was thinner than in the park and his coat had been slept in, and she saw him do the thing she had seen him do at a cloakroom counter, which was count, and arrive at a number, and decide.

He took the chain off.

The flat was one room and a kitchen. A table with paper on it, face down. A television in the corner with the sound off showing a correspondent in rain. She stood where he put her, by the door, and did not look around, and did not sit.

‘I’m not here to apologise,’ she said. ‘I want that said first, so that you don’t wait for it. I took your notebooks. It was the job, and I did it well, and I’d do the same job again for a different client. I’m here because I’ve found something that belongs with you more than with anyone else I can think of, and because this afternoon I ran out of other people to give it to.’

She took the envelope from her coat with two fingers and put it on the corner of the table nearest to her, and took her hand away.

‘A trade confirmation. Greywether Capital on one side; a company on the other that belongs to a private office in a Gulf capital, run by a cousin of a man you met at a hotel. The broker’s name is on it. So is the date. Nine days before the ship.’ She watched his face and saw that none of it was new to him except the paper. ‘You knew. The fund knew. Nobody could put it on a table. That can go on a table.’

‘Why.’

‘Because you’re the one he isn’t afraid of,’ she said. ‘He has read every page you ever wrote and he thinks you are a man who writes things down. I think so too, as it happens. I’d like to see what happens when he’s wrong.’

He did not touch the envelope. He said, ‘Where are they?’

‘His office. Mayfair, the quiet street; you know it from the paper, I expect. The room on the first floor with no screens. A steel cabinet behind the desk, locked, and he carries the key. I would look there first. They are in it, nine of them, in order, with your page folded in the ninth, thirty pages from the end, where you left it. He has read all of them.’ She let that stand. ‘I cannot get them back. Cannot, Mr Whitlock, not will not. I don’t do safes. The two men I would have

sent are his now, and have been since Friday, and you know what they did on Friday better than I do.'

He had gone very still at *Friday*. She had expected it and did not look away from it.

'He rang me at twenty to four,' she said, 'and asked me to bring him your daughter. Those words. I said no. He said he would find someone who would, and he already has. I don't know where your wife is, and I want you to notice that I'm telling you I don't, because the last time I declined to answer a question of yours you spent four days hating me for the wrong reason.' A pause. 'Whoever does know should move her by tomorrow morning.'

'Why are you telling me.'

'Because I have a rule,' Kessler said, 'and I've just found out what it costs, and I would like it to have been worth something.'

She buttoned her coat. He had not moved from the table and the knife was still in his hand, forgotten, pointed at the floor.

'Your wife let me in because I said "won't" and not "wouldn't",' she said. 'She was right to notice. You've a good deal in common, the two of you. Goodnight, Mr Whitlock.'

She let herself out, and shut the door the way you shut a door in a house where a child might be asleep, and went down two flights of a stranger's stairs into a street where, for the first time in six years, nobody was waiting to be told what she had seen.

Chapter 40

Entry 1420

Tuesday. Late. Fourth sitting, same number, because it is the same day and I am not sure the day is going to let go of me in the ordinary way. The back of the last of Calloway's printer paper. My writing has got smaller through the day; I can see it happen down the sheets.

I wrote the morning at ten, the middle of the day in a hospital corridor and the afternoon at seven, and I have read those pages back once and I am not going to again. The second member at two minutes past ten. The default fund gone by noon. Haldane at twelve, shaved, in front of the building, saying that the clearing house "may not be in a position to meet its obligations", and saying it well, because he has always said things well. At 6.40, the Bank: "all options, including the use of its resolution powers". A word that has never been used anywhere in the world about a clearing house, used about mine, read out by a man in the rain in Threadneedle Street from a statement with no name on it.

The order was right. All of it. Twelve codes. The first fell on the Monday before last and the second this morning, the third is alive tonight on money it borrowed at half past twelve, and the fourth was named by a broker at one. I have had the order since Thursday week on one page and since I was 36 in pieces, and I was right, and I am going to count what being right has bought, because counting is what

I have.

No notebooks. Nine of them, in a room in Mayfair with no screens, for six days now. No clearing house, or not after tomorrow. No signature: a woman on Horse Guards Road said no on Sunday in a sentence with the word "prudence" in it, and I have met the word before, in a covering note. Priya in a bed under a name that is not hers, her right wrist in plaster to the elbow, a nurse with a torch every two hours asking her the date. Al-Mansouri on an aeroplane home since Monday, as far as his office will say. And in the inside pocket of my coat, where the cloakroom ticket was, a brown envelope that a woman gave me at a quarter past seven, standing in this doorway, having knocked twice with a knuckle. I have not written her yet. I will, when I can. Not tonight. Tonight only this: what is in the envelope would finish Sebastian Crane, if I had anywhere to take it.

I have been through everywhere twice. The police: a man with a High Court order served on his house walks into a station with an envelope, and the envelope goes into a clear bag with a label, and the man goes into a room, and in the morning the clearing house fails whether or not he says no comment. The paper: Calloway can have it in print on Thursday, with lawyers, by which time there is no Walbrook to save. The Bank: wants the Treasury. The Treasury: no. The one man with money: a telephone call on Friday telling him to come home, and a woman in St James's telling me this afternoon that he is not in London, in the sentence she uses whether he is or not.

That is the joke, and I want it written down in case I am not the one who reads this. I have spent four years saying I could not prove it. This afternoon somebody handed me the proof, and it is paper. At the end of all of it, I have been given more paper.

Laura came at ten past nine.

I did not know she was coming, and that needs to be exact, because of what I wrote at seven. She drove down from Norfolk on Saturday,

through the photographers, against what I asked, and left word with her mother that I would know where she had gone and was not to go there. I knew. Tom and Aisha's, twenty minutes from a house she cannot go back to. I did not go there and I did not ring it, because of the thing I understand about telephones, which she has learned from me and used on me, and for three days the only words between us have been read to me by her mother off a piece of paper at nine in the morning. She said she would find me. Tonight she rang the bell.

Calloway was at the paper. I looked through the spyhole and saw my wife on a landing in Kentish Town with our daughter asleep on her shoulder in a coat over pyjamas, the rabbit's ear against her cheek, a bag at her feet, and I opened the door and did not ask how, because she was there.

'You told me his name at Mum's table, and his flat was in the phone book,' she said, before I could. 'I watched the six o'clock. I've watched you every night for a week in other people's living rooms. The patient stops answering the phone, you go to the house. Where can I put her?'

The sofa. She built a wall of cushions along the edge of it, one-handed, before she put Elsie down, and then she put her down and stood with a hand flat on her chest for a count I knew was ten, and then she took her hand away and turned round and looked at me, in that order. Hands. Face. Weight. She has lost the habit of hiding what she is doing when she does it.

'You've lost about half a stone. You haven't slept. You're holding your left arm against your ribs, so something happened to them on Friday that you didn't tell me about. Sit down.'

I sat down.

She did not ask me how I was. She has stopped asking me questions whose answers she can read. She sat at Calloway's table, where the page had been made, with her coat still on, and said, 'Tell me where it is. All of it. The way you'd tell Priya.'

So I counted it for her, the way I have counted it above. No books.

No clearing house. No signature. Priya. The envelope. The man recalled. She listened the way she listened at her mother's table, except that she did not watch my hands this time, because she already knew what they were doing.

When I had finished she said, 'And you were right.'

'About all of it. The order. The names. The days.'

'You were right,' she said again, as if she were reading a result back to me and wanted me to hear it in someone else's voice. 'And what has that done?'

I have been asked that question, in one form or another, by Priya, by Calloway, by a woman in a park, by my own wife at one in the morning in Norfolk. I have never answered it, because the honest answer has been in the seventh book since the week Elsie was born and I have never read it aloud.

I said: the record was the problem.

She waited.

I said: the memo was the warning. Six pages. I wrote it and it was filed and I was relieved, I told you that at your mother's. The record was not a warning. Nobody read it. That was the point of it. I kept score against the world for four years in a book the world could not see, and if I was wrong, nobody would ever know, and if I was right, I had it in writing. Either way I lost nothing. I spent four years being right in private because it was safer than being wrong in public. That is not what a careful man does. That is a hedge. I have been hedged since I was 36.

She did not say anything for a while. The flat made its noises. Elsie breathed behind the cushions.

Then she said, 'Then be wrong in public.'

I said I did not follow.

'You do. You've spent four years making sure that if you were wrong, nobody would see it. Fine. Go and be wrong where everyone can. Say the whole thing, out loud, in your own name, before you know how

it ends, to people who can do something about it and people who can do something to you. If you're wrong, you're wrong in front of the country, and I'll be here, and so will she. If you're right, it's the first time in four years it'll have counted for anything.'

'I don't know how,' I said.

'Jonas. You told me the whole of it in two hours at my mother's table with a child on your knee. You've been rehearsing for four years. You just said it to me in four minutes and it was the clearest thing you've said since I met you.' She stood up. 'You don't need to know how. You need to know where.'

She picked Elsie up, cushions and all, and the rabbit, and asked which room was Calloway's. I told her. In the doorway she stopped, with our daughter's head under her chin, and said, more quietly, 'I'm not telling you to be brave. I'm telling you to be the thing you've written down. There's a difference and you know it,' and went in and shut the door.

Before she went in she asked whether the flat was safe, and I told her the truth: that a woman who is paid to know stood on this doorstep tonight and told me Crane has asked for Elsie by name, that the men who watched this door for a fortnight are his now, and that the same woman thinks they are hunting a bag and a broadcast, not a child, for one more night. In the morning Calloway takes the two of them out through the loading bay before I say a word into a camera. Laura listened to all of it and said, 'Then we're where you are,' and shut the door.

Elsie.

I have written to you before. The first time is in the seventh book, and you will know the entry if you ever read in order, because it is the one where the handwriting changes. Until then I was writing to be right. After that night I was writing to someone, and I told myself that was the change your mother asks about, the one I would not write

down on the last night of my thirties. Different meaning. It was half the change. A letter you never send is a drawer. I had found someone to write to and gone on putting the pages in a garage.

Here is the other half, and I am going to write it once, plainly, and then not again, because a thing like this said twice is a thing a man is hiding behind.

Being right is worth nothing if you only write it down.

I was right at 36. I was right at 37, on letterhead. I was right 94 times by the night before my birthday and I am right 1,420 nights later, and a clearing house is going to fail in the morning, and a woman I love is asleep in a stranger's bed with her hand on your chest, and I have nothing in my hands but a borrowed pad and an envelope. That is what right is worth on its own. I have the exact figure now. I have always wanted the exact figure.

You changed the meaning because before you there was nobody the figure was for. Being right was the point; it did not need to be for anything. After you it was supposed to be for something, and I kept doing it the old way for a year and told myself the feeling was enough. The feeling is not enough. You will be told, by people who like you, that it is good to be right and that the world will come round. Some of them will mean well. Your father has conducted the experiment over four years at a cost of one clearing house, and the result is in.

What it is for is this. You say it where it costs you, to the people it is about, before you know how it ends. Your mother put it better. She said be wrong in public. She has been better at this than me for six years and I have only just written it down, which is, I suppose, the whole of what I am.

It is 11.20. Calloway has a key and will be back by midnight. He also has a lawyer's number and a studio the size of a cupboard, two floors below his desk, which he has mentioned twice this week in the voice of a man mentioning the weather. Your mother is asleep. Your father has an envelope, twelve names in an order, the only head in

London that knows how fast each one goes, and nothing left to lose that he has not lost already.

He is going to be wrong in public. He has worked out where. He is sitting in a kitchen that is not his, listening for a key.

Chapter 41

Without authority

The council would sit at ten in the morning, home time, which was eight o'clock in London, and the first item would be the decree. Khalid Al-Mansouri had been told so on Monday by a man who had rung to be kind, and he had thanked him, and had then asked Nasser to confirm it by another route, and Nasser had. From that minute his signature would be the signature of a private man. The flight was at noon. Nasser had booked it on Friday, within an hour of the call that had asked him home "for consultations", because Nasser booked things.

He had not gone on Friday. He had said that there was business in London that could not be left, which was true, and the men at home had let him say it, because it suited them that he should be in London when the decree was read and not in the room. Since Monday the office in St James's had told everyone who asked, including Mr Whitlock, that the managing director was not in London, which was the sentence it had always used and which had the advantage of being believed; a man who has been recalled and is seen to stay is a man defying, and a man on an aeroplane is nobody's business. He had let the aeroplane stand. He had used the four days as he had intended to use them. On Sunday he had sat in a room on Horse Guards Road with a man wanted by the police and put the transaction to the Chancellor

of the Exchequer in plain words, and she had said no in a sentence he could have written for her, and he had carried that sentence back to Park Lane in his head and found that it was the same sentence the four men used. It is not politics. It is prudence. He had heard it in two capitals in one week, in two languages, and in both it had meant: not on my signature.

Now it was Tuesday night, and the sound was on.

He did not usually have the sound on. He had the channels on the far wall of the bridge for the maps and the faces. Tonight, in the suite on Park Lane, he had sat in the chair where Whitlock had sat a week ago and listened to the chief executive of Walbrook Clearing House say at noon, in front of his own building, that the clearing house might not be in a position to meet its obligations, and at twenty to seven he had listened to a correspondent standing in the rain in Threadneedle Street read the words “resolution powers” from a statement with no name on it, and he had let the sound stay on afterwards because it was the only voice in the room that would say the figures aloud.

Whitlock’s second member had failed at two minutes past ten. Whitlock’s order. He had watched it happen in the sequence a man had recited to him from memory in this room, and had found that he no longer had any interest in whether the order could be proved.

Nasser came at half past nine with the evening sheet and the look he had worn since Friday, which was the look of a man carrying something he had not been asked to put down.

‘Sit,’ Khalid said. ‘Leave the sheet. I know what is on it.’

Nasser sat. He did not leave the sheet; he put it face down on the table between them, squared to the edge, which was his way of saying that it was there.

‘I am going to tell you what I intend to do,’ Khalid said, ‘and then I am going to tell you what it will cost you, and then you may say no. I would like you to hear the second part before you answer the first.’

‘Sir.’

‘The transaction we built on Sunday. The fund buys what the twelve are forced to sell, in Mr Whitlock’s order, at the open, through our three banks. The Bank of England lends against what we buy, the same morning, so that we are not simply the next men holding bonds. The Treasury stands behind the Bank. On Sunday the Chancellor declined to stand behind anything. Without her there is no Bank; without the Bank there is no borrowing; without the borrowing the fund carries, alone, for as long as it takes, everything it buys.’ He laid it out as he had laid out the instruction on a Saturday, in order, for the desks. ‘I intend to do it anyway.’

Nasser’s face did not move, which was how Khalid knew that he had already thought of it.

‘The cash from the sales is where I put it a fortnight ago, which is anywhere that is not London or New York. It can be in London by seven. Three transfers, tonight, to the three banks, into the accounts they already hold for us. The banks will accept the money; banks accept money. At the open they buy. Our desk has the list from Sunday, the names and the sizes. What it does not have is the pace: which line goes next, and how fast, and that is in one man, and he gives it on the morning, in the room, as he said he would. Not before.’

‘And when the banks ask whether the instruction is authorised.’

‘It is authorised. Until eight o’clock it is authorised by the man who runs the fund. The charter says that an instruction of that size goes to the board, and the board has not met since Friday, and will not meet before the council, because the council is the point. Nobody at home will countermand it before eight, because nobody at home will know. After eight it will have happened.’

‘If it works.’

‘If it works, Nasser, the fund will have bought the bottom of the British government bond market with the nation’s money and the market will have turned on the fact, and the men who read the decree at

ten will spend the afternoon explaining that it was their idea. I shall be forgiven. I may even be thanked. That is the easy case.'

'And if it does not.'

'Then at eight o'clock a private citizen will be found to have moved a great deal of his country's money into the one jurisdiction his country has spent a fortnight removing it from, into a market that is failing, on the word of a man wanted by the police, the night before he was replaced. There is a word for that at home. It is not "prudence".' He let the sentence finish. 'I will not go home. That is the cost to me, and I have looked at it, and it is mine.'

He had looked at it in the small hours of Monday, after the kind man's call, and had found it smaller than he had expected. He had been educated in two countries that were not his and had spent his life being trusted fully by neither; he had learned to live in rooms like this one. His mother was dead. His father's house would go to the family. He had one client, and it had been taken from him by a decree drafted by his cousin's friends, and he found, examining himself with the care he brought to a column of figures, that the client was still the client whether or not it wanted him.

'The second thing,' he said. 'The family's money.'

Nasser did look up at that.

'My father's branch. Not Faisal's.' A small dry movement of the mouth. 'The accounts you know, and two you do not, which my father kept in London for forty years for exactly this kind of night without ever saying what kind of night he meant. It goes in first. Before the fund's money. Into the same accounts, tonight, documented, so that whatever is bought in the morning is bought with my father's money until my father's money is gone, and only then with the nation's. If it fails, the first loss is mine. When the four men ask whose money was risked, the answer is in the bank's records before they ask.'

'It will not be enough to matter, sir. Not against the size of the

morning.'

'It is not meant to matter. It is meant to be first.' He turned the evening sheet over at last and did not read it. 'A man who asks a country to risk its money should have risked his own, and been seen to. I learned that in London. I learned it from the other side.'

Nasser was silent for a moment. Then he said, 'And the cost to me.'

'Yes.' Khalid folded his hands. 'You will make the calls. Three banks, tonight, on recorded lines, to men who will be woken to take them. You will tell them the transfers are coming and that the fund will be a buyer at the open and that the instruction is authorised, and they will ask you, because they are careful men, whether anything has changed in the fund's governance that they should know of, and you will say no. It will be your voice. Not mine. I will sign the paper; you will be the man on the tape saying nothing has changed, twelve hours before the decree says otherwise. If it fails, I stay here. You cannot. Your wife and your sons are at home. You will go home on Thursday and be asked, by men who already know the answer, why you said what you said.'

'Three,' Nasser said. 'The boys. You have never asked.'

'I have never asked. I am telling you now that I know, so that you cannot say afterwards that I did not.' He unfolded his hands. 'You may refuse. I will make the calls myself, in my own voice, and the banks will do it more slowly because a managing director ringing at eleven at night is a thing they notice, and perhaps it will cost us the first hour of the morning. That is a price I can pay. I can also write, now, tonight, that you objected and were overruled. It would be true.'

Nasser looked at the sheet, and at the window with the park gone black behind it, and at the carpet, and Khalid let him, because he had been with him seven years ago when a younger man had signed another paper against a man in Mayfair, and had carried that one out of the room as well.

'A paper saying I objected,' Nasser said eventually, 'is a paper saying

I knew what it was and made the calls anyway. That is worse than the calls. No.' He stood, and picked up the evening sheet, and squared it against his palm. 'I will make the calls. I will say nothing has changed. It will be true for nine hours, and I have said truer things for less.'

'Nasser.'

'Sir.'

'Thank you. I will not say it again tonight. There will not be time.'

The instruction was two pages. Khalid wrote it himself, by hand, as he had not done since he was a young man at a desk in a bank that no longer existed, because he wanted the hand on it to be unarguable. The three banks. The accounts. The sums, which he wrote in figures and did not say aloud, as he never said them. The order of the family's money and the fund's. The sentence authorising the purchases "as directed on the morning by the fund's adviser, Mr J. Whitlock, or on his behalf by the chief of staff". He read it through twice and changed one word, as he had on Saturday, and signed it at 10.52 and dated it, with the year and the day, because dates were everything this month and he wanted this one on paper in his own hand.

'The flight,' Nasser said at the door, with the pages in his hand. 'Noon. Shall I cancel it?'

Khalid considered the question honestly, as it deserved.

'No. Leave it. Either I shall be on it as the man who brought the money home, or I shall not be on it at all. Those are the only two seats.' He turned back to the set Nasser had put in on the Thursday, where the man in the rain was being replayed for the fourth time. 'Ring Mr Whitlock's number when the banks are done. Tonight, not in the morning. Tell him the fund will be a buyer at the open, with the Bank or without it. Tell him I should like to know where to put it.' A pause. 'And tell him I am in London. The office has said otherwise to him twice, on my instruction, and he is a man who keeps count.'

Nasser went. Khalid listened to the door close and sat for a moment

with his hands still on the table, and then, because there was nothing else to do until seven, he turned the sound off at last, and watched the smoke on the far wall, which had not moved in nineteen days.

Chapter 42

Live

Past midnight. Still #1420. The day ends when I sleep, and I am not going to sleep, so this is the same entry, fifth sitting, on the last clean side of paper in the flat, and the last thing I write in it will be what I said to a journalist at his own kitchen table at ten to twelve. I want it in my hand before it is in anyone else's.

The key at 11.48. He came in the way he has come in every night this week, quietly, coat on, looking at the table first to see what was on it, and he saw me, and the sheets, and the bag by the sofa that was not mine, and the shut door of his own bedroom, and worked all of it out in the time it took to put his keys down.

'Your wife.'

'And Elsie. Since nine.'

'Good,' he said, which I had not expected, and put the kettle on, and stood with his back to me while it boiled, the way Laura had at her mother's. He had a copy of the first edition folded under his arm. He put it on the table face down. I did not turn it over. I know what is on it. I was there.

'The desk wants a piece from you for Thursday,' he said. 'In your own words. The whole thing. Two thousand words, the lawyers all over it, Crane's people given forty-eight hours to respond. It would be the biggest thing the paper has run in ten years.' He turned round.

‘And it would run on Thursday, Jonas. I told them that. I told them there won’t be a Thursday worth printing on.’

‘No.’

‘So I’m asking what you want instead, because you’ve got the face on.’

I said: six o’clock. This morning. Live.

He did not say anything, so I said the rest, in the order I had put it in while I waited for the key.

The paper has a studio. He has mentioned it twice this week as a man mentions the weather: two floors down from his desk, the size of a cupboard, a camera and a light and a chair, which they use to put reporters on the rolling channels when the channels want a face and will not send a car. At six it is empty. At six the people who read the news have been on air for an hour and have nothing to say that they did not say at ten last night. At six I sit in the chair and say all of it. What Walbrook is, in the words I used to Laura. Why it will not be able to pay tomorrow. The twelve, by name, not code, in the order they fail; two have failed and the order has been right twice in public, the third paid at 12.44 with the Bank’s money, and the fourth was named by a broker at one for anyone who knows how to read a paragraph about “the next focus of attention”. Then the dates. Greywether’s positions, nine days before the ship. Faisal’s office on the other side, which I will not name because I do not need to. Sebastian Crane. The envelope, held up. And the transaction: that there is a buyer with the money in London at seven, that the Bank can lend against what he buys the moment the Treasury puts its name under the Bank’s, and that the one signature standing between the clearing house and the fire door belongs to a woman whose department wrote “Noted. File.” on six pages three years ago.

‘So that she has no choice,’ he said.

‘So that she can’t file it. You can’t stamp a broadcast.’

He sat down.

‘I’m going to tell you what happens,’ he said, ‘and I’m going to do it the way I did the phone in Clerkenwell, because you listened then. Our lawyers will try to stop it. Not at six; they’ll be asleep at six, and that’s the only reason it goes out at all. But the moment the desk tells them, which the desk will have to, because I am not putting a wanted man in front of a live camera without the editor knowing, they will say three things. One: you are about to name twelve banks, on air, as about to fail, which is the one thing nobody in this country is permitted to say about a bank, true or not. Two: you are about to call a man a party to the sinking of a ship, with a brown envelope you got on this doorstep from a woman who has been following you for a fortnight. Three: Priya’s on bail, you’re subject to an order, the paper is already in it up to the neck, and if the editor says yes it’s his licence and his pension. They will say all that and they will be right.’

‘Yes.’

‘And then the other thing. Jonas, look at me. You will be arrested within the hour. Not might. The paper’s address is on the paper. A live broadcast is a man saying “I am in this building now.” They’ve been polite with me because I’m the one in the phone book and you weren’t; the moment your face is on a screen with a clock in the corner they don’t need a form, they need a car. They’ll let you finish, probably, because the pictures of them not letting you finish would be worse. Then they’ll have you in the lobby. The envelope goes in a bag. You go in a room. Laura watches it on television.’

‘Yes.’

‘You keep saying yes.’

‘I’ve said no for four years. I know what it’s bought.’

The kettle had boiled and clicked and neither of us had moved. Through the bedroom door Elsie made the sound she makes, once, and stopped.

‘Why six,’ he said, more quietly. ‘Why not eight, with a lawyer in the room and your wife somewhere else.’

‘Because the Bank and the exchanges can hold London’s open if they’re given a reason before it, and not after. Because the banks’ calls go out at eight and the direct debits land at nine and a clearing house that cannot pay has to say so to the Bank before then, and nobody gets to be told “later” this morning. Because a man with the money has to know where to put it before seven. And because she needs to be told in a way she can’t have handled at official level in the normal way. At six she’ll be awake. At six there’s no one between her and the screen.’

‘Sydney’s just opened.’

‘Tokyo isn’t where the clearing house is.’

He looked at me for a while. Then he reached across and turned the first edition over so I could see the front page, which I had not wanted to, and I looked at it, because he was right that I should. Haldane’s face. The word in the headline that the Bank had read off a card. Below the fold, smaller, the picture of me in a tie that Elsie had tried to eat.

‘One more,’ he said. ‘You said a buyer with the money in London at seven. On Sunday he had no authority, on Friday he was recalled, and on Monday you told me he was on a plane. Who says there’s money?’

The phone said it. The cheap phone, face up on the table, which I have kept on since St James’s, rang at 12.14, and I knew the number by its length before I knew it by anything else. I let it ring twice. Habit.

Nasser. He did not say good evening. He said, ‘Mr Whitlock. Mr Al-Mansouri asks me to tell you three things. He is in London. He has been in London since Tuesday last; the office has told you otherwise twice, on his instruction, and he asks me to say that he knows you will have counted. Second, the fund will be a buyer at the open, with the Bank of England or without it. The money will be in London by seven. He has signed, in his own hand. Third, he should like to know where to put it.’ A pause, in which I heard a hotel room and a man who had been awake as long as I had.

Twice. I had. I said that he would know where to put it at six, and

from where, and that he should have a television on. Nasser said, 'A television,' in the voice of a man writing it down, and then, 'Thank you, Mr Whitlock,' and the line went. 12.16. Two minutes. The longest conversation I have had with a state, and the first in which it has told me where it was.

Calloway had heard enough of it.

'Right,' he said. He stood up and picked up his coat, which he had not taken off, and put his keys in his pocket, and stood there like a man who has just remembered he has to wake an editor, which he had. 'I'm going to go and ruin a man's night. You're going to stay here and not sleep, and at half past four I'll come back with a shirt that isn't that one, and we'll walk in through the loading bay, because the front hall has a camera and a man who reads the papers. The lawyers get told at five. The editor gets told now. If he says no, I'll tell you at half four, and you can decide what to do with the envelope and a day.'

'He won't say no.'

'He might.' He was at the door. 'You'll be arrested within the hour, Jonas. I want to hear you say it once more so that I know I said it to you.'

'Within the hour. Yes.'

'And the lawyers will try to stop it.'

'Yes.'

He stood with his hand on the latch. 'Four years you've been saying "not yet" to me, to her, to everyone. I want to know what changed. For the record. Yours, not mine.'

I told him what Laura had said. Four words. He heard them, and nodded once, the way you nod at a figure that has come out, and went.

12.20. The key in the door, from the outside. The flat quiet; the kettle cooling; a shut door with my wife and daughter behind it; a pad with my writing across the lines. In five hours and forty minutes I am going to sit in a cupboard two floors below a newsroom and say my own name into a camera, and everything after it, in order, and not one

word of it will be new. I have had it written down for four years.

Yes. I said yes. It is 12.20 on Wednesday, and I have written that down, and in the morning I am going to say it.

Chapter 43

Six o'clock

Wednesday, #1421. Written in two sittings, the arrest in the car at 8.25 on the back of a bail form and the rest after midnight on the fund's paper, because I want the day in the order it happened and I know what I do to order afterwards. The first part is the part I can write straight. It lasted eleven minutes. I counted.

Calloway came back at 4.31 with a shirt in a dry-cleaner's bag. White, a collar size too big, a crease across the chest where it had been folded for a drawer. I put it on in his bathroom with the door open, because Laura was in the passage with the bag on her shoulder and Elsie awake against her neck, and neither of us was going to shut a door.

She did not say good luck. She said, 'Say the first sentence.'

I said it.

'Slower. Look at me when you say it, not at the floor.' I said it again. She nodded, the way she nods at a pulse. Elsie put a hand on my face, flat, the whole palm, and held it there for as long as it takes to count five. Then Calloway said the car was at the end of the road, and they went down the back stairs ahead of me, to the loading bay and a van with the paper's name taken off the side. I do not know where they went. I asked him not to tell me, and he did not. A thing I do not know

cannot be got out of me, and I am a poor liar.

The building at 5.10, empty. The loading bay, a lift that smelt of newsprint, which is a smell this building has not made for years and still has. Two floors below Calloway's desk: a door like a stationery cupboard's, and behind it a room the size of my study. A camera on a tripod. A lamp on a stand with a white screen over it. A blue cloth on the wall with a seam down the middle that had been ironed in. One chair. A monitor beside the camera showing the empty chair back to itself.

The editor was in the corridor. I had not met him. Sixty, perhaps, grey, in a jacket he had slept in or had not slept in, holding a mug he had forgotten. The lawyers had rung at 5.10, Calloway said, and the editor had taken the call at the end of the passage with his back to us, nine minutes, which I counted through the glass in the fire door. They had told him what Calloway said they would. Twelve banks named on air as about to fail. A man named as a party to the sinking of a ship. An order of the High Court, and a news organisation already in it to the neck.

Calloway had put it to him in the lift at 4.45, in my hearing. 'It runs on our air, or it runs at nine on everyone else's as "a source close to the story", and we are the paper that had him in the building and sat on it.' It was not a threat. It was a choice of how to appear in the account, not whether.

The editor came to the studio door at 5.52 and looked at me for some time. 'Say it so they can't cut you,' he said. 'Whole sentences. They will want to cut you.' He put the mug on a shelf and went away, and I understood that he had chosen.

At 5.40 the picture editor had photographed both sides of the brown envelope on a desk, and the page inside it. I had asked for that. I knew what Calloway meant by *the envelope goes in a bag*, and I wanted a copy that was not in one.

A young woman with a headset put a microphone on my collar and said, 'The light's yours at six. When you're done I'll put my hand up. Don't look at the monitor.' Calloway sat on a stool at the edge of the light, below the lens, with a sheet of notes he would not use. At 5.59 the clock in the corner of the monitor turned over and the red light came on.

I am not going to reproduce it. It is in every paper by now, and I said what I had written down for four years, in the order I had written it. What I want to put here is the chair.

He asked me three questions. The first was who I was, and I said that I was the man the police had been looking for since Sunday week, and that I was saying so because I would rather it came from me.

Then Walbrook, in the words I use to Laura: two banks that do not trust each other, a third party between them holding a deposit from each, and my job, to decide whether the deposits were real. For four years I had thought some were pledged twice. I said *I think*, and said it again at 6.02. I said I had never seen it, only the fingerprints, and that I could be wrong about the thing underneath them, and that a clearing house could still fail on the thing I could be wrong about.

Then why it could not pay. What was due at the start of business today, from members who had already lost a default fund between them. That the first was gone and the second was gone. That the Bank had said *resolution* in the rain.

Then the names.

I read twelve. I read them off the page, because I did not trust my mouth, and I read them in the order they fail, slowly, as a man reads numbers into a telephone. The first two you know. The fourth had been named by a broker at one yesterday afternoon, and the third paid its call at 12.44 with money from the Bank. It took fifty-one seconds. I have not written the names here either. The habit holds. In the corner of the monitor the number watching the stream went

from nine thousand to forty thousand to a number the young woman stopped saying aloud.

At 6.05 a man appeared in the glass of the door and went away. A phone rang in the corridor and was picked up before it finished the first ring. Calloway did not look at it.

Greywether. The shell, the broker, the date on the confirmation, which I read out, and the date of the ship, which I read out after it, and nine days between them, which I did not need to say. I said: whoever sank the ship had a partner in Mayfair, who knew nine days early which way the market would go. I said his name. Sebastian Crane. I said I had met him. I did not say Faisal's, because I did not need to. There was an office in St James's listening, and a suite on Park Lane, and they would hear it in the silence where the name was not.

I held up the envelope. I turned it so that the lens saw the front, and the broker's name through the window of the sleeve, and it was lighter than I remembered.

Then the buyer. That there was one. That he had money in London by seven, which was by then fifty minutes off. That the Bank could lend against what he bought as soon as a name was put under the Bank's, and that the name was not mine and was not the Governor's.

I did not look at the monitor. I looked at the lens, as Laura said, and I said: 'Chancellor. You asked me for a signature once. I am not going to ask you for yours. It is a page, and it is in your building, and it is one page long.' It was 6.09. I said that I could not prove any of it until the morning had happened. I said that if I was wrong I would be wrong in front of everyone who was listening, and that I had thought about that, and it did not seem worse than the alternative.

Calloway asked, 'Mr Whitlock, are you sure?'

'No,' I said. 'I have never been sure. I have been right twice in public, in the order. I think I am right a third time. That is all I have ever had.'

At 6.11 the young woman put up her hand. I did not see it. I went

on looking at the lens until Calloway stood and touched my arm, and then I was a man in a borrowed shirt in a cupboard with the light off, and the sweat had gone through the collar.

'Loading bay,' he said.

'No.'

'Jonas.'

'I said where I was. It would be a poor finish to go out of the back like a man who hadn't.' I did not say the rest, which is that I wanted to see the street with the sound off, after.

He walked down with me. The editor stood at the top of the stairs with his back to the wall, and as I passed he said, 'A million and a half on the stream, and the lawyers have stopped ringing,' and I did not know what to do with that and thanked him.

The lobby at 6.38. A reception desk with a night guard who had stood up. Glass doors, the street beyond them the colour of a bruise that is going, no rain, a bin lorry working its way up the kerb with its yellow light turning. Three people inside the doors, standing in the way people stand who have come to wait. A man and a woman in plain clothes; a uniformed officer behind them with his hands behind his back. The woman said my name. I said yes.

She said the caution, all of it, in the voice of a person who has said it four hundred times and means it each time. *You do not have to say anything.* She said that I was being arrested on suspicion of offences connected with the complaint of Walbrook Clearing House, and named the Act. No handcuffs. A hand at my sleeve, above the elbow, not tight.

'The envelope, Mr Whitlock.'

I had told Calloway I would not fight for it and I did not. I took it out of the inside pocket of the coat, where a cloakroom ticket had been, and gave it to her. She had been told what it was; she held it by the corners. The uniformed man had a bag open already. The envelope went in with its flap towards the label, and she wrote the time on the

label with a pen from her top pocket. 6.43.

It is the first thing of mine that has ever been given a number by someone else.

Calloway stood behind them with both hands in his coat. He said, to the woman, in a perfectly level voice, 'He was never going to run. I'd like that noted,' and she said that it was noted.

They walked me out through the glass doors. I looked at the street, as I had wanted to. Two taxis. A man with a dog. The bin lorry, its yellow light going round on the front of the building. And on the far side, a grey saloon with its engine running and one man at the wheel, the grey car I had taken, since Kessler's visit on Tuesday, to be Crane's.

I did the thing I do. I counted. One car. One man that I could see. The window a hand's width down.

The detective put me into the back of hers, and a hand on my head, and got in beside me. The car with the yellow light went on up the kerb. The grey one pulled out when we pulled out, and stayed three cars behind, and did not hurry.

The man in the front passenger seat was looking in the mirror too.

'Friend of yours?'

'No.'

'Nor mine,' he said, and wrote the number plate on the back of his hand.

Chapter 44

The signature

Simon Carrow rang at 5.41, and said only that the Governor's office had rung his, and that she should have a screen in front of her at six. He did not say which. She had been awake since four, in the kitchen of the flat above Number 11, and she put the laptop beside the cold tea and turned the sound down to a level at which she could hear herself think.

At one minute to six the picture was a chair. At six it was the man.

She had last seen him across a table on Horse Guards Road, in a coat mended at the knee, with his hands flat on the wood. He was in a white shirt now that did not fit, under a lamp, with a blue cloth behind him, and he looked like a witness who has been told that the court is not sitting and has decided to give his evidence anyway. A voice below the lens asked him who he was. He told it. He said that the police were looking for him. He said it as a man says what he has rehearsed so often that the words have stopped being a performance, and she noted, as a professional matter, that this was the most persuasive form of testimony there was, and that nobody could teach it.

She did not take notes. She had never in her life listened to evidence without taking notes. The pen was in her hand, and for the first four minutes the pad stayed blank.

He explained the clearing house. He explained it badly, by an advo-

cate's standards: too plainly, every sentence qualified. *I think. I could be wrong.* She waited for a hedge she could use, and he hedged only before she could get there. He laid the weakness of his case on the table himself, and by the third minute she had stopped reading him for the sentence to pull at. She was reading him for the sentence that would be quoted.

Then he read twelve names, off a page, slowly. She did write those.

At 6.07 the phone rang beside her hand and the screen said *PM*. She answered it with her eyes on the laptop.

'You're watching.' He was in the study at Number 10; she could hear the clock. 'I've had the Governor, the Cabinet Secretary and my press secretary, in that order, and told all three that I would speak to you first. The channels took the feed at three minutes past.'

'Prime Minister.'

'I'm going to tell you what I'll say, Caroline. If you sign it, I'll say that the Chancellor took a difficult decision in difficult circumstances. If you don't sign it, I'll say that the Chancellor took a difficult decision in difficult circumstances. It's a remarkably flexible sentence.'

'It is.'

'I am not going to tell you to. I've thought about it for twenty minutes, and I'm not going to.' A pause. 'You know why.'

'Because then it would be yours.'

'Because then it would be mine,' he agreed, mildly. 'I'd like to go on being able to say that it isn't. Seven o'clock. The Governor says the exchanges can be asked until about then.'

On the screen the man in the white shirt had turned to the lens. She saw his mouth form the sentence before the sound reached her, and it was one she had heard on Sunday from the other side of a table.

'*Chancellor. You asked me for a signature once. I am not going to ask you for yours. It is a page, and it is in your building, and it is one page long.*'

'Did you hear that?' the prime minister said.

‘I heard it.’

‘Good.’ He rang off.

She watched to the end. He said that he had never been sure, that he had been right twice in public and thought he was right a third time, and that this was all he had ever had. In twenty-six years she had not once heard a witness volunteer the limit of his own case and gain by it. Then the red light went out and the chair was a chair, and a woman at a news desk put a hand to her ear.

Eleven minutes. She looked at the pad. It said *twelve*, underlined, and nothing else.

She walked to the Treasury, because three hundred yards by car would be photographed. It was not raining. She carried the umbrella anyway.

Carrow was in her room with the lights on and the blinds half up on the park, and a folder on the desk with a single sheet in it. At 6.43, he said, the Metropolitan Police had told the press office, as a courtesy, that a man had been arrested in the lobby of the newspaper’s offices on suspicion of offences connected with the complaint of Walbrook, and that an envelope in his possession had been taken as evidence. He did not look up from the folder.

‘That is the page.’

‘It was drafted on Sunday night, Chancellor, after the meeting. I thought it prudent to have it.’ The word sat between them. ‘I have not changed it.’

One page. The crest, the Governor’s name, and four paragraphs she could have written in her sleep, having read versions of them for eight days: that the Treasury, in exercise of its powers, would indemnify the Bank against loss on any lending or purchase made in connection with the stabilisation of the sterling collateral markets, as notified in writing by the Governor before noon that day. There was a space for a name.

She sat down. She did what she had done for twenty years with a document she did not wish to sign, which was to draw the two defences up side by side, as if for a client who had asked what he could say.

If she signed. A Chancellor, in extremis, on the advice of the Governor, with no other buyer, had indemnified a lending operation to stop a clearing house failing on the morning the failure was forecast on air, by name, and had done it within the hour. The buyer was a sovereign fund, supervised, transparent; the Bank would hold the bonds against cash. The Opposition would call it a bailout with a foreign flag on it, which would be true. On Sunday she had not been able to write the second answer to the first question. She tried now, and she could, and it was not a good answer, and it would stand.

If she did not. She had the answer to that already, because she had given it on Sunday: *prudence*, in the minutes, in Simon's hand, at her own request. A man had named twelve institutions in order on every channel in the country, and two had fallen in the order he named, and on Sunday she had said across a table that the order could not be verified. The question that would come, from a committee or from a barrister in an inquiry in a room with a tape running, was the one she put to witnesses: *Chancellor, on the morning you watched this man on television, what was your reason for not signing?* She sat with it, in those words, and went looking. The election was not a reason she could give. The Gulf state was not, because he had answered that on air by not naming it. What was left was the sentence on page four of the memo, with the date and her initials beside it, which said what she had told the country she had not seen.

She had no answer. She had spent a quarter of a century learning to tell a weak case from a case that cannot be put, and this was the second. Signing was dangerous, and she would be punished for it. Not signing was indefensible, and a lawyer does not choose the indefensible, not for a client she likes, not when the client is herself.

She took the pen from the holder, not the Chancellor's pen with the crest that she used for photographs. She wrote *C. Strand*, and the date, and the time, 7.02, and found that her hand was perfectly steady, which in a witness she would have thought interesting.

'The Governor,' she said, and Carrow, who had already dialled, held out the telephone.

'Chancellor.'

'It is signed. You will have it in four minutes. I would be obliged if the Bank would let the exchanges know that the Treasury stands behind the Bank.'

The Governor had a gift for knowing when not to speak. He said, 'Thank you,' and nothing else.

Carrow had reached the door with the page in a clear folder.

'Simon. The first letter.'

'I thought you might raise it.' He turned back. 'There is a draft in the folder, under the indemnity.'

One paragraph on Treasury paper, to the commander who had received the first, in the same plain language. That the Treasury had reviewed its letter of the date in question. That it no longer wished to draw the police's attention to Mr Whitlock's conduct. That the Bank had asked that he be available to assist it that morning and the Treasury had no objection. That all questions of investigation and charge were for the Commissioner and the Crown Prosecution Service. It did not apologise and it did not say that anyone had been wrong. It said that the Treasury's concern was withdrawn.

'It is correct,' she said. 'The Treasury withdraws. The police decide.'

'Yes, Chancellor.'

'And the official writes it.'

He stood very still. 'I wrote the first,' he said. 'I think it should be I who withdraws it.' He did not make it a plea. She had hired him for the way he did not.

She understood what he was offering: the whole of the exposure, in his own name, as a good official offers it. She had accepted it once already, behind a shut door, by saying that he should do whatever he judged appropriate. She took a sheet from the drawer and wrote on it, in the small hand that had filled a hundred blue notebooks, *Chancellor directed. CS. 7.14.* and put it on top of the draft.

'That goes on the file. Attached. In my hand.'

'It will be requested, Chancellor.'

'I should hope so.'

He looked at the sheet for longer than he needed to, and then at her, and for the first time in three years she saw something in his face that was not care. He took the folder and went.

She wrote the other letter at once, before she could improve it.

Dear Prime Minister. Then the reason, drafted as she would have drafted a withdrawal from a case. A lawyer who finds she is a witness in the matter she is conducting may not go on acting. She had read a document she had told the country she had not seen. She had declined to sign a thing and had signed it three days later. There was a note in her own hand in the margin of a Treasury file that anyone with a reference could ask for, and when it was asked for she would not be able to answer as Chancellor, because the answer was the margin. It would be better, for the country and the party and the department, that the person who answered was someone else.

Four paragraphs. She asked for nothing. She did not mention the election, except the date. She would not make the country change its Chancellor in the middle of choosing one, and she saw that this too was a lawyer's reason, and that she was glad of it, and that it was not the only one.

She read it back once. It was good. It was what she would have advised. She folded it in three and put it in the red box, under the cover note on the memo, and shut the lid, and sat for a moment with

her hand on it.

Then she took the pen, opened the lid again, took the letter out and wrote the date at the top. The Friday after polling day, in full, with the year. A week ago she would have thought she could not do it.

The hand was perfectly steady. She noticed that, and it did not seem interesting any more.

Chapter 45

Assembly

Still #1421. Two sittings. The cell and the release I wrote in the back of a car at 8.25 this morning, on the reverse of my bail form, with my own pen, which they gave back with my laces; I knew an hour like that would go if I did not hold it. The rest I am writing tonight. I have left the join where it falls.

The cell.

They took the belt, the laces, the pen, the phone, and the page out of my coat lining. A sergeant at a high desk listed each in a ledger and read it back to me. The cheap phone was ringing while he listed it. He held it up so I could see the number, and I said I would take it later, and he wrote that down too.

Cell 4. Nine feet by six. A bench with a blue plastic mattress, a steel lavatory with no seat, a light behind a grille that does not switch off. A hatch in the door at the height of a face. I counted the tiles on the back wall, six across and fourteen up, eighty-four, and then the ones I had missed round the door, and then I did the order.

I did it under my breath, as a man says a rosary. Twelve codes, and after each, what it holds and how fast it goes. Nine books in a steel cabinet in Mayfair, and I said them from a bench in a police station in the way I once said them from a desk, and I found the third was thin.

Two lines I had given Priya without a size. I said them again.

I had no watch. I thought it was twenty to eight. It was 7.52; I found that out afterwards, and was twelve minutes slow. Somewhere above me a door opened and closed, a radio said a number, and a voice that was not for me said, *the stream, on the stream*, and nobody said anything after.

What I could not do was know. The exchanges would open late if the Bank asked them. The Bank would ask if there was a signature. I had told a woman in a building I could not see to take out a page, and the whole of what I knew of the result was a light that did not switch off.

At 7.55 the hatch opened and a woman in a grey coat gave my name and then her own, and said she was the paper's solicitor, and that I would want to sit down. I thought: she is going to tell me they have charged me. She said, 'The Treasury has written to the commander. It arrived at 7.31. It withdraws their concern about you.' She looked at me. 'I should say that doesn't mean anything. A letter from a department doesn't tell the police what to do.'

'No.'

'It stops them being asked.'

The custody inspector read me the conditions himself, in the room with the high desk, from a sheet he held at arm's length. I was released on bail, to return in nine days. Reside at an address I would give. No contact with employees of Walbrook except through the Bank. And a new one, typed, on a line of its own. *To make himself available to assist the Bank of England, at its request, until further notice.*

'I have not seen that one before,' he said, mildly. 'The Governor's office rang the commander at 7.40, which is not how I'd have thought the day would go. I'm told the paper's printed the envelope, front and back. It stays with us. So does the rest of the evidence.' He gave me the form. 'Sign here, Mr Whitlock. This is the first time anyone in this

building has asked me to bail a man to the Bank of England.'

I signed. They gave me my laces and my belt and my pen and the phone, which showed fourteen missed calls, nine of them one number, and the page from my coat, flat, in a clear bag. 8.14. It was light on the street. There was a black car at the kerb with its engine running, and Calloway on the pavement with a coat over one arm.

'They won't have me in the room,' he said. 'I'm to wait outside. I've been told it twice.' He held the coat out. It was mine. 'She watched all of it. She says the collar was wrong. She said to tell you the first sentence was slow enough.'

The car.

Nasser, who does not put a hand out first, put one out. He said nothing for the length of Southwark Street. Then, looking at the road, 'My principal watched all eleven minutes standing. I have not seen him do that.' A pause. 'The money is in the three banks. All of it, since 6.51. His father's two accounts went first.'

'Is he coming?'

'He is at the hotel. He would prefer you did not thank him.' Nasser's face did not move. 'The driver has seen a grey car since the bridge.'

I looked. A bus, a van, a taxi. Nothing grey. At Trafalgar Square the driver took two turns he did not need and the road behind us was clean. That is not the same as gone.

I am writing this against the seat, and my handwriting does not look like mine.

The room.

I write this part tonight.

St James's, a street I know and a door I do not. A lift, a corridor, a second door with a keypad, and a room that has been told not to look like what it is. Forty desks and nine of them occupied. Two walls of screens, all dark but one; on the one, a clock that someone had made

on a computer, in white on black. 10:00, and below it, 12:00, and below that, a line of text I could not read from the door.

It was 8.36. The Governor's deputy was on a wall-sized screen from an office I could see a bookshelf of, a woman in her fifties in a blue jacket. The Bank, by video. She did not introduce herself and nobody asked her to. The fund's woman who runs the sterling book was at the end of the central desk, with three screens and a pen, and her legal man at her elbow with a laptop. Nasser took the chair at the head, and I was put at the middle of the desk, and a speaker the size of a saucer was pushed across to me with a light on it.

'Mr Whitlock,' it said. 'You're late. You've got a face like a bruise.'

'I've been in a cell.'

'I've been in a bed. We both look like it.' A chair squeaked in a room that smelt, down the line, of disinfectant. Behind her I could hear a trolley and a person saying *Raman, Raman* to somebody. 'I've got Graham's sixteen files open on a hospital table, and a nurse trying to take my temperature, and I'd like to start.'

The Deputy Governor gave the facts first. The indemnity had arrived at 7.09. The exchanges had agreed to open at ten. Walbrook had been told noon, and had complied: 'Mr Haldane has described it as a decision of his board. The board has not been told.' The Bank would lend through the three banks against each purchase at a haircut set line by line, on the sheet in front of us. If a line fell farther in a morning than its haircut, the Bank would stop lending against it, and the fund would hold it. 'I want that said aloud in this room,' she said, 'so that nobody tells me afterwards that nobody said it.'

The sterling woman said, 'We have the page in the machine. We've had it since Sunday. We have the twelve, and the sizes to the end of September, and a limit price for every line that I've been guessing at for three days. What I do not have is what comes next.'

'Which line, and how fast,' Nasser said.

'Which, how fast, and when to stop.' She turned the screen so that

I could see it. ‘Go.’

So we built it, a line at a time.

She read the first. A member already gone, whose collateral Walbrook was still selling off into the long end by noon. ‘That is the first buy,’ I said. ‘It has to go regardless. It is the only selling we are sure of.’ She put a number in. Priya said from the saucer, ‘Eleven point four of the thirty-year, you said on Sunday,’ and I said yes, and she said, ‘No. Eleven flat. Graham’s Q2 file restates it on page sixty-one. He initialled it.’ I said yes. The sterling woman crossed the number out and wrote a smaller one, and I thought: she has checked me for four years, and I have never once been grateful for it in the room.

The third line. The one the Bank had lent to at half past twelve yesterday. I said: you will not buy it in the first hour. It will want to be bought, because everyone will see it, and if you move first you show them the order. You wait for its bonds to come back, which at three yesterday they did, and its cash to go, and buy it at the second wave. I said that I was not certain. I said: *I think*. She looked at me for a moment and wrote it down as I said it, *I think*, in the margin, and I understood that she was going to treat it as a figure.

The fourth, the fifth. At the sixth she asked how I knew. I said what that member did on the mornings its bonds failed was in a book I did not have. ‘Then how do you have it?’ I said I had it as what I remembered of the book, and she said that wasn’t an answer, and I said it was the only one.

Nasser spoke then, in the voice for the formal question. ‘Mr Whitlock. If you were not in this room at ten, who else could do this?’

‘No one.’

Nobody moved.

‘The page has the order. Priya has the codes and the order, and she’s better than I am on the sizes. Graham has the history. Nobody has the pace, except me. Nobody has all three. I have it from nine books I haven’t seen for a week, so some of it is my memory of the books, and

some of it is my memory of the memory. I'm not saying that to make you comfortable.'

'We should like you not to be late,' the Deputy Governor said, to the screen, and I could not tell if it was a joke.

The legal man slid a sheet across the desk. One page. For the purposes of the morning I was the fund's adviser, in the terms of the managing director's instruction, for a fee of nil. 'A pound,' I said. 'If it's nil it isn't a contract, it's a favour, and I've had enough of those.' He wrote *£1* in the margin and initialled it, and I signed. It was the first time anyone had asked me to put my name to a page when I knew exactly what it was for.

We went on. I had given six lines and three had been changed, and I thought that if I could hold the next six I might have time, afterwards, to be sick.

At 8.38 the saucer made a small noise, like a woman putting down a cup.

'Hold on,' Priya said. 'Don't go on. Jonas, how many members did you flag from Graham's concentration appendix?'

'Twelve. That's the page.'

A sheet of paper turned over, close to the microphone. 'There's a line in Q2 I haven't seen you use. It isn't on your page. It's not big.' A pause. 'It's getting bigger. I need ninety seconds, and I need nobody to say anything.'

Chapter 46

Front-running

They had wheeled a television into the room with no screens, and it was the only thing in the building Sebastian Crane had ever wanted taken out again.

His assistant had done it at 5.55 on her own initiative, with an apologetic face and a trolley from the boardroom, and had stood by the door in case she was needed. She was not. He watched eleven minutes of a man in a borrowed shirt explain his firm to him. At 6.12 he said, 'Thank you, Miranda,' and she took the trolley away, and he sat for a while in the clean square where it had been.

It had been well done. He thought that now, at eight, with the telephone on the desk face up and three lawyers breathing in it. The shirt was wrong, the chair was wrong, the lamp put a shine on the forehead. None of it mattered. Whitlock had spoken in short sentences, with numbers, in the voice of a man reading from a ledger, and he had named Greywether's trade dates against the sinking one by one and held up an envelope. Crane did not need to ask where the envelope had come from. He had asked a woman for a result once, and told her nothing else.

'Sebastian,' said the senior partner. 'Are you there?'

'I am.'

'Then please hear the point again. Nothing in the broadcast is ac-

tionable by you tonight. Everything he said about the dates is a question for the police and we will answer it in writing, with counsel, at a time of our choosing. What you must not do, this morning, is trade on any information that has not been made public. Anything. Not a position, not a hedge, not a conversation with a friend.'

'Quite.'

'Do you understand?'

'Entirely. He has made it all public. It was the neatest thing about it.' He heard the silence at the other end and enjoyed it, a little, which he recognised as the habit of a man who had enjoyed things for fifty-two years. 'Thank you. I'll ring you.'

He ended the call. The two others stayed on for the length of a breath before they understood that they had been dismissed.

Then he did what he had been putting off since 6.12, which was to think about it.

They would buy. That was the whole of it, and he had known it by the second minute, before the man said the word *buyer* and held it a beat. A man does not build a map of who must sell, in what order, over four years, in order to stand and describe it. He builds it to be on the other side. Somebody with money, and a state behind the money, and a central bank willing to lend against what was bought, would stand at the open and take every line that the twelve were forced to throw. In the order they were forced to throw it. At the price that suited the buyer, which was a price that stopped falling.

Everything Greywether owned depended on prices that went on falling.

He had, in the cabinet behind him, the original of the page. It was a plain folded sheet in a clear sleeve. He did not take it out. He did not have to; it was in his head the way the books were in his head, and for the first time since the Wednesday before last it did not feel like a possession. It felt like a bill.

His telephone rang at 8.04. He knew the number.

‘Anthony.’

‘Seb.’ Pell’s voice was low and fast, a man talking from a corridor. ‘I have a board call in twenty-six minutes. I cannot be on a line with you. I will say three things and then I will put this down. The Bank has told the exchanges to hold London’s open until ten. Walbrook’s nine o’clock has been moved to noon. And at six the Bank told us to cut every external connection we have, every link, every feed, on the grounds that the broadcast was a security matter. I do not think it was a security matter. I think they did not want anyone with a login to know what they were doing.’

‘Who?’

‘I don’t know. I have not been told who the buyer is. I am on a board call.’

‘Anthony.’

The line was dead. Crane held the handset for a second longer than the call needed, looking at the grain of the desk, and thought: *he has stopped saying my name.* He put the information where it belonged, which was nowhere yet. A fund with money and no authority. An open held to ten. A clearing house that had cut its own wires.

He got up. He walked to the window, which looked across a quiet street at the blank back of a bank, and where nobody could see in; he had paid for the glass. Two hours. A little under two. The market in London was shut but the world was not. In the over-the-counter market, between dealers, by telephone, it was possible at this hour to buy the lines the fund would want; the Bank could hold an exchange’s door and could not hold a man’s phone.

He lifted the handset again and pressed the number for the floor.

‘Seb.’ His head trader’s voice, thin, awake since four.

‘Listen carefully. I want the shorts in the first eight lines closed. All of them. Buy them in pieces, through six brokers, nothing over a size that anybody would look at twice. Do it now, at these prices, before

the room at ten decides what it thinks they are worth. Then keep what you've bought. When the fund comes in at the open I want to be standing there with the goods it needs.'

A pause. 'Buy the lines we're short.'

'Yes.'

'And sell them back at ten.'

'To a buyer who has told the whole country it must have them.' He found he was smiling, though not for long. 'It is called getting there first. The rest of the book stays exactly as it is, and you will not tell the floor why.'

'The rest is the—'

'The rest stays. Do not say it on this line.'

He put the handset down. It was a clean move, and it left Greywether richer by the difference whether or not the fund won, and it was what he would have done to anyone, and it was not enough. He knew that as he put the handset down. It was a hedge against being wrong about the sum. It did not touch the man who would be giving the sum.

He had thought about the man for twenty-five minutes without noticing how.

Whitlock did not hold the plan; the plan would be in a room with a dozen people in it, and the dozen would write it down. He held the order. The page in the cabinet said what the twelve were and where they stood. It did not say what to do when the map was wrong, and a map is always wrong by ten o'clock. That judgement was in the man's head. Crane had read four years of his evenings and had found that nothing the man understood had ever been put on paper, only the evidence for it. It would be the same today.

And the man, Crane's solicitor had said at a quarter past, was being released on bail from the police station where he had been taken at twenty to seven, with a condition the solicitor had not been told.

The Bank had asked for him. *The Bank*. In the corner of his eye the television was not there any more, and he saw it anyway.

He pressed a different number and did not give his name.

'Where are you?'

'Outside, Mr Crane.' The older one. The voice of a man who read his own custody sheets. 'Where we were told.'

'Good. Follow him. He is about to be driven somewhere by people who will think they are being careful. I want the address by nine. Not before nine, if it means being seen.'

'And then?'

He had expected the question. He had not expected the little cold lift of the stomach that came with it, a sensation that in his own account he would later describe as irritation. Kessler would have said the child was not a price. Kessler would have said it standing in his room with her hands in her pockets, in a voice that made one want to put the question again to see whether it would crack. Kessler was gone. This one had been sent to the stairs on Friday and had gone. This one was waiting.

'There will be someone to meet you. The man has a daughter,' said Crane. 'You know where she was. You followed the car on the Saturday, and lost it at the roundabout, and found it again on Monday outside a house with a plane tree. She moved on Tuesday and I am told she moved back this morning, because the man she is married to has stood in front of a camera and a mother goes where her friends are. Go there first. Bring her to me. Nobody is to touch her.' The cold went through him again and he put it into his voice as patience. 'I should like to talk to him and I should like him to listen. That is all I am asking. Do you understand what I am asking?'

'Yes, Mr Crane.'

'Say it.'

'Bring her to you.'

'Thank you.' He heard how it sounded. He did not, for the first time

in his life, wait to enjoy it.

At 8.31 he took the key from the chain and opened the steel cabinet and looked at the nine books in their row, and the Treasury's stamped copy of a memo on top of them, and the unsigned page of a statement that had never been released. He had not touched any of it since Sunday.

It occurred to him, with the hurry he could not now put aside, that a man who had the original of everything could burn it, and that he was not going to, because the day was not over and only a man who had decided it was over burned things.

He sat down. He picked up the handset a third time and rang the one number he had never rung from this room, a firm in Bishopsgate that provided guards to office buildings and did not ask what a guard was for.

'I need two people on Walbrook,' said Crane. 'The street, not the building. Cannon Street, and the lanes behind Bank. They will be looking for a man of forty in a shirt that does not fit. He will be coming on foot. I want them there by nine.'

Chapter 47

The thirteenth

Still #1421. I am writing the day in pieces, tonight, and this is the piece I would leave out if I were being kind to myself. I am not going to leave it out. The map I spent four years on had a hole in it, and a woman with one working hand found the hole by telephone at 8.40 in the morning, and if she had found it at 8.50 I would not be writing anything.

It was 8.38. I had been in the room two minutes and in the chair for one. Forty desks, nine of them occupied, the dark walls, and the clock that someone had made on a computer: 10:00, and under it 12:00. Nasser at the head of the table. The sterling-book head, whom I will call by her title because she has not told me her name and I have not asked, with her pen over the sixth line; her legal man with the one-page indemnity in front of him; on the wall the Deputy Governor, a woman in a blue jacket with a bookshelf behind her. We had built the first lines. I had said *I think* over one of them and been written down as a figure. And on the saucer at my elbow Priya had just said that she needed ninety seconds and that nobody was to speak.

Nobody spoke. I had not known how long ninety seconds is in a room with a clock in it.

From the speaker: a page turned. A pen cap. A trolley in a corridor and somebody saying *Raman* again, further off. The legal man began

to tap the table with one finger and stopped when Nasser looked at him. The Deputy Governor lifted her own pen and held it above the pad. I counted, because it is what I do. At forty I knew she was not checking a figure, because a figure takes ten seconds. At sixty I knew she had found something and was checking whether she could stand it. At seventy-five, the sterling-book head put her pen down on the desk with great care, as one puts down a glass in a church.

At 8.40 the saucer said, 'Thirteen.'

'I'm sorry?'

'I've got thirteen. Appendix C, the concentration table, by member code.' A page, loud. 'It's in the first year's table and then it isn't, for three years, except as a line in the lending schedule at the back of Q2. Four letters. Not one of your twelve. Graham's initials beside it and a word. "Remote." It was big, so it went in, and he rated it sound, which it was, and it dropped off the next table because nobody puts a sound member in a table of problems. I think the ninth leans on it, and the eleventh, and the twelfth. I can't see their bonds go there. What I can see is the Q2 credit-line schedule and four years of when their cash arrives, and the cash of those three always comes in from the thirteenth. If I'm right, their bonds sit with it overnight. It's the cash behind their cash.'

I did not say anything. I could feel the shape of it before I could see it, which has happened to me perhaps four times in my life and each time I have wished it had not.

'Whoever has the dealers,' she said, to the table, not me. 'Can you look at the price of insurance on that code? What it costs to protect against its failing.'

The sterling-book head looked at a screen. 'Five weeks, as far as I can see it,' she said. 'Quiet. Up eleven basis points, a bit every day. Small pieces, three brokers, never the same size twice.' She looked up. 'I assumed it was a hedge somebody was running on the system. I have seen that footprint. I have seen it on the twelve.' She said the

name of the firm.

‘It’s not a hedge,’ said Priya. ‘It’s a short. And it’s older than the map and older than our buyer, so it was never built against us. It’s the one name Crane never needed the map for, because it never failed, and that is exactly why the map misses it. He’s been holding it for this morning, so that at ten, when we start buying, he can start pushing. Not on the twelve. On the thirteenth.’

I said, because someone had to: ‘My record doesn’t have it.’

‘No.’

‘Because it never failed.’ I heard my own voice go flat. ‘I wrote down what failed. Every entry is a fingerprint of something going wrong. A sound member leaves none. I was looking at the thing that was breaking, and he was looking at what it was resting on.’

The Deputy Governor said, ‘Mr Whitlock. Please say it in a sentence.’

I said it in two. The fund buys the first eleven in order, and they are fine, and by the time it reaches the twelfth the thirteenth has been under attack for an hour, and a bank that is under attack is calling in what it lent. If she is right, the twelfth’s bonds are at the thirteenth. They do not come home. We buy the twelfth’s debt and the bonds that should stand behind it are locked in a firm that is itself going. The chain breaks at the end, where it is longest, and we have spent the Bank’s money getting there.

‘And the fix?’ she said.

It was Priya who gave it. ‘Take the ones with bonds sitting at the thirteenth, the ninth, the eleventh, the twelfth, and move them to the front. Get their bonds home first. By the time it comes to the thirteenth, the thirteenth has nothing of anyone else’s to break, and you buy it last. Last, not first. If you do it first you show your hand.’

‘Out of order,’ said the legal man, quietly, as a man says the name of a disease.

I will put down the argument as it was, because I have not stopped hearing it.

The Deputy Governor said it could not be done in the time. She said it in a courteous voice and then said it again with the reasons. The one-page indemnity, signed at 7.02, covers by reference the Bank's lending sheet, which is the line-by-line list of what the Bank will lend against and in what order; a change to the order is a change to the sheet, and a change to the sheet meant the Treasury again. The order was in the three banks' instructions, three sets in three systems. And it was in Walbrook's own schedule, the list the auction would run from, which had been loaded at seven. 'Which cannot be reloaded,' she said. 'We cut Walbrook's data and file links at six, on advice, because there are people with logins on that board whom we have reason to think are talking to people we do not wish them to talk to. The feeds, the auction schedule and the collateral substitution interface are all dark. The telephones are not, and nor is settlement through the three banks. The schedule runs as loaded. I would put the minimum for any other course at an hour and forty minutes, and it is ten to nine.'

Nasser said, 'Mr Whitlock?'

It was the only thing he had said since I sat down. I said what I had been about to say since Priya said *thirteen*. That a file we could not reload could still be keyed. That the schedule was a list, and Walbrook's collateral staff could re-enter it by hand, line by line, in the risk room, with the Bank's officer beside them, if somebody told them the new order aloud. That the order was in my head and I could say it in about forty seconds, and could not write it in a form that three banks and the Treasury would accept in an hour and forty minutes. And that a voice line from the risk room to this room would let the fund's dealers, who execute through the three banks, hear it at the same moment as the people keying.

'You,' said the Deputy Governor. 'In the room. Not here.'

'There is no one else who knows the sequence or the pace.'

‘You are a man on bail,’ said the legal man.

‘The Bank has asked that I be available to assist it.’

‘Mr Whitlock is on my authority,’ said the Deputy Governor. A pause. ‘He is not on the Treasury’s. I will ring the Chancellor’s private office, and I will give you a letter, now, in my own name. It says my officer may change the schedule at Walbrook only on the instruction of Mr Whitlock, by name, present in the room. For the sequence only. Not for prices.’

‘Prices are the fund’s.’

‘Quite.’

Priya said, from the speaker, small and level, ‘He’ll be wrong about something.’

‘Yes,’ I said.

‘He’ll say it as if he isn’t.’

‘No,’ I said. ‘I’ll say *I think*.’ I looked at the table. ‘It’s the only way I know how to be right about this. If I am sure, I stop checking.’

Nobody said anything. The Deputy Governor almost smiled, then looked at her watch.

‘You will give the order to my people at Walbrook by ten,’ she said. ‘Not after. At ten the exchanges open and the first line will be offered whether or not it is the right one. The letter will be with my officer before you are.’

Nasser had already put the telephone into his pocket. ‘The car is at the door, Mr Whitlock. It will be forty minutes if the Strand is open. Mr Al-Mansouri will want you to go.’

‘Does he know?’

‘I told him as you spoke,’ said Nasser. ‘He said you are to go. He said also that I am to tell you he has never been given an instruction by a man who said *I think*, and that he finds he does not mind it.’

It was 9.04. There is a line in the third notebook, at the end of a week of fails that I could not make fit: *the thing I cannot see is the thing that is holding the rest up.* I wrote it more than two years ago.

The book is in a steel cabinet in Mayfair and I did not need it. I said the line to myself in the lift, on the way down, as one reads a letter from a stranger.

The car had a driver and nothing else. He did not ask where.

Chapter 48

Cannon Street

Still #1421, written at night, and the shirt is in a bin bag by the door because Laura says it is evidence and I say it is a shirt.

The car did the Strand and Fleet Street in nineteen minutes and stopped at Cannon Street at 9.24, behind a bus, in front of a bus, with a taxi alongside. The driver said, to the windscreen, that it was the delayed open: every dealing floor in the City had told its people to come in early and sit, and the roads had done what roads do. He said he could try Queen Victoria Street. I looked at the clock on the dashboard. 9.24. Walbrook's door was 600 yards ahead and a little to the left, past the station and up a lane. I have walked it two thousand times.

I said I would get out. He said Mr Nasser had said I was not to. I said Mr Nasser was not in the car.

I saw them when I stood on the pavement. One at the corner by the bank on the far side of the road, in a good dark overcoat, with a telephone held a little away from his ear so that his hand was in view. One at the mouth of the lane, hands in pockets, looking at nothing, at me. I do not know them. I have not seen their faces. But I spent four years looking for people who were not looking at me and I know what a man does with his shoulders when he is not looking at a man he is looking at. They had been there a while. Neither of them had a

newspaper or a coffee.

The one at the lane was between me and the door. So I did not go up the lane. I went in at the station.

Cannon Street station on a weekday morning is a hall with a glass roof and a platform barrier every ten yards, and at 9.30 it is the tail end of the rush, which is a thing like a tide that has not quite gone out. Perhaps three hundred people. Suits, rucksacks, a man with a cello. The departures board said every train was on time and nobody believed it. I went down the middle of it with my head down.

I am telling it in order. I do not remember it in order.

I remember the second man coming in at the side doors behind me, fast. I remember turning, and a hand in my collar, and a pillar against my cheek. I remember the noise of it, a wet clap, and thinking *the page*, and putting my left forearm across my chest where it was, and the pain in the ribs that had not been worth mentioning for four days lighting up like a grid. A voice in my ear that I recognised only as a sound: patient, even, polite. 'Mr Whitlock. We would like you to come and talk to someone. There's a car.'

'No.'

'It's not a question.'

The shirt was warm down the front. I saw it before I felt it. The nose, I think; the cheek. Blood on a white shirt in a station looks like a decision somebody has made on your behalf.

He had me by the collar and the belt. He was strong. He had the quiet competence of someone who has done this with people who weren't going to ring anybody. And then a woman near the barrier, a woman in a navy coat with a lanyard and an apple, said in a very clear voice, 'Oi.' Not shouted. Said, in the voice you use to a dog on a train. A man in front of her turned. A man behind turned. The man with the cello moved it two feet to the left, which is the kind of detail I will have forever. And a girl of about twenty-two, with a phone in

her hand, raised it. I saw the small lens. I saw it find us.

I have thought about that second more than any in the day.

He looked at the phone. He looked at the woman, and the people who had begun to make a space around us, the shape a crowd makes when it has decided it would like to see how something comes out. His hand did not let go. But I felt it make a calculation. A man of forty in a bloodied shirt, no bag, no weapon, a bad ribcage; and three hundred witnesses; and a telephone. I was worth a great deal to the man who had sent him. I was not worth killing in front of the 9.31 to Dartford.

The hand opened. He said, close, not unkindly, 'This isn't over,' and was gone through the crowd as though he had been part of it all along.

I did not stop. I think that is the only thing I did right.

I went out of the side doors onto the lane, and the first man was not at the mouth of it; he had gone round to the station front. I took a left, then a right, into Abchurch Lane, which has a church and a pillar box and was empty, and I put the heel of my hand under my nose and ran the way a man of forty with four days of bad ribs runs, which is not fast. Behind me a door banged. I did not look.

Nicholas Lane. A courier on a bicycle who swore and did not stop. Lombard Street, where for the first time in an hour I was one of a great many men in suits walking quickly, and I let it take me. At Bank the junction opened out: eight roads, a thousand people. I crossed with the lights against me and a taxi horn and found that I was laughing, and that it was not a good sound.

9.47. Walbrook's door. The lobby I have walked through at 7.40 every weekday for five years, and the man on the desk. He looked at the shirt. He looked at the face. He did not say a word. He pressed the button that opens the barrier from his side, and I want that written down.

The Bank's man was at the lift with a letter in his hand. I took it. I do not remember reading it.

The risk room. Wall screens from corner to corner, the room I built the desks for. Faces turned and nobody said anything.

On the centre screen, in the corner, in the colour I know best, a line was moving. The price of insurance on a bank that was not one of mine. It had not moved in a day except by a hair. It had started to move at 9.46, fourteen minutes before anyone was allowed to trade.

Jonas had said anywhere but there, and she had heard him and gone there anyway, because it was the only door in London that was hers, and because a man who wants to find you will and a man who does not, won't. The grey car had been at the end of the road since ten past nine. It stood on the far side, nose out, under a plane tree, a hundred and fifty yards from the front window of Tom and Aisha's. Two shapes in it. Not moving. She stood in the front room with the curtain held back an inch. It was the same car. Same colour, same make, same absence of anything that made it a car you remembered. She had counted it for two days at the end of a lane in Norfolk before she knew it was something, and on the Saturday it had been behind her all the way to this road. She knew now.

She had called 999 at 9.14 and been told that a vehicle would be allocated. She said there were men in the car and her daughter was in the house, and the woman said *I understand, madam*, and typed, and said a car would attend as soon as one was available, and gave her a reference number, which Laura wrote on her hand. It was the second time in a fortnight she had asked the state for help and been given a number.

At 9.19 the two shapes got out.

She had never seen them. She would have known them anywhere. The older man was broad and had a left-sided stoop, an old shoulder or a bad hip; he put his weight on the door to rise. The younger was thin and held his hands out of his pockets, and was looking at the houses on her side for a number. Both of them walked as though the

road were theirs.

She took the back off her phone case. The card was where she had put it, white, plain, a mobile number and nothing else. She dialled.

It rang three times, and then it was answered.

‘Yes.’

‘It’s Laura Whitlock.’ Her own voice was perfectly level, which interested her. ‘There is a grey car on Aisha’s road with two men in it. They are walking towards the house. I think you know whose they are.’

A very short pause. ‘Is the child inside?’

‘Upstairs with Aisha. The door is locked.’

‘Stay in the hall with the door shut. Do not open it until you have seen me through the glass.’ Another pause, shorter. ‘Eleven minutes. Do not telephone anyone else.’

She stood behind the door with her back to the wall, her own pulse at about ninety-four. The bell went at 9.29. It went again, and then a hand, flat, on the wood, close to her head. She did not breathe. And then, through the frosted glass, a third shape, from the left, at the pace of a woman who has not hurried in years.

‘Good morning,’ said Dana Kessler.

Kessler wore a grey coat, carried no bag, and stood at the foot of the step with her hands in her pockets. She spoke to the older man the way a registrar speaks to a consultant who has done something stupid.

‘You rang me on Saturday from a car,’ Kessler said, ‘and told me what you had done on Friday at ten to eleven. Stairs, fifth floor, a girl. I wrote it down. The time you rang, the time you said it happened, what you said Mr Crane had paid you and what he had paid you out of. It is typed. It is with a solicitor who has been told to open it if I do not collect it by noon.’

‘Dana—’ said the older man.

‘Let me finish. You will walk back to the car. You will not telephone Mr Crane from it, because his number is on a list that is not mine and

is going to be read. You will drive until you are out of this postcode. If you go on from here, the envelope goes today. To the police officer who has Miss Raman's wrist on a form. To the editor of the paper whose stairs they were. To the regulator, with the trade dates. And to your wives. I would rather not. I would send them.' She took her right hand from her pocket and it was empty and she showed it. 'This is not a threat. I am telling you what will happen.'

The older man was looking at her. Laura, through the glass, watched the muscle at the corner of his jaw, and the way his left hand went to the shoulder and came away. She had seen that look on men who had come in about a chest pain and had been told what the scan showed.

The younger one said something Laura did not hear.

'Yes,' said Kessler. 'That is what I mean. There isn't a third thing.'

Then the older man turned, and the younger one, a beat after him, and they walked down the road with a sort of care, as though the pavement might break, and got into the grey car. It did not start immediately. When it did, it pulled out under the plane tree and went the other way, at thirty miles an hour, indicating, and was gone round the end of the road.

Laura unlocked the door. The chain she took off with a hand that was not quite steady, and noted it, as one notes it in anyone.

Kessler was still on the step. She looked, close to, exactly as she had looked in the kitchen in Norfolk, which was to say very ordinary. She said, 'I put the SIM back in at six. I thought someone might ring.'

'Your men broke a girl's wrist.'

'Yes.'

'Her head needed stitches.'

'I know,' said Kessler. 'I have been told.' It was the first time Laura had heard anything in her voice that was not exact. 'I'm not asking you for anything.'

In her hand a telephone buzzed. She turned it over. Laura saw the

screen before Kessler did, or before she let her see: one line, a number with no name, *Dana. Please.* The word was the whole message.

'He has not said that in two years,' Kessler said. She laid the screen face down on her palm. 'He's frightened. Frightened men pay.'

'It's 9.38,' said Laura.

'Yes.' Kessler sat down on the low front wall, in her grey coat, in full view of the road. 'I'll wait here until ten.'

Chapter 49

The open

Wednesday, #1421. The rest of the day, written tonight. At 8.25 I wrote the cell and the release in the back of a car, on the reverse of a bail form, and I wrote nothing else until this evening. This is ten o'clock, the thing the other 1,420 entries were for, and I am putting it down in the order it happened, with the times, because I trust no other way of putting it down.

I had been in the room thirteen minutes. It is Walbrook's risk room, where I worked for five years, and nobody looked at me when I came through the door with blood on my shirt, which I took as a kindness. The wall screens were as they always are, the call sheet, the fails list, the balances. Only the lines were not going green. Richard Haldane stood at the back with his arms folded, the colour of a candle, and as I passed he said 'Jonas' in a voice with nothing in it, and I said 'Richard', and that was the whole of our conversation. In the corner of the centre screen was the price of insurance on a code that was not one of my twelve. It had started to move at 9.46. It was a little higher than when I had come in.

A desk had been cleared for me, with a telephone on it and a microphone on a stalk. Afterwards people will say it was a button. Walbrook had cut its data and file links at six on the Bank's advice, and the auction schedule loaded at seven could not be reloaded. It could be

keyed. At the next desk sat two of Walbrook's collateral staff, a young man and a woman who looked as if she had not been home, with the schedule open in a window, and beside them the Bank of England's officer, in a headset, with the Deputy Governor's letter flat under his hand. The letter said that he might change the schedule on the instruction of Mr J. Whitlock, present in the room, and on no one else's. At 9.49 I said the new sequence aloud, thirteen codes in about forty seconds, and the woman typed it a line at a time, and the officer read each line back to me before she pressed anything. It took until 9.58. The voice line ran from my microphone to St James's and nowhere else: the fund's sterling-book head, who had put my map into her machine on Sunday, with Nasser standing behind her, and her dealers, who would buy through the three banks and needed to hear the order when the keyers did, not after. On a speaker at my elbow was the hospital. Priya, in a side room, with her wrist in plaster and Graham's sixteen box files open round her on the bed. I could hear paper.

On the centre screen, the Deputy Governor, on video, in front of her bookshelf. 'Mr Whitlock. You are the person who has the sequence.'

'Yes.'

'We shall need it without ambiguity.'

I laid the page on the desk face down. It has Walbrook's September figures on it, and one corner brown with Priya's blood. I did not need it. I turned it over anyway, so that I would not be tempted to look.

At ten the exchanges opened, two hours late, on a Bank statement that used the word *orderly* three times. In the first minute the thirty-year, the 2056, went from 71.50 to 70.50. A sound in the room, not a word. It was the shape I wrote down on a Tuesday when I was 36, bonds failing to arrive, except that now it was every line at once and the whole of London on one side of it.

'First,' I said.

There is no thrill in saying it. It comes out as flat as a timetable.

‘Buy the 2056. What is left of the first member’s collateral. Eleven hundred million. At the market.’

The officer said it into the line, a second behind me. The woman at the next desk keyed the line. Eleven hundred million pounds of government bonds, spoken into a telephone in the City of London at 10.01.

Eleven seconds. ‘Done,’ said the woman in St James’s. ‘Eleven hundred, average 70.40.’ And on the screen the 2056 stopped. Not rose. Stopped, like a man on a stair who has found a step that was not there. 70.40. 70.40. 70.45.

‘Second,’ I said. ‘The ninth member. The 2034, three hundred.’

‘Stop,’ said Priya. ‘Thirty-five. The ninth is the 2035. The 2034 is the twelfth’s.’

I had said the wrong year and the officer had it halfway to the line. He stopped it. ‘Say again,’ he said, and the woman at the keys took her hands off them. A minute, I think, from that to the line being clean, and I felt every second of it on the back of my neck.

‘The 2035. Three hundred.’

‘Done.’ The ninth’s bonds, which the thirteenth was holding overnight, had been recalled with the purchase, and they came home. The eleventh went at 10.09, the 2047, two hundred and sixty, and the twelfth at 10.12, the 2034, three hundred and forty, which was the line I had called wrong, and I called it right. The fund’s three banks took the bonds to the Bank of England and came back inside the hour with cash. What I saw was the numbers going out and the numbers coming back, and a line on a side screen that said BANK OF ENGLAND: RECEIVED.

By 10.20 the three had come home. The 2035, the 2047 and the 2034 had each taken a bid the size of a street and done something I had not seen on any screen in that room for twenty days. They went up. Someone at the back made a noise like a man who has held his breath since Tuesday. The thirteenth had not been touched, and nothing of

anyone else's was left in it to break.

10.24. 'The second member. The 2038, four hundred and ten.' Done. Then the third, the 2045, six hundred, the one that had paid its call on the Bank's money and had been selling for four hours. It took the bid and moved up four pence, and I counted.

10.35. 'The fourth member. The 2052, two hundred and ninety. I think the 2052 first, then the 2041.'

'You think,' said the Deputy Governor.

I had not heard myself say it. I have said it for four years. It is in the nine books most weeks, and nobody has ever asked me to stop. Now the Deputy Governor of the Bank of England had a clock and a country's money in her hand and was waiting, politely, for me to take it out of my sentence.

'Yes,' I said. 'I think. I have never seen it. Nobody has. I have seen what it leaves behind, and the fourth member's fingerprints say the 2052 goes about ninety seconds before the 2041. That is what I have. If you wanted a man who knows, you have not got one. You have the man who counted.'

The line hissed. Then Priya, from a hospital bed, under a name on the board that is not hers: 'He's said that to me for four years. He's been wrong on a size twice and on the order never. I'd bet the lot on it.' A rustle. 'Go on, Jonas. Say it plainly.'

'The 2052 first. Two hundred and ninety.'

10.38. 'Done.' The 2052 printed 74.50, then 74.75. The Deputy Governor nodded to someone off camera and did not speak again for half an hour.

10.42. The woman in St James's said it, and her voice had lost its edges; she had been on the line forty-two minutes without a break. 'Mr Whitlock. One of our three banks is also a prime broker, and it should not have told us what it has told us.' A breath. 'It sent a margin call

to a fund in Mayfair at 10.42. Greywether. Two point one billion, due by two o'clock. They have, I am told, less than a third of it in cash.'

I thought: this is where they will look at me.

They looked at the screens. It was not Walbrook's number and had no business on the wall; it was a call between a bank and a fund. The Deputy Governor said, 'We shall not comment on any firm.' Then, after a pause that was the first human thing she had done in an hour: 'Thank you, Mr Whitlock.'

Greywether is not a bank. It cannot borrow from the Bank of England. It had a position that had paid by the minute for twenty days, and the position had been built on a map that I wrote, the original of which, with the notebooks, was taken from me out of a hotel cloakroom on the Tuesday night, and the same map was turning it inside out in my voice, line by line. Whatever it had done in the first gilt lines at eight, which the fund's desk had seen as small pieces from six brokers, its losses were in what it had not covered: the other lines, the shares of the parents of the failing members, the pound, and the thirteenth. It could not meet the call. I knew that by 10.43 with a certainty I have felt about nothing else this month, and I did not feel what I thought I would. I felt a hand on my elbow. The officer, who had held his headset for forty-two minutes, said, 'Sir, you've got blood on your cuff,' and I said, 'It isn't mine.' It was mine. From the nose, from Cannon Street.

10.47. The fifth member. 'The 2039. Three hundred and forty.'

'No,' said Priya. 'Two hundred. Q2, page fourteen restates it. Graham initialled the cut. The three-forty was last year's.'

The woman at the keys had already typed 340. She looked at me. I said, 'Two hundred,' and she changed it, and the officer read it back, and it was another minute. I want it written that I got a size wrong in the one hour of my life when it counted, and that a woman with a broken wrist caught it from a bed.

'Thank you,' I said.

‘Thank me later.’

By 11.15 the sixth, the seventh, the eighth and the tenth had gone, each in its place, each read back, each answered, *Done*. The screens had a different colour on them. The red goes. The fails list, forty lines at ten, was nineteen, then eleven, then six. The call sheet went amber, then the pale grey that means *settled, awaiting confirmation*, then the first green, at 10.27, on the first member. And what Crane had sold and not bought back, because my map told him it would fall, the shares of the parents of the failing members, the pound, the lines beyond the first eight, was rising, in step, because each of them had a buyer under it that did not go away, and a buyer who does not go away is the only thing that has ever turned a price. A price that turns is a debt somebody has to pay.

11.20. The last line. By then the room had stopped looking at me and started looking at the clock, which is how I knew it was working.

‘Thirteenth,’ I said. ‘The code Priya gave me. Three hundred and eighty million, the 2049. At the market.’ And then, because there was nothing left of the sentence to hang it on: ‘I think the whole of it.’

It was said, and keyed. For one second, nothing, the whole room hearing a woman in St James’s not answering. Then, ‘Done. Three-eighty, average 80.50.’ And the thirteenth, which a man in Mayfair had been quietly building a position against for longer than anyone had had a map, which could have broken the chain at the end of the line, found a price already turned and a buyer already there, and did nothing at all. It held. There is no drama in a line holding. It is a number that stays where it is.

At 11.52 the last line on the call sheet went green. Eight minutes before the new noon. The clearing house met its deadline with the Bank’s money gone round the building twice and the fund’s proceeds on top. Haldane did not clap. Nobody did. A man by the window began to cry quietly, and no one looked at him.

'Mr Whitlock,' said the Deputy Governor. 'Is it over?'

Every one of the times in four years I have written *I think*, I felt it in my throat like a coin.

'Yes,' I said.

Then I wrote it on the back of the page, on the brown corner, before I had said anything else. It is the first line in 1,421 entries I have written without a hedge. I will see in the morning whether I was entitled to it.

Chapter 50

Without screens

Sebastian Crane had never kept a screen in his room. The traders downstairs had eleven each. He had a desk, two chairs, a Persian rug he had bought for the pleasure of being told what it was worth, and a steel cabinet behind the desk that had held, until last week, nothing but cigars. He liked to say that a man who watches the price cannot see the market. The line had been quoted in two profiles. He believed it, which is the most dangerous thing that can be said about a line of that kind.

At 11.04 on Wednesday morning he was sitting in front of the telephone and not looking at it.

He had watched the broadcast at six with his lawyers on speaker, and had understood it before the second of them had finished saying *defamation*. Eleven minutes of a tired man in a borrowed shirt, naming the twelve in order, and then the dates, and then himself. He had admired the order of it. Then he had understood what the buyer in London at seven was for, and had said, quite pleasantly, to nobody, ‘They’re going to buy what I’m short,’ and the lawyers had stopped talking.

He had done what could be done. At eight, before the exchanges opened, he had closed the shorts in the first eight lines, through six brokers, and kept the bonds, so that when the fund came to the open

he would be standing there with the goods it needed. It was a clean move and it had made him money, and he had known as he made it that it would not be enough, because it touched the sum and not the man who was to give it. The rest of the book he had left exactly as it was. Then he had sent the two men to find the man. That, too, had been done. Crane did not examine it. The man had arrived at Walbrook at a quarter to ten with blood on his shirt and his hands free, and what had happened between Crane did not yet know and was not going to ask.

At 10.42 a prime broker had rung his head trader with a figure, and the man had walked in and said it in front of him. Two point one billion, by two. At 10.50 the second prime broker had rung, politely, to say that the firm would not be extending the terms of the facility in the current environment. At 10.56 the third had not rung at all, which he understood to be the real message. A fund of his size runs on three lines of credit and a reputation, and by eleven all three were closed to him. He had spent twenty-five years knowing precisely what such a morning looked like from the other side of the table. He had been, he supposed, rather good at the other side of the table.

'It's a squeeze,' his head trader said. He had stayed in the doorway. He had been with Crane nine years and had been awake since four. 'Every line in the rest of the book is going up in step. There is nobody to sell us the other side. By one o'clock we will have been closed out in four of the five books. By two, in all of them. The partners' capital goes first, Sebastian. Then the investors'.' He waited. 'Nobody lends to a man who is short gilts on the day the Bank of England is buying them.'

'No,' he said. 'I suppose not.'

'I need you to tell me whether to call the lawyers.'

'You may ring whom you like,' Crane said. 'Thank you.'

He went. Crane heard him go down the stairs to the floor, and then the particular silence of a floor of eleven-screened desks on which

every line is the colour of a bruise. He had known it, in his time, from the other end.

He rang Anthony Pell. He did it himself, from the handset, because there was nobody he wished to ask.

Thirty years. A man who sat at the board of Walbrook and had sat on his own board, and who had given him, a week ago, twelve names over the telephone, from an appendix to a board pack, and a pleasant lunch afterwards. It rang six times. It was answered by a woman at Pell's house who said that Sir Anthony was not available, that she could not say when he would be, and that she would pass on the message. He thanked her. He rang the club. He rang the office, and a secretary he had known for fifteen years said, with a politeness he recognised as the voice of a person reading a script, that Sir Anthony had asked not to be put through to anybody this morning, and she was very sorry.

He put the telephone down and found that he was smiling, which was habit. The smile was for the room.

He tried to see it. He was good at that. He had always been the man who saw the second move; it was what he sold. A man in a tie, in a hospital, in a cupboard at a newspaper, with a pad. A man who wrote on pages. A man who had had the whole of the thing in nine books, in a steel box in a garage, for four years, and had done *nothing with it*. That was the part that would not close. Four years in which any other man in the City would have sold the position, shorted the twelve, sold the books to the highest bidder, and he had not even tried. He had written it down. For nobody. And when it was taken from him, the thing he had done was recite it to a camera.

It did not add. Crane had never in his life lost to a man who did not want the thing. He did not know how to price it.

He had read the books, all nine, in a day, in this room. He remembered them well: the dates, the codes, the small, tidy handwriting. Whole pages he had skipped, because they were about a child. He

thought, briefly, of those pages, and then it passed.

The police came at 11.31.

He heard them before he saw them, because a floor that has been silent for forty minutes registers a change of weight. Then the door, which he had never locked. There were six: a woman in a raincoat who gave her rank and name, and held a document in a clear plastic sleeve, and four others, two of them in uniform and one carrying a long bag, and behind them, hovering, a man from the Financial Conduct Authority whom he had once had to lunch.

'Mr Crane. This is a warrant to search these premises, and anything on them, in connection with the dates of certain trades in the sterling market in the fortnight before the sinking of a tanker in the Strait of Hormuz. It also covers property that we have reason to believe was taken from Mr Jonas Whitlock and Ms Priya Raman on the nights of the Tuesday before last and the Friday just gone.' She said it in one breath, like a woman who had said it in the car. 'I would like to see the cabinet behind you.'

'Which cabinet?'

'Steel. Grey. Four-drawer, I'm told. With a key on your person.'

He considered it, as he considered most things. He had not told anyone about the key. Not his head trader, not his lawyers. Kessler had known; Kessler had made it her business, in fifteen years, to know where men like him kept what they could not afford to burn. She had been told on Tuesday afternoon at 3.46 that her firm was finished. He turned it over and could not find the fault in it. It was, he thought, a fair return on the investment.

'It is a courtesy,' Crane said, and took the key from its chain, and put it on the desk, and did not stand.

The woman in the raincoat opened it herself. She wore gloves. The first drawer: cigars, a box of them, which she lifted out, looked at, and passed to a constable without comment. The second: nine black A5

notebooks with elastic bands, standing on their spines, in order, eight of them worn grey at the corners and the ninth thinner than the rest. She did not touch them for a moment. Beside them, a young woman's rucksack, a purse, a bail notice, a red notebook. A cardboard folder with the stamp of HM Treasury on its first page, and under it six pages of Walbrook letterhead, headed *Collateral re-use in cleared markets*. A single sheet of Treasury paper with two paragraphs and a space at the foot for signatures, and no signature. A single sheet in a plastic sleeve, folded once, with twelve four-letter codes down the left and a column of figures down the right.

'That is a copy,' Crane said.

'It's the original, sir. I understand the author has rebuilt it.' She said it without emphasis. 'And we shall want everything in it, and your phone, and your diary, and I'd be grateful if you could tell me where your laptop is before my colleagues start looking for it.'

He gave her the laptop. He gave her, he found, the name of the cleaner. His hands were quite steady. It occurred to him that this was the first morning in twenty-five years that he had looked at a woman in a doorway and not known her price.

The constable with the long bag was labelling the first notebook. Crane watched the pen. Whitlock's hand, he thought, was neater than the constable's. 'Is it permitted,' he said, 'to ask something?'

'You can ask.'

'Sir Anthony Pell. I couldn't reach him.'

'No.' She lifted the red notebook, looked at the cover, and put it in a bag. 'He came in to us at ten, sir, with his solicitor. He's been very helpful about the telephone calls.'

Crane nodded. It seemed to him a reasonable answer. It also seemed to him that the sentence had been placed in the room in advance, for him, on the carpet, a little to the left of the desk, and that she had waited all morning for the moment to put it down.

'I see,' he said. He looked at the nine books being counted into bags,

one, two, three, and found that of all of it, of the twenty-five years, the fund, the carpet, the name, the only thing in the room he could not have said the price of was a row of notebooks with an elastic band round each, and the page in the seventh that he had not read.

Chapter 51

Home

The aeroplane that Khalid Al-Mansouri took on Wednesday night was not the noon flight. The noon flight had left with his seat empty, and he had watched the clock pass twelve in a room in St James's with his hands folded on a table and the screens quiet for the first time in twenty days. He had asked Nasser to book the next one, for the evening, and Nasser, who booked things, had booked two seats.

'You need not,' Khalid had said.

'My sons are at home, sir.' It was the whole of the answer, and it was the first time he had mentioned them without being asked.

They landed at six on Thursday morning, home time. Khalid had not slept. He had spent the night in a window seat with the blind half down, doing what he did in a crisis, which was to write the worst case in a column and read it back until it was no longer interesting. Arrest at the foot of the steps: a car, a room, a man from the council's secretariat whom he had known since school. A decree read to an empty chair on Wednesday, for the record. The charter said what it said, and he had acted within its letter for exactly as long as he had meant to. He had decided in the small hours of Monday that it was a price he could pay. He found, at thirty-eight thousand feet, that the knowing had worn away the fear and left only the arithmetic, and that the arithmetic was that of a man of forty-seven with a bag.

Nobody was at the foot of the steps.

There was a car, which he had expected, and in the car a man he had not: the council's secretary, who had rung him on Monday to be kind. He was grey in the face and wearing the wrong tie. He did not say good morning. He said, 'Mr Al-Mansouri. The council has asked me to bring you directly,' and Khalid, who had been trained to hear what was not said, heard that the sentence had a second half that the man had been told not to use. *Directly* was not the word for an arrest.

The council sat in the long room with the windows on the water. He had been in it perhaps forty times. Nine chairs on the near side of the table, and one, at the far end, for the chair of the fund, which for eleven years had been his.

It was occupied. Not by a successor. By his own folder, which someone had set there on Wednesday morning, so that the decree should have something to be read to. He understood this from the secretary's face. The decree had been read at ten, home time, to the folder; and the folder had stayed where it was, because by the time anyone thought of taking it away, the London opening was a rumour on the secretary's telephone, and nobody wished to be the man who moved it.

The first news had been Nasser's, a single line at ten to two, home time: *the transactions are complete*. The numbers came after, made by the council's own people from their screens in the afternoon, in the manner of a family counting the silver after a burglary. The pound. The long end of the gilt market. The ten largest holdings of the fund, marked at Wednesday's close, which were worth more than they had been on the morning the tanker sank, by an amount the secretary read out in a flat voice and which Khalid did not repeat to himself. A man could not like a number of that kind and be seen to like it.

By evening, home time, the decree had been withdrawn. Not revoked: withdrawn. The wording, which the secretary now read to

him as if it were a postal notice, said that the council noted the managing director's actions on the previous day *with appreciation*, and that matters of authority at the fund would be considered *in the ordinary course*. Khalid recognised it. It was the language of eight men who had needed to be on the right side of something by dinner. He thought of the four he had met in two capitals who had all said *not on my signature*, and of the fact that of all the signatures in the matter, the only one that had gone on the page without a second sentence was his own.

'We should like to thank you,' said the oldest of the nine, whom he had known thirty years. It was said stiffly, to the table, and it was true, and it cost the man something.

'I acted without the board.'

'You did.' A pause. 'The board has met. It would have refused. It has asked that the minutes record that it would have refused.' Another pause, and then, in the accent of the old men, the kind that does not translate: 'And that the managing director's judgement was nonetheless sound.'

He thanked them. It took eleven minutes.

There was a second empty chair, on the long side, where the family sat. He had not mentioned it, and nobody had.

Faisal.

Khalid had his cousin's name in his mouth and did not say it. It had been said at the council on Wednesday, he gathered, by one man, in a low voice, after the decree was withdrawn, and had gone nowhere. Faisal had not been at the table. He had not been at the office on Wednesday, nor at the house, nor at his club. His private office, the quiet one at the family's estate that had never once been named in London, had sent word at four o'clock on Wednesday afternoon, home time, that the principal was *indisposed*, and the Senate motion had been quietly withdrawn that Thursday morning. A word that, at home, was a verdict. It would be said in this room, in the same way, for a

month, and then it would not be said.

Khalid did not ask where he had gone. He knew, as he knew the combination of his own safe, that the answer would be shaped like the answer to the question of who had been paid and by whom and when, and that nobody in the room wished him to know it, or wished him to ask, and that if he did he would be told, kindly, by the oldest of the nine, that there were things a family did not put on paper. A shell with a correspondence address in the Gulf. A broker in London. A trade nine days before a ship was sunk. He had seen the page; Whitlock had held it up. Faisal's name had not been spoken on a screen by anyone. Faisal's name had not needed to be.

He was not seen in public again. Khalid learned it that way, without a day for it to have happened on: a diary that went on being printed, with one name omitted. It is the way things are done there. A man is removed from a list rather than from a room.

He thought, briefly and without satisfaction, of the account of the grudge he had been supposed to carry. Seven years, Crane. Seven years, Faisal. He had left the fund in Mayfair because he had decided that a man who did not think of the people on the other side of his trades as people could not be trusted with a pound. He had not decided anything about his cousin. He had simply never quite looked.

Nasser's boys were at the airport when he left the council. Three of them: nineteen, sixteen, eleven. They were standing in a row by the barrier in school jackets, because their mother had ironed them, and the eldest had a bunch of something from a garage forecourt. They had been told to wait. Nasser, coming through the doors behind Khalid with his case, stopped as a man stops who has been struck from the side, and the youngest broke the row and ran.

Khalid walked on a little way, and then, because it was a fine morning and nobody was watching, stopped, and let the car wait.

He had a telephone in his pocket, the plain one the office kept for

him, with one number in it that was not on the register. At the entrance to the car park he took it out. He had drafted the message in the plane, on the back of the menu, and crossed it out four times. In the end it was formal and short, because he had no other kind.

Mr Whitlock. The instruction was carried out as directed. I am in your debt and shall not say so again. K. Al-Mansouri.

Twenty-two words. He counted them, which was a habit he had caught from the man he was writing to. He read it once, to see whether it would improve, and found that it would not, and sent it.

He was in the car and the gates had opened before the telephone moved in his hand. A single line. He had expected a courtesy, perhaps nothing, since the man was wanted by the police, or had been, and might be in a room somewhere without his telephone. Instead:

Received. Thank you for the bid. I think we were both lucky. J.W.

Khalid read it twice. Then, because he was alone in the back of the car with the glass up and had been awake for thirty hours and his father was waiting at a house forty minutes away, he found he had to look out of the window for a little while. He had been thanked that morning by nine men and a decree. It was this he would remember: not the thanks, but the correction. *I think we were both lucky.* Whitlock had put in the one phrase that a careful man leaves out, and had not been able to stop himself.

He did not reply. He deleted nothing. He told the driver to go on.

Chapter 52

Statements

#1424. Saturday. Two sittings, the first on the pad, because the book is not mine yet.

I signed my name thirty-one times today. Thirty pages and a last one, in a room in Holborn with a window that does not open, with a solicitor on my left whom the paper pays for and two officers on my right whom the Crown pays for, one older and one with a laptop. Nine hours, with a sandwich. I counted the pages because I count the pages. The older officer read the statement back to me at the end, aloud, in a flat voice, as though somebody else had said it, and I listened to it the way you listen to a stranger describing your house: right in every particular and not one of them mine.

I gave them the dates. The memo and its stamp. The email that went to the wrong inbox at 6.41 on a Wednesday. The Saturday at Horse Guards Road and the two paragraphs I did not sign. The map, the twelve codes, the order, and how I came to have it in my head, which took forty minutes because they kept asking *how do you know* and the true answer is *I don't, I infer*. The younger one typed that down. *I infer.* He looked up and said, 'Is that the word you want?' and I said it was the only word I had ever been entitled to.

They no longer wish to arrest me. The older officer said it at about four, looking at the table, in the voice people use for a thing they have

been told to say and half agree with. Walbrook's solicitors wrote on Friday that the claim, and with it the injunction and the delivery-up order, was withdrawn 'as moot'. My bail return is in nine days and nobody has said it is cancelled. The Treasury's second letter is in the file; I have not seen it, but he said it was one page and that the word in it was *withdrawn*. Priya's matter, he said, is 'a question of weeks and not of outcome'. He did not say what outcome. I did not ask. When I stood up he said, 'We'd be glad of your availability, Mr Whitlock,' which is what the Governor's letter said, and I understood that I had become a thing the state wants to be able to find.

I went out into Holborn at ten to five. It was getting dark. Nobody looked at me. That is new, since Wednesday, and I did not like it as much as I thought I would.

Priya's flat is the second floor in Bethnal Green and the plaster goes to the elbow. She opened the door with her left hand.

'You look like a man who's signed things,' she said.

'Thirty-one.'

'I did nineteen yesterday. Don't sit on that, it's the red book.'

It was on the sofa, in a clear bag with a label and a number. The police had found it on Wednesday in a steel cabinet in Mayfair, with her purse and her bail notice, and returned the three together on Friday, with an apology printed on a form. She turned it over with her good hand. Codes and ranks, in red biro, in her fast square writing, and in the margin by the eleventh a note that said *he'll say 'I think'*, and a tick, added later. I did not ask when she had added it.

She made tea one-handed and told me, with her back to me, that the Bank had asked her to lunch on Thursday and had made her an offer over the soup. A unit. Her word was 'a unit', said with the contempt she keeps for anything with an organisation chart; a small room inside the Bank, six people, and a standing order from the Governor's office to look under the promises, at the things nobody can see, which is

what we did for four years on the quiet and were called difficult for. It would be hers. A title, a salary I will not write down because she would never forgive it, and a door that shuts.

'And?'

'And I said I'd think about it over the weekend.'

I laughed. It hurt my ribs. She watched me do it with great satisfaction.

'I got it from you,' she said. 'Not yet. I heard myself say it. I thought, that's his, I'll have to give it back.' She sat down. 'They know, Jonas. The man across the table said, "You'll have been told that line before, I expect," and smiled at me. I wanted to hit him with the cast.'

'Will you take it?'

'Monday,' she said. 'I'm going to say yes on Monday, and I want you to know I decided on Thursday. The weekend's for me to see whether I mind.' She turned her tea in her hand. The scheme her parents' savings sit in clears through a fund that survived Wednesday, she said, because of the buy; her mother has not been told anything and says only that the statement came on time.

'They'll ask you next.'

'I know.'

'Don't say it.'

'I wasn't going to.'

'You were going to say not yet,' said Priya, and she was right.

There was a note from Pryce, in the second post on Friday, which I did not open until the night, on the sofa at home: four lines in longhand, lined paper, a Suffolk postmark.

The order against me has been dropped. I am told I may go home. I have; it is flat here and I understand that I shall like it. I have been looking for the word to put at the end of this and I find that I can only write the one I have been in the habit of using, which is "not yet", and I have crossed it out. Come and see the sea when you can. Graham.

He crossed it out so that I could read it. That is Graham.

I will set Haldane and Pell down together, once, as I understand it, and the understanding is Calloway's. Haldane stood aside from Walbrook on Thursday 'to assist the Bank's review of the events of the past three weeks'. The board suspended him on Friday, and the police have asked to speak to him about the statement that went out under his name and the word in it. Sir Anthony Pell resigned from the board on Friday afternoon 'for personal reasons' and is at a house in Wiltshire where the telephone is not being answered. I have no view. I would have thought I had a view. It turns out that I have only the dates.

Dana Kessler was on a bench in Ruskin Park, by the bandstand, at four on the Friday. I had that from Laura, who had it from her phone: a number she did not know, a voice, two sentences, and then the thing Laura says when she wants me to understand she has taken a history. 'She says she'll be on the bench. She says you needn't. I said I'd decide for you, and then I decided you'd decide for yourself. I'll be in the café.' She was. I could see her through the glass, with Elsie on her knee, not looking.

Kessler had on a dark coat, no scarf, no bag. Her hands were empty and in her lap, which I took to be on purpose. She looked less like a woman who has done a thing than a woman who has finished one.

'I've closed the firm,' she said, before I sat. 'The third of us is on a train to Manchester. The two men from the stairs have been interviewed, and one of them has said things about me I would have preferred him not to. I've made a statement. A witness, as long as I say what I did and not what I knew; my solicitor was very clear. I thought you should hear it from me and not from a form.'

'The envelope.'

'It went in as it was. Your fingerprints are on it, and a woman's I trained, who has been very brave and will lose her job.' She said that

last part without inflection and I understood it was the one thing that she minded. 'I would like not to be thanked.'

'I wasn't going to.'

'Good.' She looked at the park. A man was walking a dog round the bandstand, and she watched him all the way, in that way she has, and I thought that she will do it for the rest of her life. 'I read one of them, you know. The night I had the bag in my safe, before the man came for it. The seventh.'

I said nothing.

'The entry where the handwriting changes.' She did not look at me. 'I had read enough of them by then to know what it was before I'd read ten lines. I stopped. I put it back in the bag and I was not good company for a week.' Her voice did not alter. 'That is why I said no to him on Tuesday. I would like you to know that it was not conscience. It was a page.' She said it very evenly, as she says everything, and I thought it a sentence she had said to herself before, often enough to have worn it smooth.

We sat. A child went by on a scooter, shrieking, and she did not turn her head.

'What will you do with them?' she said. 'They will be given back to you. The Crown will photograph them first, and then they'll be returned, and they're yours, and there are nine, and some of the pages are worth a great deal to a great many people. Newspapers. Publishers. A man who was in my old line of work rang me this week and asked if I could put him in touch.'

'I haven't decided what to say to them.'

'That isn't what I asked.'

I said: 'I'm going to finish them.'

She turned and looked at me for the first time. It took several seconds. She is a woman who tells people exactly what will happen next, and I watched her try, and fail, to say what would happen next to me.

'That isn't an answer,' she said.

'It's the one I've got.'

Dana Kessler stood up and put out her hand, and I shook it. It was cold, and dry, and held mine for the length of one count. Then she walked away down the path, towards the gate, and did not look back, and by the time I could see Laura through the café window, standing, she was gone.

Second sitting. 9.40pm. Home, since Thursday, with the door locked and a thing I notice myself doing, which is checking it twice. Elsie asleep.

Laura came in from the kitchen with a plate for me and set it down, and beside it, from the pocket of her cardigan, a black notebook still in its cellophane, from the box of six in the study desk.

'You saw her?' she said.

'She asked what I'd do with the others. I told her I'd finish them.'

'Good,' said Laura. She sat. She took the cellophane off herself, with her thumbnail, and laid the book open flat in front of me at the first page, the way she lays a thing flat on a couch before she examines it. 'Then you'll need a tenth. Finish them, and then we'll talk about the other five.'

I am writing this paragraph in it. The glue still smells. There are five more in the desk, and she has counted them.

Chapter 53

Polling day

The letter had been in the red box, then in her handbag, in a plain envelope, for fifteen days. It was one paragraph long and addressed to the prime minister, and she had drafted it herself on the Wednesday morning in the hours before the exchanges opened, and had dated it that morning for the Friday after polling day, because a date was a fact and she had wanted to be bound by one.

Thursday. Seven-ten. The polling station was a primary school in her constituency, in a hall that smelled of floor polish and radiators, and the presiding officer, a woman in a lanyard who had voted for her twice, said ‘Good morning, Chancellor,’ and then, in a smaller voice, ‘Good luck,’ and then looked as though she wished she had said the first one only.

There were two photographers at the gate and she gave them what they were owed. The ballot paper was the size of a bill. She took the pencil on its string into the booth and stood for a moment with it over the box beside her own name, which was a thing she had never done in twenty years, because she had always known what she was going to do. She marked it. Folded it. Posted it in the slot. A child in a school jumper, held up by its father to see, watched her do it with the grave attention of a person following a rule, and she thought, quite clearly, that there was nothing in that room that had been made safe by her,

and that this was the first time she had been able to say so without wanting to disprove it.

She went to work. It was a day on which nothing was permitted to happen. The broadcasters were silent on politics by law until ten; the Treasury, by custom, was silent on everything. The pound stood where it had stood for a fortnight, a little above where it had been before, and she did not look at it. Walbrook had met every call since the Wednesday. The Bank had been repaid the first of what it had lent, on the Friday, with interest, out of money that belonged to a man who had, according to the first person on the telephone that morning, been thanked. She had signed a page for that, one page, on a Wednesday morning, with the television on in front of her and the prime minister breathing on the line, and it had been a decision that cost her nothing but what it cost her to make. She had thought, afterwards, that it was the only decision of the year that could have been done by a lawyer rather than a politician, and that the difference was the whole story.

At five Carrow came in and stood by the door.

'Simon.'

'The committee has written, Chancellor. Whatever the result. They will want the Treasury's file on the memo, the minutes of the room under the Cabinet Office, and your private office's diary for the week of the sinking.' He looked at the folder in his hand rather than at her. 'The usual course is that the department resists, and takes advice, and discloses what it is obliged to, in the order it is obliged to.'

'I know the usual course.'

'Yes.' He waited. 'Chancellor, I wrote the letter. I should like you to know that I do not think I was wrong to. I should also like you to know that I think I was unwise.'

It was, she saw, the most that he could say, and she saw how much it had cost, and for an instant she wanted to tell him that she was sorry. She said, 'Thank you, Simon,' which was true and nothing else, and he went out.

The first projection came at ten. The line the broadcasters used, in the voice they reserve for weather, was ‘too close to call’. By midnight it was not: her party would be second, by a margin the commentators would argue about until Christmas. The swing in the marginals was in the places where people kept their savings in funds and had been told, a fortnight ago, on the radio, that a clearing house had come within three hours of failing, and what they remembered was not that it had been saved. She did not find this unreasonable. She would have voted the same.

The count was in a sports hall in her constituency, under strip lights, with trestle tables, and she stood on the stage at ten to two between the other candidates, a man from the Opposition she had been in the House with for fourteen years, and a man dressed as a bear, and heard that she had been returned with a majority of 2,114, which was down by nine thousand. She thanked the returning officer. She thanked the volunteers, whose faces she was able to look at. She did not say anything else. The Opposition man shook her hand with both his, which she thought was a decent thing to do, and with no pleasure.

The interview was in the school next door, in a classroom with a camera in it, and a sound man who had set up in the time it took her to walk across the road. It was the programme that ran at seven on Friday morning, with a presenter she had known for twenty years and been afraid of for eighteen. Carrow stood in the doorway. Her special adviser, who had cried in the car, was not there.

The presenter was kind first, which was how you knew. She asked about the seat, the result, the swing in the marginals, the cost of the three weeks. She asked whether the Chancellor had considered that the government had lost not on the economy but on the question of whether it had been honest about the warning. Strand said that the electorate was entitled to its view, which was true and was also a thing she had said in some form ever since she was twenty-eight, to every

kind of judge.

'Chancellor.' The presenter turned a page, and Strand saw that it was one page, and knew which. 'A man gave this government a six-page note three years ago. It said that the thing which happened a fortnight ago would happen in about three years. It was stamped and filed. It was in your department's papers on the Wednesday before the tanker was hit. Do you regret ignoring it?'

She had the answer. She had had it for two weeks, in its various forms, the form for the committee and the form for a court and the form for the party's historians, and she had refined it, as she refined everything, until there was no sentence in it that anyone could pull. *The advice at the time was that the arrangements were sound. The note was one view. Officials considered it in the normal way.* She opened her mouth to give it, and heard instead:

'Yes.'

The presenter waited. She had waited for a defence, and the defence had not come, and she was too good to say anything into the gap.

'Yes,' Strand said again, because it had been said, and one did not leave a sentence of that sort unfinished. 'I should have read it in the first week, not the third. I did not, because I did not wish to, and I told myself that was prudence. It was not prudence. I regret it.' She heard herself. 'That is all. I do not think there is anything I can add which would improve it.'

'You're saying you were wrong.'

'I am saying that I read it, and that I was right about the law, and wrong about the thing the law was for.' She looked at the lens, and then, because that was what one did, at the presenter. 'He had written down every weakness in his own case before I could find one. I have never met that in a witness. I did not know what to do with it, and so I did the thing I know, and that is the thing I regret.'

She stopped. The red light stayed on for another second. Then the

sound man took his headphones off, and the room was very quiet, and Carrow, in the doorway, did not move.

She had said, in twenty years, what she meant a great many times. She had never before said it by accident. It was, she understood, quite different, and it frightened her a good deal more than the count had, and she sat there for a moment with her hands on her knees and found that she had not the faintest idea who was going to be in the room when she stood up.

At twenty past four in the morning she was in the car, going back to London, and the prime minister's concession had been on the radio for forty minutes. He had used the word *honour*. He had thanked her by name.

'The letter,' she said.

'Chancellor?'

'It is dated today. It is Friday. Have the private office send it to the prime minister's, by hand, before the man's speech is repeated at eight.' She opened her bag, and took out the envelope, and handed it forward. 'And the committee.'

Carrow turned in the seat. In the dark of the car she could see the edge of his face, and the folder on his knee.

'The Treasury's copy of the memo has a stamp on it, a reference, and a margin,' she said. 'In the margin on page four there are two letters and a date. They are my initials. Whoever asks for the file will see them.'

'The department's position, Chancellor, is that—'

'The department's position is that I read it on the Thursday, which I did, in the evening, after the private office had gone.' She had not known she was going to say it until it was said. 'You will give them the file. In the order it is in. Including page four.'

He looked at her for what seemed to be a long time.

'Mark it,' said Caroline Strand. 'Before somebody else does.'

Chapter 54

The last page

At ten past six on the evening of Thursday the seventh of January, the week after New Year, with Epiphany just gone, Laura came down to the kitchen and found her husband at the table with a pen, and stopped on the bottom stair to take a reading.

Posture: upright, forearm flat, weight forward. Not the hunch of the old months, the shoulders up round the ears like a man in a draught. Hand: steady. He wrote in blocks of four or five lines and then stopped, with the pen lifted, for about the time it takes to say a sentence under your breath, and then he wrote again. Colour good. He had put on the half-stone. The ribs had knitted at six weeks, as she had told him they would, and he had not asked her, and she had not told him again.

‘Don’t mind me,’ he said, without looking up.

‘I don’t.’

She did not. That was the finding, and she examined it for a moment before she allowed it, the way you recheck a result that comes back better than you expected. For four years the table had been where he went. She had stood on this stair, or one like it, a hundred times, and watched a man leave the room while remaining in it. This was a man at a table. The difference was not in the writing. It was in whether he would look up if she spoke, and he would; he had; he had.

Elsie was under the table. She was fifteen months old and had been walking since the second week of December, and she did it with her arms up and out for balance, like a small drunk man in a corridor, and with a seriousness that Laura recognised, because it was his. She had a wooden spoon in each fist. She went round the table leg, left to right, and she did it again, and a third time, and on the fourth she put out one spoon and tapped her father's shin with it, once, and went on.

He did not stop writing. His free hand came down under the table and found her head, and stayed there for the length of one lap, and lifted away.

Laura filled the kettle.

The book had been offered, of course. That had taken six weeks and she had followed it the way she followed the weather. A man from a publisher in a coat the colour of nothing at the door on the second Tuesday, and then a woman, and then a man with the manner of a barrister and the voice of a funeral director. The third one had put a figure on a piece of paper and slid it across the table in this kitchen. Laura had read it upside down while pouring the tea. She had done the sum on the back of her hand and then gone to the bathroom and run the tap for a minute, because the sum was Elsie's school and Margaret's roof and a house with a second floor, and what she had felt was not temptation but an enormous tiredness at how easy it would be.

The publisher said *the nine notebooks, Mr Whitlock, as they stand, with an introduction.*

She did not tell him what to say. She had learned that, at least. He took the piece of paper by one corner and gave it back and said, very carefully, as if reading the number off a screen, that there were things in the books that were not his to sell. Laura had thought he would say it was private. He had said, instead, that the books contained people, and that the people had not agreed to be written down, and that there were dots at the end of #1399, in a place where an honest man ran

out of right. The publisher had asked what the dots were. Jonas had said: *the gaps. They are the only part I'd stand behind.*

The police had returned the books in the week before Christmas, in two grey boxes with a form. He had read the ninth to its last line, standing, in the hall, and then gone out and photographed all of it, a thing he did without thinking. The eight had gone back to the toolbox in Lewisham. She had gone with him that time, and sat on the upturned crate beside him in the garage that smelled of his father's oil, with Elsie in the sling asleep, and watched him lay them in, one by one, in order, on a folded cloth. He had not said anything. She had not asked him to. When he shut the lid he put his hand flat on it for a count that she knew was ten.

The ninth had been finished. The tenth had begun on a Saturday in October with a strip of cellophane peeled off by her own thumbnail.

The job she had learned by sitting next to it. He had taken the Bank's offer in the second week of December and told her in the car, at a red light, in a voice as flat as the road. A room on the fourth floor of the building in Threadneedle Street. Laura had said to her mother, loosely, that he was working in the room where the transaction was built, which was not true, that room being a dealing room in St James's; she meant the building from which the Deputy Governor had watched it on a screen. Priya, in a cast and then out of it, and four others; a standing order from the Governor to look under the promises. He had said *it's the same work, with people who can answer back.* Laura had thought: that is exactly what you need. And had said so, which was a thing she had not been able to do for four years, because for four years she had not known what the work was.

He went in three days a week. He came home before six. On the first day he had come in at seven, pale, and said, *Priya told the Governor's deputy that he'd misread a table.* She had laughed until she was sick.

At seven she took Elsie up. It took longer than it should, because

Elsie, who had been walking for four weeks, had views on being carried, and then in the dark of the nursery, with the lamp turned to its lowest, she forgot them, in the middle of a sentence she was composing in a language of her own, and was asleep with her fist on the rabbit before Laura had put the second foot on the landing.

Laura went down. He was still at the table, and the kettle had boiled and been left, and the light in the kitchen had the particular blue of an evening that has gone past its own end. He had been writing for two hours. He had five pages, she thought, or six, and she had not seen him turn back once. In eleven weeks she had never read a line. She was not going to begin with the last.

He wrote something, and stopped, and read it, and this time the pause was longer, and his hand moved up and stayed in the air above the page. She watched it. Lifted pen, a page he was not going to cross out. She thought, with the clarity that arrives in a consulting room when the patient has said the thing they came to say, *that is it. That is where it ends.*

He did not sign it. She had half expected him to: she saw the pen come down towards the foot of the page and stop a finger's width from the paper, as if it had come to a door, and go back up. He had never signed anything he wrote at that table. She had noticed it years ago, from the stair, in the way one notices a man who never says goodbye on the telephone, and had never asked why.

He looked at the page for a long moment. Then he closed the book.

It took a second, a plain soft sound, hardback on hardback, and the elastic band, which he drew across with his thumb and settled with the little tug she had watched him give it every night of their marriage. There were pages left. She could see the thickness of them under the cover, forty or more, blank and pale, waiting. He turned the book and set it down at the corner of the table, square to the edge.

In the study desk upstairs were five more, in cellophane, in their box. She had counted them in the autumn. She thought of them in the

dark, and thought: *he is not going to open the box.* And then, because she was a doctor and did not trust a prognosis, *he is not going to open the box yet.* And then, for the first time in four years, the second thing struck her as the less likely one.

He capped the pen.

She had never seen him do that. He left the pen uncapped beside the book, always, so that the tip would be ready, and every month she found one dried out in a pocket. Capped, it looked shorter than it was, a plain black object on a kitchen table, not an instrument. He put it down beside the book.

'Done?' she said.

'Nearly.' He looked at his hands, and then at her, and she could not read what was in the look, which was the first time that had happened in a year. 'Can I tell you what I wrote?'

'No,' said Laura. 'Tell me when you've finished.' She crossed the kitchen, and put the oven on, and took the lid off the pan. 'Tell me tomorrow, or never, whichever you like. Mum's coming at one and I need you to carve.'

He laughed. It was a good laugh. She heard it come out of him the way you hear a joint move that has been stiff.

'Where do you want it?' he said, and held up the book.

'Anywhere,' said Laura.

He stood and put it there, on the dresser between the fruit bowl and the radio, where anyone could pick it up, and went to look for the carving knife.

Chapter 55

#1500

Friday, the eighth of January. This is entry 1,500, and I have been looking at the number for ten minutes, because it is round, and I notice such things, and nobody else does.

Seventy-nine days since the six o'clock. I have not counted anything else. I have not counted my age since the autumn; it is on the form I sign at the Bank every month and I copy it without looking. I counted the years once, in a tidy block, as if a life were a quarterly report with the footnotes left off, and I was proud of the footnotes. I am not going to do that tonight. I will say only that the dots at the end of #1399 are still there, and I have decided to leave them.

I took the tenth down from the dresser, where it has lain since last night for anyone to pick up, and Laura is across the kitchen with her back to me. She has not asked what I am writing. She has never read a page and I think she will not read this one, and I find I would not mind if she did, which is new and which I leave here for the record.

On the last night of my thirties I wrote four lines and I had a phrase in my head for them, and I did not write it down, because it embarrassed me. The phrase was *life lesson*. In October, at Calloway's table, with a borrowed pad and a clearing house due to fail by morning, I wrote one: *Being right is worth nothing if you only write it down.* It

was true, and it was half.

This is the other half.

Nothing is true until somebody else has been able to check it.

The first half is the one Laura gave me. She sat at that table in her coat and said, tell me where it is, the way you would tell Priya, and it was the first time anything of mine left the page. The second half is the one Priya gave me, on the morning of the twenty-first, from a hospital bed, correcting me twice in front of a deputy governor. I said *I think* in my throat for four years, and I called it caution. It was a man making sure no one could ever say *no, you're wrong*. Careful is a thing you do with someone. Alone, it is another word.

I gave an order in a room at Walbrook with a woman on a telephone correcting me, and each time I was glad of her, in a way I would have found unbearable in September. She was right and I was wrong, aloud, and the market turned. That is all the transaction was, at the end: a number said out loud, and a person who could say no to it. I have spent eleven weeks looking for something larger and there is not anything.

I have never signed an entry. I used to say a signature was a claim, and that a record was only a record if nobody had claimed it. For 1,499 entries it was a good rule. I was wrong about that as well. A record that nobody has claimed is a diary; a claim is what you hand to someone so that they can check it.

This one is written to be checked. Every figure in it is somewhere else as well: in a statement in Holborn, in the Bank's log of that morning, in a red notebook on a sofa in Bethnal Green. Anyone may look, and if I am wrong they may say so, and I will be glad. That is what a name at the foot of a page is for. So.

Elsie.

Your first word was on the twenty-third of December, at twenty to seven in the morning. It was not the one I had put money on, though

I have not put money on anything since the autumn. It was not Dad. It was not Da; we agreed in the autumn not to argue about that for a year, and there are nine months of the year left, and I am not going to spend them on it.

You were on my hip. The kitchen window had gone grey and the glass was white at the corners. You took your whole arm out of my coat sleeve, like a signpost, and you pointed it at the garden. Not at me. At the shed roof, where nothing had happened, an ordinary frost, the kind I have seen for forty winters and never once been asked to look at.

Then you turned your head and checked that I had.

I had. I looked. You were right. It was exactly as you said.

Look.

Jonas Whitlock